

Foundations of
INDIAN
PSYCHOLOGY

PRACTICAL
APPLICATIONS

VOLUME
II

R. M. Matthijs Cornelissen
Girishwar Misra
Suneet Varma

FOUNDATIONS OF INDIAN PSYCHOLOGY

Volume 2

PRACTICAL APPLICATIONS

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Volume 2

Practical Applications

R. M. Matthijs Cornelissen

Girishwar Misra

Suneet Varma

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Contents

Preface	vii
<i>Karan Singh</i>	
Acknowledgements	viii
Introduction	ix
<i>R. M. Matthijs Cornelissen, Girishwar Misra, Suneet Varma</i>	
The psychological perspectives of our times...	xxiii
Three shifts of a rhythm	
<i>Aster Patel</i>	

I. Health and healing

Introduction	3
1. The philosophy of healing in Indian medicine	9
<i>Kapil Kapoor</i>	
2. Integral psychology: More than a tool for health and happiness	15
<i>R. L. Bijlani</i>	
3. Folk wisdom and traditional healing practices:	21
Some lessons for modern psychotherapies	
<i>Ajit K. Dalal</i>	
4. Psychotherapy and Indian thought	36
<i>Alok Pandey</i>	
5. Psychotherapy and Integral Yoga Psychology	64
<i>Michael Miovic</i>	
6. Concept and scope of <i>pratyāhāra</i> in management of	84
mental health	
<i>K. M. Tripathi</i>	

II. Education

Introduction	101
7. Integral education: An application of Indian psychology <i>Neeltje Huppes</i>	105
8. The blending of healing and pedagogy in Āyurveda <i>P. Ram Manohar</i>	118
9. Situating teacher education in the Indian context: A paradigm shift <i>Bharati Baveja</i>	132
10. Krishnamurti and value education <i>Vinita Kaushik Kapur</i>	147
11. Education for life: The Mirambika experience <i>Anjum Sibia</i>	156

III. Social issues

Introduction	183
12. Exploring the images used for the individual–organization interface: Experiences and reflections <i>Anand Prakash</i>	187
13. Broadening of consciousness: A healing process among the survivors of the Kachchh earthquake <i>Kumar Ravi Priya</i>	209
14. Resolution of social conflicts: An Indian model <i>Raghubir Singh Pirta</i>	225
15. <i>Lālan-pālan</i> : A psycho-spiritual experience for the Indian mother <i>Anjali Singh</i>	239
16. Being human the Sikh way: Some psychological reflections <i>Preeti Kapur & Girishwar Misra</i>	251
17. Organizational transformation through consciousness-centred training: A case study from the Indian Army <i>Kittu Reddy</i>	269
Glossary of words of Sanskrit or Pali origin	279
The contributors	289
Index	295

Preface

Karan Singh

Apart from its other achievements, the ancient Indian civilization undertook the most profound examination of the human mind that has ever been attempted anywhere. The entire process of yoga, particularly the system based on Patanjali's Yogasutras, developed a methodology for 'stilling the modifications of the mind'. The Bhagavad Gita also contains specific instructions for stilling the mind, and thereby accessing the deeper reaches of our psyche. Indian psychology therefore has a firm base and a profound underlying philosophy.

Due largely to centuries of Western domination, we have tended to be unduly influenced by the West, even in the area of psychology. This is not in any way to denigrate the great breakthroughs of Western psychology, particularly those of Sigmund Freud and C. G. Jung. Indeed, post-Jungian psychology, especially Transpersonal Psychology, which has developed in recent years in California and around the world, are welcome efforts to delve deeper into the mysteries of the mind. What is really needed is a creative fusion between the Indian psychological traditions and the newer Western methodologies.

As they do in so many other areas, Sri Aurobindo's writings throw a flood of light upon various elements connected with the quest for the inner light. He has used *Vedic* symbolism to postulate a highly original interpretation, which places Indian psychology at the heart of the entire study. It is important that Indian insights become part of mainstream psychology around the world, and not be treated merely as an esoteric phenomenon.

The editors of *Foundations of Indian Psychology* deserve warm commendations for having brought together a broad and rich spectrum of articles dealing with various aspects of psychology, including social, psychological, educational, health and emotional dimensions. This book represents a valuable contribution to world psychological studies and will be of great value to students of psychology around the world. Recent research on the brain and the mind-brain relationship has thrown fascinating light upon how the human mind functions. Indian psychology, of course, goes beyond the mind into what we would call the spiritual centre of our being. The co-relation of these various elements and dimensions represent a fascinating field for study.

Living as we are in an age of great stress and tension, the psychological aspects of human welfare and individual happiness can no longer be neglected. I take great pleasure in recommending this book not only to professional psychologists, but also to the general reader interested in delving deeper into the marvels and mysteries of the human mind.

Acknowledgements

The list of people to whom we owe an immense gratitude begins early. In fact, it begins with the ancient *ṛsis* who composed the beautiful verses of the *Rg Veda*, and it continues right into our present times through a long, uninterrupted lineage of *yogis*, poets, sages, philosophers and common men and women, who together developed the theory and practice on which Indian psychology is based.

Amongst our contemporaries, there are again too many great individuals to name all, but we would like to mention at least a few. The first who come to mind are no doubt the authors of the chapters in this book. They have not only borne with us during the long period of gestation *Foundations* took to come out, but they have also contributed in many other ways to the development of Indian psychology as a science. Then there are many others who have not contributed directly to the text of *Foundations*, but who have worked for Indian psychology in other ways, whether by writing, research or the organization of seminars, workshops and conferences. We would like to mention, for example, George Mathews, Janak Pandey, S. Narayanan, Usha Ram, Indrani Sanyal, P. Krishna Rao, Krishna Mohan, Sonali Bhatt Marwaha, Ramana Kumar Kanuri, H. R. Nagendra and his colleagues at SVYASA, and in Puducherry A. S. Dalal, Panch Ramalingam, Soumitra Basu, Larry Seidlitz and Ananda Reddy, but there are so many others.

Special mention need be made of Kireet Joshi, who in the early years of this century gave his unstinting moral and financial support to the development of Indian psychology as the then Chairman of the Indian Council of Philosophical Research. Similarly, we are grateful to K. Ramakrishna Rao, who personally and in his many official capacities has made a unique contribution to the development of Indian psychology. During the last ten years, the ICPR and ICSSR have enabled almost every seminar related to Indian psychology in India. In this connection we also want to express our gratitude to Rajiv Malhotra and the Infinity Foundation.

Finally there are those at the Sri Aurobindo Ashram and the Indian Psychology Institute who have helped with the production of the two volumes: Neeltje Huppes, without whose continuous support the book might not have come out at all, Vladimir Iatsenko who provided us with the Glossary, and Lynn Crawford, Divya Parasher and Jyoti Dalal who proofread and typeset the texts. We owe a similar gratitude to the staff of Pearson Education and to the many others who by their interest, silent support or hard work have helped with the development of Indian psychology and the production of *Foundations of Indian Psychology*.

We are grateful to the Sri Aurobindo Ashram Trust for giving us permission to use quotations from Sri Aurobindo's writings in *Foundations of Indian Psychology*.

Introduction

R. M. Matthijs Cornelissen

Girishwar Misra

Suneet Varma

What do we mean by Indian psychology?

By Indian psychology we mean an approach to psychology that is based on ideas and practices that developed over thousands of years within the Indian sub-continent. In other words, we use the word 'Indian' to indicate and honour the *origin* of this approach to psychology—the origin of the underlying philosophy, the conceptual framework, the methods of enquiry, and the technology of consciousness that it uses to bring about psychological change and transformation. It may be useful to make explicit that we do not use the word 'Indian' to localize or limit the *scope* of this approach to psychology; we do not mean, for example, 'the psychology of the Indian people', or 'psychology as taught at Indian universities'. We hold that Indian psychology as a meta-theory and as an extensive body of related theories and practices has something essential and unique to contribute to the global civilization as a whole.

It may also be useful to make explicit that this volume is not about the past, but about the present and the future. You will look in vain for chapters about the history of Indian philosophy or religion as they developed over the ages. Many such texts are already available, but this is not one of them. This volume has contributions that demonstrate how ideas and practices from the Indian tradition can be used to tackle issues in contemporary psychology and constructively inform its disciplinary practice by helping theory building and application.

Psychology as taught at present, all over the world, is still amazingly uncultural. This is rather remarkable if we consider the intensity and ease of international communications, and the fact that it is almost half a century since the political decolonization of Asia and Africa was completed. Though the large component of European and American thought in psychology is understandable historically, it is not any longer excusable. For it is not that the rest of the world has not thought about human nature, and it is definitely not that contemporary psychology has found the one and only correct way of doing so. In this context, one could argue that Indian psychology will be relevant particularly to Asian, African, or Latin-American countries which share alternative non-Western world views about mind, psyche and various psychological phenomena such as healing, health, self, or personality; but we strongly believe that in spite of all cultural differences, there is a large common core to human nature, and that, to the extent that Indian

psychology deals with that common core, it should be of interest to all members of the human family.

In short, we do not look at Indian psychology as something that belongs only to India or the past, but as a rich source of psychological insight and know-how that can be utilized to create a better future for the whole of humanity.

What the Indian civilization can contribute to psychology

The unique contribution which the Indian civilization can make to modern psychology can be looked at as consisting of three distinct elements—a sophisticated and well-worked out, psychology-based meta-theoretical framework, a wide repertoire of psychological practices, and a rich treasury of psychological theories. These three are, obviously, closely interconnected, and it may be clear that none of them can be fully understood without a fairly complete understanding of the other two. Yet, as language is inevitably linear, we will give here a separate short introduction to each of them.

A psychology-friendly meta-theoretical framework

The first major contribution the Indian civilization can make to psychology is a psychology-friendly meta-theoretical framework. To delineate the underlying theory, the basic ‘paradigm’ of the Indian tradition is, of course, a pretentious undertaking fraught with possibilities of error. The Indian civilization is immensely complex, and, given the abundance of different—often contrary—voices it harbours within itself, it is hard to state anything about it that cannot be contradicted with a striking counter-example. And yet, it is useful to give it a try, for the simple reason that without this background it is impossible to fully understand its psychological practices and its theories.

When one looks at the Indian civilization as it developed over the ages, it becomes quickly clear that within it there exists such a huge variety of distinct cultural traditions, that one may doubt whether it actually makes sense to speak of a single Indian tradition and whether it would not be more accurate to speak of Indian traditions in the plural. The doubt is understandable, but we would contend that in case of the Indian tradition, singularity and multiformity are not necessarily mutually exclusive. A rich variety of expressions does not preclude the possibility of a common thread, a single foundation supporting the variety, and we are inclined to think that especially in India such a common core indeed does exist. In fact, the idea of a single truth supporting a variety of manifestations is itself one of the core-characteristics of the deep view of reality that underlies the whole wide gamut of Indian traditions. One of the most-often-quoted aphorisms expressing this acknowledgement of divergent views in spite of a single underlying reality is probably: *ekam sad viprā bahudhā vadanti*, which means, ‘the truth is One, but the wise call it by different names’. An interesting aspect of this saying is that the differences are not described as errors: it is the wise that give different names to the one truth. Moreover, one would miss the point if one were to take this saying

as no more than a polite exhortation for religious tolerance. It rests on a deep, psychological understanding of the human condition, which says that reality as it really is, will always remain beyond our limited mental capacity to grasp, and that each individual can perceive of that reality only as much as their individual capacity and inclination will allow.

There is another ancient saying which goes a step further. It deals with the different perceptions that arise from affirmative and agnostic approaches to reality. It says—and one can immediately see how close some ancient Indian thinkers came to postmodern constructivism—that not only the name we give to an experience, but even the experience itself is determined by our ‘set’. The *Taittiriya Upaniṣad* (2.6.1), for instance, says, *asann eva sa bhavati, asad brahmeti veda cet, asti brahmeti ced veda, santam enaṁ tato viduḥ*, meaning, ‘whoever envisages it as existence becomes (or realizes) it as existence, and whoever envisages it as non-being becomes (or realizes) that non-existence’. It may be noted that in the Indian tradition such differences are not attributed only to the different cultural priming; they are attributed primarily to the different type, level and quality of the internal state of the observer. And this brings us to what might well be described as the most important difference between the Indian and the Western paradigm.

The differences

Western psychology is largely confined to two dimensions which are both fully accessible to the ordinary waking consciousness—the physical and the social. Genetics, neurophysiology and the cognitive sciences are typical for sub-disciplines with a focus on the physical dimension, and the various offshoots of psychoanalysis, social constructivism and cross-cultural psychology could be considered typical for those who focus on social factors. Between the two, there is still, in spite of many attempts at ‘softening’ psychology, a widespread tendency to take the physical dimension more seriously than the social. Even within the field of consciousness studies, the existence of physical reality tends to be taken for granted, while the ontological ‘reality’ of consciousness and subjective experience is open for discussion. Their apparent existence needs some kind of justification, and both are commonly considered epiphenomenal products of material processes. Related to this, in terms of epistemology, the ordinary waking consciousness is considered the only acceptable state for the researcher to be in, and a clear rational mind is taken as the ultimate arbiter of truth. In fact, non-ordinary states of awareness are primarily associated with drugs and somewhat frivolous new-age activities. Finally, in terms of practical methodology, objectivity is taken as the ultimate ideal, and first-person, subjective observations are taken seriously only if they are embedded in statistics and third-person objective measures to counteract their inherent weaknesses. Obviously all this is a simplification and there are exceptions to this pattern—one could, for example, think of phenomenology—but still, a strong physicalist bias, an absolute faith in the ordinary waking consciousness and a total reliance on objective methods are so much part of mainstream

psychology that amongst psychologists, they are commonly considered indispensable elements of the scientific method.

The intellectual tradition of India starts from radically different assumptions. Ontologically, the most fundamental reality is not matter, but spirit; or more precisely, the indivisible unity of *saccidānanda*, of absolute existence, consciousness and delight. In other words, the Indian tradition includes psychological phenomena like consciousness and joy as core-elements of reality, and in fact it takes not physics, but 'knowledge of the self' (*adhyātma-vidyā*) as the fundamental science. Accordingly, the possibility and cosmic importance of an absolutely silent, transcendent consciousness are hardly ever doubted, while there are major schools of thought that do doubt the importance and even the reality of the material pole of existence. While Western science has come to terms with the fact that there are many different types of physical energies and substances, of which some are not directly perceptible by the human senses, the Indian tradition takes it for granted that there are also various types and levels of non-physical existence—entire inner 'worlds' which are not directly perceptible to the ordinary waking consciousness, but that are ontologically as real, or even more real than the ordinary physical world. These non-physical realities are considered to be intermediate planes of conscious existence between the absolute, silent consciousness of the transcendent and the apparent unconsciousness of matter. As a result, physical and social factors are accepted as part of causal networks, but not as the full story—events are thought to be influenced by a wide variety of forces that include factors belonging to non-physical realities. Similarly, epistemologically, a rational mind is appreciated and cultivated, but it is understood that there are higher sources of knowledge and the possibility of a direct, intuitive apprehension of truth. Finally, objective, sense-based knowledge is considered a minor form of knowledge (or even ignorance, *avidyā*) and an immense collective effort has gone into the development of processes that can make us more open to the subtle worlds, and especially to the pre-existing inner knowledge, *vidyā*.

It may be clear that these two basic views of reality lead to a very different sense of what psychology is about, how it is to be conducted, and what can be expected from it. For those under the influence of the physicalist worldview, psychology deals either with outer behaviour or with mental processes that happen within the neuro-physiological apparatus of individual human beings; even those who stress social influences, tacitly assume that such influences are transferred by physical means. It is taken for granted that consciousness, whether individually or socially determined, depends on working neural systems. Non-physical realities are illusory and parapsychological phenomena are 'anomalous'. For an eternal soul there is no place (except as a belief of others, not as an 'objective' reality that exists in itself). Methodologically, one has to rely on statistics and sophisticated third-person methods of research. In terms of application, one aims at (behaviourally verifiable) changes in others.

For those under the influence of the Indian system, consciousness is primary. It is taken to be all-pervasive, and as existing within space and time, as well as

beyond both. The borders of the individual are porous, and the individual consciousness is found to extend through space and time, to others, to all kinds of inner worlds, and even to what is beyond all manifestation. As a result, non-physical realities and parapsychological phenomena fit perfectly within this explanatory framework, and there is no difficulty accepting an eternal soul as our real self. For research in Indian psychology, sophisticated first person methods are the natural first choice. In terms of application, Indian psychology aims primarily at the mastery and transformation of oneself.

When one lists these differences in this manner, the two systems seem to belong to different worlds, and not only serious misunderstandings, but even a certain mutual distrust appears almost inevitable. Historically this has indeed been the case. In the Indian tradition, right from the *Upaniṣads* and the stories of the *Purāṇas*, the basic ontological and epistemological assumptions of modern psychology are looked at as beginners' errors, remnants of an ordinary, naive way of looking at the world that stand in the way of a deeper understanding of how the human mind, consciousness in general, and even the physical reality actually work. Seen from the other side, from the perspective of mainstream psychology, giving up its positivist, constructivist, or agnostic assumptions looks like a return to a superstitious past, a giving up of the most valuable accomplishments of the European Enlightenment, a recipe for disaster.

Roads to reconciliation

There are several factors that may, however, help to overcome these difficulties. The first is that the inability of modern science to deal effectively with non-physical realities and 'the divine', may not be intrinsic to science as such. Future generations, who are likely to have a more globally informed cultural background, may ascribe this inability largely to the vagaries of European history. It might well be found that in the early years of modern science, Europe left these inner realms aside, not because it is intrinsically too difficult to research them in an intelligent and open-minded manner, but simply because they were too encrusted in the religious environment of the time. It is true that neither alchemy, nor the later efforts of parapsychology have led to sufficiently concrete results to convince the sceptics; but that might well be because their studies were hampered on the one side by the lack of a sufficiently supportive philosophical framework, and on the other by their failure to develop effective powers within the inner realms they purported to study.

As we will try to present in this volume, the Indian tradition might be able to provide both. Though the Indian civilization has had its own difficulties—800 years of foreign interference not the least of them—such a dramatic split between the physical and the inner domains is not part of the Indian story. In fact, the social structures and mental attitudes supporting spiritual pursuits in India are much closer to those of European science than to those of European religion. Even Śaṅkara—who arguably comes closest to what in the Christian tradition would have been called a church-father, given his role in founding centres of

religious authority and power—in the end puts personal experience (*anubhava*) above tradition. In his *Bhagavad Gitā Bhāṣya* he says, for example (18, 66), ‘Even a hundred scriptural passages will not become authoritative when they, for instance, announce that fire is cool or dark’ (Rao, 1979, p. 65). The methods of yoga and meditation are nowadays primarily looked at soteriologically, that is, as a means for salvation, as a means to arrive at *samādhi* or *nirvāṇa*—at least if they are not seen as a means to arrive at physical health and the survival of a corporate lifestyle. In the culture of origin, however, they are part of a coherent knowledge system and they are clearly looked at as a way to arrive at reliable knowledge. This is most clear in the case of *jñānayoga* (the yoga of knowledge); but one can easily discern elements of the pursuit of truth even in *karma*- and *bhaktiyoga* (the paths of works and devotion), which also, in their own way, have methods to reduce the distortions of perception and affect that are part of the ordinary human consciousness.

The good news then is that modern scientific and ancient Indian approaches to psychology may not be so much contradictory as complementary. It is true that they are based on different ontological and epistemological assumptions, that they use different methods, and to some extent, that they look at different sides of the human enterprise, but in the end, they are based on the same human urge for true knowledge, pure love, effective power and happiness. It may not be easy to come to mutual respect and understanding, but the effort will be worth it, for our preoccupation with knowledge and power in the physical domain has not solved humanity’s problems. On a global scale, suffering due to poverty, violence and disease is still rampant, and we have added a considerable risk of sudden environmental self-destruction. One could well argue that the one thing we need most at present is a more comprehensive understanding of our own nature. As editors of this volume, we would like to argue that Indian psychology can make a valuable contribution to that endeavour.

Psychological practices

According to a survey commissioned by the *Yoga Journal*, there were in February 2008, some 15.8 million practitioners of (*haṭha*) yoga in the USA alone, and amongst the rest of the adult population, another 8 per cent, or eighteen million people, were ‘very or extremely interested in yoga’. Over the years, thousands of researches on yoga and meditation have been conducted (Murphy & Donovan, 1997; Walsh & Shapiro, 2006), but according to the latter, this research is as yet rather imbalanced. Most research is conducted with beginning practitioners, and the vast majority of researches have been carried out with not more than three basic techniques—*haṭhayoga*, *vipassana* and Transcendental Meditation (TM). Almost all research is, moreover, in a mode that cultural anthropologists would call *etic*, rather than *emic*. In other words, the research is done from an outsider’s, rather than from an insider’s perspective; the techniques are decontextualized, and their effectiveness is measured in terms that belong to the theoretical framework of mainstream psychology. This is in itself not surprising, for measurement

involves the use of standards, and in science these standards have to come from previously conducted research. But the result is that the effects of yoga and meditation have been measured almost exclusively on variables like blood pressure, anxiety, depression and extroversion, which have little to do with what would have been considered relevant in the culture of origin, such as equanimity, compassion, wisdom and detachment.

While reflecting on the scope of existing research on yoga and meditation, there is another issue that warrants careful consideration. It is true that India has developed an astounding variety of structured methods to 'do' yoga and meditation. There can also be no doubt that it is worth studying these techniques, and that one should not do this only by etic, but also, or even especially, by emic approaches. The methods of yoga should be understood on their own terms, and ideally not only in their gross 'effectiveness' but in terms of the underlying spiritual and psychological processes. But even a sympathetic, insider's look at these techniques will not give us the whole story. Amongst the Indian psychological practices that could benefit humanity, there are not only such formalized methods and techniques, but there is also an implicit, informal know-how that is orally transmitted from teacher to student within the *guru-śiṣya paramparā* (the master-disciple relationship), or passed down from generation to generation in the form of social institutions, customs, and culturally prescribed—but individually adopted and adapted—attitudes and inner gestures. When we look at *yoga* not only as a way to find the Divine but also as a way to bring our entire life more in harmony with the highest we can conceive and experientially 'realize', then it becomes clear why these informal, implicit aspects of *yoga* play such a big role in the Indian civilization, and why they are so interesting for modern psychology. An anecdote from E. Richard Sorenson (2008) may illustrate the point. Sorensen relates an experience he had in a Tibetan monastery where most of the monks were young, and where he had noticed earlier that the novices were always 'eagerly rushing to share whatever special tidbit [*sic*] might have come their way (whether material or ideational)' (p. 46). As he relates:

One day, while having lunch with a group of novices, a burst of mirth snared my attention. An adolescent novice had just selected, as if solely for himself, the largest apple off a plate. Bursts of laughter from the others, no verbal comment, just hilarity, as several then did much the same, usually with some special fillip or perspective of their own. There was no obligation to be either different or the same ... they were just nuzzling at a trait all had seen outside.

The interesting part is that amongst these youngsters, there were no pejorative remarks or outbursts of self-righteous indignation. Egoism was for them not something natural and tempting, yet socially unacceptable, but an utterly hilarious trait they had so far noticed only in the behaviour of people outside their own community. Presuming there is no major genetic difference in such matters, it is clearly worthwhile to study what it is exactly that made sharing the natural baseline for

these children. It seems extremely unlikely that such a fundamental difference can be brought about by formal exercises or explicit instructions.

Regarding the spiritual core of the Indian psychological tradition, there is amongst professional psychologists a similar tendency to focus on formal practices and specialized techniques. Yet, in the *Yoga Sūtras* of Patañjali, the undisputed authority on *rājayoga*, only one of its many *ślokas* deals with *āsanas* (yogic postures), and the *Bhagavad Gītā* hardly mentions strongly structured practices at all. Even in our times, some of the greatest sages of modern India, like Ramakrishna Paramahansa, Sai Baba of Shirdi, Ramana Maharshi and Sri Aurobindo, did not advocate the use of highly structured and formalized techniques at all. They worked instead through a focussed, specialized application of—in itself quite simple—psychological processes and powers. There is an enormous variety of those, and even though all the great gurus had their own favourites—for example, Ramakrishna's absolute devotion to the Divine Mother, or Ramana's sustained and unremitting focus on the question, 'Who am I?'—they typically adjusted their method of teaching to the needs of each disciple at any given moment.

The literature contains many different lists of desirable inner attitudes and gestures. Typical examples might be: a silent, non-judgemental self-observation; a growing surrender to the highest one can conceive; a sustained aspiration towards the Divine (whether in terms of knowledge, work, love, or oneness); a systematic development of traits like equanimity, calm, patience, vigilance, kindness, compassion, love, joy, harmony, oneness, wideness; small inner gestures of self-giving, consecration, openness, silence, surrender; the relocation of the centre of one's consciousness inwards and upwards. As yet, it is hard to say with certainty, whether such non-sectarian, informal 'paths' will dominate the future of Indian psychology, or the more formalized 'techniques' that have played such a big role in the preservation of the tradition into the present. What seems clear to us is that there is an urgent need for research in both.

Psychological theories

Indian psychology has dealt with most areas in which mainstream psychology is interested, and in many of them it has something unique to add. As we will see, there is a special, common quality to the contributions it can make to all these different fields. If we start with the structure of the personality—as we do in the first volume of *Foundations*—then we find that the Indian tradition has developed the concept of *ahamkāra*, which stands somewhere in between the Western concepts of ego and self-concept. But besides this egoic centre, which belongs to the ordinary waking consciousness, the Indian tradition has also developed a detailed nomenclature for many other, more subtle and non-egoic centres of consciousness; and it has even worked out, especially in certain Buddhist schools, how a consciousness can exist without any centre whatsoever. Similarly, the Indian tradition has found below the surface of our waking consciousness not only the dark 'unconscious' that depth psychology has explored, but a whole range of subtle *kośas* or layers of consciousness, that each have their own characteristic nature.

It has even worked out many different ways of ‘realizing’ in one’s experience (or perhaps one should rather say, in one’s being) a Transcendent beyond all nature. It has found that all these inner layers, types, and centres of conscious existence have their specific influences on the surface personality, and that a direct access to them can, with sufficient training, enable levels of freedom, peace, joy, compassion, and understanding much beyond what is possible in the ordinary waking state.

In the field of cognition, we see a similar pattern. On the one hand, there is a detailed theoretical understanding of ordinary, sense-based cognition, mostly described as a system of *pramāṇa*, or knowledge-producing events. Different schools developed somewhat different theories about these matters—and they made much of their differences—but there is actually quite a large common base. It is noteworthy that the philosophical school of the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, which specialized in issues of epistemology and methodology, came to conclusions that are similar to modern thought in many respects. However, just as we saw in the field of Self and Personality, the ordinary sense-based cognition was not enough for the Indian tradition, and it developed besides a detailed understanding of intuition, inspiration, revelation, and various other types of ‘intuitive knowledge’ for which there are not always equivalent terms in English. The sheer complexity of the terminology, the subtle but significant differences between the various terms, and the stress on concrete methods to develop and refine these various forms of intuitive knowledge may give an idea not only of the enthusiasm and energy with which these possibilities have been explored, but also of the rigour, precision and attention for detail with which this work was undertaken. The study, cultivation and perfection of these subtle, not sense-based forms of cognition, might well deserve to become one of the major thrust areas of Indian psychology, as their development may lead to the creation of appropriate research methodologies for a whole new field of psychology.

Another major area of interest in psychology is that of emotion and motivation. To fully understand the various Indian theories of emotion, one has to go back to what should perhaps count as one of the greatest discoveries of the Indian tradition—the idea that the nature of ultimate reality can be described as an indivisible unity of *Sat*, *Cit* and *Ānanda*, or Existence, Consciousness, and Delight. While in mainstream psychology, it is generally presumed that happiness is dependent on the satisfaction of individual needs and desires, this theory asserts that delight is inherent in existence, even though it can be clouded in humans by their ‘ignorance’ (*avidyā*). In other words, suffering is attributed to ego-bound deformations and limitations of the over-individualized human consciousness. Seen from this angle, the satisfaction of desires may give temporary relief, but the road to lasting and unconditional happiness and wisdom runs through detachment from the ego, and a rediscovery of one’s knowledge of, love for, and oneness with the ultimate reality. With the ideal of perfect detachment and complete equanimity, a series of intriguing questions arise, which have occupied some of the best minds in Indian history, regarding the possibility of action for someone who has

completely overcome all desire, preference and attachment. If such ‘unmotivated’ action is possible—and most schools of Indian thought agree that it is—then what kind of action can that be?

In the field of emotion, a special place deserves to be given to the ideas of Bharata (400–200 BCE) on aesthetic enjoyment. Bharata starts with the fascinating question, why people enjoy watching tragic plays in spite of the fact that they already know beforehand that watching such plays will make them cry. Considering the emotions that spectators and actors suffer and savour, he arrives at the subtle theory of *rasa*, the basic ‘taste’, which triggers the original delight hidden in all things.

It is commonly held, especially amongst American authors (for example, Walsh & Shapiro, 2006) that there are several areas of psychology where the Indian tradition has little to contribute. Though this is in itself perfectly plausible, it does not hold for the most commonly quoted examples. In all four areas where Walsh and Shapiro, for example, think that ‘the meditative traditions’ have little to contribute—child-development, psychodynamics, psychopathology and psycho-pharmacology—there is in fact detailed theoretical knowledge available within Āyurvedic and Siddha literature. In all four fields, the Indian tradition has paid attention to very similar social and physical factors as are taken into account in Western psychology; but there is, besides, an additional interest in influences on more subtle planes. In child-development, for example, influences from previous lives and the unique ‘soul-quality’ of the child, the *svabhāva*, are acknowledged as major contributors to the child’s character and development. A similar multilevel understanding is part of the Indian way of looking at psychopathology, and the developmental stages later in life—the four *āśramas*. The misconception that there is no Indian contribution to any of these fields, is in all likelihood due to the same peculiar way in which Western psychology has studied the Indian tradition that we mentioned earlier. Mainstream academics have either looked at the decontextualized techniques of *yoga* and meditation, or at the other extreme, at equally decontextualized philosophical systems. The surrounding culture, as actually practiced, and the mediating theories—which are both very well developed in India—have so far not received the attention they deserve.

Indian psychology applied

Psychology is very much an applied science; and fields like pedagogy, education, social work, human resource development, organisational behaviour and therapy can all be looked at as specialized fields of applied psychology. At present, practitioners in these fields often experience a certain tension between the official theory, which prescribes well-defined, explicit methods and procedures, and experience, which tells them that a more personalized, eclectic and intuitive approach works better. The informal experience seems to come closer to reality than the formal theory. Interestingly, there is substantial statistical evidence to support this view. Bruce Wampold (2001), for example, has collected massive meta-analytical

data to show that hardly any of the efficacy in psychotherapy can be ascribed to specific methods and theories. According to his findings, the efficacy in therapy is almost entirely determined by factors that either belong to the environment in which the therapy takes place or that are internal to the therapist and the client. While this is hard to understand from within the medical model that is used in most mainstream therapy research, it is in full harmony with Indian psychology, where the focus is on the work people have to do on themselves. The guide—whether he plays the role of pedagogue, teacher, human resource professional or therapist—guides by example, and perhaps even by direct influence. He shows that growing up is both worthwhile and feasible; that difficult material can be learned; that it is possible to master complex social situations in a constructive manner; and that life's problems can be solved. In a very deep sense, the guide guides mainly by sharing who he is in the essence of his being and how he expresses that essence in his life. In many forms of therapy-training this is recognized, and undergoing therapy oneself is then an essential part of the training-process. But in Indian psychology, which is built on self-knowledge rather than on knowledge of statistically generalized others, the demand for self-work, for understanding and mastering one's own self, goes further—both in breadth and in depth. In breadth, because it extends to all fields of applied psychology, and in depth because a good guide is supposed to show that it is possible, in the words of Sri Aurobindo, to 'transcend and integrate': A good guide should be able to show that it is possible to go beyond one's limitations; to live from a higher consciousness; to act from less selfish motives; to work more in harmony with the whole.

The practical application of Indian psychology differs from present-day mainstream psychology in a manner that parallels the differences we found in the various areas of theory formation. There is on the one hand the same constant attention to the multidimensional nature of the personality—a multidimensionality that is not limited to the physical and the social, but that extends to, or rather starts with, the spiritual. And there is on the other hand, a constant awareness that each individual is ultimately unique. Both attention points come together in the important concepts of *svabhāva* and *svadharma*—the recognition that individuals have not only their own true nature, their own unique set of qualities, but also their own truth of action, their own rules of conduct. Both concepts are based on the underlying sense that the individual is not just a cluster of self-concepts and tendencies to behave according to pre-established patterns, but a spiritual being, a soul who has taken birth for a definite purpose, a purpose which it has to find and fulfil.

One book in two volumes: Some concluding remarks

Indian psychology as such is as old as history; and in a technical sense, even older than written history, given that there are indications of a long oral tradition before the first texts were ever written down. But Indian psychology as a branch of modern science is a new field, which is as yet truly in its infancy. Our attempt to use

the treasures of the Indian tradition for contemporary problems is relatively new and in that sense we are pioneering a new effort. The editors and contributors to this book make no claims on being accomplished *yogis*; they are ordinary scholars and professionals who have tried to see what various ideas and practices from the Indian tradition can contribute to some major issues in contemporary psychology. The different chapters are records of such attempts; most are exploratory in nature and not the outcome of a long, well-established tradition of research. What is more, this book looks at the Indian tradition as a knowledge system in its own right, and tries to see whether its ideas and its practices have the potential to complement and enrich modern science not only in terms of content, theory-construction and practical application, but even in basic research methodology. As said in the beginning of this introduction, this book would like to open up issues like these to a wider discussion.

Foundations of Indian Psychology has been divided into two volumes. The first volume clarifies the basic 'Theories and concepts' of Indian psychology and its first section deals with the social and philosophical context. It delineates what Indian psychology actually is, and then, in the second chapter, describes how the academic science of psychology developed in modern India. The third and fourth chapters take us back into India's hoary past: they give us a glimpse of the psychological wisdom hidden behind the symbolic language of the *R̥g Veda*, the oldest and most respected of all Indian scriptures. The last two chapters of this section offer two different perspectives on the post-modern methodological and social global environment in which Indian psychology is presently re-discovering itself. The other three sections of this first volume deal with the same major issues that modern, mainstream psychology deals with: the first is on self and personality; the second on research methods and cognition; the third on emotion, volition and motivation. But there is one big difference: as we have indicated at the very beginning of this introduction, Indian psychology is rooted in a consciousness-based, spiritual, yet secular and life-affirming tradition, and each chapter of these three sections tries in its own way to see what spirituality and a consciousness-based understanding of reality can contribute to our modern understanding of the human mind and its possibilities for further development.

The second volume, 'Practical applications', shows the deep and wholesome changes that the use of Indian psychology can make in the applied fields of health and healing, education and society. The first section here deals with health and healing and takes us, after a short, concept-packed philosophical introduction, from the application of *yoga* for integral health in one of India's best medical training hospitals in Delhi, via countryside temples and the practice of psychotherapy in an Indian *āśrama* and American suburbs, to a mental health clinic in the ancient city of Varanasi. In the second section, on education, three different perspectives are offered, those of Sri Aurobindo, Āyurveda and Krishna-murti, and the various chapters deal with the education of children as well as their teachers. The last chapter gives a detailed picture of a radical experiment in 'free progress' education. The third section takes us again to a wide variety of

physical and social settings: youngsters trying to survive Delhi corporate life; old people recovering from the devastation of an earthquake; whole villages fighting the onslaught of modern commercialism on their Himalayan forests; the role of traditional motherhood in bringing up children; the Sikh way of life; and introducing secular spirituality in the Indian army. As a whole, the second volume is testimony to an immense collective goodwill and a strong aspiration for a better, more humane society, for which Indian psychology has many valuable contributions to make.

It may be clear that, though the two volumes of *Foundations of Indian Psychology* stand on their own and can be studied independently, they do belong together: One's understanding of the practical applications of Indian psychology will be immensely enriched by the study of the first volume, which provides the theoretical foundation on which the practices described in the second, are based. Similarly, reading in the second volume how professionals use Indian psychology in their daily work with 'real people' in actual, modern-day settings, offers a much needed concrete body to the theoretical aspects of Indian psychology, which might otherwise run the risk of looking self-centred, speculative, and, indeed, 'theoretical'. So we, as editors of these two volumes, can only hope that you, as their reader, whether you start with the first, or with the second volume, will be inspired to study the other volume as well, for it is bound to complete and enrich the total picture.

Both volumes give, each in their own way, an indication of the treasures that are awaiting us if we take the trouble of exploring psychology from the perspective of the Indian tradition. There is much to learn from the scriptures and practices that are still available in India. There is far more to explore if we follow the methods and acquire the attitude that gave the ancient sages their deep insight into life and human nature, and if we take their path further towards the future. The forward march of humanity has not come to a close; there is much still to be done, and to fulfil our destiny, exploring the outer world objectively is not enough. We also have to explore the possibly greater mysteries of our inner life, and for this further adventure, the Indian tradition provides us with an amazingly solid and sophisticated basis. It would be utter folly not to make use of it. The basic theoretical and methodological foundations of Indian psychology are sound and they have a tremendous potential to enhance the quality and wholesomeness of psychological research and practice. We hope that this book may inspire many others to get involved and take this attempt further.

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The psychological perspectives of our times...

Three shifts of a rhythm

Aster Patel

As one looks within at the 'existential' position of one's being, one discovers that one is living in three distinct shifts in the psychological perspectives of our times. Time-shifts that overlap at moments, seem almost to converge and yet remain distant from reaching the 'totality' they strive for! We shall present these perspectives at some significant points of their own progression, without forcing an attempt to arrive at a comfortable-seeming conclusion!

At this stage of our journey, distinctions are needed to better understand the routes we have to follow to arrive at our destination—a collective destination for man in his effort to understand himself and arrive at his fullest potential of growth.

I

- In the Western tradition, the quest for knowledge has been marked by the Aristotelian classification of the various disciplines—which required that they be pursued in their distinctiveness and isolation one from the other—as the greatest virtue lay in rendering distinct in identity, form and function.

Thus, from the sixteenth century onward, the analytic and reductionist method of enquiry came to the fore in a kind of absolute way—to delve into the secrets of nature and to unravel her operations. And to so recombine their mechanisms as to suit the purposes of man.

- The results arrived at were so stupendous that it came to be believed that this was the method *par excellence* for all investigation, for any pursuit of knowledge.

Not only for the study of natural phenomena, where the success was all too evident, but this was also the method to be applied to the study of psychological and social phenomena—to man and society.

- Its first application to the study of man in modern times took the form of behaviourism, in which personality was seen in terms of the traits of behaviour, which could be the object of observation and interpretation.
- However, the focus shifted, in course of time, to internal subjective

factors with the need to look into causes of abnormal behaviour, which was the work to which Freud devoted himself—and developed the practice of psycho-analysis.

- In order to set right the abnormalities of behaviour, it was found that in bringing to light the causes of such behaviour, a certain ‘integration’ of the personality took place as a consequent result.

This fact of integration of the personality became for Jung, his successor, the most significant line of pursuit. How does integration take place? He arrived at the conclusion that there exists a deep-seated ‘centre’ in human personality, which exercises the function of integrating the disparate elements of the personality by attracting them to itself like a ‘magnet’. He added that he was led to posit the existence of such a centre in personality by the results that could be observed when a cure took place. But that he had personally no direct experience of its existence such as would serve conclusively as evidence. But, he went on to say, that the yogīs in India had a personal experience of it.

- There was no reversal of this perspective of psychology in the West. It came to be accepted that there are deeper levels of consciousness in the human person—other than the observable traits of behaviour—which are subliminal and subconscious, both at an individual dimension and at a racial and archetypal one.
- Our times are witness to this steady stream of exploration which has culminated in the ‘Transpersonal’ seeking for ranges of consciousness that are higher than the ones we habitually possess—in extent, quality and function.
- How far can the analytic and reductionist method go, one that we are accustomed to applying in all our investigations—this is one of the burning questions that loom large on man’s horizon. Has it begun to redefine its contours to seize the greater realities it is confronted with? Can it do so at all? Does man have to look for a new method altogether? Has such a method existed and been practiced, with good result, in other cultures and civilizations? A host of pressing questions form the search-list of these times! And the sense of urgency that accompanies them mounts with the hour!

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- Parallel to this development in the perspective of psychology, the physicist, in applying the analytic and reductionist method to the study of ‘matter’, arrives at radical results, which reverse all previous findings.

He set out to disengage ‘parts’, so as to study them in their distinctiveness and thus arrive at a knowledge of the sum of the parts, in the form of ‘aggregates’.

But he begins to find that the parts do not exist in their separateness—he is in the presence of ‘wholes’ as primary realities, that are organic and dynamic, and are present in each of the ‘parts’ and determine their character and function. Thus creating a structure and inter-linking of the ‘parts’ within the ‘whole’, with the ‘whole’ present in each of the ‘parts’.

- No discovery could have been more revolutionary! One that is irreversible in nature. A new departure in the further quest for knowledge is inevitable. Another ground is laid and to proceed farther, another methodology is needed.

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Two momentous consequences follow:

- If the physicist can discover the presence of ‘wholes’ in his study of matter by an analytic and reductionist method, then a very significant change must already have taken place in the perceiving consciousness of man to enable him to do so.
- Further, this discovery has made it possible for him to create an entirely new range of technology—one by which we live and function today and which brings the world, nay, the universe itself, in a close-knit, web-like formation of a rhythmic and dynamic action. This technology finds itself in a cycle of progressive and accelerated innovation.

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- Consequent to these findings and the resultant technology, the ancient Aristotelian scheme of knowledge of the separateness of disciplines remains altered. Each discipline not only cuts into the edge of many others but none is complete unto itself without the others.
- A new view of the universe expands the horizon. A ‘wholistic’ universe in which the inter-connectedness of structures ‘within the whole’ becomes the very basis of all its functioning. In such a universe, the pathways to knowledge amid the sciences themselves, as also amid the arts, connect, coalesce and mingle in a networking pattern of proximity and reciprocal meanings.
- The scheme of disciplines, in the West today, stands changed—with new nomenclatures reflecting unified and complex lines of endeavour. There is hardly a discipline that does not move into other zones, overlapping territories and giving rise to new disciplines. The ‘body’ is identifiable but the frontiers are fluidic.

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- Man is faced with a serious question of methodology. Is the analytic and reductionist method of enquiry, which has stood him in such good stead so far, able to sustain the journey into these other horizons that open wide their vistas before him? Whether in his study of matter—or, of the human personality? He explores afresh, within his own cultural moorings or in other cultures elsewhere, with which he has today become familiar.
- For the forces that gather momentum day by day with a striking rapidity are of the nature of a wide networking configuration—whether in international dealings, in economic structures, in communication and information, in movements of ideas and cultural interchange, in societal patterns. A sense of a vast web of the collective, as primary reality, prevails!
- The West has come a long way from its early moorings—along a path well explored, till it has been led to a point, which was perhaps the least foreseen!

It thus finds itself ‘perched’ on the experience that India has made of the universe—and the knowledge she has gathered along many routes and the methods that she has experimented with in her long, millennial history.

It is a galvanizing moment in our contemporary times—when the West, sure of its methodology, needing none other for long, triumphant centuries, comes to a kind of standstill! Unsure of how to deal with the ‘wholes’ it has discovered, on the basis of an analytic, reductionist method. The question of a ‘new’ method, another ‘basis’ altogether of methodology is of critical urgency.

It thus looks to other cultures, other civilizations which have made use of other methods—and to see if they correspond to present needs and situations.

- It is in vain, that people speak of a clash of civilizations. What we are living through is a moment of the ‘complementarity’ that cultures offer—or, even of their integration into a greater whole of culture in which mankind can participate and enrich itself. An ‘integrative cycle’ of knowledge and cultures is ours.

II

- What is the perspective in which the Indian spirit has sought knowledge of man, nature and the universe?

The Indian spirit was imbued, since times immemorial, with a sense of three great intuitions:

- Consciousness is the one all-pervasive fact of existence. All that is, is ‘consciousness’. Consciousness self-possessed or cast in forms of

its own substance, to make real to itself its outline of objectivity. The dynamics of this act of creation is inherent in it—and the joy of expressiveness in form of being is its sole purpose. An inalienable absoluteness of joy—the joy of consciousness creating endlessly ‘forms’ from its own substance.

- All experience and knowledge flow from identification with this pervasive fact of conscious existence. To know That—by knowing which all is known.
- The way of knowing That is by a secret identity with It in the immediacy of one’s consciousness. This is the one central way of knowing—by becoming That which is sought to be known. And since all existence is one and consciousness is the all-pervasive reality of this existence, man has only to fathom in himself the secrets of this consciousness and thus unravel the secrets of all existence.
- Thus the entire process of knowledge is a unitary fact and the way of knowing is to energize the consciousness-force in oneself and to become identified with the all-existent, so as to gain knowledge of its contents in their full range and extent.

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- A unique way of knowing—but, surely, the intimacy and certitude with which we know the contents of our conscious being has no parallel with other ways of knowing, which distance themselves from the subject and circle around it. Besides, this unique way of knowing has stood the test of millennia of history. It has been practiced, tested with the utmost scruple of rigour and subtlety, and has found corroboration through long centuries of persistent and arduous effort by a galaxy of individuals of varying types and approaches, who dedicated themselves to its working out and to recording the results obtained.

No method could have been so meticulously experimented with over such an endless period of time as this one; and the confirmation of results arrived at so overwhelming. The method of the natural sciences—the analytic, reductionist one—has not had such a long history of practice.

- Thus the entire quest for experience, lived in consciousness, and the resultant knowledge arrived at, of both content and form, have been pursued essentially in a psychological perspective. A perspective of sounding the depths and ranges of consciousness in oneself and in the universe. And of doing so by a method deeply ‘introspective’, such as a deliberate plunge into the profundities of one’s conscious being implies.
- The being of ‘man’ was thus central to this pursuit. What he is, what he holds secret within him as further possibility of growth in terms of

qualitatively higher levels of consciousness and how he can attain to them? These have always been the three clear goals of the abiding quest that marks the Indian psyche.

- In the light of these findings and the discovery of the truths of such psychological dynamics, it looked at all the structures of life and society. Be they of education and culture and human relationships, or the many sciences and arts of life, or the structures of economy, polity and governance. The ancient Indian psyche built up all these with an eye to the minutest detail and the method of practice—the sense of practice was essential and basic to all the rest—and recorded this knowledge in treatises which exist today, in addition to the living sense of continuity offered by the oral tradition.

Implicit in the creation of these structures was the deep psychological perception that growth to qualitatively higher levels of being was an innate fact of man's existence—both for an individual and for society. The structures followed an evolving pattern, which could serve as steps to make such growth possible—for both the individual and the society. They were created with a sense of evolutionary purpose, which they were there to fulfil.

- What was the psychological understanding of the nature of man? And what were the structures of collective life, which served the purpose of growth?

There are a few essential perceptions that have stood the test of repeated experience through timeworn ages:

1. There are four-fold states of consciousness:
 - *jāgrat*, or the waking state;
 - *svapna*, or the dream-state;
 - *susupti*, or the dreamless state;
 - *turiya*, or the state of *samādhi*, of the states beyond.
2. There are five *koṣas*, or sheaths, in the psychological being of man:
 - the *annamaya*—the food sheath, the body;
 - the *prāṇamaya*—the life sheath, the vital energy;
 - the *manomaya*—the mental sheath, the mind;
 - the *vijñānamaya*—the sheath of knowledge;
 - the *ānandamaya*—the sheath of bliss.
3. Each of these sheaths has, within itself, a range of levels in the quality and action of that formation of energy—from the lesser to the greater, the less conscious to the more conscious.
4. At the core of the being is a luminous centre, radiating joy—the *caitya puruṣa*.
5. The 'mind' itself, though characteristic of the human mould, is only one level of consciousness—and there is an entire gradation of levels superior to it in quality, action and range of possibility.

6. The total sum of energies in the personality is a subtle and complex poise and inter-penetration of the force of *sattva* (harmony), *rajas* (action) and *tamas* (inertia). One or the other can be the more dominant quality, though all are present everywhere. The dominance of a quality can be an evolving factor, making room for the other ones to take its place.
7. From the qualitative nature of the balance of energies that make this equipoise, that give to the individual his innate bent of character and line of spontaneous action, *svabhāva*—will follow the rightful law of his being, his movement towards truth in his characteristic manner of seeking, his *svadharma*. As is the man, so is his path of growth and action in life.
8. The status of being an individual enjoys—the *adhikārbheda*—which is his by 'right' is determined by the quality of consciousness and its range in the total gradation that forms the basis of the personality. The higher the quality, correspondingly will be the status to which he belongs in the hierarchy of beings. Such status is innate and self-existent—it is solely a fact of consciousness.



Among the structures of collective life, which are built into the social existence of an individual, and which offer him the steps of a ladder for his own growth of consciousness, are:

1. The *varṇas*—the four types of actions which the society needs; and which are part of the individual's own law of growth, and are necessarily present in his own existence.
 - There is the *brāhmin*—the seeker after knowledge, who also imparts it to others.
 - The *kṣatriya*—the hero soul, who battles for the right and just and maintains law and order.
 - The *vaiśya*—who creates and produces so that life can continue its exchange of means and to fulfil her needs.
 - The *śūdra*—who works with his hands and feet and puts his body at the service of both the individual and the society.

The human body itself—from the head to the feet—is symbolic of the functions that meet the needs of life. Like elsewhere, here too there is a sense of gradation, of levels of hierarchy that fulfil a just need without laying claim to domination of any kind.

2. The *āśramas*—the four stages of an individual's journey through life. Stages, which are like 'training grounds', as the term '*āśrama*' suggests. For, life is an evolving and enriching process and the psychological needs and the seeking for fulfilment changes with its progression.
 - There is the student period—the *brahmacharya*—in which all energies

are focused on acquiring knowledge. Knowledge of the sciences and the arts, practice of martial skills, body-building, character formation. And learning to serve the teachers, to learn from the example of their lives and personalities.

- There is the *grhasthāśrama*. The period of the householder's life, of making one's place in society, of drinking deep at life's many founts, of marriage and children.
- The stage of *vānaprastha*—when one's duty to society is done, one has relished the richness of life and one withdraws into the forest, into the heart of nature, to draw the essence of all the experience one has had and to share it with others.
- The stage of *sannyāsa*—when even this activity is left behind and there is felt a need to prepare oneself for the journey that lies ahead, from one life to another. So that this movement too might become a conscious one, in awareness of the purpose of this round of many lives that is ours.

Not everyone went through this complete cycle of growth, for many stopped mid-way. But the sense of progression and of discovering the full *rasa* of life and its ultimate fulfilment was built into these structures, by which man and society were given a direction which they could follow if they so chose.

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- But the fundamental psychological perspective in which the ancient Indian placed himself was that of the innate urge of man to transcend himself—to exceed his existing status of consciousness and to reach out to whatever lay ahead of him as a further possibility.

To explore the nature of this urge to transcend himself and the furthest possibilities that this could lead to—this was the unique and abiding interest and preoccupation of the ancient Indian psyche, which remains vibrantly creative to our day.

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- This exploration was pursued along three lines, which formed part of a single quest:
 - First, to understand the human person by a deep and many-sided sounding of the full range of consciousness active in him—from the level of the conscious, and below that threshold, to the levels that lead the individual into circles of his universality; and those that are infinitely superior to his habitual poise, but are accessible to him in their vast transcendence.

- To unravel the dynamics of the normal operations of consciousness—at each of these levels, separately and in their reciprocal interactions—so as to seize hold of the secret springs of these operations that function with such minuteness of an intricate complexity in the totality of all that constitutes the conscious organism of man.
- Having discovered the secret of the dynamics of the operations of consciousness—and having sounded the possibility for each part and element of the psychological being of man to go beyond its existing range or limit to a greater one—the ancients in India set out to discover and experiment with a set of processes that were psycho-physical. These processes could take up either each of these parts in itself or all the parts together in the person taken as a whole, and see if the fact of change and transcendence could not be made a ‘conscious process’, pursued deliberately and by a willed effort at practice, through a sustained endeavour.

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- Thus were created the various *yogic* disciplines—each one often specializing in taking up one significant part of the human personality and entering deep into its complex functioning, re-combining its elements and opening them up to the action of forces of a higher order in order to effectuate changes in its own functioning. Such are the disciplines of *haṭha yoga*, *rāja yoga*, *bhakti yoga*, *karma yoga*, and many others.
- In the millennial history of this endeavour and experimentation, of which neither memory nor history offer an exact record of time, there were also attempts made to look at the personality as a whole. As a complex entity of many essential psychological elements or parts—and discover and experiment with processes that could take up the entire complexity of this psychological structuring and make an attempt to raise the ‘whole’ to a higher level of being and functioning.
- Such processes of growth were embodied in the *Vedas*, its form of *yogic* discipline, that of the *Tāntric* endeavour, the *yoga* set forth in the *Gītā*; and in our times in the lived experience of Shri Ramakrishna and Swami Vivekananda, and in the creation and practice of the ‘Integral Yoga’ by Sri Aurobindo and The Mother.

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- We wish to observe here that this entire effort at the deepest level of exploration into the human psyche, the creation of psychological disciplines on that basis and their continued practice through unrecorded

time is a fact of the utmost significance in human history and for the future possibilities of man.

There is a parallel, of a different order, that draws one's attention. Since the sixteenth century in Europe, man has sought to unravel the secrets of the forces operating in nature and has made use of this knowledge to harness energies in new combinations to put at the service of man. The modern era of technology springs from such an effort.

The knowledge born of the practice of these ancient yogic disciplines—and the modern ones—could well be of inestimable value in creating a new future for man himself. This time, it is not another environment that is in question—but the being of man himself.

- It is equally significant to note that the Indian psyche has, generally speaking, a deep and abiding 'attraction' towards the pursuit of yoga, whichever discipline may be taken up by an individual. This attraction is natural to the flow of his being. Not only as a specialized pursuit to which one's life is dedicated, but all of life in its many aspects, and all the structures that have been created—offer a pathway of 'growth' for man's consciousness. This becomes evident if we carefully observe these structures which form the basis of the life of the collective, and the underlying truths which give body to this culture. Life itself is a yoga—a process of growth and transcendence of the psychological being of man. The paths have been explored, exact processes have been worked out, and there is the corroboration of results arrived at by centuries and centuries of continued practice. No scientific endeavour could ask for more!

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- In present times, Sri Aurobindo and The Mother have created a process of yoga known as the 'Integral Yoga'; and have experimented with it for almost a hundred years now. In their own beings, in the first instance—and then with a growing number of individuals round the world. This experience is gaining ground.

In line with the traditions well worked out in India, they sounded the psychological being of man, identified the essential elements of existing yogic disciplines and unified the path of practice into a core of truth which would gather all the parts and elements of the being along a central axis of process and dynamics. With this central axis identified as a psychological process that is operative in the being, the rich complexity of the process, in its wealth of detail, finds its rightful bearing in the full range of human personality.

The process of 'Integral Yoga' has a bearing not only on the individual in the entire range of his personality—but this range includes the presence

of the collective as a psychological force and reality. The two are mutually inseparable manifestations of the human race in its existential position; and in the entire unfolding of the evolutionary process on earth.

In fact, the process becomes co-terminus with that of an 'accelerated' evolution, which man can pursue consciously—in full awareness of the aim and of the processes of growth that lead to it.

- At the present moment, it is a self-exceeding of the 'mental' consciousness of man—of mind in its habitual operations—that marks our onward advance. An observation that we had occasion to make earlier.

In the ranges of consciousness that lie beyond that of the mind and which man can attain to, there is a nodal level that Sri Aurobindo calls the 'Supermind'.

He experiences it as the level in the scale of evolutionary progression where all dichotomies cease and a consciousness of the 'whole'—with its power of 'whole-willing', 'whole-feeling' and 'whole-action'—become accessible to him in one movement of his being.

A level of consciousness—a supreme grade in the ascension of man—in which the all-pervasive Spirit reveals its secrets in Matter. And Matter reveals itself to us as being none other than the 'body' of the Spirit. Matter made of the Spirit's stuff—an essential 'whole' re-creating itself in the 'parts'.

- A veritable transformation of 'matter' is the aim that the process of 'Integral Yoga' offers to man. A transformation that unravels these great secrets and with the potency of its action, brings about corresponding changes in the psychological being of man, which is rooted in the material base of the 'body'. The changes it effects are far greater than those that technology brings about in his external environment.
- We find that we are coming a full circle in our onward march!

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But a few audacious questions loom ahead. Shall we try to formulate them?

1. Is the method and process of 'Integral Yoga' what contemporary man is looking for—as a means to transcend the mode of action innate to mind and to attain that of the 'supramental' level of consciousness? This knowledge is by 'identity', which can work directly with the 'contents' of consciousness. And since consciousness is the all-pervasive fact of existence, it can eventually work directly with all existence—even with all the forms of matter.
2. What then is the role of the analytic and reductionist method that seizes things from the 'outside', disengages 'parts' to get into the 'core' of matter?

3. Is there visible already—on the horizon—a zone where the ‘subjective’ and the ‘objective’ become one ‘expanse of territory’ and the two methods move into one complex process of being and becoming?

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- The questions are of great audacity—but our times are no ordinary ones! In raising these questions—we are possibly creating a clearing for the future.

III

- The third time-shift is in need of a new rhythm! For it is marked by ruptures but holds also very rich possibilities.

The psychologist in the university circles in India is a soul who ‘wanders’—in search of his moorings! The fact that he is looking for these moorings is, however, of great significance.

- By virtue of an alienated system of education in the country—set up in a different historical time—he is bereft of the psychological heritage to which he is rightfully heir.

He has an inner awareness of this body of knowledge since the cultural patterns, of which he is a part, reflect this in a substantial measure. But, academically, he is nurtured on the perspectives of psychology that have taken shape in the Western world.

If he looks at these ancient streams of experience that India offers, it is more often than not under an implicit compulsion to see them as ‘additional perspectives’ to the ones he has acquired and to force a synthesis of sorts. This is not how true knowledge can be arrived at.

- An attempt at mere juxtaposition does not meet the criteria set by science in its rigour for an experience that needs the test of corroboration.
- An urgent task awaits him. He needs to free himself—by a deep and wide psychological action—of ‘perspectives’ ingrained in him by such education. A putting aside of certain assumptions is called for.

And, then, to immerse himself—almost literally, as in an ocean—in the cumulative energy of the body of experience that India holds and, even more so, in the grain of its practice. This latter fact is of the greatest value, for this gives to any psychologist his own field of direct experimentation.

- Once such an attempt is made, he will be in an authentic position to look afresh at what he has earlier put aside. And to see if these perspectives are complementary or can be integrated into a greater ‘whole’ of both knowledge and method.

- This is a unique responsibility that rests with the Indian psychologist. His innate capacity to sound the depths of the experience of consciousness that India has made is his to avail of. His familiarity with the method and the findings of the West are also there. He is in a position to create a new synthesis in times to come. A synthesis born of a *lived experience* of wholeness...

In sounding these psychological perspectives of our times, we find that they are present in our own conscious beings as so many dimensions—of space, time and history. We, of the third millennium, are no unidimensional beings—and we seem to draw all of the past and the present of mankind into one upward point of the spiral that pushes ahead towards the future... To rise up in one transcending movement that will succeed in crystallizing them into whatever the future holds as Totality...in the fullness of 'integration' such as the present evolutionary moment of the action of the Supermind seems to make possible. An action half-veiled—though palpable in our lives.

An action of our times...fulfilling itself.

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Section 1

Health and healing

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Introduction

It is paradoxical that as we are advancing in technology and performing marvelous feats on various fronts, the threats to health are simultaneously intensifying. As a result, health occupies a central place in the contemporary global social agenda. In recent years, the threats to health have become more complex. Many of the risks are due to human conduct but perceived as something external to our being. The increase in consumerism, production of waste, pollution, environmental degradation, and the epidemic of life-style diseases (for example, coronary heart disease, hypertension and diabetes), job burn-out, poverty, social instability at familial and community levels, and international tension—all appear to be inter-related phenomena. In some crucial ways, they represent a configuration of joint composition that is leading to a global threat. Unfortunately, due to the numerous confusing messages in our environment, we often fail to decipher the most urgent one: that the way we think about ourselves and relate to the broader ecology is central to most of the problems that we face in contemporary life. Combating diseases with medicines, genetic engineering and surgery does help in certain ways, and to that extent we need to value these approaches. However, they also pose newer problems and have limitations as a sustainable approach to life.

Ideas about health and illness are quite old and have received attention in all known civilizations. The notion of a long and healthy life is one that has been cherished by Indian people since antiquity. The Vedic seers sought to live for a hundred years—a life full of vigour and vitality (*jivema śaradaḥ śatam, ādinaḥ syāma śaradaḥ śatam*). Living a meaningful life indeed demands a harmonious intertwining of several factors distributed both within the person and without. The sources of trouble in health (*tapas*), or those of diseases, both physical and psychological (*vyādhi* and *ādhi*), may be located in physiological (*daihika*), supernatural (*daivika*) and physical (*bhautika*) factors. The person and the environment are reciprocally related. Such a conceptualization is grounded in the notion of the three *guṇas*—the shared constituents of materiality (*prakṛti*). Thus, a harmonious balance between the three *guṇas*, rather than emphasis on any one of them, is the key to health.

It is being increasingly realized that health is not merely the absence of illness, but refers to something with certain positive qualities of its own. According to the traditional wisdom of Āyurveda, it is the cheerfulness of Self (*ātman*), sensory processes (*indriya*) and mind (*manas*) that together reflect the state of health

(*svastha*). Thus, when mind, body and spirit are in a harmonious state, one is happy (*prāśnāmendriyamanah svasthāḥ*). Literally speaking, *svastha*, or the state of health, implies a condition in which a person dwells in himself or herself. In other words, the person is an 'auto-locus', or one who is self-regulated. Keeping the whole person in view, Āyurveda takes a position that is similar to what is known in the West as that of mind-body medicine.

The state of health and well-being is contingent upon the orchestration of the physical, mental, social and spiritual aspects of our being. A human being is not a single entity. Instead, s/he is held to be an *āśi puruṣaḥ*, or composite being, in whom all the components coexist and participate in collaboration to facilitate the optimal functioning of the body, enabling it to achieve its goals. Kālidāsa says, '*śarīramādyam khalu dharma-sādhanam*', and Caraka, the great Āyurveda scholar, '*dharmārthakāmamokṣhāṇām ārogyamamulmuttamam*': health is essential for each of the four life goals, viz., *kāma* (pleasure), *artha* (economic activity), *dharma* (the social order) and *mokṣa* (liberation).

Indigenous thought emphasizes psychosomatic balance or equilibrium (*sāmyāvasthā* or *samāyoga*) as the key to health and well-being. Pleasure and pain are results of the kind of association a person has with the world. It has been stated that the *doṣas* (triad of physiological functional elements), *agni* (metabolic energy related to digestion), *mala* (metabolic by-products and excretory function) and gratification of *indriyas* should be in harmony. The joint activity and correlation of time/season, sensory modalities and action can lead to a state of health. Any deviation from a balanced participation of these factors may lead to illness. Further, it is recommended that one follow a moral code of conduct (*sadvṛtta*) that demands a well-organized and balanced life-style. Accordingly, an adequate diet, sleep and control over sexual indulgence (*āhār*, *nidrā* and *brahmacharya*) need to be observed. The human body is treated as self's field of experience, incorporating the distortions and inadequacies of the five primordial elements (*śarīram pañcamahābhūtavikārātmaṁ ātmano bhogayatanam*).

From an Indian perspective, health cannot be fully appreciated as merely a state. It is more like a process of striving and engaging in certain forms of behaviour. Following a regimen that ensures stability through a search for equilibrium amidst change and flux happens to be the key to health and well-being. A lively enjoyment of health despite difficulties and stresses also requires developing a certain degree of tolerance for negative events. Understanding the reality of this world requires searching within and extending the boundaries of the self. We need to discover happiness in the happiness of others. One needs to recognize others as part of one's own being (*ātmanav sarva-bhūteṣu yaḥ paśyati sa paśyati*). Being friendly with everyone offers freedom and peace of mind. Human life is meant for expressing the divine bliss inherent in us. We need a positive approach to discover joy and happiness in life. A holistic approach to health and well-being demands adopting a bio-psycho-social and spiritual perspective.

The Indian view considers a person as consisting of a gross physical body (*sthula deha*), a soul (*jīva*) and a self (*ātman*). Modern sensibility confines itself

to the gross body. The body, sense organs, *manas* (mind) and *buddhi* (intellect) exist for the self, but the self exists for itself and there is no reality beyond it. The *Katha Upaniṣad* states that *manas* is superior to sense organs, *buddhi* is superior to *manas*, self is superior to *buddhi* but there is nothing superior to the self. Here, self refers to the supreme Self—*Brahman*. *Ātman* is considered self-luminous. It is pure, immutable and eternally free. It is witness to the three empirical conditions of wakefulness, dream state, and the state of deep sleep. The realization of the spiritual aspect of one's being paves the way for a major shift in one's identity. The spiritual nature makes it possible to enjoy an inner sense of peace, tranquillity and bliss. Well-being becomes independent of physical or bodily conditions. The applications of *prāṇic* healing, Reiki, and other methods of treatment lend support to some of these assumptions. The Āyurvedic system and *aṣṭāṅga yoga* offer effective interventions for the treatment of illness and restoration of health. The principles and practices in these systems encompass the physical, psychological and spiritual functions of human beings. The scheme of *yama*, *niyama*, *āsana*, *prāṇāyāma*, *pratyāhāra*, *dhyāna*, *dhāraṇā* and *samādhi* is configured not only to establish a harmonious relationship with the environment, but also to strengthen the physical, vital, mental and spiritual functions, thus channelling a person's movement towards the true self.

The chapters in this section elaborate and consolidate various Indian perspectives on health and healing. The first chapter, 'Philosophy of healing in Indian medicine', is a theoretical overview of Āyurveda, in which Kapil Kapoor first points out that in the Indian intellectual traditions, knowledge is an integrated whole, and Āyurveda is a good example of this. The aims of Āyurveda are two-fold—(i) freedom from illness, and (ii) protection of good health through prevention. Kapoor then notes that this science of medicine recognizes that there is a deep connection between the body and the mind, and that for good health, the mind must be at peace with itself. This peace of mind is born of moral cognition and conduct.

In the second chapter, 'Integral psychology: More than a tool for health and happiness', Bijlani argues that yoga should be looked at in a much broader sense, as a way to arrive at a more healthy style of living. In this view, a human being is made up of not only the obvious body, life, mind and intellect, but also the soul that lies behind all these. The soul is the representative of the divine consciousness in the individual and ensures that human beings are dimly aware of something greater, something higher within. Bijlani holds that by making an effort, individuals can bring that greater and higher principle forward and let it direct a greater part of their lives. True and lasting happiness becomes possible when the body, life, mind and intellect are in complete harmony with this divine principle.

In 'Folk wisdom and traditional healing practices: Some lessons for modern psychotherapies', A. K. Dalal notes that a wide range of healers and healing centres, which include temples, *majars*, shrines, local deities etc., can be found in every nook and corner of India. The country has more than half a million traditional healers, and more than 90 per cent of the Indian population use their services at some point in time. Dalal points out that traditional healing is holistic and aims at

the overall well-being of the person, and in most folk practices healers are mediators between the physical and the metaphysical (occult and spiritual). Implicit in folk therapies is the belief that illness is a social problem and not a private affair, and the healer and his/her healing practices are integral to the beliefs and practices of the local communities. Dalal further notes that the efficacy of folk therapies is widely acknowledged and there is mounting empirical evidence showing that they work. Modern psychotherapy can expand its scope by integrating elements of folk traditions.

In his chapter on 'Psychotherapy and Indian thought', Alok Pandey provides a broad overview of the many ways in which Indian psychological concepts and practices can be used in all aspects of counselling and psychiatric care. In general, the Indian view of existence is that of the journey of the divine in a person. All struggles and suffering represent a movement from an infra-rational (animal) existence to a more rational (human) existence, and further towards an even greater supra-rational (divine) existence and an end-state of Truth, Bliss, Peace and Beatitude. This is the human journey: from obscure beginnings in a half-lit animal-human consciousness to an increasingly divine humanity. The counsellor or therapist who can assist us in this journey is but a fellow traveller who has walked ahead of us from a life of relative darkness to a life of increasing Light. Only one who has mastered swimming to a high degree can save the one who is drowning; so is the case with therapy.

In 'Psychotherapy and Integral Yoga Psychology', Michael Miovic explores some of the concerns of clinical psychology with special reference to the areas of overlap between psychotherapy and Sri Aurobindo's model of Integral Yoga Psychology. Miovic utilizes Integral Yoga Psychology as an organizing framework because Sri Aurobindo interpreted yoga as being primarily a *psychological* process of self-cultivation and ego-transformation, and expressed his insights in modern English. Like psychotherapists, Sri Aurobindo was deeply interested in the problem of how to change character structure and behaviour, the only difference being that he felt the key to this change was ultimately spiritual. Miovic notes that Sri Aurobindo developed a complex understanding of human psychology, including concepts of the ego, the importance of childhood development, defence mechanisms, the unconscious, the significance of dreams, resistance, and the importance of biology. However, where Sri Aurobindo diverges from Western psychology and psychiatry is in his spiritual realism. The practical consequence of this is that he recommends that people find their souls *before* trying to work through the unconscious, because the psychic being is a more powerful agent of knowledge and action than the observing ego.

In 'Concept and scope of *pratyāhāra* in the management of mental health', K. M. Tripathi describes how yoga can be conceptualized as a system of self-healing. Tripathi notes that following the technical definition of yoga, derived from Patañjali's *Yoga-Sūtras*, one could consider *vipāssanā*, Transcendental Meditation, and *śavāsana* as techniques of *pratyāhāra*, the control of the senses. The author further points out that through *pratyāhāra*, one can attain complete isolation from

internal as well as external stimuli. Thus, the practice of *pratyāhāra* can help in managing the stresses of personal life and in regaining composure. Tripathi holds that *pratyāhāra* is sense-control, leading to self-control. It is one's sensations, perceptions, notions, imagination, and other mental activities that become the subject matter of study when the mind turns inwards for introspection. Introspection helps in regulating and modulating these mental activities by understanding their nature and field of operation, and is a means of redirecting their energy. Thus, perfection in *pratyāhāra* brings about a deep mental relaxation.

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1

The philosophy of healing in Indian medicine

Kapil Kapoor

Indian medicine is a good example of how knowledge forms an integrated whole in the intellectual traditions. While major philosophical systems provide the theoretical framework for an analysis of disease, its causes and cure, the world-view enshrined in those systems provides the governing philosophy of health and healing. It is also interesting to note that Āyurveda shares some of those theoretical categories with other disciplines such as Aesthetics.¹ In fact, Āyurveda and Art share the common goal of restoring human beings to good health, both moral and physical.²

Āyurveda is a science that enables a man to achieve a full life-span. Good health has to be sustained in order to lead a happy life, and the body has to be freed of the ailments afflicting it. It is towards this end that this system of medicine, with its two aspects of principles and practice, has been established by sages and seers. It has two ends—(i) freedom from illness, and (ii) protection of good health through prevention.³ Caraka and Suśruta are two celebrated proponents of this science, one dealing with medicine in his *Carakasamhitā* and the other with surgery in his *Suśrutasamhitā*.

Texts pertaining to the science of medicine have attested to a history from the 5th century B.C. to modern times and are divided into eight parts—surgery (for bodily pain); illnesses of the throat and above (including ENT); the main body (chest, stomach, heart etc.); drives and obsessions (including nerves); pregnancy to child-care; poisons; constituents/elements of the body (liquids, blood, fat, flesh, bones); and energy (including reproductive functions). *Carakasamhitā* deals comprehensively with all eight and is evidently a text that has emerged at the end of a long tradition of thought.⁴ Caraka describes Āyurveda as the science of a happy and useful life. He classifies the ailments of the body into three types (intrinsic to the body, afflictions from external sources, and those of the mind) and says that all ailments are ultimately rooted in what he calls *prajñāparādha*, some failure of one's discriminating intellect, and argues that to rid oneself of illnesses of the body and mind and sustain good health, one must be or become *sadvṛtta*, a person with affirmative, morally correct cognitions. 'Who remains healthy?', he asks and answers, 'One who eats in moderation and carefully, acts

with discrimination, is not in bondage of the objects of senses, treats every one alike (*samabuddhi*), is truthful, is of forgiving disposition, and always follows what the elders say' (CS, 4.2.46).

Caraka's theory of medicine is wholly embedded in the six principal *darśanas*,⁵ and is founded on the shared conceptions of what constitutes a 'good' life and what the conditions for human happiness are.

Caraka's philosophy and his theory of medicine are based mainly on the Sāṃkhya Yoga framework, although Vaiśeṣika and Nyāya are also drawn upon in the definitions of ontological categories (such as *mana*) (CS, 4.1.16–18). The living human body, its afflictions and their cure form the subject matter of Āyurveda. However, this human body is in its totality much more than just its physical substance—it also comprises the internal organs, their disposition and their functions. This 'totality' is designated by the term *puruṣa*. What constitutes a human being? What forms his totality? This needs to be understood; only then can one study what the ailments are, what part(s) of the body they afflict, what the nature and causes of those afflictions are, and what their cure is. Out of the eight *sthānas*, divisions of *Carakasamhitā*, a whole division, *śarīrasthāna*, is devoted to the human body—its constitution, its parts, its conception and growth in the mother's womb, and its sustenance after birth. The first chapter of this division is devoted to the suffering that afflicts *puruṣa*, the questions of *sukha-duḥkha* and *vedanā*, the causes of suffering and the role of the physician.

As noted above, this exposition is primarily based on the Sāṃkhya Yoga system. *Puruṣa* is defined in terms of the 24 Sāṃkhya ontological primitives—the *tattva* (CS, 4.1.16–38, 63). This entire *puruṣa* is the substratum of suffering. The suffering is three-fold—*ādhidāivika*, *ādhibhautika* and *ādhyātmika*,⁶ or *nija* (engendered in the body), *āgantuka* (received in the body from outside) and *mānasa* (of the mind) in the Caraka framework (CS, 1.11.45). Suffering is produced by a marked conjunction of six factors: failure of the intellect (*dhi*) to discriminate, of the faculty of restraint (*dhṛti*) to restrain, of memory (*smṛti*) in pertinent recall, of unrighteous experience of objects, of senses, or experience that is inimical for the self (*asātmyārtha āgama*) (CS, 4.1.98). It is recognized that suffering has as its substratum both the self (*ātmā*) and the body (*śarīra*) (CS, 4.1.84–85, 136). Mind, *mana*, is of course the cognizer of joy and sorrow⁷ regardless of where it is experienced. Further, suffering is not located in the present alone—it has a past and a future, and therefore the physician treats suffering in its three temporal dimensions (CS, 4.1.86).

Caraka says that *cikitsā*⁸ is of two kinds, symptomatic (*upadhā cikitsā*) and fundamental (*naishathiki cikitsā*) (CS, 4.1.94–97). The first is directed at the attributes of the ailment and is complete when the external symptoms disappear. The second is directed at the ultimate cause(s) of the ailment, which it seeks to eliminate. The ultimate cure for all suffering, both physical and that of the spirit, is stabilizing one's mind in the *sāttvika guṇa* (CS, 4.1.94), freeing oneself from the objects of senses (CS, 4.1.95) and overcoming desire (*trṣṇā*) (CS, 4.1.134). In other words, all *vedanā*, suffering, ceases in the state of *mokṣa*, which is but the *yogic*

state of *citta-vṛtti-nirodha* (*Yogasūtra*, 1.1.2) in which mind, *manas*, with all its *vṛttis*, tendencies of the mind, is under the complete control of the Self. Caraka defines *mokṣa* (CS, 4.1.142) as the dissolution (*viyoga*) of attachment (*sambandha*) with all that binds and, hence, torments the Self. In the next four verses (CS, 4.1.143–146, 154), he lays down the rules of conduct that help to attain this state: seek and serve the good and avoid the bad human beings; be happy in the happiness of others; live a life of restraint and discipline (*niyama*); do your duty without attachment; sustain an evenness of the mind and the intellect; and control the ‘waves’, cognitions, of the mind. These values are ingrained in the ordinary, average Indian mind, which unquestioningly accepts and follows them in the lived life. He sums up these rules—there is no liberation, *mokṣa*, without knowledge. This is right knowledge as it leads to liberation.

This philosophy of health and happiness has over a period of time sedimented into the Indian mind, and programmed it as believing this to be the only means of *ārogya*, a disease-free, state. Āyurveda is the science that deals with life, a life of *ārogya*, freedom from disease, and of good health,⁹ so that one is able to perform one’s enjoined duties and attain the four ends of life—*dharma* (righteousness), *artha* (material ends), *kāma* (desires) and *mokṣa* (freedom of the self from all pursuit). Āyurveda is thus not concerned merely with *āyu*, a long life. It asks, ‘Why must one live a long life, and what kind of a long life should we aspire for?’ Āyurveda is not concerned with ensuring a long life, *dirgha āyu*—it seeks to promote *sukha āyu* and *hitāyu* (CS, 1.1.41), a happy life and a useful life. Caraka defines a happy life as one ‘... free of bodily or mental ailments, able to do all work, endowed with strength and with energy to do [his] duty, possessed of knowledge, able to use and enjoy all his senses, ornamented with virtues, able to fulfil/achieve his tasks, blessed with different *sukha* ...’ (CS, 1.30.23).

And *hitāyu*, useful life, is defined as the life of one:

... who in all his life-time thinks of the well-being of others, considers others’ wealth as *tuccha*, of no consequence, is possessed of acknowledged virtues, *sadguṇa*, such as truth-telling, acts thoughtfully, respects those who are worthy of respect, is indifferent (*udāsīna*) to others, serves devotedly the learned and the aged, controls his passions, is constantly involved in sharing his knowledge, his wealth, sees all beings in his own self, accepts good advice (CS, 1.30.26).

Roga, disease, robs life of both happiness (*sukha*) and usefulness (*hita*). Hence Āyurveda, the science of medicine, enables *cikitsā*, a restoration of the body to its pre-affliction state (CS, 1.16.34). Afflictions are of three kinds, as we noted above, but according to Caraka, it is the third group of ailments, *mānasa vyādhi* (afflictions of mind and spirit), which needs for its treatment *darśana*, philosophy, apart from medicine.

The nature, properties and functions of *manas*, the mind, have been established by Caraka with exactitude and thoroughness with the help of ideas drawn from the six philosophical systems (CS, 1.8.4, 5, 12; 4.1.18–23). Mind is an ontological primitive and has the function of selecting objects for cognitive focus

(*saṅkalpa/vikalpa*). In this sense, the mind is the presiding sensory organ. Its functions are identified as:

1. Grasping/cognizing the sense-object contact;
2. Self-regulation for that knowledge;
3. Analysis of and reflection on cognitions.

After this, the intellect, *buddhi*, takes over. It is the intellect presided over by the self (*ātma*) that programmes the mind to select, control and cognize the sense-object conjunction. Mental ailments have their roots in a deviant programme that sets up extreme, undesirable or inappropriate goals for the mind, which generate, in terms of conduct, acts that Caraka describe as *prajñāparādha* (CS, 4.1.21)—inordinate desire and jealousy (CS, 4.1.102), for example. An inability to get what one desires and a continuing presence of that which one dislikes leads ultimately to illness. Those who are *sāttvika* of disposition, predominantly good (*sattvaguṇa pradhāna*), are not prone to acts, either mental or physical, that violate wise intelligence. Desire and hate are so classified because they harm the one who nurses them more than those towards whom they are directed. As Caraka says elsewhere (CS, 1.7.52), jealousy, grief, fear, anger, pride and rivalry are products of the failure of true intelligence, a failure to see what is bad or good for one's self. *Prajñāparādha* are those volitive acts that are not approved by the intellect (*buddhi*), tolerance faculty (*dhairya*) and memory (*smṛti*). Caraka lists acts (CS, 4.1.103) that may lead to ailments as serious as paralysis—exerting oneself beyond one's capacity, sexual indulgence, abandoning civil behaviour, insulting those worthy of respect, indulging knowingly in wrong-doings, befriending the wrong people, being susceptible to jealousy, fear, anger and greed, indulging in despicable, disgusting acts with one's body—these are all 'crimes of intellect', and show a complete absence of a discriminating faculty (*viveka buddhi*).

These acts are analogous to *vṛttis*, tendencies of the mind. When a person is afflicted by certain ailments, he has to exercise control over his mind. Caraka says:

In all ailments, the responsibility is of a physician, but in the mental ailment, it is the patients' own responsibility. A wise man keeping in mind his own welfare, acts with great care in respect of *dharma*, *artha* and *kāma*. It is these three that are the cause of internal *sukha* or *duḥkha* Such a patient should discipline himself, respect the physician and recognize the truth about himself, the *maryāda* or limits of his family honour and conduct, the nature of time and place and social and economic strength (or weakness) (CS, 1.1.46).

It is said that mental ailments can be cured or removed by cultivating *sadvṛttis*, positive or righteous cognition and attitudes. He should not 'seek his own *sukha* alone ...' (CS 1.8.26). *Sadvṛtti* is the conduct of 'good people' (*sajjana*), those who are at peace, are pure, truthful and guided by righteousness in all their acts. By following their examples, a person regains good health and also conquers his senses. This is considered so crucial for a happy and healthy life that Caraka declares that

he is laying down in detail the *sadvṛttis* (CS 1.8.18–25). A study of these shows that great value is placed on cleanliness of the body and of the mind, generosity of spirit, kindness to others, respect for elders, parents, teachers and guests, restraint in speech and movement, control over one's senses, absence of jealousy, worry and fear, possession of humility, faith in God, devotion to those who excel in learning and the arts, thoughtfulness and carefulness. We have listed only some of the properties upheld by Caraka. The whole list is a comprehensive enumeration of what everyone will agree are the virtues of a pious and good man. Evidently, these *sadvṛttis* are the same as the *daivīsampada* elucidated in The *Bhagavad Gītā* (16.1–3). Four of these—*maitrī*, *karuṇā*, *mudita* and *upekṣā* are mentioned in the *Yogasūtra* as the means of purifying the *citta* (1.33).

The science of medicine thus recognizes the deep connection that exists between the body and the mind, and that to ensure good health, the mind must be at peace with itself. This peace of mind is born of moral cognition and conduct. This thought itself emanates from a world-view that considers control of the self the highest conquest, and a deliverance from the limitations of a narrow self as *mokṣa*, the final state in which all suffering ceases. In rigorously analysing the properties and afflictions of both body and mind, Caraka, the celebrated exponent of Āyurveda, not only draws upon the major philosophical systems, the ontology of Sāṃkhya and the epistemology of Yoga, but also transforms their constructs into practical rules of conduct that will ensure people a long, happy and useful life.

Endnotes

- 1 The categories of *rasa* ('aesthetic experience' and 'chemical or substance') and *ānanda* ('joy' of art, experience and life), for example.
- 2 In fact, plays such as *Prabodhacandrodaya* and *Jīvanāndanam* had actually been composed, one of them as late as the eighteenth century, to dramatize the whole event of falling ill and recovering, ending with the joy or bliss (*ānanda*) that accompanies good health resulting from the cultivation of moral values.
- 3 *Suśrutasamhitā*, 1.12.
- 4 It is said that Caraka, an Afghan resident of Gandhara, the kingdom ruled by Nagnajit, was a contemporary of the great Persian King Daryus (Darius) in the 6th century BC, and a teacher at the University of Taxila.
- 5 In the first chapter of the fourth division of *Carakasamhitā*, in the chapter titled *śarīrasthāna*, Caraka seeks to define *duḥkha*, sorrow, and *vedanā*, suffering, and analyse their causes and their cures. Here, we only note that the vocabulary of his discussion is that of the six systems, *śaḍa-darśana*: *puruṣa*, *prakṛti*, *ātmā*, *buddhi*, *manah*, *indriya*, *bhoga*, *karma*, *bhāva*, *dhṛti*, *smṛti*, *prajñā*, *tṛṣṇa*, *mokṣa*, terms from Sāṃkhya, Yoga, Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika.
- 6 *Sāṃkhyasūtra*.
- 7 See *Vaiśeṣikasūtra*, karikā 85, which is cited as authority.

- 8 *Cikitsā* is a key concept of Indian thought in grammar, philosophy, medicine and art. The word, made up of the prefix *ci-* and the verb root *okit*, followed by the *-san* affix, means 'to systematically act almost as an act of devotion to restore or cure or elevate/purify'.
- 9 It protects and promotes the health of the healthy and cures the ills of the ailing.

Classical texts quoted

Bhagavad Gītā
Carakasamhitā
Yogasūtra

2

Integral psychology: More than a tool for health and happiness

R. L. Bijlani

An integral view of man

In terms of Vedānta, man is the latest, but not the final, product of the process of cosmic evolution. This process of evolution was preceded by extreme involution of the Supreme Consciousness into matter. Then began the process of evolution, characterized by the progressive unmasking of Consciousness in the forms of primitive living organisms, plants, animals and man. Human consciousness is unique in at least two ways. First, it expresses Supreme Consciousness better than forms that evolved earlier. Second, it has evolved to a point where it is possible for man to enhance the expression of Consciousness through his own efforts. This is possible because the faculties of reasoning, judgement and discrimination have developed to a remarkable degree in human beings. Since both natural evolution and human effort can express only what already exists in dormant form, human consciousness has layers that extend beyond what is on the surface. Thus, the total man consists not only of the obvious body, life, mind and intellect, but also of the soul that is behind all these. The soul, or the psychic being, is the representative of the Divine Consciousness in the individual. It is in the nature of earthly manifestation that the Divine Consciousness from which it emanates, and which it incorporates, remains hidden in the background. That is why ordinary life is guided by egoistic impulses and desires. But human beings are dimly aware of something greater, something higher within. By making an effort, they can bring that greater and higher principle forward and let it direct a greater part of life. Genuine and lasting happiness is not possible unless the body, life, mind and intellect are in complete harmony with this Divine principle.

Further, multiplicity and variety are only phenomenal realities. Since the multiple forms are a manifestation of the same Divine, their Divine essence is the same. Hence a common thread unites all forms of manifestation. Therefore, the outer constituents of man are able to achieve harmony with his soul only when

he reckons with the inter-relatedness of individuals. It is not possible for a person to be truly happy while ignoring the happiness of his fellow beings. These larger truths are exemplified to some extent by the rediscovery of the mind-body connection in modern medicine.

Medicine and the mind-body connection

Modern medicine made an unprecedented series of spectacular advances in quick succession in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. As a result of these advances, vaccines became available for the prevention of small pox, diphtheria, tetanus and polio; antibiotics revolutionized the treatment of pneumonia, typhoid and tuberculosis; diabetics could expect a normal and productive life-span; and surgery became safe and painless. Consequently, life expectancy more than doubled, and it seemed only a matter of time before the remaining maladies of mankind would also be wiped out. One common feature of the new tools of medicine was that they were based on the mechanistic model of life. Further, these tools were so powerful that they could act irrespective of the state of the patient's or the doctor's mind.

Towards the middle of the twentieth century, however, modern medicine had a humbling experience. There was an epidemic rise in the incidence of high blood pressure, heart disease, diabetes and cancer. Further, these new killers were not amenable to a simple mechanistic approach. Their causes lay in the modern life-style characterized by eating too much, exercising very little, and a state of perpetual hurry and worry. Since the remedy depends on the cause, there began a search for better life-styles and effective remedies for mental stress. Both these explorations converged on the rediscovery of ancient wisdom traditions such as *yoga*, because they combine superb life-styles and potent prescriptions for mental peace.

In keeping with the spirit of the times, the ancient wisdom was subjected to the scrutiny of scientific studies. Dean Ornish made headlines in 1990 when he found that a life-style intervention based on *yoga* led to an angiographically demonstrable reduction in the narrowing of coronary arteries in patients having heart disease (Ornish, et al., 1990). The significance of his work did not lie merely in establishing the role of *yoga* in the treatment of heart disease. More significant was the fact that there was also a reversal of the underlying disease process, something which was inconceivable in terms of the then prevalent thinking in scientific medicine. Here was evidence for self-healing, stimulated by simple measures dependent on nothing greater than the will-power of the patient, in a chronic degenerative disease. Other studies have revealed a similar capacity for self-healing in a wide variety of diseases; in some exceptional cases, even in cancer (Siegel, 1990).

It is now generally accepted that the mind has the capacity to influence the body in both directions. Negative thoughts and emotions such as hatred, jealousy and hostility increase the risk of disease; and love, compassion and confidence in recovery promote self-healing. Further, basic studies have provided some plausible mechanisms underlying these clinical and epidemiological observations. Stress depresses the immune mechanisms of the body, whereas mental peace is a

potent immuno-enhancer. Effects on immunity have been demonstrated by tests on blood samples, the results of which can be expressed in figures. Such studies form the subject matter of psychoneuroimmunology, which has made phenomenal progress during the last three decades. Thus, psychoneuroimmunology has unwittingly served as a bridge between ancient wisdom and modern medicine.

These developments have engineered a paradigm shift in scientific medicine (Bijlani, 2003). Larry Dossey has postulated that around 1950, we moved from the era of physical medicine into that of mind-body medicine (Dossey, 1993). Mind-body medicine needs a tool for influencing the mind positively. Further, the tool should be effective in adverse circumstances, because the patient is carrying a double burden of anxiety due to the physical illness, and the psychological factors that contributed to the physical illness. It is here that integral psychology proves invaluable.

Integral psychology as a tool in mind-body medicine

A modern psychologist, Richard Carlson, hit the nail on the head when he said that the fundamental source of all stress is the discrepancy between the way things are, and the way we would like them to be (Carlson, 1997, pp. 237–238). To reduce the discrepancy, we have two logical alternatives. First, we may manipulate our environment so that things come closer to the way we would like them to be. Alternatively, we may look at our situation in a different light, so that we start liking things the way they are.

The difficulty with the first approach is that our capacity to change either the people around us or our circumstances is extremely limited. Therefore we invariably have to use, at least partly, the second approach, which is called cognitive restructuring. Now, cognitive restructuring based on rational analysis has limitations, especially in adverse circumstances. No amount of intellectual reasoning may be convincing enough to make the patient view his situation positively. Integral psychology, however, provides an infallible spiritual framework, capable of ensuring lasting inner peace independent of external circumstances. In practice, cognitive restructuring based on integral psychology may be achieved using one out of three graded approaches. The approach used would depend on the degree of opening the patient already has for spiritual growth. Further, all three approaches may be used successively in the same patient.

Surrender to the Divine Will

At least a dim awareness of a power far greater than ourselves is a nearly universal human experience. Further, it is generally acknowledged that, in the ultimate analysis, it is this power that runs the universe. Therefore the events and circumstances of our life, including those we do not like, may be viewed as components of a complex design that embodies the wisdom of the One who runs the universe. Seen in this light, it is easier to not just accept things as they are, but in fact to like them as they are, because they reflect the Supreme Wisdom of the Creator. In

short, we surrender not only to God's Will, but also to His Wisdom. This is a stand that can never fail, because it is beyond any questions or critical evaluation. When the buck has been passed on to God, it cannot be passed any further.

Achieving cognitive restructuring by surrendering to the Divine Will does not require a bright intellect, a deep philosophy, or too much of an opening for spiritual growth. It only needs faith in an invisible supra-physical power, which is generally not an issue because the faith is almost universal.

Purpose of life?

Man has often wondered whether his life has a purpose higher than that of a feeding and breeding animal. As mentioned earlier, human beings are unique in that they have the capacity to express more of the Supreme Consciousness through their own efforts. The result of these efforts is the growth of consciousness, or spiritual growth. In terms of *yoga*, the unique purpose of human existence is spiritual growth. But man is ordinarily so engrossed in the life governed by his ego and desires that he neglects the ultimate goal of life, even if he is aware of it. What shakes him up best and reminds him of the necessity to address the ultimate purpose of life is a traumatic event, a serious illness, or some vexing problem. There can be no better way of looking at misfortune positively than to view it as a trigger for spiritual growth. Its application may be illustrated by two contrasting examples.

Why me, and why now?

The patient might have an incurable illness such as cancer, but he feels he still has so much to do in his profession, or for his family. The patient needs a gentle reminder that while his contributions are important, they are not indispensable. The world will go on, and so will his profession and his family. Running the world is God's business, and we are only his instruments. He has His reasons for discarding or adopting an instrument. Instead of asking why He has chosen me at this juncture for an incurable illness, it is better to thank Him for giving me adequate notice to shift gears. It is His way of telling me that He does not want me to remain totally engrossed in ordinary worldly activities any more. Instead, I should now shift to working for spiritual growth.

I am ready, but why the agony?

The patient might have an incurable illness such as cancer. He is ready to accept that his life is over, and he does not mind dying, but he does not want a prolonged illness. This patient needs to be shown that just because he has retired and his children are all married and settled, the agenda of his life is not over. The most important part of the agenda still remains, and can be addressed best when he is through with his worldly responsibilities, when nobody in the world seems to need him much, and he does not have much strength for physical activity. He should thank God for creating just the right conditions for spiritual growth, and also for providing a trigger in the form of the terminal illness. The knowledge that one has time, but not too much time, is ideal for accelerated spiritual growth. The

degree of spiritual growth that may be achieved by the patient (and sometimes his care-givers) in one year in such circumstances may exceed that which might be achieved in fifty years of a life in which everything seems to be going well.

Beyond happiness

A serious illness may trigger an interest in spiritual growth, as explained above. After the person has made reasonable progress on the spiritual path, he would eventually transcend the very need for happiness, as discussed below.

Implications beyond health and happiness

The implications of integral psychology go beyond health and happiness. Integral psychology promotes self-denial, disinterested performance of duty, universal unconditional love, and total surrender to the Divine. This inner discipline forms the core of *yoga*, the ultimate aim of which is union with the Divine. The health and happiness reaped on the way are fringe benefits of the inner discipline. Health is important, but has its limits. Mental peace achieved through integral psychology promotes physical well-being, but cannot guarantee perpetual health. So long as we have a body, we will have some physical ailments some of the time. What integral psychology ensures is that in spite of a physical ailment, we will not be miserable. During his last illness, Sri Aurobindo's doctor asked him where the trouble was, and whether he could give him some relief. Sri Aurobindo replied, 'Trouble? Nothing troubles me' (Van Vrekhem, 1997, p. 272). The freedom to refuse to be miserable is the one freedom that nobody can take away from us. And integral psychology gives us that freedom by enabling us to look at events in a new light, the light of the soul behind the surface phenomena. In that light, misery becomes a gift from the Divine because of its enormous potential for stimulating spiritual growth. This is a formula that can never fail, against which there is no scope for any argument.

Physical ailments are only one type of problems that we encounter in life. There are several other apparently adverse events and circumstances which may disturb our mental equilibrium. Integral psychology enables us to handle all such situations with spiritual equanimity. The consequences of psychology based on a spiritual philosophy, as integral psychology is, depend on the degree of spiritual growth. Initially it ensures happiness independent of possessions, the fulfilment of desires, and other events and circumstances. But happiness itself is part of a duality—that of happiness and sorrow. Since dualities come as a package deal, even the most event-proof happiness remains a fragile state of mind. The ultimate aim of *yoga*, which uses integral psychology as a tool, is to transcend all dualities. When the gulf between the outer and inner life has been closed, the outer life reflects the self-existent delight of the soul. In this state, happiness itself becomes meaningless. In short, *yoga* is a liberating experience—initially, liberation from dependence on external objects or events for happiness; and finally, liberation from all dualities, including that of happiness and sorrow.

Conclusion

We live in an erratic and unpredictable world. There is apparently no simple formula that connects our actions and their consequences. Bad things seem to happen to good people, and vice versa. Reason is a highly inadequate tool for reconciling with reality in such a world. Integral psychology, which leaves scope for cognitive faculties higher than the intellectual and takes into account a supra-physical ultimate Reality, provides the humbling and reconciling ingredient needed to solve the riddle of the world. Integral psychology is the foundation of *yoga*, which in turn can lead to total liberation from the bondage of dualities. Total liberation (*mokṣa*) may remain a distant dream for most of us. However, the application of integral psychology is not an all or nothing process. The journey towards liberation is itself enjoyable, and offers the universally desired but elusive emotion of happiness. Hence, even a partially successful application of integral psychology in daily life helps to achieve the basic needs of health and happiness.

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3

Folk wisdom and traditional healing practices: Some lessons for modern psychotherapies

Ajit K. Dalal

Introduction

Like in many other traditional cultures, freedom from pain and suffering has been a major preoccupation of Indian society since antiquity. Based on a shared understanding of human nature and the causes of suffering, every society has developed its own healing institutions and practices. The traditional systems so evolved have weathered the vagaries of time, and still thrive in present times on popular support. A wide range of healers and healing centres, which include temples, *majars*, shrines, local deities etc., are found in every nook and corner of the country. The burgeoning crowd which one sees around these places testifies to the fact that their relevance, when it comes to healing the human psyche, has not declined. In his book, *Shamans, Mystics and Doctors* (1982), Kakar has stated that India is a country of healers. There are *shamans*, *gurus*, *ojhās*, *tāntrics*, priests and faith healers, who specialize in dealing with a variety of social and personal problems. The rapid progress in modern medicine has hardly affected the popularity of traditional systems. According to the Fifth Plan Document (1992), India has more than half a million traditional healers. This number, of course, includes all practitioners of alternative medicine. A gross estimate (VHAI, 1991) suggests that more than 90% of the Indian population use these services at some point in time. Thriving on folk wisdom and trusted by the masses, these traditional healing practices are still an enigma for the health scientists. The main objective of this chapter is to examine these healing systems, and highlight the salience of socio-cultural belief systems in triggering a healing mechanism within the suffering individual.

The larger scientific community and modern medicine have remained critical and sceptical of the efficacy of these traditional practices. These are considered pre-scientific, and as practised by primitive and tribal people (Kothari & Mehta, 1988). It is further argued that ignorance and backwardness are primarily responsible for adherence to these non-scientific practices. However, as Watts (1975) contended,

traditional healing practices are called primitive, mystical and esoteric because our education does not prepare us to comprehend their sophistication. The work of Kakar (1982, 2003) and Kleinman (1980, 1988) have shown that most of these traditional practices are deeply entrenched in folk wisdom and sound theories of the mind. These practices provide practical solutions to personal, familial and social problems, and have been integrated within communal life. Despite their popular mass base, not enough work has been done to test the premises of traditional practices in the scientific crucible. There is a crying need to decipher this folk wisdom and traditional knowledge, and examine its import to augment therapeutic services. We need to develop methodologies and the mind-set to learn from this rich heritage.

Folk wisdom is the collective and accumulated knowledge base of a society, and is rooted in experience and practical considerations. Folk wisdom finds expression in proverbs, folklores, legends, poetry, rituals and mythologies. These sources tell us how life problems are created, construed and controlled by the collective efforts of the community. In its struggle to maintain harmony and order, every society attempts to develop an ecologically valid understanding of human nature, and its own theories of suffering and remedial measures (Kleinman, 1988). In many anthropological texts (for example, Mariott, 1955), folk practices are considered part of the little tradition, that is, the beliefs and practices of the masses. *Shamans*, spirits and local deities are all part of it. This is contrasted with the great tradition, characterized by the practices based on classical and philosophical texts, like the *Vedas*, the *Upaniṣads* and the *Gītā*. Here, God is held as the Supreme Self, realized through contemplative meditation and devotional worship. It is a misconception that these two traditions run parallel to each other, and that the little tradition is subscribed to only by the lower classes and castes. The people who subscribe to folk practices come from every strata of society.

In India, the folk wisdom manifested in traditional healing practices is indeed based on complex and cohesive systems of thoughts and beliefs, derived from philosophical texts and scriptures. Not only do folk practices derive their legitimacy from the scriptures, but they have also proven to be effective vehicles in translating the essence of the scriptures into dialects that a common man can follow. Folk beliefs and practices can be considered social representations of the formal texts and practical aspects of the classical theories. Issues such as how folk wisdom and scriptures complement each other, how folk wisdom became distilled and documented in classical texts, and how they feed into social life are, however, contentious. In my view, folk and emancipatory (or scholarly) practices coexisted peacefully, although an undercurrent of mutual mistrust always remained. Of course, due to local influences over the course of history, there have been, on the negative side, distortions, diversions and mutations in folk practices, and improvisations, adaptations and innovations on the positive side. Folk systems have remained responsive to the local needs and expectations.

In recent years, there has been a resurgence of interest in understanding and acknowledging the contributions of these traditional practices in combating

physical and mental illness. The limited success of the biomedical model and modern psychotherapies in the global scenario, as well as their impersonal character and market orientation, have led to widespread discontentment. It is now widely accepted that psychotherapy works in the broader cultural context, which takes into consideration the values and demands of society (O'Hara, 2000). With the increase in stress-borne diseases and disorders, the spotlight is turning increasingly towards the age-old practices and their relevance in the modern world. There is a body of literature that concurs with the intuitive understanding and cultural sensibilities that folk healers show vis-à-vis the working of the human mind, and its potential to alleviate suffering. This chapter explores the characteristic features of these healing practices and will attempt to decipher the way they work. The purpose is to draw parallels between folk practices and modern psychotherapies and identify learning opportunities from ancient wisdom.

Characteristic features of traditional healing practices

Sacred therapies

As mentioned by Kakar (1982, p. 5), one of the distinguishing characteristics of Indian healing practices is the role of the sacred. 'The whole weight of the community's religion, myths and history enters sacred therapy as the therapist proceeds to mobilize strong psychic energies inside and outside the patient ...' The sacred may be evoked in many forms, such as the local versions of Lord Śiva and Hanumān, the spirits of ancestors and demons. Different healing practices use different forms of the sacred, but for most of them, the physical and metaphysical worlds overlap. Deities, demons and spirits are as much part of this physical world as they are of the metaphysical. Folk healing endeavours to preserve harmony between these two worlds.

The sacredness of healing practices is further reinforced by the legends associated with the healer and/or the healing centre. This author surveyed 18 such shrines in U.P. and Rajasthan, famous for their healing powers. Each one of these centres had a story about how that shrine came into existence. It was either a deity who instructed a devotee in a dream, or some paranormal phenomena observed at a particular spot, a miraculous recovery near some enchanted groves, deification of a *sati*, or a boon bestowed on a devotee, endowing him with supernatural powers. These legends of derived powers are recounted with reverence by visitors, who often know these healing stories by heart. There are rituals associated with these legends. For example, in many temples of the mother goddess in eastern U.P., the devotees are expected to offer a fine red cloth with *zari*; or at the Kali temple in Chittor, Rajasthan, patients are supposed to enter the temple on hands and knees. The sacredness of these places is maintained by the priests, *svāmīs*, *fakirs*, *tāntrics* and *gurus* who manage these places. It may also be mentioned here that despite being sacred, many of these healing centres are secular and thronged by believers of different faiths.

Holistic approach

Traditional healing is holistic, and is aimed at the overall well-being of a person. Such well-being takes the body, self and society as part of a larger system which is in the state of dynamic equilibrium. The holistic approach takes into consideration the values, passions, beliefs, social interactions and spiritual orientation of a person in its healing practices.

Traditional healers often intuitively know about the close symbiotic relationship between the mind and the body—that the body does not remain healthy when the mind is sick, and vice versa. A sick and stressed mind sets the conditions for physical ailments to afflict a person, and consequently an ailing body can be treated by altering a person's mental state. In the community, which the healer too is a part of, altering the social and psychological matrix of the suffering person's life is considered integral to the healing process. The healer creates conditions in which physiological processes are connected with altered meanings and patterns of relationships, so that one's social world is linked recursively to one's inner experiences. In the Āyurvedic tradition, which has greatly influenced the folk practices in India, health is a balance achieved among the body humours and the conditions of the external world, mediated through diet and a hierarchy of social relations organized around the norms of purity and pollution (Das, 1974).

Traditional healing focuses on the person, not on the problem. In healing sessions, the problem comes in for merely peripheral attention; the emphasis is on who is suffering. It is people, not 'patients', who are helped to regain their normal functioning.

Thus, although some healing centres and healers specialize in the treatment of particular types of problems, the people who frequent these places often come with a variety of crises, be they physical or mental illnesses, family feuds, losses sustained in business, marital discords, or the wrath of spirits. At the healing centres, treatment for this wide range of problems does not vary significantly. At the Balaji temple in Ayodhya, for example, holy water is the standard treatment for all who come seeking solace.

Healers as diviners

In most folk practices, healers are mediators between the physical and the meta-physical. One can frequently find healers who are known for their ability to host a deity or a spirit, under whose spell they acquire supernatural powers enabling them to control the minds of their visitors and heal them. The healer becomes the medium through whom others can communicate with deities and spirits. They get visions and can dispense favours at will. As diviners, they are presumed to be in direct communication with the supernatural, and to acquire their healing powers through divine grace. They are both feared and revered by the local communities. Of course, they become diviners only when possessed by some spirit. Otherwise they are like any other ordinary person.

These traditional healers often belong to the same clan and subscribe to the same belief system. They are not formally educated in their art, but learn it

through apprenticeship and by assisting their *gurus*. They often inherit their right to practice, and this remains a prerogative of a few families whose members possess special powers to heal. No matter what the background of the healer, they need long years of internal preparation to acquire purity of body and mind. Most healers are not supposed to charge for their services. In fact, it is widely believed that if they charge a fee, their healing powers will disappear. Although the community and the patients are expected to compensate them for their work, most of the healers this author talked to had some other sources of livelihood. They do farming, rear cattle, have small businesses or shops, or teach in schools. They offer a wide range of services, and are consulted on family and community matters. They are fortune-tellers, medicine men, clairvoyants and key informers in the community they serve. However, there seems to be a clear social hierarchy, which determines their status, power and the mode of therapeutic relationship with a suffering person.

Kakar (2003) holds that it is the unquestioned faith in the paranormal powers of the healer that is at the core of positive outcomes. It is a belief in the person of the healer, not his or her conceptual system or specific technique that is of decisive importance in the healing process. Kakar (1982) visited a number of shrines and healers and observed what transpires in the healing sessions. The suffering person often does not understand the rituals in which the healer engages, but the ambience created transports her/him to an altered state. What is of prime importance is the trust and confidence that a healer is capable of instilling in the minds of his clientele. The aura surrounding a healer and his authority is carefully cultivated through stories of miraculous healing.

The tradition of the *guru* as healer is not always consistent with the notion of a diviner. A great deal of healing takes place within the *guru*-disciple paradigm, in which the close relationship with the *guru* is an extension of the parent-child relationship (Kakar, 1991). Neki (1975) has discussed at length the therapeutic value of the *guru-celā* relationship, and of surrender before the *guru*. The healing powers of the *guru* were observed to reside in his or her ability to connect with the disciple's psyche, sending him messages of strength and reassurance. For people seeking redressal for their mundane life problems, glimpses of divinity in the *guru* is an assurance that he can deal with their problems.

Socio-centric treatment

Implicit in all folk therapies is the notion that illness is a social problem, and not a private affair. Social customs, traditions, moral strictures, modes of interaction and role expectations give rise to pathologies, which vary from culture to culture. The sociogenic nature of individual suffering is a widely accepted fact in mental health literature. It seems logical that in the treatment of these illnesses, society should play a larger role. As Kleinman (1988) states, in all Asian cultures the body-self is not a secularized private domain of the individual person but an organic part of the sacred, socio-centric world, a communication system involving exchange with others, including the divine. The person involved in these therapies is seen as

embedded in a social hierarchy and a network of relationships. One's family history, which also includes ancestors, is an important consideration in understanding the problem and deciding upon the treatment modalities.

It is a general observation that traditional healing does not take place in the private chambers of the healers, but quite often as a social activity, held in an open place. People share their problems and consult the healer in full public view. Families and other community members also actively engage in the treatment process. Everybody knows everyone's problem, and helping out the person becomes a participatory venture. An ethos of this kind is ideal for both the social construction of the problem and its remedy, which has the approval and acceptance of the community. These are places where a personal problem is no longer viewed from an egocentric perspective, but from within the larger social framework. Participation in social rituals and the social nature of healing activities helps to relocate the person on a larger social canvas. This shift in focus from the personal to the social is important for relocating the ailing person within the social matrix.

Cultural compatibility

The healer and his/her healing practices are integral to the beliefs and practices of the local communities. The explanatory system that a healer employs is mostly congruous with the thinking of the masses. Evolved over centuries and verified in a countless number of cases, these beliefs concerning pain and suffering are compatible with beliefs about life and the supernatural. The theory of supernatural causation is widely believed and frequently invoked to explain a wide range of events. Healing practices that have evolved around such beliefs thus have a greater acceptability. For example, cutting a *peepal* tree held as sacred, is taboo because that would unsettle the spirits residing in it. In many parts of the country, this transgression is seen as the cause of illness or any other misfortune the perpetrator may be suffering from. The *ojhās* (holy men) are approached to pacify the spirits and thereby alleviate suffering.

How people interpret their illness and mental state is largely determined by society and social relationships. Social attitudes, beliefs, norms, values etc. provide the basis for making sense of the symptoms, etiology and import of the problem. People learn the meaning of social rituals, customs, communications, symbols and metaphors, which help them to understand their social world. The nature and intensity of suffering is often not contingent on events in the physical and social world, but on their social meaning.

How do traditional therapies work?

The efficacy of folk therapies is widely acknowledged and there is mounting empirical evidence showing that they work. Surveys conducted in India show that more than 90% of urban respondents believed that traditional therapies are effective in the treatment of physical and mental illnesses (Purohit, 2002). However, not much is known about how these traditional therapies work, and there

is dearth of empirical work in India that can throw light on the processes and mechanisms underlying healing. In this section, on the basis of available literature and evidence, I have attempted to demystify the healing process. An understanding of how these traditional practices work will make it possible to derive lessons for modern psychotherapy.

One factor that makes conjectures hazardous is that these folk therapies differ in terms of their sophistication and specialization. The cultural diversity of the country has facilitated the growth of diverse systems. It is a daunting task for any social scientist to capture the range and diversity of these healing practices. As Kiev (1965) has noted, differentiation in therapeutic practices are contingent on the advancement of a particular society. In a tribal society, as among the Bhils in south Rajasthan, the healer could be a medicine man, a village elder or a wise man (or all in one), besides being a holy man. While often not ranked high in the caste hierarchy, they are held in high esteem because of their knowledge, expertise and benevolence, and are consulted by all strata of the community. In the arid but more developed zones of Jodhpur and Jaisalmer, the same Bhopas specialize in the treatment of different snake bites.

As discussed elsewhere (Dalal, 1991, 2000; Anand, Srivastava & Dalal, 2001), traditional healing practices primarily deal with the psychological aspects of the problem. No matter what the perceived causes of the problem, be they organic, emotional or social, suffering is viewed as a state of mind, a subjective experience. Healers develop their own psychological theories about the functioning of the human mind, which are implicit in their healing practices. Kakar (1982) has concluded on the basis of an in-depth analysis of traditional healing systems in India that the healing powers reside primarily within a patient's mind, rather than in the tenets of their various faiths and ideologies. It is the tremendous out-pouring and channelling of a patient's emotions and faith, rather than any specific aspect of the healer's personality or method, which seem to be responsible for dramatic cures. Similar observations were made by clinical psychologists Frank and Frank (1991, p. 111) about Western psychotherapies as well, 'The apparent success of healing methods based on different or incompatible ideologies and methods compels the conclusion that the healing power resides in the patient's state of mind, not in the validity of a particular theoretical scheme or technique.' The equal effectiveness of different therapeutic techniques, however, does not imply that they are dispensable (Wampold, 2001). All healers need *some* technique to trigger the healing process. In all the techniques, healing is largely a by-product of the interaction between the healer and the person, particularly the way subliminal messages are received and interpreted.

While discussing what works in folk healing, it should be made clear that not all such healing experiences are emancipatory, nor do they all lead to the elimination of the problem. The practice of *yoga* and meditation may lead to a liberating experience and provide an insight into the ephemeral nature of worldly problems. It is my contention that the healer has no direct power over the disease, but does have the techniques to effect a positive reconstrual of the disease state. Traditional

therapies focus on changing unhealthy patterns of thinking, feeling and behaving, and prepare people to face the vicissitudes of the problems in their social world. At times the actual problem may not go away, but as a consequence of traditional therapy, one may learn to live with it. These therapies soothe the troubled ego of a person. In other words, the therapy may result in (i) symptom relief and (ii) improved functioning. In cases where there are no real cures, symptom relief may still be effected by lowering expectations, while improved functioning is contingent on remodelled patterns of social interaction, for which others in the family have to change as well.

It is my conjecture that folk practitioners know intuitively what works in the healing sessions. Their training and conceptual tools, however, may lead to interpretations and articulations of the process that are different from what a health psychologist would construe. In this section, an attempt is being made to unravel the healing process in traditional practices from a social-psychological perspective.

Subliminal healing messages

Healing takes place primarily in the transaction between the healer and the suffering individual. Whatever the nature of the problem, people experience emotional distress and manifest psychological symptoms of anxiety, fear, withdrawal, dissociation etc. These symptoms impair their physical and mental functioning, making their suffering worse. An experienced healer knows that these people need reassurance. A healer creates an aura of authority over the natural and the supernatural, and reinforces the belief of a sufferer and her/his family that he can control the course of events. Here, the kind of verbal exchange taking place between the two is not what is important, but how effectively the non-verbal messages are put across and received. Healing rituals make extensive use of cultural symbolism to send the healing messages across. These messages, which are subliminally transmitted and not mediated by the conscious mind, are most effective in reassuring the person that things are likely to improve.

The traditional treatment of snake bites is a good case in point. In a large part of Rajasthan, Tejaji's name is synonymous with the treatment of snake bites. Tejaji was a commoner who was once rushing to meet his wife at her father's place. He inadvertently stepped on a snake and hurt it. The snake wanted to bite him, but Tejaji pleaded with it to not do so till he returned after meeting his wife. The snake relented and Tejaji, as promised, returned later and asked the snake to bite him. But the snake changed its mind and refused to bite. Tejaji insisted, however, and the snake reluctantly obliged. Before Tejaji died the snake gave him a boon—that if anyone bitten by a snake was brought to his shrine, s/he would not die.

Since then, over the last three centuries, Tejaji's shrines, located all over Rajasthan, have been frequented by victims of snake-bite. I visited one such place near Jodhpur. In my presence a person bitten by a snake was brought in a semi-conscious state. The Bhopa (snake doctor) made strange gestures and sounds as if invoking some spirit, recited something loudly (which I did not understand), pressed his mouth on the open wound and sucked it. To my amazement the

person sat up after a while and half an hour later, walked back home without assistance. It was an amazing feat and I kept puzzling over what had cured him. I learned much later that more than 80% of the snakes are non-poisonous. So the traditional healer was providing psychological treatment to 80% of the victims, who, if unattended, would have shown all the clinical symptoms of snake-bite. I also learned that even the most poisonous snakes rarely inject sufficient poison for their bite to be fatal. So it could be that the fairly high—but not perfect—success rate of traditional healers simply reflects the percentage of snake-bite victims who would have recovered in any case, a percentage perhaps increased by those cases where sufficient poison could be sucked out. Whether this purely physical explanation is all there is to their intervention is, however, difficult to say. How such healing might take place is not clear. One possibility is that it happens through subliminal messages.

It is still not clearly known how such subliminal messages are exchanged. These messages are communicated through cultural symbols, legends and myths, which arouse positive emotions that have the power to heal. These may exert a powerful influence on the person, as their effect is enhanced by an aura created by the healer. These messages are received and processed by the unconscious mind. In an article published in *Lancet*, Evans and Richardson (1988) have shown that positive suggestions made to an anaesthetized patient in the operating room lead not only to less discomfort after surgery, but also to an early discharge from the hospital. There is much work to suggest that subliminal messages bring about a change in attitudes and emotions. Audio-tapes with subliminal messages that claim to facilitate self-healing are frequently available in the market (Galbraith and Barton, 1990).

Broadening the domain of experience

Folk healing aims to help people move away from too narrow and myopic a view of their problems and experience the larger social and metaphysical reality. The healing process connects people with their past and their future, with the living and the dead, with the demon and the divine, to broaden their range of experience. Various rituals and ceremonies solicit the indulgence of ancestors and departed relations, who are considered part of the wider support group. People develop a sense of belonging to a larger cross-section and learn to situate their problems in the broader social matrix.

Healing thus facilitates the process of becoming a social being from an individual in the face of any crisis. Healing centres are places of intense social activity where people learn to deal with their problems in newer ways. The crisis becomes an opportunity to fully integrate the person into the social mainstream. The imposition of social meaning on one's illness and exposure to cultural symbolism brings the person face-to-face with others in society; and participation in healing rituals implies that the person is accepted as an equal by those who matter in the community. Healing occurs through a broadening of the network of relationships (Kapoor, 2003). Community healing marks the transition of a person's identity

from the personal to the social. People develop feelings of responsibility, competence and inter-dependence, and are reassured knowing that they are not alone, that their predicament is not unique.

How such broadening of experiences occur is well-illustrated in a story from the Buddhist literature. This is the story of a mother who had lost her young son and was very miserable. She approached the Buddha and implored him to relieve her of her pain and agony by bringing her dead son back to life. The Buddha told her that before her pain could be taken away, she would have to perform one task. She would have to get a bowl of rice from a house where nobody had died. The woman went from door to door throughout the village to find such a household. Several days later she came back, a changed person. She had been unable to locate any such household. In fact, the more doors she knocked at, the more stories she heard of death and despair. Finally, she emerged from the confines of her private pain and realized that no one is free from suffering, a realization that assuaged her pain.

Re-patterning of affective relations

All healers know from experience that emotions can be destructive, and that once emotions follow a predictable, self-destructive path, suffering can become chronic. Folk healing thus endeavours to break this unhealthy pattern of emotions. A re-patterning of affective relations may follow different tracks. One redefines one's relationship with the self, family and the social network—from very personal to role-specific, from spontaneous to functional modes of affective relationships. Another track could entail changing from idiosyncratic conflicts and defences into conventional conflicts and ritualized symptoms that are socially acceptable. In doing so, one develops a sense of sharing and togetherness. *Shamans* often provide a kind of corrective emotional experience that leads to a re-patterning of ego-defences; what health psychologists would call 'curative insights'.

Most healing encounters are of an affective nature. These encounters make people realize their vulnerabilities and give them a chance to openly vent out their pent up feelings. In his vast clinical experience, Siegel (1991) observed that when you externalize your feelings, you heal internally. Anger, anxiety, depression, fear and many other debilitating feelings are unhealthy only if they remain buried inside, unexpressed and not dealt with. When one goes beyond one's surface emotions and begins to acknowledge one's deeper fears, one can break through the resentments and disappointments one holds, and therein begins the process of genuine healing. Expressing one's pent-up emotions, particularly deep-rooted anger, was found to be therapeutic. It helped to cleanse the system of its negativity, as was found in a case study (Anand, 2004). In the healing process, people experience new emotions, a process that changes their way of experiencing tragedy. Such a re-patterning of emotions is often followed by a change in social relationships as well. Change in emotions thus leads to more adaptive behavioural patterns, and imbues the person with the social maturity required to handle social and moral demands.

Institutionalized catharsis

Traditional village societies in India impose many restrictions on an individual's conduct. The suppression of individual desires and emphasis on role appropriate behaviour leaves little scope for the fulfilment of one's innermost desires. Poverty, mistrust, exploitation and dehumanizing life conditions result in the accumulation of pent-up emotions. Trapped in this social quagmire, many women look for legitimate channels through which to bring out their repressed feelings. Traditional societies that impose restrictions on the expression of emotions have also invented socially accepted ways to externalize emotions.

Maliamma's temple is a classic example of a healing institution born out of this Indian ethos. Located in coastal Andhra, it is the temple of a local deity called Maliamma. The daughter of a poor fisherman, Maliamma was married young and lived with her husband's family. She was tortured by her in-laws, who eventually threw her out of their house. Dejected and with nowhere to go, she returned to her father, who then wanted to get her remarried to an elderly man for a paltry sum of money. Maliamma refused, did not eat anything for weeks, and eventually died. Before her death, she was presumed to have acquired some healing powers, and it is believed that she actually healed some people. So a temple was built in her name in the village. Every year, on her death anniversary, only women are allowed inside the temple premises. A large number of women from neighbouring regions assemble and stay there the whole night. Possessed by the spirit of the deity, they shout, cry, run around, get hysterical, and do anything they wish. After returning home the next day a large number of them report psychological relief (they feel lighter, mentally free, less tense), apart from some kind of amelioration from their chronic ailments.

That this is not an exceptional case is evident from a large number of healing centres located in the hinterlands of U.P. Here, too, the social ethos is no different. Due to their low status in the family and the suppression that they are subjected to, a large number of women, unable to bear it any longer, develop conversion hysteria. The woman suddenly turns violent, indecent and abusive, and her behaviour is attributed to a spirit that possesses her, for which she is not to be blamed. No one in the family takes offence at her behaviour and during the healing sessions, she is permitted to give full vent to her feelings, which are interpreted as being brought on by the evil spirit. Once the spirit is driven out and she recovers, her behaviour during the spell is ignored, or just laughed away. Fearing a relapse, the family is now more considerate towards her.

Creating positive imageries

The success of any healing centre lies in creating strong imageries of health, well-being and prosperity. Through aroma, chanting, drumming and symbols, an ambience conducive to the evocation of some familiar imageries associated with strength and security is created. Stories of miraculous recoveries from a disease or disability are told and retold to sustain imageries of hope and optimism. These imageries are often not of the kind found in *yoga* and meditation, but relate to

the mundane world and its objects. In a Śiva temple in Varanasi, the devotees are made to believe that on the day of the full moon, Lord Śiva will open his third eye to heal their paralysed limbs and set them right. Many safe and effective techniques are evolved and intricately integrated within the healing rituals to evoke cultural imageries of well-being. Such imageries are powerful tools, and can bring about a desired change in attitudes and expectations from healing encounters.

The fact that imageries can cause physiological changes needs no hard evidence. The very image of a ripe mango can make one's mouth water. The impact of imageries (or imagination) on physiological processes as varied as respiration, blood pressure, heart rate, muscle tension, bowel movement, salivation etc. is something most people are familiar with. Imageries can bring about major changes in the functioning of the autonomic nervous system. In recent times, visualization has been used as a powerful tool in the treatment of varied diseases, even cancer (Sheikh, Kunzendorf & Sheikh, 1989).

Traditional healers master the art of heightening people's suggestibility through inducing particular imageries and healing messages. During healing sessions, the Bhopas of Rajasthan beat their drums and everyone joins in a circular two-stepped hopping dance. The rhythm of the drum synchronizes with the dance steps to create a kinaesthetic experience for both the Bhopas and their believers. This is presumed to invoke the spirit of benevolent ancestors who can bestow health and happiness. There are many other techniques used by folk practitioners to alter states of mind, such as chanting, slow breathing, rhythmic dancing, fasting, sensory and social isolation etc. This serves to lull the conscious mind, rendering the unconscious more receptive to the positive imageries induced by the healer. Other ways of creating desired imageries and mind-sets work through achieving a trance-like state. Healers in many parts of the country enter an altered state of consciousness through elaborate preparation and rituals, till they are supposed to be possessed by some divine spirit. In that state, the *shamans* and healers are presumed to be in direct communication with various deities, demons, spirits and gods. They exhibit bizarre yet familiar behaviour, which has symbolic meaning and transports the audience to a world of paranormal visions and experiences. How these techniques actually work is still an enigma to the scientific community.

Treating family and community

Most traditional healers know from personal experience that treating the person is not enough. Unless the family and the community to which the person belongs change, any improvement in his or her mental health would be short-lived. The problems with which people come to a healer often have their genesis in unhealthy social relationships. It is therefore imperative that all concerned parties participate in the healing process.

In the case of hysterical outbursts, as we observed at one healing centre, what is gratifying for the women is that suddenly the whole family wakes up to their existence and becomes concerned about their needs and welfare. Many women report that after their recovery, no one in the family ill-treats them for fear of

Bālājī (the monkey god). The family members and other relatives who participate in the healing rituals, many of which take place in their homes, are directed to bring about a change in their own attitudes. Most of these activities are planned, keeping in mind the clientele and their specific needs.

Take the example of parents whose children are afflicted with a major disease or disability. As parents, they suffer silently and need reassurance that things will improve. The Avari Mātā temple in south Rajasthan has been flourishing for the last four decades as a healing centre for polio and paralysis. The suddenness of the attack and incapacitation of the patient scares and confuses the family. Taking it as a sign of the wrath of the mother goddess and finding medical treatment ineffective, many of them are rushed to this temple when struck by the disease. Situated on a hilly terrain with a quiet river flowing past, this place forms an ideal location for an outing. The patients, who arrive with family members, camp here for several days. When I visited that place, I found a festive atmosphere all around, with people sitting in small groups and chatting, singing *bhajans*, or feasting by the riverside. A good deal of sharing and exchange of information resulted in their fears and anxieties to take a back seat. They knew they were not alone in their tragic predicament; in fact, there were people who were worse-off than them. There was an air of expectancy concerning the outcome; many stories of miraculous healing were already doing the rounds. All this not only helps to overcome the initial shock, but also creates a mental state that is conducive to physical recovery.

Towards developing relevant psychotherapies

The efficacy of folk healing remains a puzzle and is often doubted by health professionals, scientists and rationalists, who attribute their success to the placebo effect. At present we do not have the conceptual and methodological tools to establish a causal connection between folk healing practices and the well-being of the targeted person. Critics of Western psychotherapies and biomedicine have also not ruled out the placebo effect behind the claims of success of these therapies. The placebo effect provides strong evidence of the power of the mind to heal. Beecher (1955), who coined the term 'placebo effect', emphatically argues with supportive evidence that about 35% of the patients improve after treatment, regardless of the type of treatment. Kiev (1965) and Wampold (2001) also report similar findings. In recent times, the APA Monitor has prominently featured a research study showing that the active ingredient in the treatment of 225 depressed people was the clients' active participation, and the strength and duration of the therapeutic bond between the therapist and the client (APA Monitor, 1996). O'Hara (2000) concludes on the basis of an extensive review that psychotherapies are effective only when they are compatible with the value system of the society.

As evidence shows, there is an element of universality among all traditional healing practices, even though they may have evolved independently of each other. They aim to change the way people construe their world. Modern psychotherapies also work towards that end. Modern psychotherapies, though, are facing

a crisis today, and serious questions are being raised about their efficacy in managing mental health problems. The discontentment is evident from the fact that more than one-third of their clientele is now turning towards alternative therapies not covered by insurance policies. Modern psychotherapies are going through a crisis of identity and a debate is raging on about their goals, philosophy and moral vision (VandenBos, 1996). Transpersonal and humanistic psychotherapies, which had remained on the margins for the better part of the last century, are now becoming popular. There is a renewed interest in religion and spirituality and their role in the psychotherapeutic process (Miller and Thoresen, 2003). Traditional healing therapies in India have much to contribute to this end. The rich knowledge and techniques employed in traditional therapies to bring about an attitude change can provide new insights that can be used to evolve more relevant psychotherapies.

Modern psychotherapies have very limited application in India. There is one psychotherapist per half million people. Obviously, these services are highly inadequate in managing the massive mental health problems in India. Mutual learning and sharing of knowledge between these diverse perspectives can significantly enhance our ability to alleviate the suffering of people. For this, we need a new conceptual framework, which can integrate the finer elements of these seemingly diverse systems. Many positive developments have indeed been taking place in this direction. As Vishwanathan (1998) writes in his article in *Science*, Indian society celebrates diversities and contradictions, and has the tradition and resilience to absorb new systems and practices. There is real hope that a new form of psychotherapy will emerge in India, which will also be useful in the contemporary world.

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4

Psychotherapy and Indian thought

Alok Pandey

Introduction

Human thought has been preoccupied with the problem of suffering and pain since man became conscious of himself as more than just another struggling animal upon this charming and dangerous earth. Of course, this is not the whole of his evolutionary story. The greater part of his struggle has been to evolve a thinking creature out of the mud, to evolve a rational being out of the animal nature imprisoned by the sense-mind, even a spiritual person who lurks as a vague hint of light behind his familiar surface comprising of turbulent emotions, desires and passions. Still, a part of his evolutionary journey can be written as an attempt to overcome various forms of possible suffering and pain.

This move to conquer or contain suffering has taken two basic forms or approaches. One regards suffering as an inevitable and even natural state of living beings, with life being presented as a constant struggle for survival. Happiness is not intrinsically ingrained in human nature and is something that has to be acquired from the outside, although the urge to seek happiness is part of the human constitution. Here, relief from suffering and its alteration into some form of joy has to be a double approach: first, the eradication of pain through physical and psychological means, and second, the acquiring of happiness through largely external means. The other approach regards some form of joy or bliss as the natural endowment of humanity, even as the very basis of creation, and pain as a temporary imposition. This approach uses both inner and outer means to get rid of pain, but insists that true happiness can only be found in one's own depths. The first approach has led to a multiplication of outer technology and methods to overcome physical and psychological suffering. The other has led man towards inner mastery, through *yoga* and such other inner means. While the first approach is generally associated with the Western outlook on life, the second is usually regarded as Eastern or, more specifically, Indian. However, this is only a generalization. A dispassionate look will show both approaches existing simultaneously across the globe at every point in time, the relative stress on each notwithstanding. For the modern mind, though, the Western world is associated with the advancement of material technology, while in the present era

most inner approaches are associated with the Indian subcontinent, which still continues to shed an authoritative light on inner means.

The two approaches

Let us take a closer look at these two approaches with special regard to their relevance to psychotherapeutic methods. If psychotherapy is the science of changing the psychological patterns that give rise to mental distress and disorder, it must base itself on the most complete knowledge and understanding of what a human being is and can become. Much of psychotherapy is, however, based on what a human being was, either in his remote and hoary past (a pack of animals that could speak and think, as some would say) or in his more recent yesteryears of infancy and childhood. Through tracing the roots of present problems to the past, it tries to put a corrective by setting things right there. Although the principle sounds good in its own right, it has two fundamental problems. The first has to do with defining the past itself. In other words, how far back does our past go? The second problem concerns the future. Is the goal of psychotherapy to return the client to his past (when he was healthy) or to what has been till now his maximum possibility; or is it to utilize his crisis to enable an inner evolutionary journey towards a more meaningful future—that is, using the crisis as a learning experience for growth and progress? It is here that we come across the divergent world-views of people and their goals, destinies and scope, views that even provide a different understanding of the past and the future. These can be broadly divided into two main categories (at the risk of over-simplification for the sake of easier comprehension):

- Man is a creature of mud formed by a process of chance evolution. He is essentially a physical, or perhaps a chemical, being. Psychologically, he is nothing more than an erstwhile animal or worm that has somehow managed to form itself through a series of random and accidental mutations. There is no essential goal or purpose to his life except to struggle and survive as other creatures do, and this tussle between his individual instinct to save himself and the social or collective instinct to save others is the source of his inner conflict. The crude animal is his past, the refined animal his maximum scope.
- Juxtaposed to this, and somewhat of a contrast, is the other view, which holds man as a creature of heaven fallen here upon earth, and high and sublime in both origin and parentage. Psychologically, he is a soul, a miniature divinity shut in the prison house of matter, seeking release and escape. His goal and purpose is to find his true and spiritual self. Animal in nature but divine in essence, he is a cross between the two, and that is the secret of his difficulty and conflict. The animal nature is the trap; in freedom from this trap lies his hope of salvation.

As we can see, so different are these two views, so disparate their understanding,

that it becomes nearly impossible to think of a reconciling synthesis. They have existed side by side in each civilization and culture in one form or the other, but without any reconciling station. There have been some compromises, such as the one attempted by Descartes himself, giving each idea its scope in its own domain. Sometimes their fortunes fluctuated. The sophists of old, the later-day positivists and the modern materialists try and explain everything on the basis of our material sense-perception and the struggle of animal life, denying every other experience as hallucination or poetic imagination. Equally strong has been the rejection of material life as a vanity, a delusion and nightmare of the soul, by the anchorites and the ascetics.

The evolutionary aim of life

The aim of psychotherapeutic processes is the relief of psychological distress in the individual. Of course, with the emergence of the field of psychosomatics and the recognition of the role played by the mind in physical illnesses, a variety of psychological methods (bio-feedback, for instance) are being used as adjuncts in the management of physical illnesses as well, especially in the case of chronic pain syndrome. The processes involved in the Western model are to do with strengthening the ego, exchanging immature with mature defences, enhancing assertiveness and other survival strategies, increasing adaptability to change, and coping with stress. All these means have evolved essentially from the view of man as an animal who is here for an adaptive survival. The emphasis is on making the body fit, the life impulse healthy and the mind more 'mature' in dealing with the problems of life. Of course, some of the later models, like the humanistic and the transpersonal, which draw heavily from the Eastern philosophies, include strengthening the social and spiritual aspects of health. Still, the stress remains on equipping man for survival and coping with stress. In fact, the overwhelming attention on stress is because it has been found that in physical diseases, stress can be counterproductive to survival when it escalates beyond a point. Needless to say, this is a purely material view, and even though some of the strategies to cope with stress may be superficially beneficial, they may not necessarily be the right strategies from a deeper evolutionary perspective.

What is this deeper perspective? Interestingly, both the traditional Eastern and the modern Western approach converge on one point—that an evolution is taking place behind and through all these processes of Nature. Yet, there is an essential difference, in that the material view of life regards nature as a mechanical, unconscious process with no essential purpose or aim. Whatever evolution we observe (and that is an undisputed fact where material science is concerned) is at the outer level, an evolution of forms governed by pure chance and accident. However, the Indian perspective essentially considers an evolution of the soul, which continues through many cycles of life, changing form one after another, till it reaches perfection. In this view, nature is conscious in its depths, an intelligent force that has a teleological basis. The purpose is not so much material survival (as

that has only a secondary value), as a growing perfection of the soul embodying the material case. Interestingly, a deeper observation of the living world clearly points towards the existence of an intelligent force behind even the smallest of cells and the simplest of living organisms. Even the most modern findings in physics point in this direction, which we still fail to acknowledge despite it being self-evident. Is it because this would necessitate a radical shift in our self-view and world-view, which in turn would generate the stress of readjustment? Nevertheless, the Indian perspective has always recognized this evolutionary imperative, and holds that man can consciously participate in it by facilitating and accelerating it.

Thus, the aim of counselling, the processes used, and even the nature of what is considered a malady is different in the two approaches. In the materialistic system, psychological movements like anger, sexuality, attachment and greed are not regarded as abnormal, so long as they are kept within reasonable limits. Even anxiety and fear are regarded as adaptive so long as they do not become counter-productive. In the Indian perspective, however, these are to be conquered for the soul to reach perfection. The aim of psychotherapeutic counselling is therefore not merely to strengthen and assist survival and provide stress-busting strategies, but even more importantly to assist in the soul's evolutionary journey. It is against this background that we can consider some of the strategies and solutions offered to counteract psychological and other forms of human suffering.

The negative *Māyāvādin* solution to psychological suffering

There has generally been a tendency to attach the term 'Indian thought' to a process that tries to solve a problem by a radical cutting of the knot of pain, rather than by untying it. This view of the *māyāvādin* and the illusionist rejects the problem by labelling it as non-existent, a fever and malady of the soul, which can be cured by abolishing the world along with the problem. The solution therefore poses a greater problem for those left behind, the cure being radical enough to fell the body along with the disease. All life is summarily dismissed as a painful illusion, and escape from it, the sole remedy. From its radical and extreme perspective, birth itself is seen as an illness, the grandsire of all illnesses, and human life a supreme opportunity to escape from this cycle of birth and death and all that lies in between. According to this view, some form of psychological suffering will remain so long as one chooses to be born on the earth. The reasons attributed to this suffering may be different in different doctrines. Some blame it on the past, not on the individual past of this life alone, but those of other lives as well. Others, taking mercy on the poor soul (which they consider a learner and therefore prone to stumble and fall on its heroic journey), blame the root cause of suffering on a larger, cosmic principle of Ignorance, *avidyā*. It is this child of *māyā* that clouds the soul and keeps it enslaved to Ignorance, leading naturally to suffering. Still others speak of the cosmic principle of desire as the source of all misery, and cessation of desire as leading to a state of blissful calm and freedom, or *nirvāṇa*. In these conceptions suffering refers not only to the conscious suffering experienced by

the mind, but to a deeper, unconscious and greater suffering experienced by the soul because it is trapped in this meaningless world of Ignorance. Yet so long as the soul chooses to be part of this *avidyā*, it will continue to suffer in some way.

The task of a counsellor subscribing to these views is to awaken the soul from its earthly nightmare by reminding it of its essential nature. The only solution is to cease from birth. Conscious suffering is used only as a strong point of support, a lever to develop *vairāgya*, a state of detached indifference towards life and world, leading thereby to non-affliction. It is a kind of desensitization or de-addiction programme for our world-addiction and craving for material happiness, which brings much suffering in its wake.

In actual practice, however, one does not take this extreme approach. The client's mind is led through a cognitive framework, starting from his present crisis, to reveal the transient rather than the illusory nature of this world and all its events. The mind is made to note the utter impermanence of things; the wealth, position and fame, family and children, fortune and misfortune, are all too little to grieve for. The believer adds that the only thing worthy in life is that which is eternal and imperishable—the soul in man and the Divine above; some combine these individual and universal aspects of the Divine into a single formula—the *Brahman*. Here, a common misconception needs to be clarified. Some modern writers tend to use the word *Brahman* as interchangeable with the later *Paurāṇika* deity *Brahmā*, the progenitor of our world. *Brahman* is no particular god, although all gods, and everything else originates from It. *Brahman* is the stable, unchanging and eternal basis of all existence. Even if all creation, including the trinity of the gods, is dissolved, *Brahman* would still remain, as untouched as ever. One of the principal *Upaniṣads*, the *Kena*, describes through the sublime poetry characteristic of that period, how everything originates from *Brahman*, and therefore That alone is the object of our pursuit—*tadeva brahma tvam viddhi, nedaṃ yadidaṃ upāśate*, Know That to be the *Brahman*—and not this that men follow after here. Another *Upaniṣad*, the *Kaṭha*, describes through a beautiful verse the transient nature of worldly goods, attachment to which brings only grief and suffering and, at the end, death. Death, in these beautiful passages, lauds Naciketas, the young aspirant, for his choice of *śreyas*, the true good of the soul, over *preyas*, the momentarily pleasant and transient worldly good. Thus, through examples and narratives drawn from the everyday life of the client, the crisis he has faced and passed through, as well as from the cultural context, the person is gradually led away from psychological suffering and helped to focus his attention within, towards the true and ultimate goal. Even the first step is considered good enough, since by impressing upon the mind the concept of transience and impermanence, the client is able to detach himself from his malady and feel lighter and freer.

However, one may proceed a step further, depending upon the readiness of the client. One may, for example, help the person view the problem more objectively, since he would now be detached from its emotional effects. A certain distancing always helps us see better and understand the situation more clearly. This impermanence, far from being a cause of grief, becomes a positive thing,

since it also means that grief and unhappiness, tragedy and suffering are not an eternal damnation or a permanent doom. They are only a temporary setback, an inevitable learning experience for the soul in its sojourn over one or several lives. Through pleasure and pain, happiness and grief, success and failure, the march goes on. The journey of the soul does not end at temporary halting points, but goes on and will go on till one has reached the goal.

Common to all *Vedāntic* systems is the belief that this world is not what it seems to be, and that our values have been misplaced due to the mind's conditioning through centuries of evolution (and a series of births and rebirths). The psychotherapist corrects this cognitive error through a dialectic process involving thought, utilizing the person's experiences to demonstrate this. But there is also a later divergence, which lies in the goal placed before the soul after it has thus disengaged itself and is able to look at the problem and enigma of human life and its events dispassionately. Useful as this is for certain problems, it has its own drawbacks. First, it presumes a certain degree of intellectual development, although perhaps less than is required to understand the complex dynamics of the classical Western models of psychotherapy. Compared to that, it is much more direct and close to the person's experience. However, it does require a forceful mind on the part of the therapist, who should be able to logically lead the person from the events at the surface to the deeper phenomenon, and from the apparent to the real. There is a second and even more serious difficulty. According to the system itself, most souls are trapped in the snare of worldly *māyā*. So how can the blind lead the blind or the trapped rescue the trapped? The average graduate in medicine, opting for psychiatry as a field, is not interested in the high philosophy of life or its ultimate goal. He, like everyone else, the client included, is caught in his own nightmares and delusions. Even if he were to undergo some course, it would serve no purpose unless he was himself convinced, either through an innate sensitivity or through a deeper and calmer outlook, awakened through life experiences. This imposes a serious limitation on who is really qualified to administer this form of counselling. It is evident that outer degrees and qualifications, even a crash course in some *Vedāntic* school, is of little value here. Only that which has been lived through is convincing; the rest is only superficial and cannot bring about an inner and radical change. Third, the solution, if taken to its logical extreme, may induce total indifference towards the world. While this may be appreciated by certain extremist schools, the seers who propounded this thought were careful enough to not create confusion in the minds of the average person. An over-emphasis on this other-worldliness may well lead to inertia, justified under the holy name of *vairāgya*. One often finds such escapists who have joined the *nirvāṇa* bandwagon to avoid responsibilities. A visit to any *āśrama* will reveal quite a few who, unable to bear the stresses and strains of life, have taken recourse to the jungle. Those who have suffered disappointments sometimes espouse the philosophy, but nevertheless continue to nurture secret ambitions, which they find themselves inadequate to fulfil. This hypocrisy creates a serious dichotomy between thought and practice, and may lead to complications. It may, for example, lead to a person no longer

being fit for life with its many problems and complexities while s/he waits for *nirvāṇa* to come to the rescue. Such an outcome is obviously undesirable. Individually, it may induce one to lead a double life, a sort of spiritual neuroticism, in other words. However, it is even more undesirable collectively for it weakens the very fabric of the race, depressing its vitality and vigour with its inevitable decline. Even genuine individual victory can lead to the doctrine being misunderstood and used to justify disparate things, leading to a collective social defeat with its attendant psychological and cultural problems.

Therefore, the wise ones insist upon not deluding the minds of the average who are not ready by enrolling everyone in the list of candidates for counselling—*na buddhibhedam janayedajñānām karmasaṅginām*—he who is established in the Knowledge (true Knowledge or *jñāna*) should not create confusion in the minds of the ignorant (who are still attached to their egos and not yet ready). In other words, the doctrine requires a high degree of inner development on the part of the counsellor.

It is important to understand that ancient Indian thought saw in this impermanence only a passage towards a higher Permanence. The illusion was to be understood and torn in order to find the Real and not to rest in a midway house built upon the sands of nowhere. But doing so needs effort, a strong predisposition, a positive seeking that few can command. Yet if such a psychotherapist can take this final and crucial step of turning a negative experience into a positive seeking for the Eternal, it would mean a great and true release for the client. An example of this type of counsel appears in the classical treatise of *Yogavāsiṣṭha*, wherein the sage Vasiṣṭha counsels Rāma while the latter is going through a stage of non-involvement vis-à-vis life in the world.

This form of counselling, while useful for a select group of clients who suffer from depression arising out of life situations, is of little use in other forms of psychological disorders, although it may be useful in the case of those whose suffering stems from the pain of their near and dear ones. To take just one example, the depressed and suicidal mother of a mentally handicapped child was asked how she would have reacted had this child been her sister's, and she had to bring him up for some reason or the other. The reply was evident. She would do all she was doing now, perhaps even more, but without the depression, perhaps even with the joy born from a selfless act. As she replied, she could see the obvious—how to live in this world without attachment or possessiveness. A single short session was enough to change her self-view and world-view. She actually recovered and remained well for years.

The positive *Vedāntic* solution

Indian thought, however, is not only about *māyāvāda* and illusion. Despite the current emphasis on other-worldliness, there have been other, equally powerful and positive streams of Indian thought. In fact, *mukti* of the *Vedāntin* view and *nirvāṇa* of the Buddhist view, which propose discarding this world as a nightmare,

are not the only ideals conceived by Indian thought. The *Vedic ṛsis* were extremely life-affirming. In fact, there have been other equally powerful tendencies in Indian thought. These views propose a more positive outlook and try to reconcile the material and spiritual aspects of existence. Of course, the life affirmation suggested here is not the one attempted in the material model, which is essentially an affirmation of the ego. Here the emphasis is on affirmation of the soul upon nature through a growing inner perfection. From a psychotherapeutic point of view, it is this that can be even more effective in dealing with problems of the mind. Some of these major trends can be roughly classified into the following.

The ideal of inner purification

Indian thought views Nature as not only a single continuous movement, but also as a continuum of ascending degrees or potencies. This continuum presents itself as an evolutionary ladder for the soul to ascend to its own innate perfection. According to this vision, all phenomena can be reduced to a three-fold movement placed one on top of the other, like the steps of a ladder. In this view, the true value and significance of an action or any phenomenon in general lies not so much in its appearance as it does in the level or type of consciousness motivating it. The inward and outward reactions and consequences that follow result from the type of consciousness involved, rather than the actual observed movement or action. Three major movements or modes are recognized: *tamas*, *rajas* and *sattva*.

The source of human misery, according to this view, comes at a certain middle stage of our psychological evolution, called the *rājasīc*. In a nutshell, the human soul evolves through at least three levels over several rounds of birth before it is ready for the highest spiritual good. The first level is the *tāmasīc* or the darkened state of inertia and resistance to change. Here, the law of the masses or the rules of the herd drive him like a subconscious beast or a half-conscious man. Next comes the *rājasīc* or the state of kinesis and dynamic movement. This second stage can be further sub-divided into two: one, the preliminary or the predominantly *rajo-tāmasīc*, wherein the being is engaged in self-flattering indulgences of every kind; two, the *rajo-sāttvic*, wherein the individual begins to seek some rule of inner law to govern his unruly nature, which he begins to perceive as the source of internal disturbances. Finally, there is the third or *sāttvic* stage, wherein the individual learns to subordinate his ego and take from life only what is rightfully his. He seeks harmony intuitively and is balanced in his conduct and in the distribution of life energies. In the primitive or *tāmasīc* stage the individual does not consciously suffer, although he may be the cause of suffering for many others. The need for violent sensations to feel alive drives some of these people towards alcoholism and violence. Others simply enter a depressed state, refusing to budge from or outgrow this stage. The second stage is one of fiery pleasures and equally swift swings to the blues. An inordinate self-seeking and excessive ambition with its natural fallouts of anger, fear, hope, expectations and frustrations bring in their wake opposite reactions from their environment, and this egoistic narrowness makes these

individuals extremely susceptible to misery. This suffering is actually Nature's corrective, aimed at helping them to push forth and find a way out of their miserable existence. So lastly comes *sattva*, the great balancer, after the soul has experienced these lesser rungs of existence and grown through them.

It is the middle stage of the *rajo-tāmasic guṇa* that predisposes human beings towards extreme forms of cruelty, directed both at others and themselves. Many perversions, including sado-masochistic tendencies and drug dependence, arise due to a preponderance of the *tamo guṇa*. Illnesses like depression and some forms of schizophrenia can clearly be seen as gravitating towards the *tāmasic* state of nature with its attendant inertia, inability to exercise one's will, a tendency to not alter one's psychological condition, and to become progressively animal-like and stone-like, dubiously termed regression in modern psychology.

According to this strand of thought, psychological pain and suffering and pleasure and thrill are two sides of the same coin. Further, thrill (*sphurana* or *indriya-sukha*), which is predominantly *tāmasic* and pleasure (*viśaya-sukha*), which is largely *rājasic*, are clearly distinguished from happiness (*sukha*), which is *sāttvic* in nature, being subtler and therefore closer to the fundamental joy (*harṣa*) of existence. The highest and purest form is of course Bliss (*ānanda*), which belongs to the purely spiritual domain. To strive for thrill and the egoistic forms of pleasure is to invite suffering. We must grow out of such momentary sense-bound joy as well as the equally momentary joy arising through the possession of outer objects and move on to the happiness that can be observed in people whose mind is in a state of balance and satisfaction through moderation. What is necessary, therefore, is moderation and balance through enlightened reason and discrimination, *sattvaśuddhi*. This is the ideal of a sane moderation, similar to Aristotle's golden mean. It is a conscious and deliberate cultivation of positive qualities of the mind and the heart, which help one grow into *sukha* or gladness and *prakāśa* or light of wisdom.

Inevitable to this system is the fact that the nature of the advice given to a client depends upon the stage of her/his inner evolution. A story attributed to Swami Vivekananda well illustrates this point. When approached by a man eager for *sannyāsa* (renouncing the world), a man moved by a desire to escape his responsibilities rather than by a positive call for Truth and God, the great one's reply was: 'What is it that you possess and can renounce? First go and earn a lakh of rupees and then come for renunciation!' Unfortunately, most people today associate renunciation with escape from the struggle and labour of life. In actuality, true renunciation requires far greater inner strength (and is therefore an evolutionary move towards self-mastery) than the struggle necessary to satisfy one's desires. It may be noted that even in modern psychoanalytic thought, certain *sāttvic* qualities like renunciation, non-possession and suppression (as opposed to repression) are regarded as mature defence mechanisms, the signs of a mature and healthy mind.

A counsellor working along these lines will therefore first assess the level of the individual's inner evolution. Elaborate descriptions of the type of inner personality and constitution according to the three *guṇas*, as these three evolutionary

stages are better known, abound in ancient Indian thought, especially in the *Gītā* and *Āyurveda*. While we are all a mixture of the three, there is often a predominance of one or the other *guṇas*, which leads to physical and psychological afflictions. The therapy and advice given, therefore, varies. Thus, a *sāttvic* person who suffers due to his idealism and sympathy for others is advised, helped and encouraged to develop a still deeper and spiritual outlook; the *rājasic* man of a higher order is advised to do his work while placing his trust in God and in accordance with the inner laws of his nature, *svabhāva* and *svadharma*. The *rājasic* man of a lower order is counselled and helped to achieve moderation in habits and outlook, and tone down the excess desires that torment and trouble him. His unruly and excess energy is channelled into healthy activities like sports. The army has learnt to use the *rājasic* type of man and channelize his energies into war. But for the *tāmasic* man, very little counselling works unless something shakes him up, some terrible misfortune, for instance, which affects him and arouses the energies dormant within him. Anything that can stimulate this type of person to work with concentration and perseverance is considered good counsel. Fine crafts and manual work requiring physical concentration help, as can be seen in cases concerning psychotics and extreme forms of depression. Also helpful is anything that can stimulate a sense of joy—like eating a dish they relish, or simple things that heighten pleasure. These people are rarely advised to pursue spirituality of the meditative ascetic type because they might use it as an excuse to remain a recluse or justify inertia and addictions that transport them to altered realms without much inner effort.

These *guṇas* have other sub-divisions, but all people can be classified along the lines of these three types. The utility of this typology in treating certain personality and behavioural/conduct disorders is evident. It is also useful in understanding some of the conflicts that arise when an individual transits from one level to another with divergent pulls in his nature. In such cases, the task of the therapist is to assist the transition to the higher level while working through the conflict. A detailed discussion of all possible variations is beyond the scope of this chapter, but as is evident, this system offers great practical utility. It also settles the question of suitability for deeper spiritual counselling. Besides, it does not require great philosophical capacity or outlook on the part of the client, although it does require inner tact and understanding on the part of the therapist. Finally, this understanding can be combined with other forms of counselling as well, adding to its immense usefulness.

The harmony of body and mind

Illusionism is most commonly (mis)understood as representative of Indian thought, and some kind of mind-body harmony through *yoga* exercises is the most commonly sought after therapeutic technique. The *haṭhayoga* exercises (better known as *āsanas* or *yogāsanas*) *prāṇāyāma* and meditation are among the best-researched imports from India that have already found a place in modern

psychotherapeutic systems. Many researches undertaken in both the East and the West from the 1960s (or perhaps even earlier) have demonstrated the efficacy of these simple techniques. While theories pertaining to the exact mechanism of their actions might differ, there is hardly anyone who would deny their efficacy in creating some sort of harmony between the body and the mind. While the West continues to search for material explanations, it would be interesting to know what the originators of these systems thought about the 'mechanism' of their actions. This may only help us to modify them to suit our needs.

First, these 'techniques' were originally not meant to be mere techniques. These exercises were part of a larger movement—that of coming in contact with our own Divine essence, hidden in everything and at each plane of our existence. They were also meant to prolong life, stabilize the life-force and increase mental vigour; however, these gains were not so much for adaptive survival as they were for creating the best possible conditions favourable to our inner journey towards perfection of the soul. Here, it must be clearly understood that the ancient Indian mind viewed the body and its preservation not as an end in itself, but as a means for right conduct and the fulfilment of *dharma*, *śarīram khalu dharmasāadhanam*. Although these ancient practices are now being seen as the Indian counterpart of behavioural therapy, they are not so in their true essence, for the simple reason that very few things in Indian thought are divorced from spirituality, least of all the systems of *yoga*. Even atheistic and agnostic conceptions have their spiritual element.

In *haṭhayoga* and *prāṇāyāma*, the practitioner first tries to regulate, and then still, the otherwise restless physical and vital energies. This, however, is a preliminary first step. The next and more important one is where he tries to gather and concentrate these energies in an attempt to reach their divine source and bring out their deeper divine possibilities. Before this divine possibility emerges, and certainly after that, the energies of the body and life-force become forceful, effective, balanced, harmonious and, thereby, curative. This is excellent for those not so psychologically minded, and for those less inclined towards an esoteric spirituality. It is quite effective, and has been used with considerable success in treating psychosomatic disorders. The principle here is that diseases of the body arise due to an imbalance in the flow of *prāṇic* currents (life-force), which moves mainly along five different channels, two lower (*apāna*), two upper (*udāna*) and one in the middle (*samāna*). These practices were meant to regulate the life-force along its five-fold path in a balanced and harmonious way—an occult knowledge that we are only fragmentarily discovering again. The disadvantage lies in the fact that these methods, to be fully effective, have to be practised regularly. They are time-consuming and often need the supervision of a qualified expert. They are best used as adjuncts in treating a wide range of disorders, including psychoses.

Meditation is slightly different, even though it falls under the broad category of 'techniques' evolved by the Eastern paradigm, although nowhere is the range and variation as wide as it is in India. It is a vast subject and one need not go into every detail of the different techniques and their relative efficacy. Suffice it to

say that one of its well-known effects, recognized now the world over, is toning down the response of our sympathetic nervous system, creating a sense of calm at the most physical level. There may be deeper reasons though, since the nervous system, more specifically the autonomic nervous system, is a sort of interface between the gross physical energies, and those of life and the mind, which act upon matter and influence it. Two techniques are especially helpful. One is the Buddhist method of witnessing self-reflection and introspective meditation. This technique is useful for undoing certain habitual nervous responses, anxiety states, obsessive patterns of thoughts and behaviour, in anger management, and even in studying and thereby controlling oneself. The essential steps here are thought-observation, witnessing, control and mastery. But this is difficult and usually demands some isolation on the part of the practitioner; further, it is only a somewhat developed mind that can separate one part of it from another. The other, more popular and easier, yet very effective, technique is dynamic meditation and its scientific off-spring—guided imagery. This method relies on the faculty of imagination and can be considered a first cousin of auto-suggestion. In fact, the two are often combined together. It is used largely in the treatment of psychosomatic disorders, anxiety disorders etc.

The integral thought of the *Gītā*

There remain two powerful, widely used, but often misunderstood systems of ancient Indian thought. These systems appear to move along very different lines, although there is an unspoken occult and higher synthesis between them. The first is the ideal of the *Gītā*, often misrepresented as the gospel of *karma*, and further reduced to mean a motivation to duty, regardless of its effect. One can only smile at such summary dealings of a great scripture that has endured centuries of invasion and corruption, and yet continues to inspire and transform mankind. All one can say is that if the *Gītā* were to teach nothing more than mere moral rectitude, it would not be worth the trouble. In fact, quite a few words and *sūtras* in the *Gītā* can be utilized for counselling and therapeutic purposes. This is because unlike many similar scriptures, the *Gītā* is an attempt to synthesize various truths known till then. In addition, it adds something unique, profound and new, enriching the old with a fresh insight.

First among these *sūtras* is the truth that *man is essentially an imperishable soul* who uses the body as a charioteer uses the chariot. This reverses the dependence of our psychological state on the physical events of life by constantly reminding us that we are eternal and imperishable souls that assume a transient body, just as a person wears clothes. This doctrine has had such a great impact through the ages that till date it is the most effective counselling for the grief and pain of death. Millions of people have used the *Gītā* in times of crisis—especially loss—and found solace and strength. This is the first thing to remember—that we are essentially souls that cannot be destroyed by the catastrophes of life and nature.

The second doctrine is that man need not take this soul merely on faith

(although faith is a great power, the blind man's indispensable staff till he begins to see the higher truths). He can discover his soul through many ways, one of which, according to the *Gītā*, is the *enlightened use of his intelligent will*. Instead of turning it constantly outward and downward to satisfy our desires or remaining caught up in the web of surface phenomenon, this intelligent will can be turned upward and inward to discover our own sublime realities, which free us from bondage to grief, error, suffering and pain. The *Gītā* also briefly mentions one or two psycho-physical practices and forms of concentration to help us go within.

A third principle states that we have not been abandoned upon earth; God Himself is concerned with *the march of civilization* towards some ultimate Good. What that ultimate Good is, has been left unsaid or only hinted at, but the *Gītā* assures us that He is concerned intimately with the earth and men. Each element of the universe has a Divine superconscient (not the super-ego or the conscience, which are human things, aspects of our mind and the ego's constructs) hidden within it, and not just a subconscient animal principle (instincts as the base of everything) as Freudian psychology at one time asserted. The *Gītā* states that Divinity dwells within the human being, and that it is the task of each to bring it out rather than stifle it. This is the great conflict occurring at the macro and micro levels.

The principal conflict, therefore, is between the cosmic principles and powers of Light and their opposites—darkness and Ignorance. This is the fourth principle, that war and conflict will remain unavoidable evolutionary necessities so long as earth and mankind are imperfect. Our inner conflicts are essentially *evolutionary conflicts*, our inner and outer crises are essentially cries for evolutionary change. Man can choose to remain in a darkened state, pursued by suffering, till he once again chooses the path towards eternal good, which is also the collective good. The *Gītā* elaborately describes in the closing chapters the nature of the powers of light and darkness. Thus man, to be free of error and grief, has to consciously cultivate the qualities of light and truth.

A fifth element of the *Gītā*, and the most widely known, is the concept of *niṣkāma karma*. The principle of *karma* and its consequences depend upon the level on which an action has been done. This has already been hinted at. Suffice it to say that according to the *Gītā*, *karma* is an inner evolutionary mechanism and not a summary disposal by a judge through a system of rewards and punishments. If anything, the rewards and punishments come from within, through an ensuing inner psychological state. Thus, acts done under a *tāmasic* state delude our consciousness, making it more dense and impervious to Light and Joy. Similarly, even philanthropic acts done under a *rājasic* state of 'I' and 'My' (committed under the stress of the vital ego) bring in their wake happiness that is transient, and invariably mixed with or followed by suffering. *Sāttvic* acts lead to increased inner happiness and wisdom, *sukha* and *prakāśa*. We can, however, be free of *karma* and its consequences by arriving spontaneously at that high point of our soul's evolutionary career towards which the machinery of *karma* and Nature is driving us, that is, to discover the Divine secret within us. The *Gītā* suggests that we dedicate our everyday actions to the secret indwelling Godhead and Lord who resides within

the hearts of every living and thinking creature, Vāsudeva (the indwelling Deity) and *mānuṣim tanum āśritam*. Thus practised, even our most trivial everyday actions can lead us to a happy state of being, if done in a selfless spirit of dedication to the Divine Master and as long as one remains equal to the fruits that they may bring. This emphasis upon a mind that is tranquil under every circumstance—the seemingly pleasant and unpleasant, in success and victory and in failure and defeat—is a great liberating principle of the *Gītā*, and helps to ameliorate much of our everyday psychological and even physical suffering. This equality is not indifference but a state of joy by dwelling constantly in The Lord’s remembrance and abiding solely by His Will.

The establishment of *equanimity* is therefore another practical method prescribed by the *Gītā* to free us from the stress of everyday life. But would it not lead to a casual lackadaisical approach towards life? This question stems from an assumption that desire for a particular result is the sole motivator of human action. While that may be true of certain needs such as hunger and thirst, desire is very clearly a distortion that arises when need turns to greed. Even need, though, is not an imperative. For according to *yoga*, needs are nothing but habits of Nature, conditioned responses of the mind to an object. We can recondition ourselves to such an extent that even the needs of food and water can be done away with (in an extreme form of yoga). Still, the question of motivation remains. The *Gītā* commands us to approach all work as the work of God, to do them for the benefit of the world, since He alone knows what is best for all. Our role, or rather the role of nature in us, is to be a faithful and perfect instrument. In other words, the *Gītā* enjoins us to pursue perfection and excellence as part of our instrumentality, but with the sole motive of service and love inspired by a higher knowledge and guidance, arising in a tranquil mind free of the turbulence of desires and passions. The rewards, which are not to be sought after for their own sake, are an intrinsic delight and unconditional peace, wisdom, freedom and, above all, the growth of our entire being towards God. Equanimity is not only a strong foundation for a higher life, but also a bedrock of safety against the harshness of the world. We can arrive at it through several ways, one of which is to practice stepping back. Before rushing to speak or act in haste, we need to hold back for a while and look at the relative importance of a thing from the widest possible frame of reference. If practised sincerely, it will help us to discover the triviality of many things we considered important.

Another method is to look at the essence of events and circumstances, and at the place they hold in the totality of life. For things are often ascribed a place that is out of proportion to their real value when seen from a truer perspective. Setting things in their right place and viewing them from the right perspective helps us avoid troubles and misunderstandings in life. Yet another way is to develop a dispassionate and philosophical outlook, or resilience and fortitude that can endure shocks. However, equanimity can be best developed by a conscious and willing surrender to God’s Will in the cosmos.

This brings us to the greatest word of the *Gītā*, which assures us that God

will deliver us from all fear and evil if we can learn to *surrender* ourselves into His hands. Modern psychology, born out of a sceptic temperament suited to material pursuits, has little sympathy with the idea of God. It may even regard talking of God in matters of science as blasphemous. But we must remember that psychology is not a physical science. It deals not with physical but with psychological phenomena and, whether we like it or not, the fact remains that the quest for Divinity and all that is good, faith and surrender are all psychological phenomena, as ancient as the mountains, yet at the same time as modern as the quantum theories of space and the universe. Psychology will suffer a great loss if this body of psychological self-experience is left unutilized, for it is not scientific scruples but our blind attachment to Ignorance that prevents us from seeing the Light and offering greater possibilities to man. Whether accepted in scientific circles or not, the empirical fact is that faith in God has continued to relieve and cure people around the world, cutting across man-made and natural barriers. The two views of science and faith are perhaps merely two different ways of seeing the One Reality, which exceeds and fulfils both.

In actuality, there is no real opposition between faith in God and reason. If we are sincere, reason leads us to the doors of agnosticism and even hints at some cosmic Intelligence at work. When we regard this vast and wonderful world of myriad phenomena, we clearly see the workings of a perfect Intelligence that is conscious and precedes its works, even when the object worked upon is not aware of It. It even adapts Itself to Its instruments; it is then logical to say that one's supreme fulfilment would be in the ability to express and manifest that Intelligent Will as perfectly as one can. If we can concede this simple observational and inferential truth, then we have to make only one other logical extension—that this perfectly conscious Intelligent Force is also at once a Being, which we can relate to. In fact, it is our own highest Self, the greatest possibility hidden within us. Several eminent men and women have experienced this essential divinity, which cuts across the boundaries of space, time and education. The difficulty lies in reconciling the various notions of God created by different religions, whose external details do not coincide. However, since science seeks to go beyond appearances, it can learn to look behind the various religious practices and arrive at an essential truth about Divine Perfection and a Conscious Force existing behind this world and Nature.

A bold reconciliation: The path of Tantra or an inner technology

Reconciliation, however, is possible. The first attempt to reconcile the two apparent opposites (the materialist and the spiritual) took place in the great and now lost tradition of Tantra. The *Gītā* seeks to reconcile life in the world (the problem of the practical man) with spiritual realization. Tantra seeks to reconcile the energies moving this cosmos (the field of the scientist) with the Supreme Energy from which these lesser forms, forces and energies originate. Given this, it might be possible to master the lesser energies through the stronger and greater ones. This is the fundamental principle of Tantra—to understand, possess, control and master

the forces and powers of nature, as well as those of a greater super-nature. From this perspective, it is closer to our conception of science, albeit with a much wider application.

Thus, while science studies and tries to master physical forces and the energies of matter, Tantra goes deeper to study and master other occult energies beyond the play of our material universe. It sees physical phenomena as by-products or the final end result of still deeper occult events occurring at other levels of our consciousness. In the field of illness, for example, it believes that there are entities, beings, and forces of disruption and disintegration on which one can act directly if one has the occult knowledge, thereby curing an illness without physical intervention. Unfortunately, modern insistence on physical causes alone has damaged this highly developed science, which has its own rationale of working. Tantra itself fell into disrepute since few occultists and Tāntrikas had the required inner purity to handle such intense forces. Many, attracted by the power but unable to pay the inner price, turned to lower and derivative activities like black magic, witchcraft etc. The worship of power not backed by a solid grounding in the highest knowledge led to a further decline of the discipline, and indulgence in practices that were more in the nature of occult quackery than wizardry. The presence of incompetent doctors or quacks in the field of medicine does not abrogate medical science as a genuine branch of science. So too the modern disrepute of Tantra does in no way mean that Tantra in itself belonged to a lower order, or that its practitioners were indulging in some mumbo-jumbo.

Indian thought and psychiatry

There is a lot that Tantra can offer psychiatry, not by way of our modern misreading of its hieroglyphs through the lens of psychoanalysis, but in terms of increasing our understanding of the subtler causes of illness. Thus, according to Tāntrika knowledge, insanity results from possession by certain entities emanating from the dark and hostile worlds. These turbulent energies first enter the atmosphere of a person susceptible to them (through affinity of some parts of his nature). This is the prodrome stage, when the first stage of occult prevention can be undertaken. They next cast an influence which usually takes one or the other following forms:

- Early influence leads to some personality changes (loss of faith and will, doubts, depression, confusion, perverted religiosity, excessive self-vanity, excess of sexual and other appetites, uncontrolled impulsiveness).
- Epilepsy, which is characteristically due to resistance offered by the affected person against the force.
- Hysteria, especially states of possession, dissociation, multiple personality etc.
- Active communication with these dark entities through voices and other means, as seen in certain forms of psychosis.
- Finally, frank possession / incarnation of one of these stronger dark entities, leading to a total perversion of thought, feeling, will, action and

speech, resulting in personalities known as the tyrant, the psychopath and the pervert.

These dark forces and beings have been elaborately classified in Tāntrika literature. Some of these are the *asuras* (distorters of mind, specifically thought and speech), the *rākṣasa* (those perverting and distorting feelings and will) and *piśācas* (distorting sensations and physical instincts). There are other minor entities, such as elemental beings called *bhūta* and disembodied beings called *preta*, who float in the vicinity of the dead, especially those who have died traumatic deaths. These beings and entities are known everywhere, and are mentioned under different names in Western, Arabic and other spiritual literature.

Now the Tāntrika, the occultist, the *shaman*, the thaumaturgist—call him whatever you will—knew about these forces and the ways to neutralize them, just as a modern scientist would know about the forces of wind, rain and fire, and how to handle them. The Tāntrika can be further sub-divided into two main types. The lower type has within its control some powerful entity of the same plane, which executes its will, either for good or for evil. Others have mastered the higher energies through sufficient purity and self-control. These can then neutralize the lower beings with the power of Light. Naturally, it is the latter Tāntrika who is preferable and also the one whose powers are more permanent, but this type is rare to find as too much inner austerity is called for on the part of the practitioner.

The lost knowledge of Tantra is now being recovered, albeit in forms more suited to the scientific temper of our times—Reiki, *prāṇic* healing, working with body and mind energy, a study of the effects of thoughts and other vibrations upon the body and mind and so on. Despite the onslaught of modern science, this ancient science is not dead; rather, it is being reborn through new sciences such as parapsychology. In fact, physical science itself has entered the threshold of the occult and it would not be surprising if in times to come the old ghosts return in the garb of new names and the buried are raised in a different attire.

The two roads to the one solution

Before embarking upon a synthesis of all these diverse systems of Indian thought, a recapitulation. The practical side of Indian thought can be broadly divided into two main categories. The commonly known method is the way of knowledge—Vedānta—and its child, Yoga. The aim here is to rise above suffering through discovering a level higher than and outside the sphere of our pain and suffering. While this will not help us to end suffering or change reality, we can definitely transcend it. This itself is a significant gain and, for many, it is enough. They say, 'Let the stain remain, the imperfection of our earth-nature and its resultant suffering continue; it is enough if I can escape its psychological consequences. If others too do it, we all can collectively ascend to a level where suffering is not felt or experienced even though all below is disarray and strife.'

The other method is that of power or Śakti and its child, Tantra. An effort is made here to understand the forces that create confusion and disorder, sickness

and imperfection, suffering and pain. Effort is also made to conquer them, and therefore this method is known as the *vīra mārga* or the hero's path. But inadequacy can set in here too, since power without knowledge is unsatisfactory. One cannot find the final cure if one is unaware of the ultimate origin. A knowledge of the origins of suffering and evil and imperfection can alone lead to a perfect and radical cure. In other words, in their highest station, Vedānta and Tantra, the Highest Knowledge and the Supreme Power, are essentially one. But somehow they have not been reconciled. The *Vedāntin* who knows only one half of the truth dismisses the issue of suffering as an illusion without caring to find out why this illusion was superimposed upon the Supreme Truth. The Śākta Tāntrika, who has the power, also misses the truth since he does not know how this fall into error and confusion came about and the means to rescue the energies that have seemingly deviated from their true purpose.

The grand synthesis and more

In our own times, a grand synthesis of Vedānta and Tantra, Eastern and Western, the spiritual and the materialist approach has been achieved and effected in the work and vision of Sri Aurobindo. Of course, Sri Aurobindo's *yoga* is not an eclectic combination of different methods and paths, although it embraces the highest knowledge possible to the Vedāntin and the greatest power possible to the Tāntrika. And yet it includes something more, something not found elsewhere. What that is and how it can help us in our knowledge and practice of medicine and psychiatry has been discussed in the following section. Sri Aurobindo has shed light on practically every sphere of life, reconciling not only the great streams of Indian thought, but also joining materialism and other prominent ideas with the currents of Indian spirituality. It is therefore rewarding to study it as a prototype in some detail as it can form the backbone of an integral synthesis of ancient Indian wisdom and currently prevalent modern thinking on the subject. For our present purposes, however, we shall confine the exposition to the problem of psychological well-being and view it against the background of this grand vision of Indian thought.

First, Sri Aurobindo confirms the ancient knowledge that man is not just an aggregate of physical cells or chemical reactions. He is that only in his outer material basis. His true self-identity lies in his possession of a soul. Sri Aurobindo does not use the word 'soul' in a vague or general sense. There is a universal Self, but there is also an individual soul that has been projected from the One Self into the drama of earthly life. This individual soul, called the psychic being, is important to our psychological well-being. The psychic being is our true being, the secret divinity present in us. Its very essence is peace, harmony and joy; it has a natural affinity towards the true, the good and the beautiful. However, it remains veiled in human beings by their surface nature and its movements. But it exists even in the crudest of human natures as a ray of light and hope, a spark of undying truth covered by darkness.

One source of psychological maladies springs from our inability to dwell in the *psychic consciousness*. We live our lives mostly upon the surface, where there usually is nothing but confusion and disorder. Our nature, in the absence of guidance, depends heavily upon our outer mind and sense data. Our desires, emotions and passions further corrupt this imperfect, partial and broken knowledge (called Ignorance). The result is a falsification of knowledge, a crass Ignorance about others and ourselves. This wrong identification with the ignorant movements of nature as if that were 'me' is the origin of our subjective sense of the ego which appears so very real. With this notion of the superficial 'me' comes the idea of what is 'not me'. And thus begins a conflict and clash of forces, since no real unity or harmony is possible with the ego, only at best some accommodation, tolerance and adjustment. The sense of ego leads inevitably to conflict with all that is not perceived as myself, whether it be as seen in others or hid in our own subconscious depths, which in essence is the same thing. For we almost instinctively see in others a reflection of our own selves. We also wish to see in others the perfection that we secretly desire, but have not yet achieved. Much of our social and emotional conflict with others stems from the separative ego-sense and its attendant Ignorance, or vice versa. This does not mean that there is no such thing as the individual. On the contrary, there is indeed a true divine individual within us that has been projected to manifest one or the other aspect of the Integral Divine. It is our individual drive and need that leads us to arrive at that manifestation of the divinity within us. The more we do so, the more fulfilled and thereby truly satisfied and happy we feel, and our conflict with others lessens as we begin to perceive them as equally representative of yet other aspects of the One and Infinite Deity. The mutually contradictory parts within and outside us begin to appear as mutually complementary, thus resolving many conflicts and contradictions that arise in our everyday lives, from unresolved internal conflicts to discord in relationships. To put it more precisely, *the outer conflicts of man are the reflections of his inner conflicts*.

Another source of conflict is a tussle between what we are and what we secretly aspire to be, between our animal past and our god-like future. There is no part of human nature that can truly resolve this conflict. Reason, even at its best, often leaves us in a quandary, as happened in the case of Arjuna. What should or should not be done often leaves even sages perplexed, says the Master of the *Gītā*. The standards of reason are those of Ignorance, since reason has not the sure light of perfect truth on which to act. Besides, we are often left to the mercy of our emotions, impulses, passions and desires, which can all too easily override reason. Not all of us are fortunate to have an embodied *avatāra* or *guru* by our side to guide and lead us. But there is in each of us the inner *avatāra*, the Divine spark within, the psychic being which can guide us infallibly. This is the first line of psychological help available to us, the inner healer who can put things straight within us, *yaṁ paśyanti hṛtayechindoṣa*.

Not content with theorizing, Sri Aurobindo and The Mother have provided us with abundant practical methods to aid us in the *discovery of our psychic being*. To

discover and uncover the psychic consciousness is to break through the first rank and file of the army of Ignorance into our own true nature, *svabhāva*, and unleash the knowledge and power of the soul. But this is only the first step. There are other aspects of Ignorance that are important, without which we can never be free of suffering and imperfection. This next step is towards our spiritual evolution. Sri Aurobindo once again affirms the ancient truth of rebirth, but imbues it with a new and unique significance. Rebirth, or rather birth itself, in Sri Aurobindo's vision is neither a chemical nor a spiritual accident. It is not an issueless creation where a stern judge sits over us watching and passing decrees of reward and punishment over souls stumbling helplessly through the dark forests of Ignorance. From one birth to another and through different experiences the soul in us grows till it is ready to manifest its inherent divinity upon the earth. *Mukti*, which amounts to an essential freedom from our lower nature and its reactions, is only a preliminary step towards something higher. It is the manifestation of a higher Super-nature upon the earth. Although our soul is inherently divine and its discovery helps us to recover our inner poise and outlook, the nature the soul gathers around itself is not necessarily perfect. As long as the nature that we wrap around us remains fallen and obscure, life on earth shall be replete with error and suffering. The realization of our individual souls will no doubt save us from personal misery, but the common universal problem will continue, leading to disease and disorder of the body and mind.

So the next step is to *ascend to still higher levels of spiritual consciousness*, and with each ascent to take up the lower levels and elevate these to a higher quality by the touch of the higher descending into the lower. This is the evolutionary aspect of life, which can be best described as ascent and integration towards a greater degree of wholeness. This gives man a new aim and psychotherapy a new goal. This evolution is paralleled by the evolution of the consciousness. While it is an unconscious process in animals, it is a more conscious one in humans. In other words, we are not helpless, mute witnesses or unconscious automatons in nature's hands, being shaped by struggles towards higher development. We are and can be active participants, and our choices can help or hinder the evolutionary pace, although it cannot alter the inevitable outcome. Our evolutionary journey stretches through many lives, and it is here that we discover the real significance of rebirth. Our illnesses are not punishments for bad deeds, they (as everything else) are a learning process, an inner growth through which we learn about our different responses to the different energies put forth by our nature.

Here we discover another source of conflict. The first is a general one between our true being and our lower nature, that is, between our true spiritual self and the false ego. The other conflict is between the different parts of our nature that dwell on different levels of consciousness. Thus, the mind may be ready to evolve while the heart may refuse to move and remain confined in its narrow boundaries. Or the heart may be ready to widen, but the life impulse may be mired in lower motives and the body may refuse to move. This creates an *inner disharmony*, leading to psychological and physical imbalances. If the imbalance is too strong and the

psychic development weak, the cosmic forces of disruption and disorder may create more serious imbalances, as seen in psychotics, sociopaths and criminals.

The concept of *cosmic forces* has been present in all ancient mystic thought. The modern mind, unable to see beyond the ego's immediate field of vision, knows nothing about it. But the insight of the *yogi* and the mystic goes deeper and reaches farther into the infinite landscapes of our Consciousness. He sees the hidden forces that move life, the occult sources of our action, both the dark and bright sides to our reality, the play of the gods that lead us to harmony, truth and light, and the evil luring the human heart. From another point of view, we may simply see them as evolutionary challenges, assisting our growth by throwing at us obstacles that need to be overcome. The evolutionary journey therefore presents a double challenge, the outer challenge for overcoming the stresses of our environment, and the inner challenge to the soul to overcome the pressure of cosmic forces. When correctly mastered, the first of these challenges leads to a harmonious adaptation between our nature and the environment. The inner challenge can be successfully overcome through inner growth, leading to harmony between the different parts of our nature and their equation with the cosmic forces.

Finally, Sri Aurobindo has provided the widest possible map of consciousness that can be considered a common matrix for a reconciliation between Science and Spirituality. Both admit to Consciousness, but while one sees it as a by-product of our mental evolution, the other sees evolution itself as the natural outcome and an act of Consciousness that is the immaterial and subtlest of subtle Reality behind everything. It is a new way of seeing and mastering life and its anomalies, a top-down view rather than the bottom-up we follow now, leading to much confusion. To take just one example, in the traditional psychoanalytic model lust and anger would be considered primary forces while love and strength are seen as their sublimated and altered versions, and therefore only a civilizational eyewash. But in the spiritual view, it is Love and Strength that are the original forces (among others), and lust and anger their degraded forms. The difference is radical, since the former implies that in effect, man's natural state is akin to that of a fallen animal, and therefore any humanness in him is merely a temporary and fragile cover for the beast; the other view holds that man is essentially a spiritual being and his animal nature as well as his humanness are only a temporary phase leading towards godliness.

A terrestrial divine perfection: The complete solution

To grow in knowledge (the aim of the Vedāntic *yoga*) and to grow in power (the aim of Tāntrika *yoga*), and through this growth to discover the *ānanda* of becoming is the great human journey. The meeting point of these two seemingly different aspects of existence is Consciousness, which in the ancient Indian conception is at once knowledge and power, *cit-sakti*. A growth in Consciousness is the aim of human life and the solution to our human misery and suffering. The more we grow in Consciousness (that is, towards higher levels of knowledge and power),

the more we become progressively free of Ignorance and limitation, and the more we discover the peace and *ānanda* hidden at the base of everything. To discover these hidden springs of *ānanda* is to be free from suffering, to discover the hidden source of Light is to be free from error, to discover the hidden source of Love and Oneness is to be free from disharmony and disorder, and to discover in this ascending scale the divinity of Life is to be free from death.

Illness, in this sense, is a barometer, geared towards discovering our hidden weaknesses that need to be developed and perfected, or, in Darwinian language, challenges thrown to the soul by nature to uncover its own inherent divine potential. Each illness represents the obverse of some potential yet to be discovered. Each shadow of the body or mind in the form of illness conceals some possibility of light. Our illnesses are therefore evolutionary challenges, our crises and conflict means for greater self-discovery. Nature utilizes our pain and struggle so that a greater delight and strength may be born within us. It is the task of the therapist to assist this evolutionary process.

How does he do it? What are his means and tools? The first and most important instrument in this catalytic process is the therapist himself. It is the consciousness of the therapist that interacts with the consciousness of the client to effect this change. According to the ancient Indian conception, such an inner change in another individual can only be effected by someone who has worked out the change within himself. The next best alternative is that the person must at least have a strong conviction and faith in the intended change. When neither alternative is available, this change can be brought about by faith in some past Master or representative of God, in whom the client can trust. In either case, the main task of the therapist is to induce faith in a higher Grace or Power and awaken in the client the will towards the possibility of change. Till that happens, the therapist takes on the role of a spiritual midwife to assist the delivery of the client through his dark and painful passage in the womb of nature. The task is indeed a delicate one: moving from dependence on something outside to the discovery of the only true and authentic freedom, brought about by placing oneself in the hands of the divinity within. This was the original conception of '*guru*' provided in Indian thought, on which so much stress is laid. The *guru* is not merely a counsellor (although he is that as well); according to ancient Indian conception, he is a representative of the Divine who is now veiled to the eye of humanity. He reveals to humanity its own higher aspect, the spiritual self concealed by our surface consciousness. The shock of contact with the *guru* acts as a force to bring forth our hidden self, and inspires us to make the necessary effort to discover the inner *guru*, the Divine within. And since the *guru* embodies not only knowledge but also power, the greatest of *gurus* aid the person in distress to discover his own inner divinity. It is only a modern and vulgar misconception that leads to the *guru*'s power being seen as a means of satisfying one's frustrated desires. The *guru* may do that if necessary, but more importantly, he equips the disciple with his own inner power and light, which can weather a million frustrations without breaking down. The *guru*'s light also unmask the hidden weaknesses in the disciple without his needing to undergo

the painful and difficult processes of disease and crisis. It is this growth in sincerity through the *guru's* intervention, this stripping off of our subconscious defences so that we may see ourselves as we are and then, with the *guru's* help, grow into our own divine nature that is forever free of afflictions and imperfections, full of harmony, peace and *ānanda*, which is the crucial movement of inner growth. In ancient Indian conception it is not the ego defences (mature or immature) that are strengthened, but the strength of the soul that is cultivated. The ego, however necessary at a particular stage of our evolution, becomes a prison at another stage, and must be replaced by the soul. This does not mean a defeatist attitude of inaction as those who know of no other identity than the surface ego perceive it to be. Defeatism is only another warped expression of the ego. The evolution we aim at is an exchange of our surface orientation, superficial understanding and limited responses with a deeper, truer and more powerful understanding and response to life, people and the world. Life assumes the appearance of a frightening struggle so long as we live in Ignorance and for the ego. It becomes a self-possessed delight when we live in and by the soul and for Truth and God.

The means, the instruments and the tools

The counsellor therefore leads the client through a progressive deepening, heightening and widening of his consciousness, using every experience of life, past and present, as materials to aid in the evolutionary process. Towards this end, he may use any and every means, again depending upon the client's readiness to accept, his natural bent and temperament, and most of all, his constitution and faith. All the methods mentioned above can be used. In certain situations the counsellor may even refer the patient to a particular technique as a temporary aid, say for example *yogāsana*s or *prāṇāyāma*. But he must know that these techniques are merely temporary devices, which will eventually need to be outgrown. The goal of the psychotherapeutic journey is not just to ward off the present symptoms, but to discover the inner healer who can heal all anomalies of life in all times to come. It is this discovery of the true soul, this ascent to our own higher levels of consciousness that will progressively reduce our dependence on the *guru*, since we will have discovered the same *guru* within.

This is no easy task. It requires colossal inner development on the part of the counsellor himself. Outer knowledge matters little in this process; in fact, a lot is not even suited to this process. It needs a certain predilection and temperament; perhaps, to use the ancient Indian language, some are destined for it. It is not a question of inner spiritual achievement or merit alone; along with spiritual self-development, it calls for wisdom with strength, a high degree of faith and conviction, an inner goodwill and generosity, but most of all a deep compassion and love for humanity. It is not a Ph.D. course in spiritual counselling, neither does it provide intellectual mastery of the subject but a real living of the truths that one wants to communicate, that matters.

There are lesser alternatives. A client may have faith in a lesser mortal, and

still be helped. His faith becomes the guide and the Divine uses it to lead the student through the medium of the teacher. One could also suggest a guided or direct reading of *Śāstra*, a book rich in spiritual knowledge and power. Millions of people all around the world have been helped by reading the Bible, the *Gītā*, the *Dhammapada* in times of crisis rather than by visiting a professional psychiatrist. The modern medical man with his rational tools is often a poor substitute for faith in our own soul's strength and in the Divine Grace. Depending upon the client's need, he could be a teacher, a father figure, a loving and kind mother, a generous and understanding friend, or even simply one human being leading another on the great journey. A counselling session willing to accommodate all possible variations in human nature cannot be based on rigidly fixed principles. The approach has to allow flexibility and not a uniform prescription, for example meditation for all and sundry. In fact, the counsellor should work as an influence whose personal example inspires the client and instils him with faith. And even his counsel should proceed after due consideration to the client's present level of evolution, his natural seeking, his hopes and expectations, his strengths and his weaknesses. This can be best learned through a long and close association with the teacher rather than through any formal course. Ancient Indian thought understood this all too well, and therefore such learning took place largely informally through living with the *guru*, rather than relying on bookish knowledge and the classroom method. The methods of our reductionist science cannot apply if we are to treat the prospective counsellor and client as a living whole. Our problems are not isolated from our total being. Even when they arise in one aspect, they affect the whole.

The counsellor-client relationship in Indian thought

It must, however, be noted that the *guru-śiṣya* form of counselling in the ancient Indian setting was not just a ritualistic formula or method, but simply a statement of fact. Not everyone can be a *guru*; only the man who has moved far on the path of self or God-realization can do so. The *guru* is not an erudite scholar trained in spiritual dialectics or a master in spiritual philosophy. He may or may not be any of these. He may not be a trained psychologist or perhaps even a man of letters, although these would only work to his advantage. He must, at the least, be a man who has found his true soul and was living consciously in it. If he can transmit this soul experience to another, it would help. This is important because the modern mind often misreads in the *guru-celā* relationship either a dependence of a Freudian type, or else a convenient device to facilitate the psychotherapeutic process through faith alone. Faith is no doubt important in the Indian setting, but the emphasis on faith does not sanction blind and irrational obscurantism. On the contrary, it is a necessary pre-condition to arrive at knowledge. It is an enlightened faith that is necessary, a faith consistent with reason; if there is a Divine sense and purpose in this world, then surely there must be a means to discover it; if there is a soul that can help heal, then surely there must be a means to find it; if one man has found it then, given the right means and method, others too can find it. Above

all, a faith that if there is at all divine guidance in this world behind the so-called anomalies of life, then there must be a purpose in each trial and tribulation, behind each crisis and failure, behind every stumble and fall. The *guru* assists in this process of discovering the real meaning and significance of crisis, and through it the meaning of our own life in this seemingly meaningless universe. Faith and surrender to the *guru's* guidance is the starting point of this discovery; will, effort and aspiration, the middle stage; knowledge and union with the truth found, the third and last stage of this process. According to Indian tradition, counselling ideally does not end with immediate recovery from the perceived distress, but is carried further till the person has moved beyond all possibility of distress. Distress is only an excuse that the soul uses to start the great journey. Its end is not temporary relief from the transient stresses and satisfactions of life, but the establishment of permanent peace and an unfading joy in the being, a radical cure from all present, past and future ills.

It needs to be mentioned that the spirit of counselling is not commercial at all. If we revert to ancient Indian thought, we find that there was only one criterion that the *guru* used in taking on disciples—the readiness to evolve along the same lines as the master, the *adhikāra bheda*. But once accepted, all commercial and other considerations were put away. If the disciple offered something of his own will, it was another matter. Indeed, the disciple was expected to offer something by way of *guru dakṣiṇa* at the end of the course, and this may have been something as small as a penny or as big as an empire or an object held dear. The disciple gave it in faith and gratitude, trusting that the master knows best. This gift of love at the end of instructions boded well for the student, since ingratitude towards the master, whose debt can never be repaid, was considered the worst of all lapses. Some masters even shouldered their disciples' burdens, not only for one life but for all lives to come.

How relevant is all this in our modern scenario? And is it practicable at all? We must understand that ancient Indian thought aimed at making the ideal pragmatic and practically possible, and the spirit of ancient India is not dead, despite the onslaught of material thought. Even now there exist teachers, instructors, counsellors and masters who go about their task silently without any considerations of money or fame. The gift of knowledge and the help they provide is the greatest gift of all. By the very fact of it being a gift, it becomes one with love and the two are the most potent powers to effectuate the deeper change that is the goal of all authentic psychotherapy.

The goal of psychotherapy

The goal of psychotherapy can be no different from the general goal of mankind in its great evolutionary journey. A crisis only pushes us further towards the goal. The psychotherapist, in the Indian conception, is only a catalyst in this journey from darkness to light. He provides support through authentic love, compassion, wisdom and strength, but most of all through his inner being rather than through

the techniques and processes that he may advise, suggest or prescribe. The end result is not just a temporary restoration of the original status quo, but a growth in consciousness towards greater wisdom, greater love, greater freedom, greater harmony that come through our ascent out of animality into divinity, through the discovery of our secret soul. This is beautifully summarized by Sri Aurobindo (2005, p. 4):

To know, possess and be the divine being in an animal and egoistic consciousness, to convert our twilit or obscure physical mentality into the plenary supramental illumination, to build peace and a self-existent bliss where there is only a stress of transitory satisfactions besieged by physical pain and emotional suffering, to establish an infinite freedom in a world which presents itself as a group of mechanical necessities, to discover and realise the immortal life in a body subjected to death and constant mutation,—this is offered to us as the manifestation of God in Matter and the goal of Nature in her terrestrial evolution.

... For all problems of existence are essentially problems of harmony. They arise from the perception of an unsolved discord and the instinct of an undiscovered agreement or unity. To rest content with an unsolved discord is possible for the practical and more animal part of man, but impossible for his fully awakened mind, and usually even his practical parts only escape from the general necessity either by shutting out the problem or by accepting a rough, utilitarian and unilluminated compromise.

In conclusion: A question of faith

This chapter has touched upon the theoretical framework of Indian thought and its relevance to the psychotherapeutic process. The framework is vast and heterogeneous and, despite several points of agreement, there are important divergences as well. Besides, a number of techniques, processes and methods described in various ancient and modern treatises are too exhaustive for even a summary discussion. Each of these needs sustained and persistent practice for practical utility, and cannot be picked up from a book, however helpful they may be. The repeated message that comes through is that Truth is what is lived and experienced within one's soul, and mere preaching without practice will lead nowhere.

In conclusion, one may say that Indian thought moves along many lines simultaneously, resulting in an extraordinary complexity. While on the one hand it creates difficulties in comprehension, on the other hand this richness can be practically useful in catering to the diverse strands and demands of human nature. Yet, certain general principles can be culled out of this complex structure, which can help mankind in its pursuit of relief from suffering. These general principles are elements common to most systems. Since psychotherapy is more concerned with relieving psychological suffering than with philosophical dialectics for its own sake, the thing of the greatest utility is also that which is closely held in the collective faith of the human race. The role of the psychotherapist is not to convert the sick and suffering to any particular belief or to proselytize for narrow sectarian

and evangelical purposes, although that might just happen, given that it is natural for a person to develop a faith in something that has been of help in moments of crisis. Faith is a common denominator in Eastern and Western thought, and in both ancient and modern systems. A philosophical doctrine will remain ineffective unless it seizes and holds not only the mind's interest, but also the heart, faith and will. Therefore, what is first necessary in the practical application of ancient Indian thought is that the psychotherapist lives in a wide catholicity, utilising the intrinsic faith of the patient as an essential means of support in his work. And if the faith is found insufficient to support the change, he will work towards instilling and widening it keeping in mind the client's natural bent and past evolution, rather than trying for conversion. Faith works best when it arises from within, and works poorly when it is superimposed from without. This blossoming of faith is a crucial element in all psychotherapy, without which everything else remains incomplete. So common is loss of faith in psychological problems, especially depression, that one may say that most crises of life are actually crises of faith.

This is the first important element in Indian spiritual thought—an insistence on faith as a key element in life, more so than reason. For in spirituality, it is necessary to suspend all judgement and begin with faith as it transcends the mind. It is said that in the end, this faith is fulfilled and justified by the knowledge that emanates from direct and authentic spiritual experience. In a sense this is true of everything else, including science. One begins with faith in a proposition or a method and works patiently till one finds the answer. Thus, we choose one out of many possibilities to strive for. Widening this intrinsic faith rather than confining it within a fixed system of belief is perhaps the most important task of the therapist. Here we must distinguish between faith and belief since the two are commonly confused; although somewhat allied, they are very different in their power and potency.

Belief is directed outward. It is a system of thought held by a mind or a heart and will be conditioned to respond to certain social movements. Faith is more intrinsic, the very grain and mark of man, as the *Gītā* says. It is the spontaneous cry of the soul, which is often buried beneath dead rituals, mechanical beliefs and professed creeds. It is the psychotherapist's task to patiently extract this intrinsic faith, the inner scripture hidden in every heart. This is the Indian version of cognitive therapy, where a client's mind is approached through her/his soul. To change from within by using the client's own faith is therefore the method favoured by the therapist. Towards this end, he moves from the surface to the depths, from outward and professed beliefs and non-beliefs towards that which is concealed in the secret spaces of the soul. Using the helpful material offered by the client's mind, heart and will, the therapist works patiently, offering timely suggestions and intuitive guidance to recover this faith. And it is in this process that we find the role of cognitive and other aspects of the patient's inner constitution.

Despite the enormous complexity of Indian thought, the common cognitive and emotional structures supporting belief are fairly simple. They can be chiefly summarized as belief in an individual soul, in a personal Divine (whether

outwardly professed or not in the corresponding philosophical school), in rebirth as one of the means used by nature to arrive at evolutionary fulfilment, in the existence of cosmic forces that help or harm us, and finally, a belief in *mukti* or liberation or a state of soul-perfection as the final goal which all shall one day reach. At the same time, the Indian mind has one great advantage vis-à-vis this complexity—it has become catholic in its approach since it readily accepts the presence of diverse approaches to Truth and Freedom and God. The Indian mind is more ready to accept the word of an enlightened man. It is not because Indians are more credulous, as is commonly believed, but because of the nature of their inner being, which is awake to subtler and deeper realities and is aware that the mind must subordinate itself before the spirit. They know instinctively that Truth can be arrived at not through reason and analysis, but through faith and practice. Most of all, they believe that God's Grace or the intervention of a highly developed person can help us overcome difficulties. The therapist can use these cognitive structures and emotional bonds, already deeply rooted in the Indian psyche.

Whether faith is scientific or not is not the issue here. But if what we have discovered is nothing compared to what remains to be discovered, then man must indeed proceed on faith, a faith in matter or in the spirit, in reason or in faith itself. Especially when it comes to something as subtle as psychology, we must know that truth is not only an external objective reality but an intimate subjective reality, deeply real to the one identified with it. And of all realities known to mankind, there is none more insistent, attractive and universal than the experience of the Divine within and around us, the one simultaneously objective and subjective experience. To deny it in the name of science is to deny the very roots of life itself, and to deny man and his total existence. This is the great truth that Indian psychology carries within it, if we care to listen to its voice of wisdom and compassion. To deny it and give our material research precedence may harm the progression of the human race and its hope to conquer pain and evil. But let us hope that this denial is temporary, for beyond the vision of our material science waits the spirit of a greater truth in man's heart, ready to free us from grief and suffering. The limits of our sight are not the limits of light!

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5

Psychotherapy and Integral Yoga Psychology

Michael Miovic

Introduction

In the last decade, a consensus has been reached that it is important to address existential, religious and spiritual concerns in the daily practice of clinical psychology and psychiatry (Richards & Bergin, 1997; Karasu, 1999; Josephson & Peteet, 2004), as well as in palliative care settings (Sulmasy, 2006). For not only are religion and spirituality pervasive cultural phenomena that can have both positive and negative effects on mental health (Shafranske, 1996; Koenig, 1998; Richards & Bergin, 2000), but it is also quite possible that soul and Spirit actually exist. That is, nothing in science or philosophy definitively *disproves* the existence of a divine reality, and therefore mental health professionals need at least to be acquainted with spiritual models of psychology (Miovic, 2004a). Even if they do not personally ascribe to such models, they will encounter many clients who do and find them useful.

The current author has detailed elsewhere the history and central issues of spiritual psychology, from both Western and Asian perspectives (Miovic, 2004a). With regard to Indian spiritual philosophy, there is a tradition in the West stretching from James and Jung through contemporary transpersonal psychology that has always been sympathetic to the experiential insights of Hindu and Buddhist psycho-spiritual practice (Jung & Jaffe, 1961; James & Marty, 1982; Scotton, Chinen & Battista, 1996; Cortright, 1997; Taylor, 1999). In addition, an increasingly compelling body of scientific research supports the veracity of various parapsychological phenomena, and has demonstrated that consciousness is non-local, that is, not limited to the confines of the brain (Byrd, 1988; Radin, 1997; Harris, Gowda & Kolb, 1999; Braud, 2000; Koopman & Blasband, 2002; Standish, Johnson, Kozak & Richards, 2003; Radin & Schlitz, 2005). Today, the convergence of these two streams of thought is leading to a growing interest in Indian psychology, which has always been interested in methods of expanding consciousness so as to find spiritual liberation and overcome suffering (Cornelissen, 2001; Rao, 2002; Joshi & Cornelissen, 2004; Rao, Paranjpe & Dalal, 2008). Indeed, the present book is proof of this renewed interest in the ancient tradition of Indian psychology, both in India and abroad.

Within this larger context, the aim of this chapter is to explore some of the

concerns of clinical psychology, with special reference to the areas of overlap between psychotherapy and Sri Aurobindo's model of Integral Yoga Psychology (IYP). Here, IYP is used as an organizing framework because Sri Aurobindo interpreted *yoga* as being primarily a *psychological* process of self-cultivation and ego-transformation, and expressed his insights in modern English. Like psychotherapists, Sri Aurobindo was deeply interested in the problem of how to change character structure and behaviour; only, he felt the key to this change was ultimately spiritual (Dalal, 2001a). Indeed, many of his letters discuss a variety of neurotic and even psychotic symptoms that today fall under the purview of clinical psychology and psychiatry (Sri Aurobindo, 1970; Dalal, 1987). Since IYP accepts the existence of a divine Being/Reality who supports the relative existence(s) of all subsidiary beings/realities, this chapter will present a more theistic model of spiritually informed psychotherapy. For readers who prefer other metaphysical orientations, Indian psychology is graciously broad and diverse, and other chapters in this book present various approaches to spiritual psychology based on non-theistic yet non-dualistic world-views.

Faith as a developmental milestone

As just highlighted, there are many legitimate conceptual frameworks for spiritually informed psychotherapy, and these can generally be grouped into one of three metaphysical orientations, namely theistic, non-theistic (or agnostic) and atheistic (as in non-local studies based on a quantum model of consciousness). Regardless of one's personal orientation, however, it is useful to consider that if indeed there is a supreme Being/Reality, then to have faith in the existence of It is an important step in psychological development. That is, in a divinely constituted universe, to have spiritual faith is not regressive but progressive, and is a normal stage of psychological development to be followed by a subsequent stage in which one actually perceives, experiences and relates intimately with the supreme Being/Reality.

Perhaps an analogy may help illustrate this point: as Mahler showed, the development of object permanence around months 18–24 of a child's life is a major developmental milestone that allows the infant to separate from his or her mother, because s/he now has the capacity to maintain an internal image of 'mother' despite her physical absence. Object permanence is therefore not a defence against separation anxiety; it is an improved perception of the nature of reality that helps the child to master separation anxiety (Gabbard, 2000). Likewise with faith in the Divine: the correct conviction that the Divine exists even when not physically visible allows adult human beings to master the larger anxieties of living based on an improved internal representation of the actual nature of reality. Thus, genuine spiritual faith is not a psychological defence against existential anxiety; it is a developmental achievement that allows one to master existential anxiety. Admittedly the analogy is not perfect, because the process Mahler described establishes the child's ego as separate from the mother's, while spiritual faith leads beyond the ego towards a relationship in which the ego experiences itself as merging into the Divine. Nonetheless, the analogy is good enough to establish why, from the

perspective of a theistic model of psychology, the development of faith should be clinically supported (Miovic, 2001).

While no one has yet managed objectively to prove or disprove the existence of the Divine, it is important to understand the philosophical issue described above in order to develop a critical perspective on the literature about psychotherapy and spirituality. Thus far, most Western psychologists writing on the subject come from either a Judeo-Christian or Buddhist background. Not surprisingly, the Western literature on Buddhist psychology adopts a pragmatic and non-theistic approach to spirituality, much as did the historical Buddha (Molino, 1998; Michalon, 2001; Twemlow, 2001). Meditation and mindfulness practices are empirically noted to improve spiritual, mental, emotional and even physical well-being (Kabat-Zinn, Lipworth & Burney, 1985; Kabat-Zinn, Massion, Kristeller, Peterson, Fletcher & Pbert, 1992; Kaplan, Goldenberg & Galvin-Nadeau, 1993; Miller, Fletcher & Kabat-Zinn, 1995; Carlson & Garland, 2005); and fascinating new work is beginning to elucidate the neurophysiological basis of meditation as well (Newberg, & d'Aquili, 1998; Newberg & d'Aquili, 2001; Lazar, Kerr, Wasserman, Gray, et al., 2005; Cahn & Polich, 2006). Also, psychotherapists report that engaging in non-judgemental awareness of the moment during therapy sessions improves their effectiveness as therapists and facilitates the resolution of emotional suffering in clients, which is the main work of psychotherapy (Epstein, 1995; Finn & Rubin, 2000; Germer, Siegel & Fulton, 2005). However, the question of whether or not soul and Spirit exist, and whether clients might be having experiences or perceptions of such at times, is almost entirely avoided in this literature.

On the other hand, psychotherapists writing from the Judeo-Christian perspective have naturally grappled more with the issue of spiritual faith and the individual's relationship with the Divine. This line of inquiry began with Jung's work on archetypes and the phenomenon of a psychological 'God-image' (McLynn, 1996), although his views had little direct effect on mainstream psychoanalytic thinking because of the historic split between Freud and Jung. However, within the Freudian tradition, Winnicott's notions of transitional objects and transitional phenomenon allowed various analysts to re-interpret what Freud called the 'illusion' of religion as a developmentally necessary need for human beings to find meaning and creative connections in the world around them. Subsequently, Rizzuto advanced this line of thinking by showing how the development of intrapsychic structures of God-representation parallels the development of other object relations and may complete an integrated sense of self (Rizzuto, 1979). Rizzuto stopped short of asserting that God is actually real, but Meissner advanced this trajectory by exploring how faith can be understood simultaneously in psychodynamic terms and as referring to a real Christ, a real God, and a real sacrament (Meissner, 2000). Still, he remained cautious about the following step in the sequence, Spero's introduction of an ontologically real God as a factor both in the God-representation and in the therapy process (Spero, 1992). Meissner was concerned about the dangers of therapists wrongly presuming to *know* the Divine's will in the therapy process, but others have gone on to address these legitimate

concerns and articulate appropriate ways to conduct faith-based psychotherapy (Richards & Bergin, 1997, 2000).

This brings us to IYP, which synthesizes the experiential insights of *yoga* and Buddhist phenomenology with the spiritual faith of Western monotheistic traditions and the empirical insights of material science, so as to arrive at what we might characterize as non-dual evolutionary theism. That is, Sri Aurobindo proposes that Matter is a densely dormant involution of the infinitely conscious *saccidānanda* into a poise of apparent unconsciousness, and that evolution is the ordered process through which the Divine then progressively reveals itself across space and time under the conditions of matter. In this world-view, transpersonal and spiritual experiences represent the leading edge of the evolution of consciousness on earth, and presage the future emergence of a supra-human life form that will exceed the human consciousness even as human consciousness currently exceeds that of animals and lower life forms (Sri Aurobindo, 1970). Evidently, this interpretation of the aim of life and the ultimate nature of reality offers an interesting new perspective from which to conceptualize some of the central concerns of psychotherapy (Dalal, 2001b; Miovic, 2008).

Soul and ego

Sri Aurobindo uses the term 'psychic being' to refer to the individual soul, which he equates with the *caitya puruṣa* of classical Indian yoga psychology. In *yogic* terms, he defines the psychic being as an eternal but evolving aspect of the *ātman* (non-dual transcendent Self) that the *jīvātman* (an individualized but non-evolving aspect of the *ātman*) puts forth into the phenomenal play of *prakṛti* (mutative substance of all the physical and supra-physical worlds of manifested existence). However, in contradistinction with traditional notions of reincarnation, Sri Aurobindo places a new emphasis on the evolutionary aim of the process. He posits that the purpose of reincarnation is not to prepare the soul to transcend the cycle of karma (as in the classical definition of *nirvāṇa*), but to increase the soul's capacity to perfect life in the physical world, which, as previously mentioned, is itself a manifestation of the Divine reality. Indeed, he argues that this evolution of consciousness is the real force driving the physical evolution of biological forms that are increasingly able to express higher levels of consciousness, for example, the evolution of the animal into the mammalian brain, culminating currently in the human brain (Miovic, 2004b).

In terms of psychotherapy, this world-view implies that psycho-spiritual development consists of two broad lines of evolution, one the growth of an eternal psychic being or soul, the other the growth of a transient outer being or ego, which is a nexus of cognition, affect and physiology. Now the concept of the ego is the central, organizing principle among the diverse schools of Western psychotherapy. Although it is temporarily being under-used due to the ascendance of neurobiology and psychopharmacology, informed psychoanalysts have pointed out that the concept of the ego encompasses neurophysiology and can therefore

still help to integrate the treatment of even 'biological' diseases such as schizophrenia (Diamond, 1997). In fact, the whole premise of the reigning biopsychosocial model of clinical practice is that biological and psychosocial therapies are both relevant to caring for the total human being. What Sri Aurobindo and others add to this proposition is that spirituality is a fourth dimension of consciousness that needs to be annexed to the biopsychosocial model. Even if one rejects the notion of reincarnation, as long as one accepts the reality of a soul that takes birth on earth at least once, the issues of psycho-spiritual growth outlined in this chapter remain fundamentally the same, the only difference being in how many lives the incarnating soul has to work them out.

So then, what exactly is the relationship between the soul and the ego according to IYP? And what are the psychological qualities and characteristics of each? We shall examine these two questions in order. First, there is the problem of what is meant by 'transcending the ego'. In psychodynamic therapy, the whole aim is to strengthen the ego by repairing deficits (giving 'corrective emotional experience') and making unconscious conflicts conscious. In the vernacular of spiritual practice, on the other hand, people are enjoined not to have 'big egos' and to 'be humble' before God. How does one resolve this apparent antithesis? The key is that the vernacular 'big ego' in psychotherapeutic terms refers to narcissistic vulnerability, an ego deficit well-described by Kohut, which is compensated for with narcissistic defences of grandiosity (Mitchell & Black, 1995; Gabbard, 2000). Sri Aurobindo (1970, p. 1392) touches on the neurotic issues of narcissistic grandiosity vs. a punishing superego in the following letter to a disciple:

Humility is needful, but constant self-depreciation does not help; excessive self-esteem and self-depreciation are both wrong attitudes. To recognise any defects without exaggerating them is useful but, once recognised, it is no good dwelling on them always; you must have the confidence that the Divine Force can change everything and you must let the Force work.

The stable confidence that Sri Aurobindo prescribes here requires a well-integrated ego that allows for what Rizzuto and Meissner would call a mature object-relationship with God. Therefore, in spiritual philosophy, what is really meant by 'transcending the ego' is not to regress to earlier stages of ego development, but to complete the growth of the ego by adding to it another source of sustenance—the awareness of the soul. Thus, genuine spirituality does not erode individuality in a regressive fashion, as happens in different ways in schizophrenia and cults, but rather heightens and deepens true individuality by bringing out the soul, which is a unique manifestation of the Divine. In Sri Aurobindo's words (1970, p. 1368):

There is individuality in the psychic being, but not egoism. Egoism goes when the individual unites himself with the Divine or is entirely surrendered to the Divine.... On the higher spiritual planes there is no ego, because the oneness of the Divine is felt, but there may be the sense of one's true person or individuality — not ego, but a portion of the Divine.

This distinction between soul and ego is the theoretical foundation of IYP's

approach to spiritually informed psychotherapy. Sri Aurobindo acknowledged that childhood and adolescence are critical periods for ego development, and on that basis—for the most part—did not recommend taking up a serious spiritual practice until adulthood. He encouraged families and schools to accept that children do often have spontaneous contact with their souls (a phenomenon mostly overlooked by Western psychology), but he did not advise undertaking conscious efforts at ego-transformation until later. When people are developmentally ready, however, he described the process of transforming the ego as follows (1970, p. 1376):

Everybody has the ego and it is impossible to get rid of it altogether except by two things — the opening of the psychic within and the descent of a wider ego-free consciousness from above. The psychic being opening does not get rid of the ego at once but purifies it and offers it and all the movements to the Divine, so that one becomes unegoistic through self-giving and surrender ... but it cannot happen in so short a time.

The complexities of how Sri Aurobindo classifies spiritual experiences according to their subjectively perceived somatotopic organization (that is, opening from within or descending from above) go beyond the purview of this chapter. What bears repetition here is that the final ‘unegoistic’ state he recommends is progressive and adaptive. While both psychosis and neurosis (to a lesser degree) increase fear and decrease the capacity for intimacy and generative love, spirituality as Sri Aurobindo defines it decreases fear and increases the ability to see reality as it is and love others as they are, because one is psychologically fulfilled in the Divine. As Erikson showed, the ego naturally broadens its scope of concerns to include more and more people as it matures, culminating in the healthy generativity of adulthood (Erikson, 1997). IYP would interpret this natural trend towards un-selfishness and individuation, which connects rather than separates one from the others, as due to the covert influence of the soul (psychic being) on ego development. This interaction effect accounts for the stages of faith development identified by Fowler in his research (Fowler, 1981). However, note again that IYP views the soul as ontologically distinct from the ego; hence, it is possible for people to have mature souls but immature or impaired ego-functioning (as happens, for different reasons, in spiritually gifted children, certain patients with psychotic disorders, and dementia in people with strong psychic development).

The second issue of concern, and one more apposite of the practical needs of psychotherapy, is how to distinguish the psychological qualities and characteristics of the soul from those of the ego. According to Sri Aurobindo, the soul’s influence is felt in all that leaves the impression of ‘sweetness and light’. By this, he does not mean any artificial pleasantry or niceness, but a deep and genuine inner ‘movement’ that flows purely from a spiritual fount. To name a few such qualities: sincerity, honesty, compassion, joy, love (in the sense of *agape*), forgiveness, patience, humility, courage, devotion, gratitude and the appreciation of beauty. Most people have felt the soul-touch at least once, if not frequently, in the charming innocence of children, in whom the psychic consciousness is often active, albeit in an unformed fashion. Many people also have openings to

the soul when appreciating great music, literature, or art (Sri Aurobindo, 1992), or when communing with nature—flowers, for example, are especially full of psychic beauty (The Mother, 2000). For psychotherapy, the most important quality of the psychic being is that it is inherently joyful and free of ambivalence or conflict:

Let the sweetness and the happy feeling increase, for they are the strongest sign of the soul, the psychic being awake and in touch with us. Let not mistakes of thought or speech or action disturb you—put them away from you as something superficial which the Power and Light will deal with and remove. Keep to the one central thing—your soul and these higher realities it brings with it. (Sri Aurobindo, 1970, p. 1117)

Significantly, a new school of Western psychology, called ‘positive psychology’, has recently started to study the sources, benefits and sustenance of positive emotions and character traits such as gratitude, forgiveness, joy, love, courage, the appreciation of beauty, hope, curiosity, team-spirit, and so on (Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi, 2000; Snyder & Lopez, 2002; Fredrickson, 2004). Research in this field is beginning to empirically validate interventions that foster positive emotions (Seligman, Steen, Park, et al., 2005), and has found that such feelings often arise during ‘flow’ states in which the consciousness of the agent becomes one with the activity, as can happen sometimes during satisfying work, play, sports, prayer, meditation, or artistic expression (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990). From the perspective of IYP, all of the feelings and traits aimed at in positive psychology are due ultimately to contact with the psychic being (soul), and all methods for fostering them simply varieties of *sādhana*. The main concern from the *yogic* perspective is therefore not theoretical but practical, e.g., actually finding and practicing the method that best helps any given individual or group increase the depth, duration and frequency of contact with the soul.

We have thus addressed the first half of the clinical problem—how to recognize and cultivate the soul-influence in human life. But the second half remains, namely the differential diagnosis of various levels of ego functioning, which is the bulk of what confronts practising clinicians. Therapists have all seen countless instances of false or inauthentic positive emotion, such as altruism that hides unconscious anger, faithfulness that avoids loneliness and fear, hypomanic happiness that distracts one from grief, forgiveness motivated by guilt, etc. What does Sri Aurobindo say about such instances in which apparently positive emotions are being used to defend against awareness of hidden negative ones?

Defence mechanisms vs. transformational processes

Before answering the last question directly, let us review the context first. The notion of defence mechanisms is one of the enduring pearls of wisdom gleaned from psychoanalysis. In his research following a cohort of Harvard graduates over several decades, Vaillant elegantly studied the interaction between defensive styles and Eriksonian stages of adult development across the life span. He found that in general, people tend to grow towards using more mature defence mechanisms as they

age, and that those who are stuck behind are unhappy and fare poorly (Vaillant, 1993, 2000). The basic defence mechanisms cluster into four groups: psychotic, immature (borderline), intermediate (neurotic) and mature (see Table 5.1).

1. Psychotic	a. Delusional projection b. Denial c. Distortion
2. Immature	a. Projection b. Fantasy c. Hypochondriasis d. Passive aggression e. Acting out f. Dissociation
3. Intermediate (Neurotic)	a. Displacement b. Isolation / Intellectualization c. Repression d. Reaction formation
4. Mature	a. Altruism b. Sublimation c. Suppression d. Anticipation e. Humour

Table 5.1. Mechanisms of ego-defence
Source: Vaillant, (1993; pp. 36–37).

1. Transitional	a. Witnessing b. Listening c. Going into d. Understanding (Mindfulness)
2. Spiritual	a. Aspiration (Invocation or Remembering) b. Surrender (Offering or Sacrifice) c. Rejection (Purification or Discrimination)

Table 5.2. Processes of ego-transformation
Source: Miovic, 2001.

Now, in terms of Indian psychology, what Vaillant has demonstrated is an evolution of consciousness, a growth out of the darkness and turbulence of the inchoate ego to the relative stability and self-mastery of the well-formed ego. Over two millennia ago, the *Bhagavad Gītā* described the same sequence of ego development as in Table 5.1, only in less detail and without listing specific defence mechanisms. In his discourse on *yoga* to Arjuna, Kṛṣṇa described personality growth as proceeding from a *tāmasic* character structure (primitive/immature), through *rājasic* (immature/intermediate), to *sāttvic* (mature), and finally beyond into spiritual. Thus, both Indian and Western psychology agree that mature defences are necessary for the pursuit of happiness: people who know only how to deny and project live in raw misery, while those who can sublimate and deploy humour are much freer to find meaning and spots of joy in life, or, as Freud put it succinctly, 'to work and to love' despite the burden of normal human suffering.

IYP also recognizes the existence of defence mechanisms, but understands them within the larger context of the evolution of consciousness. Take, for instance, the following observation by Sri Aurobindo (1970, p. 1329):

The vital started in its evolution with obedience to impulse and no reason — as for strategy, the only strategy it understands is some tactics by which it can compass its desires. It does not like the voice of knowledge and wisdom — but curiously enough by the necessity which has grown up in man of justifying action by reason, the *vital mind* has developed a strategy of its own which is to get the reason to find out reasons for justifying its own feelings and impulses.

This passage clearly conveys Freud's idea of the 'id' (although the Aurobindonian concept of the 'vital' is broader than that of the 'id'), implies the existence of the unconscious, and cites the defence of rationalization. Sri Aurobindo did not explicitly catalogue the other defence mechanisms listed in Table 5.1 (although he alluded to some in other letters) because he was more interested in the fact that all of the defence mechanisms depend *a priori* upon the ego. His primary aim, therefore, was to transform the ego into a centre of individuality capable of manifesting the Divine. The only way to achieve this goal, in Sri Aurobindo's opinion, is to evoke the psychic being (soul) through spiritual practice, and then infuse the psychic consciousness into the outer mental, vital and physical parts of the ego, so as to slowly effectuate a radical transformation of egocentric into soul-centric awareness. From the Aurobindonian perspective, cognitive behaviour therapy (CBT) attempts to change ego-functioning via the influence of the mental being, psychoanalysis via the vital, and psychopharmacology via the physical. However, while each of these approaches has its own relative utility, the problem is that the mental, vital and physical components of the ego are all inherently ignorant and in conflict with each other, and in any case no final solution to the ego is achievable at the level of the ego. Only the psychic being (true soul) is by its very nature capable of lasting harmony and unalloyed happiness, because it is a portion of the Divine, and therefore one must find and harness the psychic consciousness in order to definitively transform the ego. Hence the relevance of the psychic being to psychotherapy.

However, if the psychic being (soul) is real and can actually transform the ego function, then it must have modes or processes of operation that are distinct from the defence mechanisms listed in Table 5.1. Sri Aurobindo explained that such psycho-spiritual functions of the psychic being (soul) do indeed exist, and he named them ‘aspiration, surrender, and rejection’. He defines *aspiration* as a conscious remembrance of the Divine and invocation for It to transform all of one’s inner and outer awareness and action, while *surrender* is the inner movement of opening oneself entirely to the Divine will, and receiving and following its guidance without any reservations. Finally, *rejection* is the process of actively evaluating the source and quality of one’s thoughts, feelings and actions, and discriminating and discarding all that does not express the soul (that is, all that is motivated by the ego or by adverse forces of ignorance and falsehood that seek to oppose spiritual evolution). The essential impulse for these three movements comes from the psychic being; however, if the ego is willing, it can take them up and consciously elaborate them. To do so constitutes spiritual *sādhana* or faith-practice, and thus, a deficiency in any of these psycho-spiritual movements, or an imbalance among them, leads to an incomplete practice of *yoga*.

Against this background, we can now expand the hierarchy of ego development in Table 5.1 by extending it vertically to add the ego-transformational processes listed in Table 5.2. The definition of transformational processes is that they are psychological movements that approach negative or otherwise painful content (drives, wishes, feelings, thoughts) directly and transmute it, instead of trying to ignore, disguise or divert it as defence mechanisms do. Sri Aurobindo named the ‘spiritual’ processes in Table 5.2; however, in order to integrate IYP with the existing knowledge of psychotherapy, I have created a bridging category dubbed ‘transitional processes’. Transitional processes are already used extensively in both CBT and dynamic therapy, and are synonymous with the analytic concept of the ‘observing ego’. These functions are classified here as transformational processes because they are not defence mechanisms per se, but rather adaptive capacities of the ego that derive ultimately from the soul’s covert influence on the ego (Miovic, 2004b). Although one does not have to be conscious of one’s soul in order to have a good observing ego, if the soul is entirely dormant (as in sociopathy), there will be a weak or absent observing ego.

In terms of definitions, to *witness* means to detach from and observe the flow of thoughts and feelings without interfering, controlling or altering them. Witnessing is taught formally in *vipāssanā* and other meditation techniques, and is used extensively in CBT to identify negative automatic thoughts and cascades of catastrophic thinking. Freud also sought witnessing in his method of free association, in which he enjoined the patient to ‘say whatever comes to mind, without holding anything back’. On the other hand, *listening* means to turn one’s awareness towards arising content so as to study and learn from it, while *going into* means to consciously experience a thought/feeling as much as possible, particularly if the experience is painful or difficult. Finally, *understanding* is the balanced process of practising witnessing, listening and going into over time, the result of which is

that liberating awareness that analysts call ‘curative insight’ and Buddhists call ‘mindfulness’. Prototypically, in psychotherapy periods of witnessing allow painful content to arise, which can then be listened to and later gone into, so as to arrive eventually at directly experienced understanding. This cycle is repeated in miniature within each therapy session, and on a larger scale over time across many visits. Also, clients often initially delegate the transitional capacities of ego-transformation to the therapist, and it becomes the therapist’s role to gradually help clients learn and internalize these capacities over time (Miovic, 2001).

Practical implications

One good clinical illustration of the transformational processes listed in Table 5.2 is the 12-step method of Alcoholics Anonymous (AA). Much has already been written about AA from sociological, psychological and scientific perspectives, and we should briefly review these findings before proceeding to amplify this knowledge in the light of IYP. To begin with, AA is the single most used method for treating problem drinking in the world, and the scope of AA’s organization is now global. After more than half a century of debate regarding its efficacy, scientific research has recently established that participation in AA is not merely *correlated* with decreased drinking, but actually *causes* it (McKellar, Stewart & Humphreys, 2003). Research has also shown that while both professional treatment with CBT and non-professional treatment with AA are probably equally effective for light to moderate drinkers, for heavy and severe drinkers AA is more effective (Morgentstern, Bux & Labouvie, 2003); and that regardless of drinking intensity, more frequent and prolonged attendance at AA meetings yields greater rates of abstinence (Bond, Kaskutas & Weisner, 2003; Cloud, Ziegler & Blondell, 2004; McCrady, Epstein & Kahler, 2004; Moos & Moos, 2004b; Bottlender & Soyka, 2005). Finally, one of the important mediating factors of AA’s effectiveness involves opportunities for recovering alcoholics to help each other and help their communities (Pagano, Friend & Tonigan, 2004; Zemore & Kaskutas, 2004), and neither psychotherapy nor psychopharmacology has ever been shown to be *more* effective than AA (Vaillant, 2005). Thus, the best treatment for alcoholism probably entails a collaborative relationship between mental health professionals and AA, especially for patients who have severe mental illnesses (Brooks & Penn, 2003), and indeed data show that such collaboration can improve clients’ long-term participation in AA and thus improve outcomes (Kelly & Moos, 2003; Moos & Moos, 2004a).

As for the spirituality of AA, Vaillant has noted that the individual and group spirituality of AA probably taps into some of the same pleasure and reward circuits in the brain that addictions do, and much more powerfully than professional treatment can, so AA offers something invaluable to the alcoholic. Also, he has argued convincingly that AA is neither a cult nor a religion (Vaillant, 2005). Nonetheless, sceptics may still maintain that the ‘Higher Power’ invoked in AA may just be a useful fiction for eliciting a placebo response, and that the real benefits of AA derive from the solidarity of group membership, frequent and ubiquitous meetings

to provide an alternative to drinking, confrontation by peers who challenge the drinker's defences of denial and deception, and a series of tasks (the 12 steps) to restructure the alcoholic's sense of self and overcome feelings of guilt. However, philosophically speaking, it is important to remember that the existence of such mechanisms of action does not negate the existence of a Higher Power, and if indeed the Divine exists, then these mechanisms of action are simply the channels through which the spirituality of AA works.

From the perspective of IYP, the effectiveness of AA re-demonstrates the perennial wisdom that spiritual groups (including *āśramas*, *saṅghams* and churches) help to propagate *dharma*. The more people convene to seek help from the Divine, the more the Divine answers through all available channels—provided, of course, that the inner call is sincere. Second, IYP would note that the proverbial 'devil in the bottle' is not just metaphorical, but real. *Yoga* has always acknowledged the existence of hostile forces and beings (*rākṣasas*, *asuras*) that seek to slay the spiritual seeker and retard or destroy spiritual evolution (Sri Aurobindo, 1970, pp. 393–398), and IYP posits that these hostile forces frequently use alcohol and other intoxicants as an entry into the vulnerable individual, because intoxicants cloud consciousness and undermine reasoning and judgement (Basu, 2004, and personal communication). Lastly, it is impressive that AA charges its clients no fees and most AA service positions are unpaid; that its organizational structure has no significant social hierarchy; and that its governing principles prevent members from gaining fame or consolidating power (Vaillant, 2005). Few other organizations in the world can claim an equal purity of process and dedication to egalitarian ideals. Also, the Big Book's language is often quite beautiful, and the sincerity, honesty and lucidity of its thought and feeling substance reveals a psychic inspiration. Appreciate, for instance, the penetrating transparency of the following: 'Anonymity is the spiritual foundation of all our Traditions, ever reminding us to place principles before personalities' (Alcoholics Anonymous, 1976). That is pure eloquence of the soul speaking.

Likewise, consider the remarkable 12 steps themselves, which on paper read like *yoga sūtras* that teach the soul movements of aspiration, surrender and rejection. Step 1 begins with understanding, or the observing ego's ability to hold a painful truth without enlisting defences to alter or distort perception, while Step 2 proceeds upwards with an *aspiration* to the Divine for transformation:

1. We admitted we were powerless over alcohol—that our lives had become unmanageable.
2. Came to believe that a Power greater than ourselves could restore us to sanity.

Steps 3 through 7 focus on *surrender*, with aspiration and rejection in the background:

3. Made a decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of *God as we understood Him*.
4. Made a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves.

5. Admitted to God, ourselves, and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs.
6. Were entirely ready to have God remove all these defects of character.
7. Humbly asked Him to remove our shortcomings.

Steps 8 through 10 focus on *rejection*, or the psychic being's conscious will to transform the faults of the outer personality. In this working-through process, the functions of the observing ego are enlisted and applied inter-personally:

8. Made a list of all persons we had harmed, and became willing to make amends to them all.
9. Made direct amends to such people wherever possible, except when to do so would injure them or others.
10. Continued to take personal inventory and when we were wrong promptly admitted it.

Finally, Steps 11 and 12 consolidate the work and provide a prescription for spiritual living based on the continued application of aspiration, surrender and rejection in all activities:

11. Sought through prayer and meditation to improve our conscious contact with God as we understood Him, praying only for knowledge of His will for us and the power to carry it out.
12. Having had a spiritual awakening as the result of these steps, we tried to carry this message to alcoholics, and to practice these principles in all our affairs.

These last two steps, minus the passing reference to alcoholics, are as concise a definition of *yoga* as any written and integrate the three main approaches to the Divine described in the *Bhagavad Gītā* and reaffirmed by Sri Aurobindo in his *Synthesis of yoga: bhakti* (devotion, prayer), *jñāna* (knowledge, meditation) and *karma* (action, work). Thus, whatever the limitations of the human beings who seek the help of AA, from the perspective of IYP it is clear that the 12-step method is a spiritual discipline that seeks to re-awaken the psychic being (soul) slumbering in the alcoholic and save him or her from the devil in the bottle. It is a genuine spiritual inspiration.

A second area of IYP's clinical relevance is in deepening clinicians' understanding of the unconscious and resistance, which are primary issues in dynamic psychotherapy. Sri Aurobindo preferred to call the unconscious the 'subconscious' or 'subconscient', because in his view even inert matter is endowed with consciousness (1970, p. 1597):

For the subconscient receives impressions of all we do or experience in our lives and keeps these impressions in it, sending up often fragments of them in sleep. It is a very important part of the being, but we can do nothing much with it by the conscious will. It is the higher Force working in us that in its natural course will open the subconscient to itself and bring down into it its control and light.

The Aurobindonian concept of resistance encompasses the entire psychodynamic sense of resistance, plus more. This is why transformative spiritual practice is a life-long endeavour and takes even more time and discipline than psychoanalysis, because its scope is total and its final aim is to manifest the Divine in the world:

The mind resists with an obstinate persistency in argument and a constant confusion of ideas, the vital with a fury of bad will aided by the mind's obliging reasonings on its side, the physical resists with an obstinate inertia and crass fidelity to old habit, and when they have done, the general Nature comes in and says, "What, you are going to get free from me so easily? Not, if I know it," and it besieges and throws back the old nature on you again and again as long as it can (Sri Aurobindo, 1970, p. 1111).

Thus, we see that without reading a word of Freud or Jung, Sri Aurobindo developed a complex understanding of human psychology, including concepts of the ego, the importance of childhood development, defence mechanisms, the unconscious, the significance of dreams (alluded to above and elaborated elsewhere), resistance and the importance of biology. However, where Sri Aurobindo diverges from Western psychology and psychiatry is in his spiritual realism. The practical consequence of this is that he recommends that people find their souls *before* trying to work through the unconscious, because the psychic being is a more powerful agent of knowledge and action than the observing ego. This was the basis of his objection to psychoanalysis as a disciple explained it to him:

If one wishes to purify and transform the nature, it is the power of these higher ranges to which one must open and raise to them and change by them both the subliminal and the surface being But to begin by opening up the lower subconscious, risking to raise up all that is foul or obscure in it, is to go out of one's way to invite trouble. First, one should make the higher mind and vital strong and firm and full of light and peace from above; afterwards one can open up or even dive into the subconscious with more safety and some chance of a rapid and successful change. (Sri Aurobindo, 1970, pp. 1606–1607)

Note that when Sri Aurobindo wrote this letter in the 1930s, he was criticizing the early analytic preoccupation with quickly unearthing childhood libidinal conflicts. However, since then psychoanalysis has evolved along the lines Sri Aurobindo recommended, such that today analysts are careful to strengthen the observing ego (that is, to 'make the higher mind and vital strong and firm') before exploring Oedipal issues. Also, there are many approaches to dynamic psychotherapy that avoid working directly with the unconscious and focus rather on the conscious, pre-conscious and real-time aspects of transference.

Case material

The following case material from a general out-patient psychiatry practice in the United States further illustrates the principles outlined in this chapter as they apply to psychotherapy:

A 24 year-old married Hispanic woman, with three young children, presented for treatment of severe panic disorder with agoraphobia, and moderate PTSD from childhood sexual abuse. She was grateful for education about her diagnoses, and obtained moderate relief after 3 weeks on clonazepam and citalopram. Based on this positive experience, she was eager to continue on in weekly therapy and medication management with a female resident, as I was leaving the clinic. At our third and final session, it struck me that the patient had consistently exuded an atmosphere of genuine sincerity, gratitude, trust, and an underlying joy of being despite her obvious anxiety. My counter-transference reaction to her was a peaceful feeling in my heart and the thought 'what a lovely person, such a blessing to meet her.' Further exploration revealed that she had an active Catholic faith but she had recently stopped going to church because she always 'yawned and got sleepy' during the services, and was worried that might be rude to her priest and to God. I asked if she felt bored by the sermons, and her face lit up as she replied to the contrary, 'oh no, the words are sometimes so inspiring, they go right into my heart.' I suggested that perhaps she got sleepy because she felt safe, and that maybe God could accept her sleeping in His arms 'like a little baby.' The patient visibly relaxed and replied, 'Yes, I think He wants me back. Two of my kids have dreamed of the Cross recently. I think it's a sign.'

Contrast that with the following vignette:

A 48 year-old divorced, Hispanic woman with an inactive Catholic faith, presented with moderately severe panic disorder and PTSD from sexual trauma as an adolescent. She spent 8 months of treatment not tolerating medications, resisting education about her diagnoses, and making me feel very frustrated and irritable. Dynamic exploration revealed many ways in which she had felt oppressed by her mother and was in turn oppressing her teenage daughter, but progress in therapy was painfully slow. During our last session before I left the clinic, she finally realized that she truly had panic attacks and agoraphobia, and expressed limited appreciation for my help.

The major difference between these two cases is the prominence of the psychic atmosphere in the first woman vs. a stubborn vital ego in the second. I would expect the first woman to be able to use spiritual processes of transformation (Table 5.2) to amplify the action of her observing ego in therapy. As she has active psychic movements, she might need help at times in differentiating these from ego defences. For example, she might confuse true aspiration with the defences of fantasy, reaction formation or altruism; or true rejection (a conscious will to change and grow) with the defences of repression or suppression. Her dreams might be rich and vivid, and one would need to distinguish between common dreams that reveal the subconscious and subliminal dreams that reveal the inner being (as happened when her *children* had dreams with a spiritual message for her). Naturally, resistances would arise at times during therapy and restrict the patient's contact with her psychic being, but the working-through process could be accelerated by offering each session to the Divine in whatever way would be mutually

agreeable to both the patient and the therapist. This could be done quickly and simply, with or without a particular theological overlay, but the key would be to do it with sincere aspiration and surrender.

Conclusion

This chapter has introduced Sri Aurobindo's Integral Yoga Psychology (IYP) as one possible model for integrating the wisdom of Indian spiritual philosophy with the insights of Western psychotherapy. The primary focus has been on exploring the relationship between the soul (psychic being) and the ego, and understanding how the soul can transform ego functioning. It is proposed that the psychic (soul) movements of aspiration, surrender and rejection extend the range of ego-functioning from ego-defensive operations to ego-transformative processes. Also, the 12-step model of AA is interpreted as potentially evoking these movements of aspiration, surrender and rejection. While Buddhist psychology offers a valuable non-theistic alternative to IYP's more theistic model of psychology, the strength of IYP is that it has a more richly developed concept of evolution and offers an orientation towards the future. Other frameworks for spiritually informed psychotherapy can and should be elaborated as well in order to suit the diverse needs and interests of patients and clinicians. Also, there is much work to be done in order to integrate culturally diverse understandings of spirituality into the mainstream of modern clinical practice.

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6

Concept and scope of *pratyāhāra* in management of mental health

K. M. Tripathi

The last five decades have seen a growing body of research in the areas of mental health and stress disorders on the one hand, and in the potential and promise of *yogic* practices in bringing about positive neuro-physiological and psychological changes on the other. A large number of medical reports showing the efficacy of *yogic* practices in the management of psycho-physiological problems have been published in a variety of journals. As far as the utility of *yogic* practices in managing mental problems are concerned, they are usually applied as an adjunct to other psychotherapeutic systems, or as part of psychosomatic rehabilitation and relaxation training.

The system of *yoga* can be conceptualized as one of self-healing. Following the technical definition of *yoga*, derived from Patañjali's *Yoga-Sūtras*, one could consider *vipāssanā*, transcendental meditation, and *śavāsana* as techniques of *pratyāhāra*, the control of the senses. Through *pratyāhāra*, one can attain complete isolation from both internal and external stimuli. Thus, the practice of *pratyāhāra* can help in managing the stresses of personal life and in regaining composure. *Pratyāhāra* has been described differently by different schools of thought. The *aṣṭāṅga yoga* view, the early and later *Upaniṣadic* view, and the Jain and Buddhist views are described below:

Pratyāhāra in aṣṭāṅga yoga

In the *aṣṭāṅga* or Eight Limb *yoga* of Patañjali, there are eight elements:

1. *Yama* (moral instructions)
2. *Niyama* (self-purification)
3. *Āsana* (posture)
4. *Prāṇāyāma* (rhythmic breath control)
5. *Pratyāhāra* (sense withdrawal)
6. *Dhāraṇā* (concentration)
7. *Dhyāna* (meditation)
8. *Samādhi* (higher unitive consciousness)

These eight limbs have been divided into two categories, viz., *bahiraṅga yoga* (exterior *yoga*) and *antaraṅga yoga* (interior *yoga*). Since *antaraṅga yoga* leads to meditation and transcendence as well as to the higher spiritual levels, it occupies a focal place in *aṣṭāṅga yoga*. The process of *antaraṅga yoga* begins with a perception, reflection or query, which finally leads to a momentary or prolonged state of transcendence. The whole course of *antaraṅga yoga* is a cognitive *yogic* practice, and not merely physical exercise as popularly perceived. The cognitive or psychological part of the eight-limb approach of *yoga* begins with *pratyāhāra*, which occupies a special conjunctive place between *bahiraṅga* and *antaraṅga yoga*. Thus, *pratyāhāra* can be seen as the entry point from *bahiraṅga* into *antaraṅga yoga*. In fact, without a proper comprehension of the concept, components, practice and application of *pratyāhāra*, further psychic upliftment in *yoga* is not possible.

The term *pratyāhāra* consists of three Sanskrit parts, viz., *prati* (in response to, obverse, opposed to, against), *ā* (near, towards) and *hr* (to bring back properly), and thus it literally means 'the act of collection' or 'to step back purposely in order to attain the right mode of consciousness in a more powerful way'. According to Patañjali,

The state of physical cutting-off of contact between the sense organs and their respective objects, i.e., the reflections of the sensory world in the mind, is called *pratyāhāra*. Regular practice of *pratyāhāra* leads to attainment of greater control over the senses and the functioning of the organismic system, and gradually the ability of complete attention and concentration is achieved (*Yoga Sūtra*, 2.54–56).

Here, the term *indriya* (translated as senses), used by Patañjali in reference to *pratyāhāra*, should be comprehended within a wider perspective, as all the mental processes and components that intervene in the interaction between consciousness and the material world. All these mental processes or components are subject to the practice of *pratyāhāra*. Thus, the entire process of *antaraṅga yoga* seems to be a continuum of *pratyāhāra* that initially starts with cutting off the interaction of the external sense organs with their respective objects, followed by disconnecting the *manas*, that is, sense-mind, from the senses. Further, at a more advanced level the *buddhi* (intellect), the discriminatory element of the mind, is detached from the mind, and finally the *ātman*, the real Self, is isolated from all mental impacts. Patañjali provides only a very brief account of *pratyāhāra* in the *Yoga-Sūtras*. In the later *Upaniṣadic* literature, the concept and methodology of *pratyāhāra* is duly developed into a more technical and applicable procedure. In modern times it has emerged as a powerful technique for mental health management, working through the modification of the mind-matter interaction.

***Pratyāhāra* in the *Upaniṣadic* scriptures**

***Pratyāhāra* in the early *Upaniṣadic* literature**

Pratyāhāra as a process and a continuum leading to self-realization is lucidly depicted in the *Taittirīyopaniṣad*, one of the earlier *Upaniṣads* (3rd chap. *Bhṛigu Valli*),

as the progressive experience of the five sheaths of the true Self, viz., corporeal (physical), biological (vital), psychological (mental), gnostic (supramental) and the beatific (spiritual). In its second chapter, the *Bhagavad Gītā* emphasizes the need for and importance of controlling the fickleness of mental activities (*Bhagavad Gītā*, 2.58–62, 67–68). While advocating the state of withdrawal from the senses inwards, the *Gītā* asserts that the one who is able to withdraw the senses from their corresponding objects, like a tortoise withdraws his limbs within the shell, finally attains perfection of the intellect (*Bhagavad Gītā*, 2.58).

Pratyāhāra in the later Upaniṣadic literature

Described below are the conceptualizations, rationale, techniques and outcomes of *pratyāhāra* as proposed in the later *Upaniṣadic* literature, composed between the 9th to the 13th centuries AD:

- *Pratyāhāra* is the introverted state of mind (*Trīśikhā-Brahmaṇa Upaniṣad*, 30).
- Detachment of senses from their respective objects, finally leading to a restrained state of mind, is called *pratyāhāra* (*Maṇḍala-Brahmaṇa Upaniṣad*, 1.7; *Yoga Cūḍāmaṇi Upaniṣad*, 120; *Darśana Upaniṣad*, 7.1; *Yoga-Tattva Upaniṣad*, 68).
- *Pratyāhāra* is the pleasant state of consciousness that observes the mind preoccupied with the impacts of objects of senses, and requires repeated and sustained practice (*Tejobindūpaniṣad*, 34).
- The same notion is depicted in the *Amṛtanādopaniṣad* (*Pratyāhāra-lakṣaṇam*, 5) with greater clarity. It says that *pratyāhāra* is the practice of realizing that the five senses and their respective sensory objects are the sources of agitation in the mind and consciousness, and it finally deems them as the extension and emanation of the serene Self, just as the divergent beams of the static sun give rise to different colours, shades and forms.

In the *Sāṇḍilya Upaniṣad* (1.17.1: a *pañcavidha pratyāhāra*) and the *Darśanopaniṣad*, five different kinds of *pratyāhāra* are described as follows:

- Forcible withdrawal of the sense organs from the objects of sensual pleasure with which they interact.
- Looking upon everything one sees as the *ātman*, the true Self.
- Giving up the desire to attain the fruits of one's actions and observances, performed as part of daily living.
- Turning one's attention away from all material things and thoughts.
- Projection of *prāṇic* (vital) energy and mind on the 18 vital regions of one's body (*marmasthānas*) by shifting attention from one point to another in a prescribed, sequential ascending and descending order.

Thus, as per the description of *pratyāhāra* available in the later *Upaniṣads*, the popular practices of *yoga-nidrā*, *yonī-mudrā* and *śavāsana*, as well as certain other

kinds of meditation practices, are actually different kinds of *pratyāhāra*. These are described in a subsequent section of this chapter.

Role of Jainism and Buddhism in evolving technical and practical strategies

Gautama Buddha evolved a technique of meditation based on certain aspects of respiration and supported by the practice of certain observances, and called it *vipāssanā*. It was widely advocated for modifying one's state of mind as well as for uplifting one's level of consciousness. Presently, it is a widely used technique of meditation, and has shown positive clinical results. Another technique of meditation, prescribed by *Yoga-Vāṣiṣṭha* (10th–12th century AD) and known as *anapana-sati*, also leads to positive and psychotherapeutic effects. The later Jain literature lucidly elaborated a similar and allied process which focused on related problems, and which evolved into the practice called *prekṣā*. The *prekṣā* method (Mahaprajna, 1980; Mishra, 2003–2004) has been found to be a very powerful and effective technique for controlling one's internal functioning, for restraining the five senses, and for getting rid of mental afflictions (Muni Nathamala, 1970). On the basis of the description found in Jain literature and the later *Upaniṣads*, many fruitful techniques modified to suit specific needs can be derived. *Vipāssanā* and *prekṣā* are described in some detail in a later section of this chapter.

Pratyāhāra: Contemporary issues

In recent years, through integrating the *shamanic* and *Upaniṣadic* views, Sri Yogendra and his disciples have made a remarkable contribution towards understanding and conceptualizing the applicable aspects of *pratyāhāra*. Yogendra (1997) defines *pratyāhāra* as 'deconditioning the mind' from its customary activity toward internalization. *Pratyāhāra* serves as a bridge between the control of the external senses through the first four stages of *aṣṭāṅga yoga* and control of the internal senses through the last three stages, viz., *dhāraṇā*, *dhyāna* and *samādhi*. It is an exclusive practice of *yoga* 'to discover one's inner self and experience subtler thoughts and feelings'. Sequeira (1997) emphasizes that *pratyāhāra* is the practice of turning one's sensory orientations inwards, for introspection and for the analysis and re-analysis of one's reflections. After reflection, one is able to prioritize one's needs in order to set one's priorities right and curb the wilful nature of the senses. *Pratyāhāra* is sense-control leading to self-control. It is one's sensations, perceptions, notions, imagination, and other mental activities that become the subject matter of study when the mind turns inwards for introspection. Introspection helps to regulate and modulate these mental activities by understanding their nature and field of operation, and is a means of redirecting their energy. Perfection in *pratyāhāra* confers a deep mental relaxation. The basic procedure begins with attaining a state of physical relaxation (by assuming a relaxed posture) followed by mental relaxation (through *pratyāhāra*), leading to the relaxation of the vital (*prāṇic* relaxation). The

greater the relaxation of the body and mind, the greater the ability to communicate with one's internal aspects. In recent years, the term *pratyāhāra* has come to be used to refer to the process of roping in/reining/withdrawing/manoeuvring/marshalling the jumble of thoughts and feelings which tumble about on the screen of the mind in a disorganized and disoriented fashion (Modi, 1997). The process leading to *pratyāhāra* requires one to pay attention to one's thoughts and day-to-day actions, watch the sensory inputs, reactions and behaviour, and observe their interplay. It allows for intelligent and insightful decisions based on observation, and this helps in honing the *buddhi* (intellect). It makes one vigilant against disturbing thoughts, feelings and actions.

Application models for *pratyāhāra*

To facilitate a better understanding of the process and role of *pratyāhāra*, three models are described below:

1. **Children's classroom model** (Modi, 1997): The disorderly crowding of thoughts, emotions and images in the mind when one begins meditation can be compared to a class of mischievous children who have been asked to move out of the room in an orderly queue. Just as a class monitor tries to bring about order and organization in a classroom, *pratyāhāra* is an important preparatory step in the practice of meditation, to bring about order and organization in mental activities.
2. **Recess-time announcement model**: This model proposes a comparison between the scattered romping of boys in the playground during recess time and the swarm of ideas, feelings, images, reactions and thoughts in the mind during meditation. In the case of schoolboys, if an important announcement has to be made, order needs to be restored; similarly, one needs to bring about order in the mind during meditation. To establish order in the playground, a special bell might be rung, the boys might be asked to stand in lines according to the classes they belong to or in increasing order of height; similarly, a step-by-step method needs to be followed to calm the mind.
3. **WRIDASM model for *pratyāhāra***: *Pratyāhāra* involves many psychological techniques, which can be represented by the acronym WRIDASM. The letters in the acronym stand for the following psychological processes:

W Withdrawing the senses followed by witnessing of reflections.

R Rallying and regulation of reflections.

I Introverting attention and introspection of mental activity.

D Detachment of senses from their objects and deconditioning of the mind.

A Attempting abstraction.

S Sensory control leading to internal seeing.

M Manoeuvring and marshalling.

Popular techniques of *pratyāhāra*

In this section, seven popular techniques of *pratyāhāra* are outlined.

Upaniṣadic technique of *pratyāhāra*

The *Kṣurikopaniṣad* (6–10), one of the later *Upaniṣads*, prescribes that an aspirant of *yoga* should bring the senses under control and make his mind and *prāṇa* steady and strong (in the region of the heart) by using the thumb, aided by the little finger and the ring finger, and fixing their tips on the root of the thumb. He should then fix his eye and mind on the different sense organs and the limbs. Finally, the mind and the *prāṇic* (vital) force should be channelized to the *suṣumnā nāḍi*. (The *suṣumnā nāḍi*, *idā nāḍi* and *pinglā nāḍi* are the three channels of *prāṇic* energy flow in the ‘subtle body’ as described in the *yoga* system, and are referred to as the central, left and right channels respectively.) One shifts one’s attention and fixes it in the great support of the heart, shining like a blood-red lotus of *anāhata*. Breaking through that lotus, the attention should reach the throat or *viśuddhi*. Then it should be fixed in the middle of the eyebrows on *ājñā* and finally in the *sahasrāra* at the top of the head (*anāhata*, *viśuddhi*, *ājñā* and *sahasrāra* are four of the seven *cakras*, the critical *yogic* points in the *suṣumnā*).

Yonimudrā

Yonimudrā is an important traditional *haṭhayogic* technique, which forms a continuum with *pratyāhāra*. It starts with the ordinary consciousness but finally reaches a higher, transcendental state (*Dhyānabindūpaniṣad*, 86; *Yoga-Cūḍāmaṇi Upaniṣad*, 59). In the simpler form of *yonimudrā*, after assuming a meditative posture the eyes are closed by the index fingers pressing the eyeballs; similarly, the ears are closed by the thumbs and the nostrils are pressed by the middle fingers. The ring and little fingers are placed above and below the lips respectively. *Yoga* experts prescribe a varied degree of pressure on the respective parts of the face: pressure on the ears 100 per cent; pressure on the eyes 50 per cent; pressure on the nose 25 per cent; pressure above and below the lips 10 per cent.

For the purpose of *pratyāhāra*, *yonimudrā* as proposed by Yogendra (1997) involves strong imagery-building techniques. A beginner in the practice of *yonimudrā* is advised to concentrate on the area of the forehead and build images. The images consist of happenings in the sky, such as the scene of dawn followed by sunrise, the diffusion of sunbeams, the scene of sunset followed by the panorama of dusk, followed by twinkling stars scattered in the whole area of the forehead. The meditator then has to imagine the gradual rising of the moon followed by the gradually increasing and gentle darkness. *Yonimudrā* techniques range from those for beginners to those suited for advanced practitioners.

Yoga-nidrā

Certain references to *yoga-nidrā* can be found in the later *Upaniṣadic* literature (*Sāṇḍilya-Upaniṣad*, 1.17.1), but in modern times the technique of *yoga-nidrā* has

been developed and propagated by Swami Satyanandaji (1976), the founder of the Bihar School of Yoga, Munger. The term *yoga-nidrā* means *yogic* sleep. Although the technique of *yoga-nidrā* was developed by the Bihar School of Yoga, it contains a good amount of *tāntric* components and has hypnotic effects. Research pertaining to the medical efficacy and the physiological and psychological effects of *yoga-nidrā* has brought to light many positive findings, which have been reported in prestigious journals. The component of resolve (not to be confused with will-power) plays a significant role in *yoga-nidrā*. A wide range of techniques of *yoga-nidrā* have been developed to suit different needs, and it is very popular.

Vipāssanā

The Buddhist tradition uses the term *vipāssanā*. It is derived from the Sanskrit term '*vipaśyana*', consisting of two terms '*vi*' + '*paśyana*', which mean 'special visioning'. The special feature of *vipāssanā* is profound concentration on different aspects of respiration, which leads to the regulation of subtle internal physiological and mental processes directly or indirectly associated with the process of respiration. The variations in respiration are linked with various affective states and related autonomic functioning. It is difficult to exercise control over one's affective states and their related autonomic functioning, but it can be achieved, albeit indirectly, by conscious control over one's breathing. This control over affective states and autonomic functioning, and consequently the ability to calm one's mind, leads to a blissful state, followed by the attainment of higher stages of consciousness.

Prekṣā

The technique of *prekṣā* was propounded by Acharya Tulsi, a renowned Jain spiritual leader and social reformer, on the basis of ancient Jain literature, and has been further propagated by his disciple Acharya Mahaprajña. The term *prekṣā* means to observe and experience the internal psychic and vital functions in order to regulate them. *Prekṣā* is quite similar to the Western bio-feedback technique, the difference being that bio-feedback is carried out with the help of certain gadgets, while *prekṣā* is done with the help of individual consciousness and will-power. An effort is made to feel and observe internal physiological and biochemical changes and the faculty of resolve is used to regulate them. Jainism does not place much importance on rigorous breathing exercises. Like *yonimudra*, *prekṣā* also has a range of techniques for both beginners and advanced practitioners.

Śavāsana

Śavāsana is a classic Indian *yogic* technique prescribed for psycho-physiological relaxation. The word *śavāsana* is a combination of two words, *śava* and *āsana*, which means the dead-body posture. The description of *śavāsana* may be found in classical *haṭhayoga* literature with varied nomenclature (*Haṭha Pradīpika*, 1.32; *Gheranda Saṁhitā*, 2.4, 2.19), but is mainly depicted as *śavāsana* (corpse pose) or *mṛtāsana* (dead pose). The classical *haṭhayoga* literature does not provide detailed instructions on how to use this technique, which may be due to the fact that the

instructions vary, depending upon the teacher and the requirement of the learner. The techniques of *śavāsana* have been developed by health scientists in contemporary times to address the problems of psychosomatic illness. A noteworthy three-stage clinical technique for *śavāsana* has been developed by Datey and Bhagat (1975) and Datey et al. (1969). The first stage of Datey's technique is to lie down flat in a relaxed and comfortable posture. In the second stage, breathing should be unusually deep and long, and one should concentrate on the abdominal movements. In the third and last stage, Datey suggests concentrating on the coolness of inhalation and the warmth of exhalation. In this *śavāsana* technique, a relaxed posture is not sufficient. As the meaning of *śavāsana* is a dead body-like posture, one's body should be, as far as possible, tensionless at the muscular level, passive at the vital (*prāṇic*) level, and relaxed at the mental level.

Another technique of *śavāsana* has been developed by Tripathi and Singh (1984) in the Manasa-Roga and Rasayana Clinic, I.M.S. Banaras Hindu University. In this technique, effort has been made to enhance the psychological efficacy of *śavāsana*. The technique has been developed in such a manner that it not only follows the traditional *yogic* criteria, but also incorporates the fruitful components of other techniques, so as to emerge as an effective, scientific relaxation technique. The description of this technique is given in Figure 6.1.

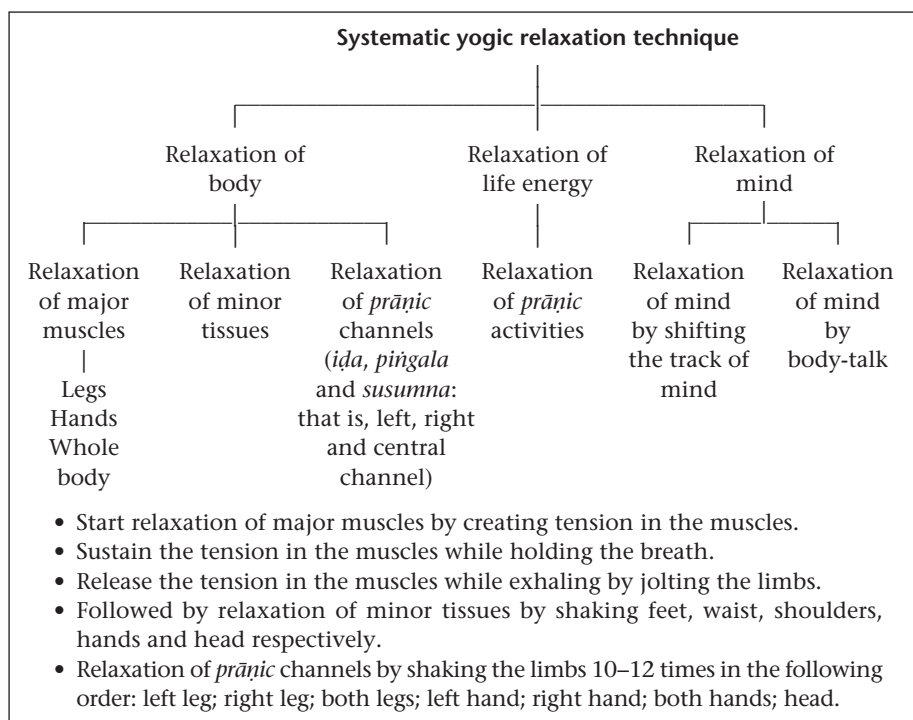


Figure 6.1: *Kramika śavāsana* (corpse pose)

Source: Tripathi, 1987.

Three of the most important exercises are as follows:

Relaxation of prāṇic activity by simple contemplation on breathing

This technique helps to lower the rate of metabolism, calm the mind and promote 'body-talk' (awareness) to enhance the influence on internal activities.

Procedure: One should lie down in a relaxed manner, like a dead body that has no control over its limbs. After lying down comfortably in *śavāsana*, attention should be turned to the immediate environment. An effort should be made to decipher the tactile sensations, smells and sounds present in the immediate environment. The next step is to expand the circle of attention to the outward environment in all directions simultaneously. At first, the clear sounds originating from the most distant places should be attended to, followed by an attempt to attend to the minute sounds of the immediate environment. The next step is to move the attention inwards and observe the sensation of the breathing pattern. The breathing pattern should be observed in the following manner:

- It should be kept in mind that the duration and amount of air inhaled and exhaled must be equal.
- A soundless and effortless pattern of breathing is adopted, but the breathing is deep and prolonged.
- The effects of inhalation and exhalation are observed, that is, the depth of inhalation is observed at the neck/throat region, at the umbilicus and below the navel. If possible, the pressure (intensity) of the exhalation is measured in centimeters outside the nostrils.
- The physiological and psychological functions occurring during inhalation and exhalation are observed.
- One inhalation followed by one exhalation completes one respiration cycle. It has been found that as the observation of respiration progresses, it becomes lighter, minute and subtle, till it becomes negligible.

Relaxation of mind by shifting the track of mental activities

This stage involves imagining the soul leaving the body. In this exercise, one visualizes the body lying on the ground. Then one visualizes the place around the body and shifts attention to the areas beyond the body. Then one has to imagine the soul gradually levitating and simultaneously expanding in size, which will finally lead to an expansion in the area of vision. One imagines and visualizes the sight of the city, then the outskirts of the city, thereafter the whole region, the whole state, the whole country, the subcontinent, the entire continent and finally, the entire earth. This experience leads to the emergence of a wider range of vision as the smaller one is replaced. Gradually, after the vision of the earth disappears, the soul is imagined to be ascending upwards and passing through the solar system, as well as through the galaxies. After spending some time in infinite space, the soul then begins to descend and everything appears again in their respective order in reverse. Passing through the galaxies and the planet systems, the soul reaches the

earth and floats in the air as light as a dry leaf or a piece of cotton. Finally, the soul approaches the body and enters it.

Body-talk

After the above exercise, one experiences an added freshness and energy, and observes a consequent increase in the flow of blood to various parts of the body, starting at the toes and gradually ascending upwards through the heels, calf muscles, knees and thighs. Thereafter, one feels the same in the perineum, below the navel, as well as around the abdomen. Then the concentration moves to the centre of the chest, on to the neck and chin, followed by the lips, the tip of the nose and between the eyebrows. The blood flow then passes through the forehead, the apex of the head, and lastly to the hind part of the head, touching the ground. The same parts of the body are then attended to in descending order, starting from the head. While attending to the head, if thoughts, feelings, ideas and images swarm the mind, they are to be observed for a while. Then the focus of attention shifts to the point between the eyebrows, also referred to as the point of the third eye. A sparkling light is imagined to be shining at this point of focus. Then attention shifts to the eyes, where the reflections of light and colour are to be observed. At the nose, breath as well as smells are observed, at the mouth wetness and taste, at the throat the cool of the inner side of the neck, at the chest the palpitation of the heart and the movement of the lungs, at the stomach the movement of the gastro-intestinal system and the heat at the perineum. Lastly, attention passes through the thighs, knees, calf-muscles, ankles and toes. This leads to a feeling of freshness and energy in the body. This technique requires building strong visual imageries involving all five senses equally. One has to imagine oneself lying on a sloping grass field in a garden under a tree, or by the banks of a lake or pond in full yet gentle sunlight, with the wind gently blowing the fragrance of flowers and birds chirping all around. One then has to attend to all the clear sounds originating from a distance in the environment, followed by the minute sounds in the immediate environment, and only then the immediate sounds, touch and smells. Then attention is turned inwards, and breathing is observed. Finally, one has to open one's eyes, look around for a while and then gently sit up, and before standing and resuming normal activity, the normal active phase is revived by sitting calmly for a minute.

It may be hard to believe that the imagination of death can bring about relaxation, yet the state of death and the experience that follows death are perceived in different cultures as relaxing. Greater relaxation can be achieved through the incorporation of these relaxing components into the instructions of *śavāsana*. The dead body essentially does not breathe. Thus, in the practice of *śavāsana* one has to concentrate upon the pattern of breathing until it becomes too minute to detect. This in turn induces silence in the mind. Although a dead person is in a state of thoughtlessness, it is difficult for most people to keep the living mind quiet because it is a human tendency to think. Instead of interrupting the natural process of thought, it can be allowed to continue on a tensionless path. It is for

this purpose that the author uses instructions about imagining the soul leaving the body, travelling and then returning to the body; and the last set of instructions about imagining a pleasant place helps bring about feelings of freshness.

Introspection

The author proposes that this practice be followed before going to bed at night and after waking up in the morning. For this exercise, one either needs to lie down or sit in a cross-legged position in a calm state of mind. The mind is then left free for thoughts to swarm in, and after a considerable amount of time has been spent reflecting on these thoughts, attention should be focused on the routine of the day, beginning with waking up in the morning, the people with whom one interacted, what the interactions were about, the reactions the interactions elicited etc., till the time one went to bed. Each detail of the day has to be recalled vividly, in a systematic and sequential manner. One then has to observe all the happenings of the day as a neutral observer, the positive and negative events have to be examined, accomplishments stored away, and the things remaining to be accomplished to be planned. After everything has been reviewed, the author suggests that the mind is to be left free for thoughts to come and go, and they have to be observed neutrally without trying to either suppress them or care about them, or feeling good or bad about them. These thoughts can be compared to the rising and falling of a wave. However, if a thought, desire, feeling or memory disturbs the mind, the body has to be loosened and 10 to 11 deep breaths taken. If, at night time, this leads to sleep, one should let sleep overcome oneself. If one wants to remember something or commit something to memory, it can be done before sleeping, and this committed or memorized idea will become rooted in behaviour.

Before practicing this in the morning, the author suggests that one should wash one's face, hands and feet and be seated in a cross-legged position, keeping the back straight. Then the same method described above has to be followed, and plans for the day ahead can be made. Thereafter, one should let the mind relax for five to seven minutes. Finally, 20 to 30 deep breaths need to be taken, the respiration observed, and then one can begin with the daily routine. If at some point during this exercise one feels like noting salient points, that can also be done.

Pratyāhāra as a method of psychic modification and mental health

Elucidating the concept and methodology of *pratyāhāra*, the later *Upaniṣads* assert that just as the practice of *āsana*s alleviates minor aches and pains of the body, the practice of *pratyāhāra* helps in ridding oneself of mundane ills, afflictions and mental disorders (*Yoga-Cūḍāmaṇi Upaniṣad*, 109; *Darśana Upaniṣad*, 7.9). In the *Yoga-Sūtra*, Patañjali emphasized that practising *pratyāhāra* on a regular basis helps in attaining greater control over the senses. Control over the senses not only implies components of the external senses, but also a mastery over the internal senses, including the proprioceptive, introspective and kinesthetic senses, and the

sensory areas of the mind. All these lead to better control over the functioning of the organism, finally leading to control over the self. Certain traditional practices of *pratyāhāra* (*Sāṇḍilyopaniṣad*, *Darśanopaniṣad* and *Kṣurikopaniṣad*), including *vipāśanā*, provide an opportunity to change the style of thinking and feeling, from a stress-prone to a less stress-prone one. The process and instructions used for *śavāsana*, *yoga-nidrā* and *prekṣā* help the person to forget worldly worries and tensions. Instructions regarding concentration on the body are also included when attention is centred on different parts, from the toes to the head, and then back to the toes. This concentration yields a new energy to both the entire vital system and the body.

During the practice of *pratyāhāra*, when one sits calmly and detaches one's senses from external objects, one conserves psychic energy, which would have been wasted through sensory interaction with the material world, and through a reactive attitude. It is believed that in order to conserve or revive psychic energy, one needs to isolate oneself and go into seclusion. Usually only the lower brain functions are active during external sensory involvement and continuous stimulation, and there is insufficient policing over the regulatory mechanism of the internal psycho-physiological and autonomic sympathetic nervous system. As the external sensory involvement and the resulting reactive tendencies calm down, it gradually brings forth the realization that the actual locus of control lies inside oneself, leading to a greater relaxation of the autonomic sympathetic nervous system. Gradually, with practice, one is able to establish better communication with the regulatory centres of the autonomic sympathetic activities in the brain. Consequently, one's affective states settle down. It is evident that the stressful and hypersensitive contemporary life-style creates a number of emotional problems. One is always reacting to one's environment and situations present around oneself. These emotions, if not observed in the right perspective, can lead to mental disorders or neurosis. Due to lack of time or lack of will, people tend to avoid this introspective technique to locate the causes of the problems, and the consequence is reactivity and the corresponding affective state. The eyes are closed during *pratyāhāra* to de-condition the mind from its usual sensory activities, bring about a change in the style of thinking and emoting, and categorize mental reflections to regulate mental activity. This effort, by and large, calms the mind. When one isolates oneself for constant and deep reflection, one begins to organize one's notions, emotions, reflections and reactions on one's psychic screen; this not only decreases the complexity of the problems, but also reduces over-sensitivity and reactivity, which in turn encourages a healthier style of living.

The internal physiological functions can be regulated through the practice of *āsanas* and *yogic* breathing, and the regular practice of *prekṣā* and the 'body-talk' of *śavāsana* can regulate bio-chemical changes and endocrine secretions. Further, different *yogic* practices may offer individualized devices to overcome the fears, anxieties and stresses of day-to-day living. Through a sincere and regular practice of introspection, one is able to rearrange one's priorities and needs and modify one's behaviour accordingly. Thus, a composed state, which is considered a favourable

environment, is created to resolve conflicts, and a way to manage these conflicts is actively sought. The five sheaths in the *Tattiriyopaniṣad* (described earlier) represent the psychotherapeutic process of *pratyāhāra* in all its depth. In the *Tattiriyopaniṣad* model, at the initial exterior corporeal stage, the practitioner undertakes an analysis of the dietary habits, waking and sleep patterns, and daily routine of the client in terms of proper and improper styles of functioning with the help of appropriate literature and instructed guidance. At the next stage, that is, at the inner vital level, the management of psychosomatic factors and the regulation of autonomic functioning take place through the practice of *āsanas*, *prāṇāyāma* and *yogic* relaxation. It should be kept in mind that certain aspects of *pratyāhāra* are always indirectly present in all practices of *yoga*, including *āsana* and *prāṇāyāma*; otherwise, their *yogic* effectiveness would be doubtful. If at this stage the problem still persists, one needs to probe into a deeper psychological level. Here, the connative complexity of behaviour is probed to bring about emotional catharsis, followed by the analysis and re-analysis of day-to-day reactions and reflections. Further, cognitive conflicts and complexes are detected and resolved, and problem management techniques formulated. This results in psychic emancipation, accompanied by feelings of relief and delight, which falls within the purview of the beatific level.

Concluding remarks

In general, all psychotherapy aims at the resolution of emotional suffering and promotion of well-being in clients. Thus *pratyāhāra* qualifies as a form of psychotherapy, as it attains these goals and takes the practitioner closer to the larger goal of self-realization. Our conclusion is in agreement with that of Fritjof Capra, who in his book, *The Turning Point*, (1981) notes that *yoga* resembles psychotherapy more closely than it does religion or philosophy.

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Section 2

Education

Introduction

Development of the mind is central to the pursuit of a civilization's goals and the realization of the agenda for social and economic transformation envisioned by any society. Through facilitating certain modes of thinking, education can generate a specific world-view and behavioural patterns, as well as channelize both personal and social endeavours in a given direction. Education thus ensures continuity in the modes of thinking and acting, while allowing for change in a given cultural context.

Indeed, one of the most significant moves in the history of mankind has been the institutionalization of the processes that go into the making of the mind. Education, thus developed, systematically hones the mind under the aegis of technology, as well as the overall political and economic climate of the times. The prevalent social values both direct the nature and processes of education and perpetuate them. In today's world, economic values are prominent, and have precedence over social and moral values. As a result, the teaching-learning of those disciplines that are perceived as lucrative gains more popularity and attention, as compared to the disciplines promoting creativity in the domains of culture and human potential. This might be beneficial from a short-term perspective, but may not be good in the long term.

Today, formal schooling at various levels is an accepted part of the national agenda. Being uneducated is disadvantageous and deprives one not only from availing the opportunities that could lead to growth and development, but also leaves one helpless. It is in this context that the right to education is treated as an important human right. In India, efforts are being made to universalize primary education and extend educational opportunities to the underprivileged sections of society. Education is considered a panacea for all social ills. But just any kind of education cannot offer the benefits desired from it.

In contemporary practice, education is often treated as an enabling mechanism, or a tool for the acquisition of information and skills relevant to various professions. In fact, after the minimum literacy and skill provided by general education, it is professional education that is at a high premium since it is considered to guarantee economic prosperity, social status and power. Strangely enough, the practice involves a uniform system with a fixed curriculum, which all learners, irrespective of their backgrounds, aptitudes and interests, have to adopt. The issue of individual differences in the style, goal or purpose of learning is often

overlooked and the same standardized structure is implemented, irrespective of a person's potential and contextual particularities. This often results in wastage and stagnation of available resources, and leads to negative consequences like frustration, anger and violence.

Historically, a major shift took place in the Indian context with the introduction of Western-style education, which systematically eradicated the indigenous system of education which was rooted in the ideals of liberation of the mind, and the empowerment of people to think and imagine in the best possible ways. The underlying assumption behind Indian education has been one of *samskāra*—a deliberate effort aimed at enhancing virtues, bringing all that is good in a person to the fore while removing negative features. From the Indian perspective, education is a value-laden process of self-transformation.

Therefore, in a broader sense education is a human activity that assumes many forms and takes place in different situations. The various agents of socialization such as parents, teachers, the school, one's peers, and significant others play an important role in shaping the process of education, both directly and indirectly. They not only provide instruction and guidance to the learner, but also provide models, and create occasions for the performance of different types of activities. All this occurs not on a *tabula rasa* or blank slate, but in an active and conscious being with certain intrinsic qualities as well as preparedness for learning. This stands in stark contrast to the received view of learning endorsed by most scholars grounded in the dominant Western discourses on education.

The differences between the various conceptualizations of teaching-learning are deeply rooted in values, and function in a value-embedded environment. The organization and conduct of education is inescapably directed towards facilitating certain values and goals, all of which revolve around an ideal concept of what it means to be human. The image of an isolated and independent individual pursuing her/his self-interest is neither viable nor desirable. The contemporary human condition clearly portrays a scenario in which interdependence and mutuality are the need of the hour.

However, till recently much of the emphasis of the prevailing models of educational processes has been on a mechanical, reductionistic, associationistic, atomistic, non-developmental and objectivist paradigm, with its underlying assumption of an empty organism frozen in time and space. Such a conception certainly under-represents the human reality, and fails to capture the dynamism of human learning. This view prevailed because it was considered secular and (apparently) value-free. All it does provide an account of learning on the part of an isolated individual, adapting to the demands of hedonistic and homeostatic functioning.

Evolutionary theory has helped to zero in on the mechanisms that are common to both animals and humans. Thus, behaviouristic learning theories (for example, conditioning theory) were originally developed in the context of animal behaviour and then extended to the domain of human learning. Despite the fact that they provided a poor approximation of the complexity of human learning,

these theories prevailed for a long time, and continue to provide a prototype for the same. The advent of information theory has led to the emergence of computational and connectionist models. Humanistic theories of learning, along with those of cooperative and collaborative learning, provided more enriching accounts. Analyses of human interaction in the classroom-setting, viewed chiefly as a communicative process, drew attention to aspects of human interaction and social ecology. However, these theories of development still do not receive sufficient attention in the mainstream of education.

The Indian psychological perspective operates with a keen awareness of the value of continuous transformation and development in the direction of spiritual uplift. This transformation is one in which self-expansion is undertaken in an increasingly inclusive manner. It is neither egocentric nor individualistic in its basic outlook. The chapters in this section address some of the possible ways in which education can be moulded and directed as a pedagogical process related centrally to consciousness. The authors share reflections and document illustrations of such interventions.

In Chapter 7, titled 'Integral education: An application of Indian psychology', Neeltje Huppel explores how the basic understanding of life and its purpose which one finds in ancient Indian texts, could revolutionize modern education. In the Indian view, some aspect of the supreme consciousness, though often concealed, pervades each and everything. In our daily consciousness, this supreme consciousness is mostly covered up, yet each of us carries a spark of the Supreme deep within, called the *caitya puruṣa* or soul. Huppel emphasizes that if the soul is allowed to come to the foreground, it can influence the mental, affective, volitional and physical surface consciousness to act more in harmony with this universal consciousness. The psychological process of human development is thus seen as a progressive development; a development balanced between the innermost part of the being—the soul—and the outer life. Huppel notes that the ideal of integral education combines two lines of development: the revealing and unfolding of the soul, and the development of the mental, affective and physical domains as instruments for expressing that soul in daily life.

In 'The blending of healing and pedagogy in Āyurveda', P. Ram Manohar highlights how the medical tradition of Āyurveda has preserved a rather unique concept of education that blends principles of healing with those of pedagogy. With its intense focus on the promotion of positive health and well-being, Āyurveda has discovered that elevated levels of health can be achieved only by a subtle transformation of the inner personality. While diseases can be cured, managed or prevented by medical intervention and such other physical means, higher states of health can be achieved only through self-awakening. Manohar thus emphasizes that the process of self-education is essentially an educative development, a psycho-spiritual transformation that enables the individual to not only live with awareness, but also with health. The meeting point of the most refined methods of pedagogy and healing result in the notion of the physician par excellence as the *vaidya*, the one who knows the essentials and helps the individual through

education to reach a state of heightened awareness, a state most conducive to the acquisition of both knowledge and health.

In 'Situating teacher education in the Indian context: A paradigm shift', Bharati Baveja indicates how teacher training could be made more responsive to the actual needs of children using theories derived from the Indian tradition. Baveja points out that discourse in education, particularly teacher education, has its origins in pragmatic concerns overridden by social pressures in the late nineteenth century, concerns that are largely, if not entirely, irrelevant today. At the same time, educators in India have consistently failed to acknowledge the richer and more convincing concepts that exist in the Indian traditions since time immemorial. Basing herself on ideas given in the *Bhagavad Gītā*, Baveja notes that teaching is not a collection of skills but an ongoing process of contemplation; a continuous search for truth; an ongoing quest to understand the learner, the processes of learning, the ways of providing learning experiences and inspiration to help students embark on their inner journey. Thus, a teacher has to be a true *karma yogī* who engages in enjoined actions in the pursuit of knowledge, and is committed to the development of her self and her students.

In 'Krishnamurti and value education', Vinita Kaushik Kapoor notes that the aim of education must be to awaken an intelligence through which thought and knowledge find their right place. Such a perception may be seen as a religious perception. Kapoor further emphasizes that it is only when the truly religious mind informs the values on which we build our daily existence that there is a possibility of a sane and orderly world, free from conflict and sorrow. Krishnamurti emphasizes the importance of understanding oneself first, and the role of the educator here is to help the child observe the ways in which thought creates its own prison. Krishnamurti also stresses the relationship of the child with nature as an essential part of education. Finally, Kapoor notes that Krishnamurti initiates a strong and consistent thrust towards establishing values rooted in the sacred, the truly religious.

In 'Education for life: The Mirambika experience', Anjum Sibia utilizes the ethnographic method to examine the teaching-learning process in Mirambika, a centre of learning based on Free Progress Education, as outlined by Sri Aurobindo and The Mother. Sibia explicates the pedagogic processes occurring in the classroom in order to understand the relationship between the school philosophy, activities and student outcomes. Sri Aurobindo emphasizes that 'The chief aim of education should be to help the growing soul to draw out that in itself which is best and make it perfect for a noble cause'. Sibia notes that Free Progress Education is based on the assumption that a person is good in him/herself, and that positive freedom is a pre-requisite to help children by allowing them space to experiment, and by providing them with opportunities for growth.

7

Integral education: An application of Indian psychology

Neeltje Huppes

At present mankind is undergoing an evolutionary crisis in which is concealed a choice of its destiny; for a stage has been reached in which the human mind has achieved in certain directions an enormous development while in others it stands arrested and bewildered and can no longer find its way Man has created a system of civilisation which has become too big for his limited mental capacity and understanding

—Sri Aurobindo, *The life divine*, p. 1053

Introduction

Sri Aurobindo wrote this more than 60 years ago, but how true it still is. We see humanity struggling with the issues of individual and collective use (and abuse) of power and their concomitant responsibilities. We are experimenting with values and redefining our belief systems. There is a massive upsurge of both progressive and conservative forces. Each of these movements seems to be seeking to reshape and redefine itself, to search for a new identity, to find and express a new aim in life. They often clash, each proclaiming that its truth is higher or greater than that of the other.

Could it be that all these endeavours and upheavals are pointing to the need for a decisive change? For thousands of years humankind has focused on sharpening, increasing and refining our human capacities. There has been a manifold development of our physical and mental abilities, resulting in great achievements in many spheres of life. The most obvious effect of this mass development has been a remarkable technological progress that, while allowing many comforts, has also brought a tremendous over-stimulation to our lives. With the click of a mouse we can access almost any information we need, or communicate with people anywhere on the globe. Yet, when we read or watch the news, we get the impression that collectively we lack the right approach to handle wisely the enormous powers we have unleashed with our mind. Each of us is challenged. Do we really have the knowledge and wisdom to resolve the myriad conflicts we have created for

ourselves? How can we help restore the balance, and create a more fulfilling life and a more harmonious world for all of us?

The truths that have guided us so far are apparently not enough to handle the tremendous powers technology has set in motion. Technology forces us to live globally, and so we must recast our identity in a world in which our self is no longer embedded within the limited context of traditional family values. Education plays an important role in both individual and national development, and so one wonders why education has been unable to guide humanity towards greater harmony, providing fulfilment to all. What is this wisdom needed to bring about that decisive change? We are confronted with the ills of continuing imperialism and rampant commercialism, destroying not only human life but threatening the very life of the planet. Our most urgent need is to replace imperialism with more beneficent forms of globalization, and to realize a deeper understanding of personal freedom—a freedom not gained at the expense of others, but based on unity with others and harmony with Nature.

We can look at our world from many perspectives—economic, ecological, cultural, personal, and so on. Seeing the limited successes we have achieved so far in creating that harmonious world that we long for, we find that none of these perspectives goes deep enough. All are part of the larger whole, but even together they are incomplete; they are not integral enough.

During the last couple of centuries Western civilization has dominated the way our world has been shaped. Its influence remains dominant, and today's problems originate to a large extent from the fact that Western cosmology lost integrality hundreds of years ago. Simplifying history, one could say that it began when science parted ways with the Roman Catholic Church at the time of Bruno, Copernicus and Galileo. When science parted from religion, it also tossed out spirituality, and since science has been so successful, the dominant world-view is now based on a physicalist, scientific paradigm. India did not escape this development, and even now Western psychology dominates the study of psychology at Indian universities. Is it not time to research what the more integral Indian psychology has to offer?

PART I — INTEGRALITY IN THE INDIAN CONTEXT

What is integrality?

Each of us is endowed with various levels and forms of consciousness. We know that we have thoughts and feelings, and are able to take action through the use of our body. At any given moment we can shift our centre of identification between these mental, affective, volitional and physical domains. What is more, each of these domains has not only a surface layer, but also deeper, inner layers. This means that during a day we shift many times, not only from domain to domain but also between our surface nature and the various inner parts of our being. Over the millennia humans have developed an incredible complexity of which most of

us are hardly aware. As a result we do not live up to our true potential. Our present fact-based and marks-oriented education makes it worse, as it is very limited and taps only a narrow part of our potential. Integral education strives for a much wider and deeper development. But let us first take a closer look at the philosophical context of integrality.

Integrality in the context of Indian education

Indian civilization has its foundation in a deep understanding of integrality. It sees the universe not as a purely material fact, but knows that a Supreme, although often concealed, consciousness pervades each and everything. In our daily consciousness this Supreme consciousness is mostly covered up, yet each of us carries a spark of the Supreme deep within, called the *caitya puruṣa* or soul. If the soul is allowed to come to the foreground, it can influence the mental, affective, volitional and physical surface consciousness to act more in harmony with this universal consciousness. Our surface then becomes an instrument for the soul to act in this world. All this is part of a life-affirming spirituality which reaches beyond the divisions of religion. In the perennial cosmology of India, the psychological process of human development is seen as *a progressive development; a development that is balanced between the innermost part of the being—the soul—and the outer life*.

In harmony with this, the ideal of integral education combines two lines of development: the revealing and unfolding of the soul, and the development of the mental, affective and physical domains as instruments for expressing that soul in daily life. It calls for an individualized process of education. Of course, we want universal education for all the children of India, but for universal education to work, it must respect individual differences and provide an education that is relevant for every child. Consider the differences in daily inputs and the experiences of children growing up in one of the metros and children in interior rural areas—how can prescribing the same textbook be meaningful for both categories? If ‘universal education’ could have come about through a standard textbook, it would have been achieved long ago. Consider the large variety in intelligence, capacities and qualities of children. Only an education based on genuine respect for individual differences can provide a meaningful development for each student.

Some theoretical and practical aspects of integral education

Based on his deep understanding of the Indian psyche and his emphasis on integrality, Sri Aurobindo wrote a series of short introductory essays on the general principles of education between 1910 and 1920. He says (1990, pp. 13-14):

...true and living education ... helps to bring out to full advantage, makes ready for the full purpose and scope of human life all that is in the individual man, and ... at the same time helps him to enter into his right relation with the life, mind and soul of the people to which he belongs and with that great total life, mind and soul of humanity of which he himself is a unit.

Sri Aurobindo understood that education is a magnificent tool for building up a nation. He and his spiritual associate, The Mother, called their model of education integral education. First, it is centred around the innermost consciousness, the soul. Second, it emphasizes optimum development of the mental, affective and physical domains, not as an aim in itself, but as instruments through which the soul can express itself in the world. The principles of integral education do not impose a belief system or a set of rules to adhere to. They respect the vast individual differences of the students and can be applied anywhere in the world.

Two basic assumptions

The impulse towards self-exceeding is an innate part of being human.

Education needs to implement more methods that facilitate the action of this innate tendency to excel. In sports, the principle of self-exceeding has become so commonplace that records which seemed impossible to be surpassed the year before are being regularly broken. I have experienced similar feats in mental development in a Free Progress school, and saw students excel in solving math problems far beyond the levels of their age group.¹

Self-exceeding also has a spiritual component, which brings us to the concepts of *svadharma* and *svabhāva*. Here, *dharma* is not used in the sense of morality or ethics. *Svadharma* is action governed by the *svabhāva*, the essential law of one's nature. When we act here on earth according to our highest or inmost *svadharma*, our action emerges from and is an expression of our essential Self, our soul. Integral education trusts that each one of us is able to find his or her own balance between developing, training and refining one's mind, heart and body, and discovering how to live from one's soul. *We perceive the nature of reality according to our state of being. Consequently, everything depends on where we place our consciousness.*

From the experiences of daily life, we can easily learn that each mental, affective and volitional domain has its own 'laws'. The 'laws' pertaining to the physical domain are different from the laws that provide structure to the affective domain, and these in their turn are different from those of the mind. During the day, without realizing it, we often shift our consciousness between the various domains. As we observe ourselves, we become aware that our perceptions change according to the domain we identify with. For instance, most of us have experienced the difference it makes when we react to a situation with our reasoning mind, and when we react with our emotional heart. Our soul brings in other qualities yet; qualities that illumine and harmonize whatever we do. Once we realize this, we can begin to live consciously and choose the domain from which we interact, thereby changing what we allow to influence our life. Integrality starts with becoming conscious of all the parts and layers of our being. Integral education aims to help children become conscious of these inner and outer processes without forcing students into a fixed mode. Spirituality is not a subject to be taught. Neither can 'being spiritual' be imposed. *All integral education can do is provide an environment in which students are free to make choices, while encouraging*

them to do so as consciously as they can. It trusts that self-observation will naturally lead to self-awareness. This can help the student to feel responsible for self-made choices, which in turn can lead to an accelerated self-development, leading to becoming a truly responsible citizen.

Key concepts of integral education

There are four key concepts of integral education:

- Acknowledgement of the fact that *the whole spectrum*, from unconsciousness to divine consciousness, from the surface layer to the greater depths and heights, is present in everyone. It is also present everywhere around us in people and nature, and thus in the classroom we should not narrow it down to the layer of the mind only, but provide scope for developing the other layers as well. The aim is to give students the opportunity to extend their own range of consciousness by heightening, widening and deepening their instrumental domains.
- Respect for the relationship between *being* (to live in the presence of the highest consciousness an individual can perceive) and *becoming* (the outward, surface consciousness in which we usually live).
- The view that each student is a *unique* being who is developing the inner nature and the innermost qualities of the soul as well as the outer capacities in the surface domains—mental, affective, volitional and physical. The progressive manifestation of the soul in the surface nature has to take place in and through daily life. Each student has to be able to find his/her individual level of integration.
- The acknowledgement of the concepts of *svabhāva* and *svadharma* as the essential principles through which a human being can express him/herself in this world.

Reflections

Living according to one's *svadharma* generates true and perfect action in the world. It is the best that an individual can give to society. By neglecting the search for one's *svabhāva* one loses one's true authenticity; neglecting the ideal of *svadharma* leads to both the nation and the individual losing out. The modern consumer society encourages us to live completely in the surface consciousness and wants us to believe that we are happiest when spending money on all kinds of goods. By now, we all know that this attitude has ruined our earth, bringing it almost to a point of no return. It is the task of education to offer students the broadest range of world-views with as little bias as possible, so that they can reflect on the choices they want to make. It is for the students to decide consciously how much importance they give to the soul and to the surface nature, and to work out a personal balance between these in their daily lives.

A broad-based integral education asks for a shift in educational methodology.

Teachers often complain about the lack of motivation in students. But is it really the fault of the students? In our present educational system, students can construct or create a positive self-image only with reference to their success in the material and external world. Education has largely turned into a race for the highest marks, which, it is wrongly believed, will enable children later to make the most money and so be happy. Unfortunately, this system inherently gives importance and provides satisfaction to the natural inclinations of only a few students; it hardly allows other precious aspects of the human nature to be developed in the classroom. Yet, many children know from within that they have other important qualities, and that the value of their life is reduced by not cultivating these. My experience is that students deeply appreciate it when they are getting time to reflect without compulsion. Learning primarily for outer gains, like the highest marks, has reduced students to the level of input-output devices. Not being part of the highest 20 per cent leaves a feeling of being-not-capable-enough in 80 per cent of young adolescents. As long as the educational model complies with this single-track race, the nation loses the great potential and precious qualities of millions of young people.

A clear sign pointing to the need for a shift in methodology is the complaint of employers that young recruits are not creative, and that they lack initiative and responsibility when they enter the job market. The responsibility rests squarely with schools, where rote-learning is still the accepted mode of knowledge transfer, destroying enthusiasm, creative potential and an inquiring attitude. Allotting plenty of time for self-directed learning, as in the project-mode, is an alternative that seems to work well.

Looking ahead

For a long time, educationists have been talking about child-centred education. But even now, in practice, instead of appreciating the faculties and qualities of the child in its entirety, it is the mark sheet of the child that stands at the centre! There can be no doubt that the Western model of education has allowed humankind to make enormous technological progress, but it has by and large ignored the spiritual aspects of life. This one-sided progress has led us close to the destruction of the ecological balance of the earth. The craving for power and wealth is so strong that even now, calls for constraint by eminent scientists are hardly heeded. Can the balance be restored so as to prevent the world-wide disasters set off by indiscriminate human craving? Paying greater attention in education to the qualities of our innermost essence will help us to utilize our scientific discoveries in a more ethical manner. At the beginning of this century a light on the educational horizon has been the fact that the UNESCO has realized this need and appointed a commission to bring out a report on the educational model of the twenty-first century. Significantly, this report is titled *Learning: The Treasure Within*. Basically, Indian education was founded on this concept, even though it was lost during colonial times, the echo can still be heard. India, located as it is at the beginning

of a significant economic development, can still avoid making the same mistakes as the West. The inherent strength of the integral world-view that she nurtured throughout the ages needs now to be translated into a new model of education.

India plays an important role in the information society. To remain not only a successful but also a responsible player in this field, both the content and method of schooling have to change. The fact that the changes needed in schools and colleges are so much in harmony with a more integral, more Indian approach to life seems to provide a wonderful opportunity. My experience in working with young adults in colleges showed that they want a curriculum that incorporates time for self-enquiry and self-development, with open-ended discussions that help them to reflect on their role in society. In short, they want a study environment that encourages them to discover for themselves who they are and how they want to shape their lives and become responsible citizens.

PART II — SUGGESTIONS FOR IMPLEMENTATION

Shifts in the content of education

To bring about this integration, two major shifts related to educational content are needed.

The first concerns the way we look at the content of the syllabus. The course content must not be seen as mere information that has to be transferred to the students. Instead, the content must serve as a means to evoke in the students thought processes and personal experiences. In this way, learning can become truly experiential. It is only when a teacher shifts focus and starts concentrating on the *self-development* of the student instead of on the effective transfer of content that learning becomes integral.

The second shift is related to learning levels and modalities. Students are naturally at different levels of both inner and outer development. Moreover, they come from a variety of backgrounds and have various talents. The use of a single textbook approach will not provide opportunities for optimum learning. Most teachers will agree that in the present system, both the intelligent and the weaker students suffer. Moreover, students with some special gift are not given the opportunity to practise and develop it other than in a few periods of so-called co-curricular activities. There is thus a need for an entirely new approach related to learning material.

A practical solution allowing for the required diversity in learning levels and learning content is a combination of a relatively small compulsory *Minimum Common Syllabus* for all students, combined with extensive periods of self-directed learning in which the student chooses what and how s/he wants to learn. It could be acquiring a skill, working on a quality, speeding ahead in a certain subject, mastering a certain content in depth, using time for self-reflection etc.

In practice, this can be worked out by daily setting apart certain common

self-directed learning periods for all students at a certain level (let's say class 9 and 10) in the school. This makes most of the teachers (including arts and crafts teachers) who teach at that level available to the students during these periods. This also offers students a wide variety of choices and teachers. Students sign up in advance for a certain project, either offered by a teacher or requested by one or more students. One of the requirements for a positive outcome of project work is the availability of a rich diversity of learning materials on various learning levels. This provides individual students with a good choice and allows for a wide range in learning opportunities and optimum development. The project approach has been successfully implemented in several integral schools.²

The details of the other half of this method, the Minimum Common Syllabus, has to be worked out with great care, but the total quantity of learning material in the MCS need not be more than what an average student can complete in half the time of the regular syllabus.

Shifts in methodology linked to present day technology

It has been explained that our present situation calls for major shifts in our teaching-learning practices. The major shift here is to acknowledge that *learning is a process*. Several facts point in the same direction. First is the revolution in educational technology, with data readily available on CDs and on the Internet. This calls for an important change in our attitude towards information transfer: it has become more necessary for students to learn *how to process* information than to collect a vast stock of facts learned by rote. Two other important trends need to be considered here. Due to the fast progress of science, data become rapidly outdated and have to be re-adjusted continuously. Also, knowledge has become so specialized that it is impossible for any educational system to offer inputs that are complete enough. So we find that when a graduate begins a new job, most companies first provide him or her with a specialized training period of several weeks. Thus, the current reality is that any effective system of education must equip students with the skills needed for the fast pace and complexity of the information age, in which memorizing one fixed set of facts useful for all has become less relevant than it used to be.

Shifts in the process of education related to values

When the aim of the educational process is the development of the student, the subject matter is meant to help a student widen and deepen his world, and gain insight into his own qualities, capacities and skills. Applied in this way, it will lead the student to ask questions such as—*Who am I? What do I want to do, to become? What is the required factual knowledge? What type of inner knowledge do I need to reach my goals?* The aim here is not to tell the students the 'right' answer, like in moral education classes, but to be a good facilitator and create an environment in which the student feels safe to truly grapple with these questions, and come personally

to the most authentic answers. Only when self-knowledge is thus gained and integrated can we utilize it effectively in our daily actions, and only then do we become self-reliant citizens.

In an integral learning environment, self-reflection can become a natural part of the daily routine. Quiet time can be set aside on a regular basis to create the habit of self-observation. On an individual level, it centres on the question 'Who Am I?' and includes reflection on personal problems and achievements, positive as well as negative incidents. Reflection in a group is beneficial when it relates to a specific event, positive or negative, that occurred in the classroom during the day. This will foster in the students a high level of self-awareness and encourage sensitivity to group dynamics. In this way, students become aware that they are endowed with different capacities and qualities and start utilizing them to enhance the social fabric. Many students start realizing their natural weaknesses and natural strengths. Consequently, they make an effort to overcome their weaknesses and perfect their strengths all the more.

Each one of us is like a doorkeeper (*dvārapāla*). Self-perfection is closely related to self-control. It gives enormous strength when one has learnt, through self-awareness and feedback (not moral judgement), to view the effect of one's actions and one's decisions. The point here is to help a student grow into a conscious young adult, who can make conscious choices about his/her aim in life and live from that strength.

Another important shift that needs to be made is in the attitude towards mistakes. When we stop chiding students for their mistakes and allow them space to see that mistakes can actually help on the way and are pointers towards greater perfection, fear and stress will fall away. If we look at ourselves, we have to admit that we never learned anything without making mistakes. So mistakes are a natural part of any learning process. We must end practices that make students feel ashamed or shrink from their mistakes. Instead, we must help students realize that each mistake is an opportunity for further development, a pointer or a road sign to greater accomplishment.

In general, to gain self-control from within, the attitude towards the teaching of values has to undergo a drastic change. Control through punishment and moralizing takes away trust and responsibility from the learner, and deadens motivation. A caring teacher allows students the space to take responsibility for good as well as bad behaviour. S/he allows self-exploration, so that the values can arise from within.

Proven practice

To illustrate these points, I quote here part of an article written in 2006 by a young woman who was for 10 years a student of an integral school.³

Once Damini (a friend) and I did a project on [our school]—we made a whole booklet out of it, with a lot of metaphorical drawings, interviews of students, teachers and the principal. All this was compiled together with our own, very

coherent opinions. So, each project included many different facets—a wide variety of ways to learn, apart from just the academic bit. There was a lot of art, fieldwork (like a trip to a marble factory, collecting heavy rocks etc.)

... the system lays a lot of emphasis on freedom; freedom from structures, from prescribed modes of thought, from inhibitions, from fear. But this freedom never came without responsibility. Freedom and responsibility go hand in hand, and together culminate into self-discipline. Self-discipline is to me true discipline, which comes from within a human being and is not imposed or forced on her/him. This constitutes an individual in the true sense of the word—someone who does not do things by being compelled to by others, but simply because her/his convictions urge her/him to do it. Motivation and freedom that are self-realized see much better results than those that are obligatory (Saranda, 2006).

Shifts in procedures of evaluation

Assessment of the students' work has to be in harmony with the process of awakening, and in harmony with the focus on the development of qualities and capacities of the students. Therefore, a major shift to be introduced in assessment procedures of students is that assessment has to be focused on development and not on ranking. The main role of the teacher should not be that of a taskmaster and judge, but that of a guide and facilitator. The new attitude is to help a student make progress, not for the sake of high marks, but for individual growth. In this context, it is important that teachers observe the students with empathy.

The assessment required should be diagnostic and not judgemental. This is an assessment in which the student participates and gains insight into his own learning process. The teacher/facilitator provides positive feedback and helps the student to understand for her/himself if something needs more attention, or if s/he can directly proceed to the next stage etc. Self-evaluation by the student is an important component of this process (see also Huppes, 2001, pp. 252, 226, 176).

Shifts in teacher education

A shift in the content and methodology in Elementary and Secondary education necessitates a shift in the content and methodology in Teacher Education. This in turn requires a shift in the attitude of teacher-educators—from taskmaster to facilitator. The core issue is that the methodology of the teacher education colleges has to reflect the philosophy of learning for personal growth. Imposition and rote learning, which entails a closed learning process in which we create dependency, has to be replaced by an open learning process of positive suggestion in which student-teachers explore their own capacities and qualities, and simultaneously acquire the knowledge and skills related to the teaching-learning processes that facilitate self-development. It is important to realize that high marks in test papers do not provide certainty for being a good teacher. The length of this chapter prevents detailed descriptions, but some of the major shifts are listed below:

- The methodology of the teaching-learning process of teacher education institutes has to be in harmony with the aim that the student-teacher will learn to become a guide and facilitator instead of a task master and disciplinarian.
- Student-teachers must be empowered with planning skills for optimum individual learning, simultaneously handling a variety of learning materials for multiple levels of learning in the classroom.
- The focus of learning must be learning-for-development, while recognizing that the physical, affective, cognitive and spiritual domains all have a place in the teaching-learning process. The shift in methodology must help the teacher to experience the value of all these domains for her/himself, and through that develop the skills for implementing such learning in the classroom.
- Another important component to be introduced in the teaching-learning process of teacher education institutes is allotting time and structures in their syllabus for self-observation and self-reflection. Keeping a daily journal will lead to self-awareness and self-perfection. It is important to encourage student-teachers to find ways unique to their disposition and develop their style of facilitating learning so that they will continue this while working in schools.
- Implementation of these components will necessitate a change in the evaluation procedures of the teacher education institutes, and make self-evaluation by the student-teachers a component that matters.

Conclusion: *Kurukṣetra* in our own life

We are living in a period of great intensity. Spiritually as well as materially, it is a time of transition and change. How can a positive change come about? Till now, humanity has mainly been busy with what we could call 'outer' changes, in the hope that these would bring a more comfortable life. It is time to realize that happiness will be an elusive aim unless we learn first to live a nobler life. We can go on changing strategies and institutions, but this will have a lasting effect only if we first change ourselves. Sages and social scientists have told us over and over again that inner change has to precede outer change, and that the future of the world will not improve by changing only outer conditions and remodelling institutions. For as long as human beings remain the same, outer innovations will break down rapidly. It is the quality that comes from a profounder state of consciousness that has to be the guiding principle in the new initiatives that humankind is looking for. The changes that we have to bring about in our organizations and institutions have to be founded on an inner truth that is waiting to be expressed. This 'living from within' does not mean an impoverishment in the mental and affective domains. What it does mean is self-knowledge and mastery, which will keep us away from action at the expense of others or the earth. When we live a more integrated life, we naturally create harmony and beauty. Since our lives are still embedded

in the old ways of living, it requires effort to make this inner shift. Some parts in us may resist and shy away, or return to the beaten track. Yet, if we look at the present world, it seems to cry out for a qualitative change. The appreciation and cultivation of soul qualities has from ancient times been inherently linked with the Indian civilization. It is one of the most precious gifts that India can give to this world. In the field of education, it is up to administrators, psychologists and educationists to be instruments in this process.⁴ The time seems to be ripe for a change in this direction; it is an ideal whose time has come!

Endnotes

- 1 See, for further details, Anjum Sibia (2006).
- 2 There are many schools in India, drawing inspiration from the vision of Sri Aurobindo, that have amalgamated the CBSE syllabus with Integral education. However, there are two schools, SAICE (Puducherry) and Mirambika (New Delhi), which have implemented the principles and methodology of Integral education quite radically. Mirambika has an Integral teacher education programme (duration 3 years) on the same campus. The student-teachers do their teaching practice at Mirambika.
- 3 Sarandha, A Tribute to Mirambika on its 25th anniversary. Published in *The Awakening Ray*, Vol. 10, 4, (2006).
- 4 The ordinary way of man's individual and social living seems indeed to be a contradiction of these principles; for certainly we bear a terrible weight of external necessity, rule and law and our need for self-expression, for the development of our true person, our real soul, our inmost characteristic law of nature in life is at every turn interfered with, thwarted, forced from its course, given a very poor chance and scope by environmental influences. Life, State, society, family, all surrounding powers seem to be in a league to lay their yoke on our spirit, compel us into their moulds, impose on us their mechanical interest and rough immediate convenience. We become parts of a machine; we are not, are hardly allowed to be men in the true sense, *manuṣya*, *puruṣa*, souls, minds, free children of the spirit empowered to develop the highest characteristic perfection of our being and make it our means of service to the race. It would seem that we are not what we make ourselves, but what we are made. Yet the more we advance in knowledge, the more the truth of the Gita's rule is bound to appear. The child's education ought to be an outbringing of all that is best, most powerful, most intimate and living in his nature; the mould into which the man's action and development ought to run is that of his innate quality and power. He must acquire new things, but he will acquire them best, most vitally on the basis of his own developed type and inborn force. And so too the functions of a man ought to be determined by his natural turn, gift and capacities. The individual who develops freely in this manner will be a living soul and mind and will have a much greater power for the service of the race. And we are able now to see more clearly that this rule is true not only of the individual but of the community and the nation, the group soul, the collective man (Sri Aurobindo, 1976, pp. 499–500).

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8

The blending of healing and pedagogy in Āyurveda

P. Ram Manohar

Introduction

The medical tradition of Āyurveda has preserved a rather unique concept of education that blends principles of healing with those of pedagogy. With its intense focus on the promotion of positive health and higher states of well-being, Āyurveda has discovered that elevated states of health can be achieved only through a subtle transformation of the inner personality. Diseases can be cured, managed or prevented by medical intervention and other such physical means. However, higher states of health can be achieved only through self-awakening. The process of self-awakening is essentially an educative development, a psycho-spiritual transformation that enables the individual to not only live with awareness, but also with health. The meeting point of the most refined methods of pedagogy and healing gave birth to the notion of the physician par excellence as the *vaidya*, the one who knows the essentials and educates the individual, enabling him to reach a state of heightened awareness most conducive to knowledge acquisition and a healthy existence.

Healing the sick to cure and the healthy to liberate

The *Caraka Saṃhitā*, the celebrated medical textbook on Āyurveda that dates back to a few centuries before the Common Era, opens the section on the medical treatment of diseases with chapters on *rasāyana* (rejuvenation) and *vājikaraṇa* (reproductive medicine and eugenics).¹ At the first instance, the reader would find it appealing that the ancient masters emphasize the importance of prevention over the cure of diseases. But on a closer look, it becomes evident that there is a more profound message in this clever arrangement of topics in the medical treatise. The message is that even the so-called healthy individual needs further treatment—'*svastho'pi cikitsyaḥ*'. Health according to Āyurveda is definitely not the mere absence of disease. Āyurveda does not encourage the individual to remain complacent by eliminating the physical or mental discomfort caused by illness. It is not enough to adopt a conservative and defensive approach to life in order to

prevent disease. The focus is on empowering the individual to evolve to elevated levels of health and fulfil the higher goals of human evolution. Health becomes synonymous with an awakening of the mind in an invigorated body and with a life lived with an awareness of the spiritual self. The target of Āyurvedic knowledge is the '*karma puruṣa*', also known as the '*rāśi puruṣa*', the acting individual, who has to participate actively and consciously in this programme to soar into the realm of positive health and well-being.² Terms that mean diseased—such as *rogī*, *ātura*, *vyādhita* and so on—are only used in the context of grave diseases where external help from the physician is more important.³ Since the overall goal of Āyurveda is to be a holistic system of healthy living, these passive terms have been replaced by the term '*karma puruṣa*'.

Central to Āyurvedic healing is the notion of the human persona as a three-dimensional composite of body, mind and self.⁴ Āyurveda aims to empower the body to invigorate the mind and, consequently, to use the invigorated mind to generate self-awareness. The conscious self shines through every individual, but in different degrees, depending on the stage of evolution of her/his psycho-spiritual apparatus. The ultimate healing, according to Āyurveda, involves a subtle manoeuvre that enables the physical hardware and the psychic software of the human personality to upgrade itself to become capable of manifesting the true nature of the self in all its glory and completeness. This is the true disease-free state that Āyurveda aims to guide each human being to gradually evolve to.⁵

The chapters on rejuvenation and eugenics have been placed before the discussion on the treatment of physical and psychic ailments for the simple reason that Āyurveda considers every individual to be an incomplete and vulnerable entity till the full potential of the inner being has been awakened to perfection through a process of psycho-spiritual transformation.

Āyurveda stresses the importance of begetting progeny by choice rather than by chance, and emphasizes that only individuals enjoying higher states of health should reproduce to ensure that humanity can collectively raise itself to the sublime levels of spiritual awareness. The purpose of *rasāyana* (rejuvenation) is to tone up and empower the physical body as well as invigorate the mind. Eugenics and reproductive medicine are mentioned after rejuvenation in order to indicate that one should plan for progeny only after rejuvenating one's physical and psychic being.

It is very interesting to note that only these two chapters have been divided into quartets (*pādas*), thus partitioning each chapter into four subsections. No other chapter in the treatise shares this feature. Each section represents one of the four Vedic goals of human life—the *puruṣārthas*. Rejuvenation and eugenics have been placed on the four pillars of the *puruṣārthas* to indicate that their purpose is to realize the four major goals of life, viz., *dharma*, *artha*, *kāma* and *mokṣa*.⁶

One verse in the section on *rasāyana* explicitly states that the purpose of this modality of treatment is not cure of disease or a long life. One who adopts this regimen is able to follow the path of self-evolution attained by the great sages and becomes one with the supreme Brahman.⁷

Psycho-spiritual transformation of the healthy leads to liberation

According to Āyurveda, the conscious self is the immutable awareness⁸ upon which no medicine can act. It is entrapped in matter and masked by the delimiting nature of the material plane of existence. The liberation of awareness comes by the transformation and transmutation of matter and not merely by cultivating intellectual thoughts and ideas. Therefore, Āyurveda gives emphasis to physical medicines and physical procedures that aim to transform the material body so that the mind becomes powerful and capable of reflecting the true nature of the conscious self. Mind is not different from matter but is the other side of the material continuum, a finer state of matter itself. By definition, *rasāyana* is the means to clear the path for the smooth transformation of the life sap (*rasa*).⁹ The manifestation of consciousness in the relative world of experiences is very much a matter-bound phenomenon; the qualitative state of matter determines the degree of expression of consciousness in living beings. On the other hand, when consciousness manifests itself fully by liberating itself from the clutches of matter, it exerts a direct and transforming influence on the states of matter that delimit it in the first place.

This process of transformation cannot be started by external means. It has to happen from within. Physical illness can be healed, to some extent, with external medical help but to attain higher states of health, there has to be a conscious effort by the individual. The ideal Āyurvedic physician, therefore, has a dual role to play in the realm of healing. He has to first become a healer of diseases—in Āyurvedic terms, a *bhīṣak*, or one who drives away the fear of disease.¹⁰ Second, and most importantly, he has to become a healer of the personality, the knowledgeable *vaidya* who can facilitate self-transformation and impart knowledge of the self.¹¹

The dictum 'Physician, heal thyself' underpins the approach to the formal training that the Āyurvedic physician had to undergo in ancient days. Texts such as the *Caraka Saṃhitā* point out that apart from learning about diseases, medicines and treatment, the physician himself has to effect an inner transformation and become the ideal of the healthy existence that he will attempt to invoke in all those who approach him for solace and relief from suffering.

We do come across a method of training of the physician that culminates in the transmutation of the personality and the awakening of a higher awareness, comparable to a second birth of the fully trained doctor who now becomes fit to go out into the world as a healer.¹² It is very pertinent to note that this discussion falls within the quartet on *rasāyana*, an indication that sophisticated modalities of treatment like *rasāyana* should be done by a physician who has transformed himself into higher states of health and well-being.

Healing the healthy is education of the self

We see in the exposition of Āyurveda the emergence of a context where the principles of healing and pedagogy blend naturally to create an approach to self-transformation that transcends the scope of both healing and education as they are popularly understood.

This higher modality of healing in Āyurveda is truly 'self-education', which can mean educating oneself on the true nature of the higher self as well as education that has to be self-initiated and self-completed.

In Āyurveda, we can see a continuum being formed by healing and education, beginning with education about healing and culminating with education becoming a process of healing. The physician par excellence, or *apūrva vaidya*, in Āyurveda is one who eliminates the six faults of the mind and thereby roots out the seeds of disease once and for all.¹³ Thus, the true physician is one who can balance the two roles of healing and teaching, who can offer a helping hand to a sick person sinking in the swamp of illness and uplift him to the highest level of healthy existence by facilitating an inner transformation. That is why in ancient days, the physician was considered a manifestation of the Lord himself—'*vaidyo nārāyaṇo hariḥ*'. In due course of time, this higher role of the physician was neglected, even forgotten. The noble vocation of healing became a means of livelihood, a business, a lucrative profession. The *vaidya* who was Nārāyaṇa himself became the brother of the Lord of Death—Yama—who takes away both the wealth and life of the sick people who approach him.¹⁴ The *Caraka Saṃhitā* says that in the long term interests of humanity, such individuals deserve to be punished by molten metals being poured down their throats!¹⁵

The section of the *Caraka Saṃhitā* that deals with nature of the physical body, including anatomical considerations, devotes a full chapter to discussing the psycho-spiritual nature of the individual. It is in this context that serious questions are raised regarding the outcome of healing. Can healing eliminate sickness forever? What is the means to attain a disease-free state in which one is not afflicted by sorrow of any kind?¹⁶

The answer is *yoga*, the text declares. One can transcend the limitations of relative existence and go beyond disease and sorrow only through the practice of *yoga*. In *yoga* and *mokṣa*, there is freedom from pain. In *mokṣa*, which is the end result of the practice of *yoga*, there is complete cessation of sorrow and freedom from all limitations.¹⁷

Pain and pleasure are two sides of the same coin and cannot be avoided by living beings. In Āyurveda, both are together referred to by the technical term '*vedanā*'.¹⁸ The practice of *yoga* enables the individual to rise above them and attain equanimity of mind, which eventually leads to self-awakening and liberation. In that state, the individual identity dissolves completely; the individual becomes one with existence and evolves into a cosmic individuality characterized by the experience that he is one with the universe and the universe one with him.¹⁹

It can, thus, be seen that the higher aspects of Āyurvedic healing aim to take the individual on the path of *yoga*, the path of self-transformation. Interestingly enough, there is no single textbook on Āyurveda that deals with the eightfold path of *yoga*. There is not a single reference in any Āyurvedic textbook recommending physical postures or breath regulation as a means to heal disease or improve health. Not that they are not useful for these purposes, but Āyurveda seems to have understood *yoga* as a process of the psycho-spiritual transformation that leads

to union with the higher self.²⁰ This goal cannot be achieved by practicing *āsanas* or *prāṇāyāma* alone.

Suffice it to say that *yoga* in Āyurveda is, then, the means to psychic transmutation that leads to mental stillness (*sattvasamādhāna*) and, eventually, to complete self-awareness.²¹

Āyurveda advises the physician to become a parent to the sick and to treat the ailing person as one would one's own child.²² In other words, Āyurveda beseeches the physician to take up the responsibility to facilitate the physical, psychic and spiritual growth of those who approach him for succour.

The twin goals of healing and education

Āyurveda is made an example here to demonstrate the compact manner in which all knowledge systems in the Vedic tradition have been organized to serve the dual purpose of material prosperity (*abhyudayaḥ*) and spiritual uplift (*niśreyas*). Āyurveda fulfils the dual purpose of *aparā vidyā* (mundane knowledge) and *parā vidyā* (spiritual knowledge) by defining two modalities of treatment. The lower level of healing diseases is called *cikitsā*, which corresponds to the realm of *aparā vidyā* in the *Upaniṣads*. The higher level of healing is called *naiṣṭhiki cikitsā*, and it corresponds to the realm of *parā vidyā*.²³ Āyurveda thus fulfils the Vedic ideal of embracing both the physical and the spiritual in an act of balance, and to guide physical evolution to reach out to the higher realms of spiritual evolution.

The Āyurvedic example also demonstrates the need to complement vocational training with self-transforming education, and conveys the powerful message that any branch of human learning must blend the lower vocational component with a higher self-transforming programme of education. Training in any knowledge system was designed to develop vocational skills as well as facilitate the self-evolution of the student. In the context of Āyurveda, however, the physician is himself expected to become a powerful catalyst of self-awakening.

The principles of higher education in Āyurveda

The Āyurveda accounts that reveal the system of education through which students of Āyurveda were trained to become physicians give very valuable insights into techniques and methodologies that aimed to facilitate psycho-spiritual evolution and the balanced development of the personality.

The main principles of the Āyurvedic approach to education can be summarized in the following points:

1. *Right parenting*: The education of parents, the pre-conception behaviour of expectant couples and the proper upbringing of the child.
2. *Right nutrition*: The nutritional requirements of the child have to be properly met because growth and development of mental functions are dependent on the physical body, which works as a hardware for the mind.
3. *Right medical care*: Higher mental functions can be awakened by

appropriate medical care, and defective development rectified to a great extent by suitable medical intervention.

4. *Right teacher*: The teacher makes all the difference between knowledge and ignorance. The true teacher is a facilitator of learning and not a mere transmitter of information.
5. *Right teaching*: For a harmonious unfolding of the inner potential, it is essential to strike a balance between acquisition of professional skills and personality development, and teaching must give equal emphasis to both these aspects.
6. *Right student*: The student should be endowed with the necessary qualities to be able to imbibe the teaching completely and effectively. Preparing the student to receive knowledge is a key factor in education.
7. *Right environment*: Learning has to take place in an environment conducive to the acquisition of knowledge as well as self-development. Most importantly, the environment must nurture the process of learning in a natural and effortless way.
8. *Right learning process to suit needs of a student*: Each individual is unique. The ideal teaching programme should recognize individual differences and customize the teaching to suit the specific requirements of an individual.

A more detailed discussion on these points will provide better insight into the method of education for self-development advocated by Āyurveda.

Right parenting

The foundation for the complete education of the child begins before its conception. Educating the child begins through the education of the parents. Being born with a healthy physique gives a natural advantage to the individual in the effective pursuit of learning. Āyurveda advises a couple to rejuvenate itself physically and mentally, and to improve the quality of reproductive tissue with special treatments (*rasāyana* and *vājīkaraṇa*). The quality of parental tissues will reflect upon the quality of the reproductive tissues and, consequently, on the child that will be born to them. Āyurveda emphasizes that major developmental handicaps can be averted by proper planning and intervention. Āyurveda has also discovered that neurological development can be influenced by behavioural regimens adopted by the expectant mother during gestation. The pregnant woman is advised to mentally visualize the qualities she desires the child to be born with.²⁴

Two legends in the tradition give an indication that the influence of gestational behaviour on the developing personality of the child was a widely accepted principle in ancient times. One is the story of Prahāda, the devout child of the *asura* king, Hiraṇyakaśipu, who rebelled against his father and was able to invoke the blessings of Lord Viṣṇu in the ferocious form of the man-lion. Prahāda, it is said, did not develop *asuric* traits like his father because he was influenced by spiritual discourses delivered by the sage Nārada when his mother was pregnant. Another is the story of Abhimanyu, the son of Arjuna, who learnt the technique of piercing

through the *padmavyūha* formation in warfare when he was in his mother's womb. A story from the epics depicts a couple praying to Lord Śiva for a child and facing the predicament of having to choose between a long-lived dullard and a short-lived but intelligent child—they ask for the latter. The role of right parenting in laying the foundation for proper education of the child has been well expounded in the Āyurvedic classics and also finds parallels in the popular culture.

Right nutrition

Āyurveda has discovered the relationship between proper nutrition and balanced growth of the mind. Without being provided with the right nutrition, mental alertness can be hampered and during gestation and early childhood, this could lead to permanent mental disability. A story from the *Upaniṣads* demonstrates the importance of nourishment for the proper functioning of the intellect and the mind. One day, after a teaching session, a teacher advises the students to go on a fast and return with empty stomachs. In the fasting state, the students are unable to remember their lessons. They regain their memories after eating. This was an ingenious way in which the teacher of the *Upaniṣads* impressed upon children that the mind was a product of food—'*annamayam hi soumya manah*'.

Right medical care

Āyurveda recommends medications to enhance the higher mental functions of the growing child so as to facilitate the process of learning. Āyurvedic textbooks abound with lists of formulations for improving mental functions.²⁵ There is specific reference to the awakening of a faculty called '*medhā*', which is, according to one definition, the enhanced ability to read and understand books, and, according to another, the capacity for constant remembrance and the application of acquired knowledge.²⁶ There is also reference to the ability of herbal formulations to improve '*smṛti*', or ability to store and recall acquired knowledge.²⁷ Āyurveda has understood that mental functions have a physical basis and that the mind is but a finer form of matter. Only the conscious self transcends the realm of matter and mind and remains unaffected by the changes that take place in the material plane. Medicines can change the quality of physical matter, including the mind, and make it fit to reflect consciousness in a profound and intense manner.

Right teacher

It is very interesting to note that the ideal teacher described in the Āyurvedic texts is a facilitator of learning rather than one who drills information into the minds of his disciples. The teacher is compared to the timely rain that falls on fertile land sown with viable seeds.²⁸ In other words, the true teacher helps the student to unfold his inner potential. The relationship between the teacher and student was characterized by the sentiment of *vātsalya*, or deep affection. According to the commentator, *vātsalya* is the intense feeling of affection that a cow feels spontaneously for her newborn calf.²⁹ The main role of the teacher was to mould the character of the student, much like preparing a vessel to hold water. Knowledge

is compared to water and the mind of the student to the vessel.³⁰ It is easier to transfer knowledge than to organize a student's mind to use it in a benevolent way. The teacher was, therefore, one who was vested with the responsibility of ensuring that knowledge was passed on to only deserving candidates. The quality of a teacher was measured not merely by his ability to bestow knowledge and skills but also by his ability to build character. A student was given the right to examine a teacher before accepting him, just as a teacher would examine a student before enrolling him for study.³¹

Contrary to popular belief, the student enjoyed great freedom in the learning process. We find in the *Caraka Saṃhitā*, for instance, that teaching begins only when disciples raise questions.³² In many sections, the teaching is in the form of dialogues between the teacher and the pupil. According to tradition, even a teacher's mind is awakened by a student's stimulating question that is asked with the right attitude.³³

The *vidyārambha* ceremony, which is a very popular event (albeit nowadays only an occasion for celebration), symbolizes the role of the teacher in the Indian approach to education. The *navarātri* festival, which culminates in the *vidyārambha*, or the initiation into the learning process, lasts for nine nights and ten days. During the first three days, devotees worship the Goddess Kālī, the next three days, the Goddess Lakṣmī, and the last three days, the Goddess Sarasvatī. This festival represents the gradual victory over the lower tendencies of the human mind that manifest when *tāmasic* and *rājasic* qualities predominate. Kālī is the fierce aspect of the divine that overpowers the *tāmasic* tendencies of the human mind, Lakṣmī is the dynamic aspect of the divine that conquers the *rājasic* tendencies and equips the individual with the resources of nature. And, finally, Sarasvatī indicates the awakening of the *sātvic* tendencies of the human mind, indicating the maturity of the individual to receive knowledge. The grand finale is on the tenth day, which celebrates the victory of the higher nature over the lower, and represents the rebirth of the individual as a new person. It is no coincidence that these ten days correspond to the ten months of gestation in human beings. Āyurveda refers to *rajas* and *tamas* as the two faults of the mind, and spiritual education as the means to rectify them.³⁴

Since true education leads to the mental rebirth of the individual, the teacher became more sacred than one's biological parents and the teaching became sacrosanct. While the biological parents bring forth the physical body of the individual, the teacher brings forth the inner personality to complete the manifestation.

The function of the teacher as a source of information is slowly becoming redundant in this age of information technology and virtual reality. But the role of the teacher as a humanizing and catalyzing influence to facilitate the inner growth of the individual is assuming significance as never before.

Right teaching

The teaching should be appropriate and effective. It should strike a balance between theory and practice. As an Āyurvedic text says, one who is grounded only

in theory will become like a soldier who will run away from the battlefield at the mere sight of the enemy; and one who has only practical training will falter in complex situations. Theory and practice are like the two wings of knowledge. A very important concept regarding appropriateness of teaching is *adhikāra*. It is not easy to translate this word, but it would roughly mean eligibility or preparedness. The right teaching is like a potent seed that sprouts spontaneously when it is sown in the fertile mind of the disciple. Teaching becomes effective only when the mind of the student has been ploughed and made fertile. When the sage Bharadvāja approached Indra to get knowledge of Āyurveda, Indra explained Āyurveda in a very brief and suggestive exposition, knowing the powerful and receptive state of his disciple.³⁵

Right student

The *Caraka Saṃhitā* mentions in one place that the sage Ātreya had six disciples and that he taught all of them in the same manner, without favouritism. However, Agniveśa, his most brilliant disciple, got an edge over the others and became the first to systematically expound on Āyurveda.³⁶ There are three types of teachers and, likewise, three types of students—superior, mediocre and inferior. When a superior teacher meets a superior student, the best possible outcome can be expected. The worst scenario is when an inferior teacher meets an inferior student. Yet, a superior teacher can salvage something from an inferior student. The importance of the student putting in the effort to inculcate the necessary qualities to imbibe knowledge cannot be underestimated. Examination of a student was compulsorily carried out before initiation and was known as *śiṣyaparīkṣā*.³⁷

Right environment

True learning occurs spontaneously in the right circumstances. Creating the right environment for education alone can bring success. In the ancient Indian tradition, it was customary to send students out on specific tasks without giving them any formal lessons; the students would learn automatically from the situations that they found themselves in. Two stories in the Āyurvedic tradition exemplify how the ancient masters would cultivate professional skills and nurture personality development. Bhikṣu Ātreya told his students to roam around and find a plant that had no medicinal value. Only one of his disciples, Jīvaka, came back empty-handed, declaring that he could not find any plant that did not have medicinal value. Bhikṣu Ātreya announced Jīvaka as the only student of his who had qualified to be a physician. In another story, Nāgārjuna, the famous alchemist, asked two of his students on probation to prepare medicinal linctus. Both returned the following day: one had prepared the medicine while the other one came empty-handed. Nāgārjuna asked his second disciple why he had not followed the instructions. The disciple explained that on his way to collect herbs, he had met an old, ailing man calling for help. He could not ignore the old man's pathetic calls and attended to his needs and, therefore, could not make the medicine. The other disciple confessed that he had ignored the old man, fearing his teacher's wrath,

and went on to make the medicine. Nāgārjuna explained to them that compassion and not just the skill of making medicines was the more important quality that a physician must cultivate. He chose his compassionate disciple as his successor and forsook the more skilled one. Nāgārjuna clarified that it was easy to teach the skill of pharmacy but very difficult to nurture the value of compassion.

Right learning process to suit needs of a student

The teaching most appropriate to an individual's temperament and potential has to be imparted. In other words, teaching has to be individualized. Mass education and uniform standards were not the salient features of the ancient method of learning and teaching. The *Upaniṣadic* tradition itself reminds us of the importance of personalized teaching based on a very close and intimate relationship between the teacher and the student. Āyurvedic texts explain that the teaching should be modified according to three levels of intelligence of the students—the brilliant, the mediocre and the dullard.³⁸ Teaching should be suggestive to the brilliant, elucidative to the mediocre and instructive to the dullard.³⁹ The dullard student's training is application-oriented, the mediocre student's training theory-oriented, and the brilliant student's training discovery and innovation-oriented. These three levels correspond to the three-tier structure of a knowledge system dealing with the practice, theory and principles of a particular subject. Further, the Āyurvedic texts proclaim that one who has the qualities of a *brāhmaṇa* can study Āyurveda to teach and propagate science; one who has a *kṣatriya* disposition can learn it to become a health administrator; one who has a *vaiśya* character can learn it to practice and make a livelihood; and everybody can learn it for self-protection and to help the suffering.⁴⁰ Once again, the purpose of learning is differentiated on the basis of the inner qualities of the student.

In its approach to the training of a prospective student, the classical tradition of Āyurveda has captured the essence of the Indian approach to education in a vivid and clear manner. The goal of psycho-spiritual metamorphosis and the balance between professional skills and personality development constitutes the core of this method.

Conclusion

Both education and healing have two aspects—higher and lower. The lower aspect of education deals with vocational training and the imparting of professional skills with which one is able to serve society and make a living; this is the breadwinning education that we are quite familiar with. The higher aspect of education, however, deals with personality development that eventually leads to self-realization; it is an education that transforms the human personality and transmutes the beast into the human and the human into the divine. The lower aspect of Āyurveda is to prevent and cure disease; this is the profession of medicine, the so-called noble profession that helps humanity to free itself from the clutches of disease and discover the health of the body and the mind. The higher aspect of Āyurveda

is no different from the higher aspect of education in general. Knowledge systems in India used this two-fold approach with a view to impart professional skills and transform personality so as to achieve deeper self-awareness to ensure that the acquired knowledge would be applied for the welfare of humanity and the world at large. In Āyurvedic learning, we have a powerful and suggestive representation of this ancient wisdom.

True education heals. It is not a mere acquisition of information but an unfolding of the personality to actualize inner potential. It is, therefore, hardly a wonder that Āyurveda discovered that the higher forms of healing were synonymous with the process of education itself. In the Indian tradition, the undeveloped state of the inner self has long been considered a disease in itself, even outside the medical tradition. This disease is known as *bhavaroga*, or the disease of relative existence. The one who removes this disease and helps self-evolution is a physician, even if he is not trained in the medical sciences. In this sense, all spiritually awakened individuals become physicians in India. For this reason, even the Buddha came to be known as the '*bhaiṣajya guru*', or the preceptor of physicians, and came to be revered in some traditions of Āyurveda. Both Āyurveda, in particular, and the Indian cultural process, in general, bear testimony to the fact that at the higher levels of expression, education and healing become synonymous in facilitating a profound psycho-spiritual transformation of the embodied being.

Endnotes

- 1 CS. ci. 1.1–5, *svasthasyorjaskaram yattu tadvṛṣyaṁ tadrasāyanaṁ*—the two modalities of healing that enhance the health of the individual are rejuvenation and reproductive medicine.
- 2 CS. śā. 1.53, *puruṣo rāśisamjñastu mohecchādveṣakarmajaḥ*—the embodied individual is born out of delusion, likes, dislikes and the fruit of action.
SS. śā. 1.16, *yato/bhīhitam—pañcamahābhūtaśarīrasamavāyaḥ puruṣaḥ iti, sa eṣaḥ karmaṇ puruṣaścikitsādhikṛtaḥ*—the person who is embodied in the physical body made up of the five great elements is the subject of treatment, the enjoyer of the fruits of action.
- 3 AH. ut. 40. 64, *ātāṅkapaṅkamagnānām hastālambo bhiṣagjitaṁ*—medical treatment is the helping hand that uplifts those who are sinking in the swamp of disease.
- 4 CS. sū. 1.46, *sattvamātmā śarīraṁ ca trayametata tridaṇḍavat*—the mind, the self and the body constitute the tripod upon which life subsists.
- 5 CS. śā. 5.23, 24, *vipāpaṁ virajaḥ śāntaṁ paramakṣaramavyayaṁ, amṛtaṁ brahma nirvāṇaṁ paryāyairi śāntirucyate*—the sinless state of perfect composure, the abode of immortality, was attained by the sages who became free from delusion and attained everlasting peace.
- 6 CS. sū. 1.15, 16, *dharmārthakāmamokṣāṇāmārogyaṁ mūlamuttamaṁ, rogastasyā pahartāraḥ śreyaso jīvitasya ca*—health is the foundation for the pursuit of the four goals of human life, and disease is verily an obstacle in this path, taking away merit and life itself.

- 7 CS.ci.1.1.80, *na kevalam dirghamihāyuraśnute rasāyanam yo vidhivanniṣevate, gatiṃ sa devarṣiniṣevitām śubhām prapadyate brahma tathaiti cākṣayaṃ*—by the use of rejuvenative medicine, one does not merely attain long life but becomes one with the supreme Brahman.
- 8 CS. sū. 1.56, *nirvikāraḥ parastvātmā sattvabhūtaguṇendriyaiḥ, caitanye kāraṇam nityo draṣṭā paśyati hi kriyāḥ*—the supreme self is the cause of awareness and is a witness to all actions operating through the mind, the senses and the five-fold material world.
- 9 CS. ci. 1.1.8, *lābhopāyo hi śastānām rasādinām rasāyanam*—rejuvenative medicine is the means to obtain tissues endowed with good qualities.
- 10 *vācaspatya*, Vol. 6, p. 4701, *bheṣaṃ rogabhayaṃ jayati iti*—the physician is one who removes the fear of disease.
- 11 The word *vaidya* is derived from the root ‘*vid jñāne*’, meaning to know. The *vaidya* is one who is knowledgeable and can impart this knowledge to others. *Vācaspatya* defines the *vaidya* as a *pañḍita*.
- 12 CS. ci.1.4.52, 53, *vidyāsamāptau bhiṣajo dvitīyā jātirucyate, aśnute vaidyaśabdam hi na vaidyo pūrvajanmanā, vidyāsamāptau brāhmaṇi vā sattvamārṣamathāpi vā, dhruvamāviśati jñānāttasmād vaidyo dvijaḥ smṛtaḥ*—on the completion of education, the physician is known as the twice-born, and one does not become a physician by birth; on completing education, the mind of the physician is transformed to that of *brahmā* or a *ṛṣi*; therefore, the physician is known as the twice-born.
- 13 AH. sū. 1.1, *rāgādirogān satatānuṣaktān aśeṣakāyaprasṛtānaśeṣān, autsukyamohārati dañjaghāna yopūrvavaidyāya namostu tasmai*—I bow before the physician par excellence, who eliminated the six diseases of lust and the like, which plague all living beings constantly.
- 14 A popular verse portrays the physician as a messenger of death—*vaidyarāja namastu bhyam yamarājasahodaraḥ, yamastu harate prāṇān, vaidyāḥ prāṇān dhanāni ca*.
- 15 CS. sū. 1.131, 132, *varamāśiṣiṣaviṣaṃ kvathitaṃ tāmrameva vā pitamatyagnisantaptā bhakṣitā vā/pyayoguḍāḥ, natu śrutavatāṃ veṣaṃ bibhratā śaraṇāgatāt, gṛhitamannaṃ pānam vā vittaṃ vā rogapiḍitāt*—this verse describes the fate of a physician who commercializes the noble profession of medicine.
- 16 CS. śā. 1.13, *kva caitā vedanāḥ sarvāḥ nivṛttiṃ yāntyaśeṣataḥ*—a question addressed to the teacher on the complete cessation of pain and suffering.
- 17 CS. śā. 1.137, *yoge mokṣe ca sarvāsām vedanānāmavartanam*—the teacher answers that in the state of *yoga* and *mokṣa*, there is a complete cessation of all suffering.
- 18 CS. śā. 1.133, *sparśanendriyasamsparsaḥ sparśo mānasa eva ca, dvividhaḥ sukha dukhānām vedanānām pravartakaḥ*—this verse says that *vedanā*, or sensation, has the dual nature of pain and pleasure.
- 19 CS. śā. 5.7, *sarvalokamātmmanyātmānam ca sarvaloke samamanuṣāyataḥ satyā buddhiḥ samutpadyate, sarvalokaṃ hyātmani paśyato bhavatyātmaiva sukhaduḥkhaḥ kartā nānya iti, karmātmakatvācca hetvādibhīryuktaḥ sarvaloko/ahamiti viditvā jñānam pūrva mutthāpyate/apavargāyeti*—a vivid description of the self-realized state in which one develops a cosmic individuality of oneness with the universe.
- 20 CS. śā. 1.138, 139, *ātmendriyamanorthānām sannikarṣāt pravartate, sukhaduḥkha manārambhādātmasthe manasi sthīre, nivartate tadubhayaṃ vaśitvaṃ copajāyate,*

saśarīrasya yogajñāstaṃ yogamṛṣayo viduḥ—a very clear and lucid definition of the state of *yoga*, characterized by liberation in the embodied state.

- 21 CS. śā. 1.141, *ityaṣṭavidhamākhyātaṃ yogināṃ balamaiśvaram, śuddhasattva samādhānāttat sarvamupajāyate*—one enters into the state of *yoga* and obtains higher mental powers when the mind is calmed and quietened.
- 22 CS. ci. 1.4.46, *bhīṣagapyātūrān sarvān svasutāniva yatnavān, ābādhebhya hi saṃrakṣedicchan dharmamanuttamam*—this describes the responsibility of the physician to look after the patient like his own son, which is much like how a teacher looked after his disciple in ancient times.
- 23 CS. śā. 1.94, *hantityuktaṃ cikitsā tu naiṣṭhiki yā vinopadhām*—the definition of the higher form of spiritual healing.
- 24 AH. śā. 1.30, *icchetām yādṛṣaṃ putraṃ tadrūpacaritaṃśca tau, cintayetām, janapadām stadācāraparicchadau*—instructions to expectant parents to visualize the desired qualities of the progeny they wish to be born to them.
- 25 AH. ut. 1.42–49, lists several formulations that enhance the higher mental functions.
- 26 Dalhana on SS. sū. 2.3, *medhā granthāvadhāraṇakarṣaṇasāmarthyam*; Hemadri on AH, sū. 5.37, *upadiṣṭagrahaṇe śaktiḥ dhiḥ, gṛhītasya vicchedena dhārayitum śaktiḥ smṛtiḥ, avicchedena medhā*—these are two definitions of *medhā* in two different contexts.
- 27 AH. ut. 39. 78, 175 may be referred as examples of two formulations that enhance *smṛti* in a profound manner.
- 28 CS. vi. 8.4, *evam guṇo hyācāryaḥ sukṣetramārtavo megha iva sasyaguṇaiḥ suśiṣyamāśu vaidyaguṇaiḥ saṃpādayati*—the ideal teacher is portrayed as a facilitator of learning.
- 29 Dalhana's comments on SS. sū. 1.4, *vatsāḥ iti pakṣapātātīṣayatvasūcakaṃ sambodhanam, athavā vatsāḥ prathamavayaso gavām putrāḥ, vatsāḥ iva vatsāḥ, anena viśeṣaṇena prathamavayastvaṃ putrasādrśyaṃ damaniyatvaṃ ca sūcayati*—an elaboration of the concept of *vātsalya*, the sentimental relationship between the teacher and the disciple.
- 30 AS. sū. 2.12, *śastraṃ śāstrāṇi salilam guṇadoṣapravṛttaye, pātrāpekṣiṇyataḥ prajñam bāhuśrutyena br̥mhaḥ*—the importance of bestowing knowledge on the right person.
- 31 CS. vi. 8.4, *...tato/nantaramācāryaṃ parikṣeta*—instruction to examine the teacher.
- 32 CS. śā. 1.1, questions about the true nature of the self.
- 33 Chakrapani's comments on CS. si. 1.5, *apraduṣṭena bhāvena prasannenāntarātmanā, śiṣyena samyaṅprṣṭhasya gurorbuddhiḥ prakāśate*—guidelines on how to ask a question of the teacher to get an effective response.
- 34 AH. sū.1 *rajastamaśca manaso dvau ca doṣāvudāhṛtau*, and 1.26, *dhidhairyātmādi vijñānaṃ manodoṣausadhaṃ paraṃ*, CS. śā. 4.36, *trividhaṃ khalu sattvaṃ, śuddhaṃ, rājasam, tāmasam ceti, tatra śuddhamadoṣamākhyātaṃ kalyāṇaṃśatvāt, rājasam sadoṣamākhyātaṃ roṣaṃśatvāt, tāmasamapi sadoṣamākhyātaṃ mohāṃśatvāt*—various references to the influence of *rajas* and *tamas* on mental states.

- 35 CS. sū. 1.23, *tasmai provāca bhagavānāyurvedaṃ śatakratuḥ, padairalpaiḥ matiṃ buddhvā vipulāṃ paramarṣaye*—Indra expounds on Āyurveda to the sage Bharadvāja very concisely.
- 36 CS. sū. 1.32, *buddherviśeṣastatrāsinnopadeśāntaraṃ muneḥ, tantrasya kartā prathamamagniveśo yato/bhavat*—a difference in the quality of the intellect makes Agniveśa more successful than his counterparts who received the same teaching from the sage Ātreya.
- 37 CS. vi. 8.8, ... *adhyāpane kṛtabuddhirācāryaḥ śiṣyamevāditaḥ parikṣeta*—instruction to the teacher to examine the student before initiation.
- 38 CS. vi. 8.3, *trividhaśiṣyabuddhihitam*—the ideal text should aim to give an exposition that can be understood by all three types of disciples.
- 39 CS. sū. 4.20, *etāvanto hyalamalpabuddhinām vyavahārāya, buddhimatām ca svālakṣaṇ yānumānayuktikuśalānāmanuktārthajñānāyeti*—the scope for the intelligent student to go beyond the boundaries of the formal teachings.
- 40 CS. sū. 30. *sa cādhyetavyo brāhmaṇarājanyavaiśyaiḥ, tatrānugrahārthaṃ prāñinām brahmaṇaiḥ, āraḥsārthaṃ rājanyaiḥ, vṛtyārthaṃ vaiśyaiḥ, sāmānyato vā dharmārthakāmaparigrahārthaṃ sarvaiḥ*—the knowledge of Āyurveda can be put to different uses depending on the nature of the person who studies it.

Abbreviations of classical Indian texts used

AH	<i>Aṣṭāṅga Hṛdayam</i>
AS	<i>Aṣṭāṅga Saṅgrahaḥ</i>
CS	<i>Caraka Saṃhitā</i>
SS	<i>Suśruta Saṃhitā</i>
sū	<i>sūtra sthānam</i>
śā	<i>śarīra sthānam</i>
vi	<i>vimāna sthānam</i>
ut	<i>uttara sthānam</i>
ci	<i>cikitsā sthānam</i>

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9

Situating teacher education in the Indian context: A paradigm shift

Bharati Baveja

The genesis and development of teacher education in India

Discourse in education, particularly teacher education, has its genesis in pragmatic concerns overridden by social pressures in the late nineteenth century. Much like in the field of intelligence, where the testing of intelligence was a social necessity and tests were constructed without the existence of a sound conceptual base, teacher training also arose to meet the demands of providing education to a larger population of the society. Teacher training programmes also lacked an underlying theoretical framework. However, unlike the field of intelligence, there did exist a sound, well-articulated and time-tested discourse on education in the Indian tradition, but this was ignored. The teacher training programmes launched in British India were not rooted in the cultural context and ethos of the soil. Ad-hocism and reductionism characterized the nature of these programmes, with an over-emphasis on the technical skills involved in teaching. Consequently, learning and teaching came to be treated as synonyms. The limitations of such an approach gradually became too obvious to be ignored. It was realized that teacher preparation, which has serious social implications, cannot be based on a random collection of hypothesized ideas about teaching. It is an enterprise which not only involves the academic learning of children, but also provides direction to the development of society. The need to consider the education of children a serious academic endeavour was realized, and it was argued that a deeper and systematic understanding of the field was a precondition to teacher preparation.

Teacher education essentially required a more intense and systematic effort to understand and explicate the nuances of the educative process. The Calcutta University Commission in 1917 (popularly known as the Sadler Commission) recommended inter alia a significant organizational structure at the university level. The goal was to promote the development of education as a legitimate field of study. The academic pursuits that followed considered teacher training in the psychological, sociological, political and epistemological contexts. The phenomenon of teacher training was expected to be understood according to the varied findings

drawn from the cognate disciplines (psychology, sociology and philosophy). Consequently, there occurred a shift in nomenclature from teacher training to teacher education. Epistemologically, as in all other areas, education too followed the 'scientific approach'. Within this framework Western psychology, more specifically behaviourism, came to dominate academic thinking until the 1960s. In its recommendations, the Education Commission (1964–1966) emphasized the creation of new and strengthened organizational structures to facilitate academic pursuits with deeper understanding. Unfortunately, pedagogy and education developed as two distinct branches of education as a social science, just as test construction and theorization in the field of intelligence developed as two disjointed fields. Although the multi-disciplinary nature of education was recognized, education as a distinct area of study was reduced to an applied field. Ideas from 'pure disciplines' such as philosophy, sociology and psychology were generously and unhesitatingly applied. The continued dissatisfaction and attempts at reform were addressed not by creating a holistic discourse emerging from the cultural context, but by adding newer theories from the cognate disciplines. This led to a false sense of efficacy and relevance. The relevance and universalism of content were taken for granted. The role of culture in the process of 'meaning making' remained unattended. For instance, the inclusion of humanistic psychology, which places self-actualization at the centre-stage, was considered sufficient to compensate for the earlier 'excesses' of behaviourism.

A call for change

How compatible the notion of self according to the Western humanistic tradition was with the Indian concept of self and its evolution was not considered. Even though over the years changes have occurred (in theory), from behaviourism to cognitivism and humanism, and now to social constructivism, the vital point still remains missing—the need for a discourse in education and psychology based on Indian traditions. In the existing teacher education curricula, not only are the concepts of childhood and adolescence derived from Western theories, but their development is also understood from the Western perspective. Needless to say, teacher education is still ineffective and leaves a lot to be desired.

The periodic surveys of research in education in India since 1974 given below stand testimony to the fact that the teacher education programmes have remained largely unchanged.

- The roles and functions of a trained teacher as an agent of change in India have remained unexplored through research. Identification of the goals of teacher education is a relevant theme for further research (First Survey of Educational Research, 1974, p. 444).
- The curriculum of teacher education does not seem to have changed much. It is not adequate for just any one to suggest what changes should be brought about. Researchers with deep understanding and analysis should offer guidance in this regard. It should be within the ingenuity

and genius of our researchers to make a dent and develop indigenous approaches (Second Survey of Educational Research, 1979, pp. 421–422).

- In-depth studies of teacher education institutions, training situations and teachers at the micro level are essential to discover new variables for improving the effectiveness of teacher trainees and for exploring the results emerging from a macro analysis of these studies (Third Survey of Educational Research, 1986, p. 789).
- There is a need to know more about the teacher's role expectations, the relationship between the individual teacher's role expectations and her/his social responsibilities, the relationship between the teacher's conception of her/his role and their performance as observed by others in society. To make research meaningful, studies should be comprehensive and reflect rigour (Fourth Survey of Educational Research, 1993, pp. 915–916).
- Research projects aimed at understanding the multi-faceted process of teacher education in its totality need to be undertaken by agencies and organizations like the NCERT, the NIEPA, the UGC etc., as well as individual researches supported by the government (Fifth Survey of Educational Research, 1998, p. 457).

Empirical support

The early researches in the field were survey-based and quantitative in nature, and provided data regarding the inadequacies and ineffectiveness of teacher education programmes. Besides, these studies also indicated crucial areas requiring immediate attention in education and the school system. This was followed by a large body of research in the field of education technology, leading to a lopsided emphasis on technology in education. The 'organic' dimension of the educative process not only remained untouched, but was also suppressed by the more tangible and attractive idea of technology in education. Consequently, means became confused with ends. For instance, today computer-aided learning has become a goal in itself. Such innovations have only added to the existing behaviourist nature of education.

Some recent qualitative researches (although they are very few in number) have pointed towards the need to focus on individual processes of knowledge construction, the contextual situatedness of meaning-making, ways of strengthening inter-personal communications, the importance of teacher development, and so on. Even when self-development is emphasized in some cases, there is often very little understanding about the concept and the processes of its development.

Research in the field of psychology, particularly cognitive psychology, conducted in the previous century was also in the reductionist-logical-positivistic framework. In its quest to reinstate 'mind' in psychology, the cognitive revolution of the 1960s transplanted a mechanistic mind based on a computational model. The model of mind as an Information Processing System explains the

processing of information in fixed ways and assumes isomorphism between external and internal or constructed reality. The complexity and vastness of the mind, the existence of the inner self and its journey across different levels could not be conceptualized within this framework. Furthermore, the context of cognitive development, physical or cultural, was viewed as an external variable, distinctly separate from the mind and therefore subject to external control. Independent researches were conducted in the fields of perception, memory, problem-solving and the nature of the task to be learned. Although these were collectively referred to as mental processes, they were not conceived of as inseparable parts of an indivisible whole. Thus the subject matter, the learner, the context of learning, the process and product of learning were treated as independent units of analysis. In this framework, the learner got separated from learning, the subject matter to be learned and the cultural context of learning—the chronic Cartesian impasse. Although today we do talk of constructivism, distributed cognition, embedded or situated cognition, wherein the continuity of context, mind and task is asserted, yet the context is defined in finite, material terms. It fails to capture the Indian view that all entities are inter-dependent and inseparable parts of the same cosmic whole—the Supreme Consciousness—as different manifestations of the same reality—*Brahman*. There is an unwavering belief in the unity and mutual relatedness of objects which form a whole that is indivisible, and manifests in all things—the Self.

Concepts such as *brahman*, *īśvara*, *puruṣa* and *ātman* are rarely understood by contemporary Western thinkers. Brahman, the Universal or the Supreme Self, supersedes existence and encompasses everything that exists; it envelops space and time and is thus expanded in the cosmos and beyond. This changeless and imperishable Self is the essence of all existence. When Brahman is considered in relation to the Universe, it is regarded as *Īśvara*. *Īśvara* is Brahman with attributes—united with its powers. *Puruṣa* is the higher nature of *Īśvara* and is the manifestation of the Supreme Self in all living forms. *Māyā* is *Īśvara*'s lower nature or *prakṛti*. When Self as *Īśvara* interacts with *māyā*, *prakṛti* bursts into form and activity and constitutes the phenomenal reality—*kṣetra*. The *Jiva* or Individual Self is only a part of the Supreme Self and is a limited manifestation of the infinite reality. The world is dependent upon Brahman, but Brahman is not dependent on the world. It is the cause of all activity in the world, yet it itself does nothing. It pervades every entity, living as well as non-living, and sustains everything, yet has a distinct identity. It is in itself the existence, the knowledge, the joy, that is, the *sat*, *cit* and *ānanda*, respectively. If situated and embedded cognition is conceptualized according to this perspective, its meaning, orientation, expanse and scope changes tremendously.

We have consistently failed to acknowledge the richer and more convincing concepts that have existed in Indian traditions since time immemorial; concepts that are not just an outcome of sensory experience, but the result of prolonged and continuous reflection at the higher levels of consciousness; concepts which are robust enough to withstand the test of time. At the same time, they are flexible

enough to provide a framework for understanding varied experiences, irrespective of time. Among the galaxy of preceptors, the impact of Sri Aurobindo's thought has been distinctive in the field of education. His views on Integral psychology and the corresponding Integral education provide a well-articulated framework for education based on Indian thought. The emphasis in this system of education is on enabling learners to locate the experience of 'I' within them. Silence is basic to such an introspective and meditative process when one undertakes the journey to discover the true nature of Self, 'the inner I'. The essence of spiritual practice is attaining that state of experiencing the inner feeling where existence is independent of the physical body and the outside world. It is then that one is able to see oneself as part of the Infinite; an unbroken continuity of Universal Consciousness. The unique feature of such a spiritual experience is its motiveless urge. Such experiences have become even more relevant in contemporary times, when personal and social conflicts are taking a heavy toll on both individuals and societies. The addition of a course on Education for Peace in the National Curriculum Framework 2005 testifies to this effect. 'Peace as an integrative perspective for school curriculum is an idea whose time has come' (NCF Review, 2005, p. 183).

The paradigm shift

The previous two centuries witnessed a dominance of quantitative research situated in the experimental research paradigm. Replicability and public verification were at the heart of such an approach, and generalizability its logical outcome. Phenomena, experiences and internal processes that could not be verified by others were not considered worthy of research as these did not lend themselves to observation and measurement. The physical world may lend itself to an explicit demonstration of causality, but the 'inner world', which governs the thoughts, feelings and actions of humans, does not lend itself to the 'hard science' research methodology. In such a situation, there existed only one option—rejection of one of the two, that is, the content of research or the method of research. The intangible, unobservable and immeasurable content of human experience was denied substantive existence and therefore rejected in favour of the scientific method, which enjoyed the reputation of a legitimate approach to inquiry. Consequently, personal experiences, despite being genuinely real, were not acknowledged, and therefore not considered valid enough to be researched. Over-mechanization and dehumanization of mankind was met with resistance by the humanists and took the shape of Third Force psychology, which placed the individual human experience at the core of its analysis. It was increasingly acknowledged that the deeper and subtle issues that govern human life cannot be understood according to the parameters prescribed by the scientific approach. However, since these issues are real to the experiencing self, there must be other methods of enquiry that can deal with them. This view was supported by researches conducted in cultural anthropology, which attempted to analyse and describe the lives of people 'as they lived'. The Fourth Force, namely transpersonal psychology, with its thrust

on transpersonal inquiry, further legitimized this emerging argument. It became increasingly clear that the method of science was not only inadequate, but also an inappropriate tool of inquiry for understanding deeper and subtler issues of a metaphysical nature. The need for qualitative rather than quantitative research was strongly felt, and there occurred a remarkable shift from objective to subjective, reductionist to holistic, scientific to phenomenological, experimental to descriptive, and contrived to naturalistic research in the late twentieth century.

Qualitative research derives data from participative observations and verbal interactions with a focus on meanings and interpretations made by the participants. Its major goal is to explore the deeper and intense aspects of the phenomena under study, and essentially involves a search for meaning. Ethnography, biographies and phenomenological approaches are examples of qualitative research. Phenomenology is primarily oriented towards experience and its meaning for the subject—the experiential reality. Emphasis is laid on how the 'life-world' is perceived and described by the subjects themselves. Such a research is not governed by a theoretical priori, but through a construction of meanings and categories or themes emerging in the process of interpretation. The essence of reality is to be understood as it exists. The aim is to capture lived experience with all its emotions and feelings.

Thus, with experiential reality acquiring a respectable position in what are considered legitimate ways of knowing, it seems perfectly reasonable to frame questions and seek answers to what is observed and experienced in everyday life. The everyday observations of most individuals, irrespective of age, gender or class, highlight an effort to contemplate something that is convincingly real, and yet denied as reality by the mainstream intellectual tradition. The need to create space for dialogue on such issues has been expressed silently as well as overtly, and therefore can no longer be brushed aside under the garb of scientifically invalid content or secular education. Observation of this expression itself warrants intellectual deliberation on the subject. It is fitting to note that in a seminar on the theme 'Personal Re-engineering in Management', organized in Bangalore in 1998, an agonized management professional remarked, 'Do I understand right that living (being) is the goal of life? If that be so, why should all that not be told to me at an early age? I am, actually learning to live life after one third or two third of it is gone. Do I have to stumble upon the goal?' The other management personnel also shared their anxieties, feelings of insecurity, loneliness, fears and despair at the same seminar (Swami Dayanand, 1998, p. 35).

While pursuing his teacher preparation course, a physics post-graduate from Delhi University chanced upon a book, *Jnanayoga* (1993), written by Swami Vivekananda. He shared his experience of reading this book with other members of the tutorial group, including the tutor (the author), in October 2005. He reported that reading this book was an elevating experience and remarked in a thoughtful voice,

I wish I had read this book earlier, I would have been a different person.
I have passed through tremendous inner turmoil and state of uncertainty.

This book has changed me by putting my mind to rest. It has answers to so many questions which nagged me as a young boy. Today I feel happy—happy without any apparent reason. But I know the reason, I have discovered something, perhaps the truth or the essence of life. There is peace inside and I can look at my experiences objectively. I think this book should be taught as part of our school curriculum. Every child must read this book. There will be more peace and harmony inside and outside.

He then asked the most difficult question: 'Why is it not part of our school curriculum? It is neither religious nor communal.'

Another member of the tutorial group also opened up and said,

I was feeling terrible yesterday after my practice teaching. Nothing seemed to work, I felt very incapable and dejected since all my plans and theory went down the drain. When I came back home, I cried and was feeling very depressed. Suddenly I turned the pages of the book called *Psychic Education*.¹ I opened it with no intention of reading it seriously but the page I opened described just how I was feeling. I got interested and started reading and very soon I was following the suggestions given in the book. I realized I was meditating. It cheered me up and made me feel light inside. I think every B.Ed. (Teacher Education) student must read this book.

The tutor wondered how a simple act of placing certain books on the table around which the tutees sit, and asking them to glance through them if they so desired, could make such a difference. The students found a space in this tutorial class to share something that the system does not want to acknowledge. Talking about religion, spirituality or inner experiences is not only considered unacademic, but also communal. After all, our education is secular, with secularity defined in curious ways! However, spirituality is part of the human experience, and it is naïve to confuse it with any religion or community. Furthermore, if the aim of education is to address the whole child, it is absolutely imperative that room be provided for understanding inner experiences and integrating them with overall thought and behaviour.

Cultural context

All along, from ancient times to the present, Indian psychology has cogitated on the depths and heights of consciousness, and the inner world has been a major subject of inquiry and analysis. The UNESCO report of the Education Commission, 1996, titled 'Learning the Treasures within', proposed that '... the process must begin with self understanding through our inner voyage whose milestones are knowledge, meditation and practice of self-criticism'.

What clearly emerges from the analysis is the need for reorientation, deconstruction, and a paradigmatic shift in our approach to education and teacher preparation. The importance of a sound theoretical base, and the lack of the same, has been stressed upon by various commissions, committees, and those involved in education. A persisting concern in teacher education has been the enhancement

of its 'impact potential'. The urgency to reorganize teacher education courses has been highlighted by all concerned with education. The National Policy on Education, 1986 (revised in 1992), reiterated the same, and emphatically suggested that there is something basic to teacher education programmes that needs to be remedied urgently. These programmes fail to convey a coherent and meaningful view of the school education system. The revised National Curriculum Framework (2005, p. vii) opens with a quotation from Rabindranath Tagore's essay *Civilisation and Progress* (1924) in which the poet asserts that 'creative spirit' and 'generous joy' are key in childhood, and that both can be distorted by an unthinking adult world. As regards teacher education, it suggests a complete overhauling; there is a need for a fundamental change in the approach to teacher education in order to make it field-sensitive and participative in nature. It visualizes the teacher as an 'encouraging, supportive and humane facilitator in teaching-learning situations who enables learners (students) to discover their talents, to realize their physical and intellectual potentialities to the fullest, to develop character and desirable social and human values to function as responsible citizens' (Yadav, 2005).

The agenda of education stands crystal clear. There is a need to redefine the goals of life, self, knowledge, processes of knowing, and processes of enabling others to know and connect with others' selves. This obviously involves a deeper consciousness. Well-articulated views already exist in this regard in the Indian tradition. There is need to capitalize on these before they are sold to us (*yoga* and alternative medicines are good examples). Our society has lost its earlier structure and orientation towards 'progress inside', and lacks the culture to deal with the 'progress outside'. There is a need to build on our culture of 'growth inside' to deal with the growth of the world 'outside'. This requires a cognitive reorientation; a culture of learning to be at peace with oneself; a structure which provides space within oneself, composure within ourselves so that we can view the world objectively and decide about actions in consonance with our basic nature as human beings (see Swami Dayanand, 2002).

The task ahead

As stated in the previous section, the Teacher Education programmes in India were not only reactive, but also mechanistic, and were based on the 'teacher as a technician' metaphor. The goal of Teacher Education was to equip teachers with the tools and techniques effective in 'handling' and 'moulding' children according to fixed, preconceived and, quite often, contrived notions of humans and human life. A system that does not allow space for individual variability systematically stifles creativity, curbs originality of thought and action, and impedes the actualization of potential; it injects intellectual anaesthesia and produces academic robots. Denial of individuality or uniqueness in children is denying the existence of the self; it is tantamount to the denial of the existence of consciousness and thus cannot serve as a valid conceptual base for human development. Therefore, there is a need to reorient teacher education programmes towards a more proactive

stance, which will ensure the conceptual, contextual and ethical validity of the teacher education curriculum.

The immediate response that comes to mind while trying to answer the question of 'how we want our children to grow up' is that we want them to grow into individuals who are healthy, with life-styles conducive to the sustenance and promotion of life in all its forms; who appreciate the beauty and potential of nature, the inter-dependence of all forms of life and the need for harmony; who are happy and at peace with themselves, and consequently 'make peace' with others; who reason dispassionately about natural and social phenomena; who are tolerant to ambiguity and multiplicity and can resolve, or at least understand, the antinomies of today's world; who have understanding and respect for cultural diversity and are able to communicate and cooperate with persons of different origins; who value good human relations and are committed to mutual trust and coexistence; and work towards the common goals of society and mankind. (Baveja, 2005)

To sum up, these are individuals who are competent and self-propelled to undertake the journey of the evolution of self and society in its widest, deepest and highest sense.

In view of the above, there cannot be a better characterization of education than that education is a process of 'drawing out the best in body, mind and soul'. The aims of education flow directly from this immensely meaningful statement of Mahatma Gandhi's. There seems to be no substitute for this eternal definition of education. Although education has to essentially address these major dimensions of the child, they cannot be viewed as independent components that develop and function in isolation from each other. Body, mind and soul form an integral whole not amenable to fragmentation, thus pre-empting a reductionist approach.

Our prevailing education system not only fails to address the 'whole child', but also fragments knowledge into discrete areas of study, rendering life experiences incomprehensible. No wonder research indicates that in comparison to 'unschooled' children, 'schooled' children are better equipped to memorize discrete bits of often meaningless information. Although schooled children are at an advantage given their ability to comprehend symbolic information such as graphs and formulae, they are not better in day-to-day problem solving when compared to 'unschooled children'. 'That students failed to connect their formal symbol manipulation procedures with "real-world" objects represented by the symbols constitute a dramatic failure of instruction' (Schoenfeld, 1988, p. 150). 'People who perform poorly in the test situations show great skill on similar problems in their everyday lives' (Rogoff, 1984). The fact that 'school knowledge' does not connect the child to real life and remains for the most part 'inert knowledge' is too well-known to be emphasized further (Brown, et al., 1989). Teacher education is no exception. The traditional approach in teacher education programmes is to teach the philosophical, sociological, psychological and pedagogical aspects of education as distinctly separate areas of study. Further, there is no explicit attempt

to illustrate the inter-connectedness of these areas. As a result, most practising and student teachers not only fail to see the relevance of some of these content areas, but are also unable to comprehend the same. Researches conducted in the last two decades (Behari, 1997; Ramanathan, 2004) indicate that most teachers feel that although the B.Ed. course prepares them for specific subject teaching (which is no doubt the goal of secondary and senior secondary teacher education), it does not address those dimensions of their personality that are important to becoming fully functioning teachers, or, for that matter, fully functioning humans. The existing teacher preparation courses are not focused on preparing 'teachers', but are designed to prepare 'subject teachers'. Subject teachers can only produce academic robots. This is part and outcome of the mechanistic scheme of our teacher education programmes. Most participants in both the researches either directly or indirectly pointed to the irrelevance of foundational courses such as philosophy and sociology of education as they perceived their jobs as subject teachers. The real classroom poses different kinds of challenges for which they are ill-prepared. The need to structure teacher education programmes according to holistic themes emerges clearly, both at the research and experiential levels. It might be more useful to structure teacher education programmes according to broader thematic areas that transcend the boundaries of traditional disciplines and focus on learners, learning, pedagogy etc. The other major problem sighted by teachers in the above research was how unprepared they were to meet the challenge of variability that exists in actual classrooms. The teachers' own ability to connect positively with children from diverse backgrounds and, in turn, enable children to relate effectively with each other is not nurtured in the existing teacher education programmes. And neither is concern for good inter-personal relationships among teachers a significant focal area.

Given the pluralistic social order, marked by aggressive global forces, communal conflicts and vested political interest, it is essential that education produces critical thinkers who can take informed decisions and act with courage and conviction. '[...] it is vital to prevent social conflict through an education that fosters understanding and respect for cultural diversity as well as communication and cooperation between persons of different origins' (Dasen, 1992). Urbanization, industrialization and cross-border conflicts have generated unprecedented human mobility. Teachers are invariably faced with multi-cultural classrooms and have to communicate with children and parents from different cultural origins, and thereby have to deal with complex inter-group dynamics. 'It is therefore important to train teachers to understand the phenomenon linked to migration, cross cultural communication and social psychology Explicit attempt should be made to enable teachers to overcome their own ethnocentrism by reflecting on their enculturation recognizing their prejudices' (Dasen, 1992). Such goals cannot be achieved through verbal communication alone. They require an experiential and more participative approach to teacher preparation. Internship or school life experiences should essentially include inter-cultural education and provision for self-development and working with the community.

Perennial foundations

The greatest challenge for human beings is to understand the Self, the inner essence of one's existence. This awareness is totally experiential and not conceptual. (*The Hindu*, National daily, dated 28 December, 2005, p. 9)

The Western traditions look at the concept of self as the potentiality and possibility of development inherent in humans. These inherent potentialities are actualized through interactions with the phenomenal world. Carl Rogers (1951) defines self as an 'organized, fluid, but consistent conceptual pattern of perception of characteristics and relationships of the I or the "me" together with values attached to these concepts'. The structure of the self is formed as a result of interaction, particularly evaluative interaction, with the environment, which comprises significant others and events. 'Self actualization involves becoming whatever one can become through activities determined by one self' (Maslow, 1970). 'The organism has one basic tendency and goal—to actualize, maintain and enhance the experiencing organism' (Rogers, 1951). Although a fully actualized self is allocentric, altruistic and autonomous, its locus of existence lies essentially in the individual. The individual self is the be all and end all; a single point, a uni-dimensional entity.

The concept of self according to Indian traditions, particularly the *Bhagavad Gītā*, is a multi-layered construct. It simultaneously connotes the metaphysical, spiritual and phenomenal realms of existence. A well-defined hierarchy of the many selves within the composite universal self is conceptualized. *Brahman*—the Universal Self—is the highest layer in this system. *Brahman* pervades everything that exists, organic and material (physical). Human beings are miniscule in the larger cosmic order. *Brahman* can neither be fully known, nor can it be achieved by the 'human form'. *Brahman* is inconceivable or *acintyārūpa*. It is also unmanifested—*avyakta*. It is therefore beyond cognition, experience and comprehension.

Next in the descending order of pervasiveness is the individual self or *puruṣa*. *Puruṣa* is the knower, the cognizing being. It is addressed by different scholars as *ātman*, *jīva*, consciousness or life force. *Puruṣa* pervades only living entities unlike the *Brahman*, which pervades the entire universe. *Dharma* or the nature of *puruṣa* is to illumine all that comes in contact with *buddhi* (reasoning principle), *manas* (mind), *aharīṅkāra* (ego sense), *indriya* (sensory perception apparatus), and the external world with detachment. However, in human life *puruṣa* comes in contact with the *triguṇa*—*rajas* (activity), *tamas* (inertia) and *sattva* (purity)—leading to enjoyment, incurring pleasure and pain. To attain true knowledge of the Self, the limitations imposed by the gross-subtle body and by the three *guṇas* must be transcended. The individual has to become *triguṇātīta*—an individual who is led not by personal choices, but by duties with complete detachment. Surrender or attachment is not to the persons or objects served, but to *svadharma* and *svabhāva*. Lower down this order is the personal self. This conception of self addresses the misconception of self entertained by human beings. Although the true Self of man is the *puruṣa*, yet with the *prakṛti*-borne body-*manas*-intellect-*aharīṅkāra* apparatus, the consciousness principle is conceived as a means to worldly ends rather than as

an end in itself. In this process, the ego-sense (mis)identifies with the body, and the cognitive apparatus with the self.

This level (personal self) is akin to the Western notion of self, which includes the physical, social, intellectual and emotional dimensions of an individual's personality. These, according to the *Bhagavad Gītā*, are components of *prakṛti*, and must be transcended for self-realization. The goal of life is to strive for the evolution of the personal self to higher levels, rather than limiting its evolution to the actualization of inherent bodily potentials.

The pursuit of knowledge leads to the discovery of Self, which is the source of liberation. Knowledge is possible only when the mind is free from desire, likes and dislikes, fears and threats. One's commitment to knowledge leads to self-learning, *svādhyāya*, which is pursued for its own sake; the commitment comes from within; the knower or the epistemic subject is intrinsically motivated to discover the truth. Discovery of truth or knowledge is an outcome of inquiry; however, when the learner is not mature enough or is unable to conduct a successful inquiry, he may be taught. *Pravacana* is teaching. *Svādhyāya* and *pravacana* form a continuum, wherein the one who knows shares knowledge with others who are keen to know. Learning requires an inquisitive, perceptive mind which engages in reflection and articulation. It is not ingestion of what is told but is a constructive and a generative process which requires a contemplative mind. A contemplative mind has to be discovered and developed by releasing the mind from the bonds of likes and dislikes. Suitable measures and appropriate means have to be adopted to free the mind from the shackles of personal likes and dislikes. One who is continuously learning and sharing knowledge, that is, engaging in *svādhyāya* and *pravacana*, leads a contemplative life: s/he is a life-long learner who is sincerely committed to enabling others to learn. However, learning and teaching—*svādhyāya* and *pravacana*—are two separate, though intimately related, processes. Learning and teaching both require a contemplative mind. The teacher teaches, but does not indoctrinate or impose. The student must construct his own understanding, decide for himself and assume responsibility for his actions. As described in the *Bhagavad Gītā*, Arjuna asks for advice from Lord Kṛṣṇa and He teaches Arjuna about the nature of action and renunciation while leaving the understanding of the scheme and the consequent action to him. The teacher is a facilitator; he shows the path, provides exposure, but leaves the analysis and contemplation to the learner. The '*adhikāra*' or choice of action lies with the learner. A contemplative mind is fundamental to metacognition and is an outcome of the evolution of the inner self. A developed and evolved contemplative mind, fundamental to metacognition, is free from biases and can embark upon objective decision-making.

The Self is *akartā*, actionless; it neither performs any action nor leads anyone to do so; the knower of the self is indeed the Self. Here, it is not action that is denied; it is the *kartṛtva* or doership that is denied. 'Actions are performed by the body and the wise man is not identified with the body; he knows himself to be actionless Self. So the knowledge of actionless Self is freedom from action' (Swami Dayananda, 1987, p. 4). The discovery of the self involves the renunciation of

the sense of doership. Pursuit of '*karma*' (action) involves the sense of doership. *Karma* is action and *vihitakarma*, the enjoined actions known as duties. Nature is in perfect harmony to sustain the Universe. This harmony can be disturbed only by humans as other living beings are not endowed with volition—the faculty of choice. *Vihitakarma* are conducive to the maintenance of harmony in life, which is the duty of every human being. Duty is borne out of maturity and appreciation of one's role in the scheme of things. It can be seen as a mandate until it is internalized. A sense of duty culminates in a proper attitude towards life and evolves into *niṣṭhā*—commitment. Actions that disturb the harmony in the universe and life are '*niṣiddhakarma*'. A true *karma yogi* is one who avoids '*niṣiddhakarma*' and engages in '*vihitakarma*'. A *yogi's* actions are governed by duties performed through detachment from personal likes and dislikes, as well as from the outcome of actions. *Yoga* here implies equanimity of mind.

Concluding remarks

These ideas, taken from the *Bhagavad Gītā*, help us reconstruct the conceptual framework for teacher education. First, it clearly indicates that teaching is not a collection of skills but an ongoing process of contemplation, a continuous process in the search for truth. It is an ongoing quest to understand the learner, the processes of learning, ways of providing learning experiences and inspiration to embark on the inner journey. A teacher has to be a true *karma yogi* who engages in enjoined action in the pursuit of knowledge and is committed to the development of her own self and those of her students; one who makes discretionary use of the faculty of choice.

The development of self is basic to all aspects of development. An evolved self is naturally committed to altruism, justice, diligence and genuine concern for the development of society. Teachers should be facilitated in their journey towards self-development and in helping their students move towards the same goal. Legitimate space should be provided for self-development activities in the Teacher Education Curriculum. A non-evaluative, accepting, threat-free environment is basic to self-development. It inspires sharing, increases receptivity and, most importantly, promotes self-reflection, leading to the development of a positive self-concept. Opportunities for self-expression in different art forms with a view to unfolding aesthetic sensibilities would also lead to a sense of fulfilment. Teachers need to be taught how to create learning environments that are non-competitive and threat-free; permissive environments that inspire and nurture creativity, critical thinking and reflexivity, thereby preparing the child for problem-solving and conflict resolution.

The Teacher Education Programmes should provide space for developing teachers who are conscientious and committed to unity and harmony. A true teacher is one who engages in an ongoing process of self-evolution through contemplation, self-reflection and self-correction; s/he initiates and enables the pupils to engage in these processes with equanimity, taking into account the student's

cognitive, cultural, economic and physical characteristics. Knowledge should include the discovery of the Self, as already stated; thus, all the attributes mentioned above can only be realized through experience and reflection. Therefore, it is essential that the teacher education curriculum be experience-based and interactive, with ample opportunities for self-observation and self-reflection, leading to self-development. Only an evolved self can facilitate the evolution of the selves of others. Vertical development inside is expected to lead to horizontal development outside; the deeper the connection with the inner self, the greater the comfort and ease in connecting with others outside. Biases and prejudices dissolve when realization of the oneness of the omnipresent consciousness dawns.

Endnotes

- 1 See Huppes, 2001.

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10

Krishnamurti and value education

Vinita Kaushik Kapur

The world is in such chaos that even if you deliberately set about to make the world more chaotic than it is you could not succeed.... And it needs a very sharp, clear, decisive, sane mind to resolve such a chaotic condition. I do not think such a mind can come about, except through religious perception.

—Krishnamurti, *The religious mind*, p. 4

Education and the human condition

For Krishnamurti, the means to religious perception is through scepticism, doubt and questioning, and this can come about through right education. All through his teaching years he emphasized the crucial and vital role that education can play in the creative regeneration of the way human beings think, and therefore live. Enquiring deeply into the nature of the mind, he posited that the aim of education must be to awaken an intelligence through which thought and knowledge find their rightful place. Such perception is religious perception. And it is only when the truly religious mind informs the values on which we build our daily existence that there is a possibility of a sane and orderly world, free from conflict and sorrow.

Education, as generally understood, is the movement generated by social systems to ensure their perpetuity through time. It is a process of imparting and acquiring skills for life, at home, in schools and colleges; it is also the total process of psychological imprinting that is absorbed and perpetuated in tandem with the acquisition of such life skills. Wherever human beings have lived in groups, they have created structures, both physical and psychological, in order to ensure the safe continuity and security of their offspring. Workable solutions, ways of being, of understanding the world, have been codified and passed on as a means of coping with inner (psychological) and outer exigencies. These patterns are mostly subject to the needs and requirements of the maintenance of power structures within societies. All new entrants to human groups must necessarily submit to these established structures. They must be programmed to fit into pre-determined and socially approved slots.

Education generally conditions the mind to accept these structures of society. Therefore, such a mind is unable to see beyond this socially constructed reality.

The process begins at home and continues throughout the life of a person. Societies are so particular about the maintenance of social order that deviations are kept in check through formal and informal means of social control. Those considered mad or wayward are re-oriented, even re-parented in order to fit them back into society.

Krishnamurti questions the very basis of this kind of education. He suggests that conditioned human beings can neither bring about nor participate in a society that is free and creative. Hence, for him, the most important concern of education is to help the child enquire into and understand the movement of conditioning as it expresses itself in the individual and in society, and thus be free of it.

In order to appreciate his vision of an education that can bring about deeply religious values, it is necessary to understand the nature of human existence as he saw it. For Krishnamurti, it was axiomatic that the human mind operates from a base that is made up of patterned responses, which themselves are the result of thousands of years of human struggle with nature and with the ever-evolving world-views that make up our social environment. These responses are so deeply embedded in the fabric of our psycho-physical natures that it has become impossible to meet the movement of life without the filter of these pre-established means of cognition. These means manifest themselves in the way human beings think. Our thoughts are directly linked to the basic assumptions held by the society we are born into. There is a continuous back and forth movement of patterning between the conditioned individual and the conditioned society. And this is what sustains the system.

At a more fundamental level, human conditioning inevitably brings about a sense of fragmentation within the psyche, and separation from other humans, other social groups and from nature. The culture one is born into plays an integral role in the way the instinctive drives take shape, and the child is programmed to respond to fear and approval from a very early age. The personality created through conditioning is the constructed self, the prison in which one is held. Any 'action' that emanates from such conditioning is therefore based on a partial and fragmentary view of a given situation and of the totality of life. And being a constructed piece or 'fragment' that has been plucked out of a whole picture, it must necessarily lead to partial action. Partial, biased equations can never be balanced; by their very nature they will be in conflict with other fragments operating from similar backgrounds.

It is this kind of conditioning that has brought about sorrow, confusion and pain. The wars and battles fought over the territorial identities and interests of religions, nations, corporations and individuals; the escalating stress and misery in every field of life; the momentary relief and pleasure that act as buoys on the ocean of the constructed 'me', all these form the human condition—a prison from which human beings must find a way out if humanity is not to destroy itself and the planet we live on.

Enquiry and human values

The process of educating the mind is generally aimed at conditioning the intellect

into pre-determined ways; however, for Krishnamurti, education implies a process of un-conditioning. It is freedom from given ways of thinking that allows the mind to observe without a parallel biased movement of interpretation. In this kind of education, understanding the ways of the self is more vital than the accumulation of knowledge.

The whole movement of enquiry into knowledge, into oneself, into the possibility of something beyond knowledge, brings about naturally a psychological revolution, and from this comes inevitably a totally different order in human relationship, which is society. The intelligent understanding of all this can bring about a profound change in the consciousness of mankind. (Krishnamurti, 1984)

Most of what we know as values are culturally defined ways of responding to life situations. Each social system has its own parameters for socially appropriate behaviour. So, depending on a multiplicity of factors, which include religious beliefs, customs, and the economic and political status of a society, the codes of conduct that are the guiding principles in one society may not be so in another. This is an anthropological truth. Several themes for enquiry emerge from this: are human beings doomed to live by a conceptual relativity where any value system is bound to clash with another unless it shares a common set of assumptions? Or are there values that are true regardless of time, place, culture or situation? Are there universal human values that will bring about an order that cannot be found through identifications such as nationalism, religion, sect and caste and political ideologies? Are there values that cut across the cruel lines of class division and racial discrimination? Is it at all possible for a mind born into the complex web of culture to ever be free of it?

In all the talks and dialogues he conducted over the span of more than half a century, Krishnamurti paid little heed to the details of cultural differences between societies. He examined directly the fundamental reality of the common human condition, the nature of man-made ways of thinking, and the universality of basic instincts as they manifest in forms like greed, fear, envy and the desire for security. Subservience to these movements is the cause of human bondage. He maintained that it was possible for man to be totally free of these bonds so long as he could hold them in awareness, without taking recourse to any means of relief. The moment the mind in distress seeks a way out, it moves away from the reality of its situation (the 'what is' in Krishnamurti's terminology) and gets caught in another pattern. Thus, the original problem gets superimposed with another idea and in effect remains un-addressed because 'Truth alone liberates, not your desire to be free. The very desire and effort to be free is a hindrance to liberation' (Krishnamurti, 2002, p. 108).

How does one discover the nature of this machinery that keeps generating patterns within which we live as subjects? The first step is to observe one's own mind and see how 'cluttered and burdened it is with belief' (Krishnamurti, 1999, p. 6). Krishnamurti points out the sheer absurdity of using systems of 'belief as a hypothesis' (Krishnamurti, 1999, p. 6). A mind that is enquiring must put aside faith, belief, tradition and the learned ways of man. 'When a man is enquiring, he does not start out with a hypothesis, he has a free mind He is not bound by any fear.

He starts out denying all that and then begins to seek' (Krishnamurti, 1999, p. 6). The very enquiry contains the answers, but they need to be looked for.

It is thus evident that the mind looking at facts as they are cannot possibly look clearly through the prism of fear. Fear in any form bends the lines of perception towards that which will bring security. These barriers to seeing are created by the mind, which seeks security within the confines of thought. It is not physical security that prevents the mind from enquiring beyond known frontiers; it is deep psychological fear that does not allow the movement of seeing to go beyond the known.

'Fear dictates conformity, fear dictates that I must imitate, that I must follow somebody in the hope that I shall find comfort' (Krishnamurti, 1999, p. 8). So, one sets authority up as a guiding light that will show the way out of uncertainty. Thus we barter away freedom for certainty, which promises security but never delivers.

Krishnamurti held that mankind could and must become free of these layers of conditioned responses and come upon the nature of the mind in its natural state. It is '... only a mind that is free from conflict, free from problems, free from sorrow that can find out. And you must find out because that is the only way out of this misery, this confusion that we have created in this world' (Krishnamurti, 1999, p. 7). Hence, meaningful education would be concerned with allowing for the flowering of this kind of intelligence, and not merely with building the intellect.

Academically, it is not very difficult to analyse relations within and between power structures in society. Sociological enquiry into the operating axis of power can reveal the underlying motives, the polarizations and struggles between unequal elements in individual or social schemes. All these and more are possible and essential as pedagogical techniques for the development of a clear mind, but for Krishnamurti, this kind of enquiry is still limited. Modern education stops short with developing the intellect alone. Enquiry must be carried further into the examination of the nature of thought itself. Thought carries memory and belief. It is the vector for the assumptions that further thinking is based on. Thought, in fact, is the attire of the self.

The thousands of years of human thought overflowing with a plethora of ideas explored to their logical limits and their ramifications—intellectual, emotional and, very concretely, physical—are apparent in our day-to-day living. Working from within these given paradigms can only lead to answers situated within these same paradigms. Is there a way of looking that operates from outside the circular confines of thought? If understanding the nature of thought is imperative to a clear seeing of the human situation, if such understanding is essential to coming upon a sense of the sacred, then learning about oneself is a necessary part of education.

Learning about oneself

Krishnamurti makes a distinction between learning about oneself and accumulating knowledge about oneself. Consistent with what has been said, learning about oneself is an awareness of our patterns, beliefs, hopes and fears, as revealed in

our daily lives and interactions. Awareness brings its own order without taking recourse to imposing control over it.

The beginning of the religious mind is self-knowledge—not the knowledge of the supreme self, that is sheer nonsense. How can a petty mind, a narrow mind, a nationalistic mind, a mind that is begotten through fear, through compulsion, through imitation, through authority—how can that petty, shallow mind try to find out what is the supreme self? To seek the supreme self is an escape; it is pure unadulterated romanticism. The fact is—you have to understand yourself first. (Krishnamurti, 1999, p. 9)

The task involves the art of looking, listening and observing choicelessly, neither denying nor accepting what is revealed through such observation. The mind must watch its own functioning to understand the ways of the constructed self. Can the educator learn and help the child learn to observe the myriad ways in which thought creates its own prison? Instead of pushing beliefs, whether religious or secular, as a priori premises for living life, can the educator place the multiple stimuli that storm the brain and senses, within an objective context? Can one learn to see clearly and without bias? In the classroom and at home, an atmosphere that invites the colourful variety in which life and man express themselves and still enables a holding of such questions, may inculcate an enquiring mind.

It is becoming more and more important in a world that is destructive and degenerative that there should be a place, an oasis, where one can learn a way of living that is whole, sane and intelligent. Education in the modern world has been concerned with the cultivation not of intelligence, but intellect, of memory and its skills. In this process little occurs beyond passing information from the teacher to the taught, the leader to the follower, bringing about a superficial and mechanical way of life. (Krishnamurti, 1984)

Relationship with nature

Relationship with nature is fundamental to the kind of education that Krishnamurti envisaged. Man's relation to nature is perhaps one of the few areas where there is a possibility of direct perception without the interfering noise of thought. Children growing up amongst scrub jungle and animals, climbing trees and eating raw fruit have the possibility of touching and perhaps retaining a sense of being one amongst a 'community of beings' (Gadgil & Guha, 1997, p. 18), an inherent identity within the natural world that is man's genetic inheritance.

With the Industrial Revolution, there has been an accelerating separation between man and nature. From being in a state of participation with nature, mankind now sees itself as manipulator of the natural world. The resulting alienation has brought about the near destruction of the planet. Simultaneously, it has consigned mankind to a state of psychological alienation, where humans are divorced from their real and simple roots. They have become creatures of thought, occupied with creating and solving abstract problems that work well only within the parameters of mental logic.

Therefore, Krishnamurti repeatedly stressed the absolute necessity of a relationship with nature as part of education, in order to provide the ground for coming upon “value”, which is an act rather than a concept. After all, to value something is to respect it, care for it and treat it with sensitivity. This cannot come about through the mere inculcation of frameworks and paradigms. Therefore, education is not just imbibing information from books or teachers, not just learning how to manage the examination system and achieve technical proficiency, it is also being vulnerable enough, ‘... to be able to listen to the birds, to see the sky, to see the beauty of a tree, and the shape of the hills and to feel with them, to be really, directly in touch with them’ (Krishnamurti, 1974, p. 14).

Nurturing the individual

Working with children demands awareness and attention on the part of the educator. It means seeing the child as s/he is, without measuring her/him against ideals dictated by one’s own ambitions or by society at large. To see the process of life as it is and people as they are without any distortion implies a denial of comparative modes based on measure and mean, on better and worse, on success and failure. In today’s fiercely competitive, achievement-oriented culture, this presents a formidable challenge. In terms of everyday life, this means being aware of one’s own conditioned responses in the process of dealing with children. Confronted with a child who is either conforming or reacting to conventional academic structures, a great deal of energy and understanding is needed to meet the situation adequately without judging the child through the social context that exists within the mind of the teacher. It means coming up with the response that addresses that particular child and helps her/him discover the movements necessary to actualize her/his own individual potential.

Individuality, Krishnamurti maintained, is not the same as personality, with its shifting identities. Any kind of identification born out of insecurity and comparison leads to separation. Through our present structures of competition and comparison, we strengthen identity and the alienation that inevitably accompanies it. Individuality, on the other hand, has to do with the inner grain of the person, her/his unique and specific dispositions. Individuality has its own movement of excellence and passion, which does not need competition and comparison to sustain it.

The role of the educator is to pay heed to the inner movements and feelings of the young—who, ‘if they are at all alive, are full of hope and discontent’ (Krishnamurti, 2003, p. 42)—and in awakening an intelligence that can see the myriad influences one is subject to. Each individual student needs to be helped to watch these movements within her/himself, to observe how personal impulses and ways of apprehending the world are deeply rooted in collective values as well as in one’s own habits and patterns. The educator may then guide that flame of discontent, not into reaction but into ‘self-knowledge and self-abnegation’ (Krishnamurti, 2003, p. 42). In this way, young people can be helped to break free from the ways of the self ‘... from the craving for self-fulfilment that brings endless

conflict and sorrow' (Krishnamurti, 2003, p. 29). Out of this may emerge the truly creative action of the individual.

There are dangers that inevitably arise in a process of deconstructing deeply rooted ways of being. Personalized and idealized interpretations of freedom emerge. The mind, freed from the grosser forms of social regimentation, reacts with a stubborn self-indulgence. Explorations into the pernicious nature of authority, combined with a refusal to use authority, and the withholding of reward and punishment which are generally used as a means of cultivating susceptibility to external control may leave participants in a psychological atmosphere where there seem to be no guidelines.

Like Ariadne's thread, which showed a way through the labyrinth of Minos, the only possible guiding factor is the mirror of relationship. Quite apart from the overt modes of interaction, it is in the subliminal layers of the psyche that engagement with students really takes place. Even an intellectual acceptance of the fact that the use of authority is damaging to the process of education leads to a questioning of one's own self-importance, and the possibility of being free of the burden of authoritarianism. Teachers no longer need to invest energy into projecting images about themselves. The result is an opportunity to develop an open and caring relationship with children who, through this means, learn the value of relationship without the need for dominance. This ground of relationship is where the teacher and the student are learning and moving together and understanding the process of conditioning. There need be no dichotomy between living and learning. There is not even a distinction between the teacher and the taught. In the field of life, teacher and students are both participants in an exploration into an arena that is common ground for them both.

In such an environment of love, there is little need for constructed ways of exercising the control commonly referred to as discipline.

Discipline is an easy way to control a child but it does not help him to understand the problems involved in living ... with the right kind of educator and a small number of students would any repression, politely called discipline, be required? If the classes are small and the teacher can give his full attention to each child, observing and helping him, then compulsion or domination in any form is obviously unnecessary. If, in such a group, a student persists in disorderliness or is unreasonably mischievous, the educator must enquire into the cause of his misbehaviour, which may be wrong diet, lack of rest, family wrangles, or some hidden fear. (Krishnamurti, 2003, p. 33)

If an educator is able to establish such an atmosphere in the classroom, mischief and natural exuberance can flow together with the flowering of an innate sense of responsibility. Freedom and responsibility are generally perceived as antithetical. In Krishnamurti's understanding, freedom means responsibility. 'Freedom does not mean the opportunity for self-gratification or the setting aside of consideration for others' (2003, p. 31).

The right kind of educator, aware of the mind's tendency to reaction, helps the student to alter present values, not out of reaction against them, but

through understanding the total process of life. Co-operation between man and man is not possible without the integrity which right education can help to awaken in the individual. (2003, p. 31)

Questioning value systems in contemporary India

Today, India stands at the threshold of a major economic leap. Links with global arteries of material nourishment are within reach. Affluence is no longer a far-off dream for a large section at the top of the ladder of wealth and achievement. The millions strung on the rungs below are scrambling to revise their technical skills in order to be part of this chain of wealth.

Yet, even as technical knowledge and skills outpace the best the world has to offer, stride for stride walks a spectre. Paradoxically, it is the spectre of our ancient heritage. Replete with the self-transcending wisdom of the ages, it also carries the most rigid and unblinking adherence to belief and tradition.

Deep cultural imprints, especially when overlaid with semi-tones of religious emotion and 'truths', can begin to masquerade as the real thing. Tradition and custom have a deep hold on the Indian psyche. Known practices rooted in belief systems may appear as pre-requisites for a sense of psychological security, but are neither necessary nor mandatory stepping stones for 'coming upon the sacred'. In fact, Krishnamurti has pointed out that the quest for security through these systems of thought is a barrier to clarity, and actually creates insecurity.

As symbols of the sacred, systems of religious belief lend themselves to a host of interpretations. They have been the receptacles of the human being's need for something bigger than her/himself. And in the face of any disturbance, they seem to stand as guarantors for the elusive truth of the universe. In India today, religious values are being interpreted in ways that can provide a counter to the insecurity that social and economic change has engendered. New and varied inputs from the world pose questions that threaten old customs and beliefs. This has led to a revival of deeply separative trends as people cling to known ways that have, for centuries, been concretized in religious forms.

Any system of values, whether rooted in a set of religious beliefs, a vision of Utopia or in the ideology of the marketplace, creates divisions. The result is an increasing hardening of identities that can never reflect upon the very process of identification. In such a scenario, what economic and technological superstructures are we setting up? Factionalism cannot end with material comfort. And the invention of faster and easier ways of doing things cannot bring about an order that embraces a true appreciation of life on this marvellous and wonderful earth, where life can be lived in true freedom and dignity.

In Indian society, the most threatening divisions are between one religious identity and another, as well as that between a society rooted in religious tradition and one rooted in secular, modern values. Both approaches are partial and fragmentary. Each position is content to oppose the other and reiterate its own beliefs without asking more fundamental questions about the nature of the

psyche, of relationship and whether there is something sacred that is not put together by thought.

Krishnamurti's approach to the nurturing of values offers a possibility of moving outside the dichotomies of belief—secular or religious. He initiated the process towards establishing values that are deeply rooted in the sacred, in the truly religious. In contrast to other religious thinkers and educators, Krishnamurti provides no prescriptions and no methodology. He did, however, direct exceptional energy and passion into creating educational institutions in India, England and America. The Krishnamurti schools attempt to create conditions that may foster a spirit of freedom, enabling enquiry into the nature of the self because '... it is essential that education should above all, help the individual to understand his own psychological processes'. It is only on this ground that a truly religious mind can be nurtured.

A religious mind is a mind that has no belief, that has no dogma, that has no fear, that has absolutely no authority of any kind. It is a light unto itself. Such a mind, being free, can go very far. Then you will find out for yourself that extraordinary stillness of the mind—it is not an idea but an actual fact. A mind that is completely still without any distraction, a still mind, but not the romantic mind, a mind that is not begotten through conflict or through contradiction or through misery—it is only such a mind that is completely quiet and therefore completely alive, totally sensitive; it is only such a mind that can receive that which is immeasurable. (Krishnamurti, 1999, p. 18)

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Education for life: The Mirambika experience

Anjum Sibia

Adopting an ethnographic approach, this chapter examines the rich and dynamic life of teaching-learning in Mirambika—a school based on the Free Progress Education as envisioned by Sri Aurobindo and The Mother. The school ideology influences the social environment, the behaviour of its inhabitants, and provides sources and resources of support, guidance and reinforcement. The influence of the ideology of Mirambika is evident in its physical environment and organization of pedagogic processes. The interactions between teachers and children encompass a range of meanings and messages, which are largely governed by this ideology. A selective account of classroom realities in Mirambika is presented as an attempt to build up the school culture through ideas, thoughts, feelings and artefacts.

The school Mirambika attempts to practice the educational views of Sri Aurobindo and The Mother, and seeks alternatives in curriculum, content, as well as in transaction. This chapter attempts to explicate the pedagogic processes taking place in the classroom with a view to examining the relationship between the school philosophy, activities and student outcomes.

Education in India: A brief overview

Concern for education in India can be traced back to the *Vedic* age, from the age of the *Upaniṣads*, the *Gītā*, the Buddhist and Jain scriptures, *Smṛtis* etc., through the medieval and British periods to the post-colonial systems of traditional education. Education was accorded the highest priority right from the pre-historic days. However, the aims of teaching-learning have shifted in focus during different periods. As described by Altekar (1965), during the Vedic period the focus was on imparting sacred literature and family occupation to the children. Memorization was the dominant pedagogical method, along with interpretation and creativity. These, however, became less important during the *Upaniṣadic* period, where the emphasis was on accuracy, correct accent and intonation. In the *Dharmaśāstric* period, a systematic teaching of reading, writing and arithmetic took place. The focus was also on memorizing the *Vedas*. The *Paurāṇika* period had four types of teachers:

the *ācārya*, the *guru*, the *śikṣaka* and the *upādhyāya*. The *ācārya* was the highest level that a teacher could attain. During the Buddhist period, the *upādhyāya* was considered the most revered teacher, and instructed students in proper conduct, morality and notions of *vinaya* (humility) and *dharma* (duty). The nature of pedagogy during the early period was 'oral, repetitive and exemplary' (Altekar, 1965). Prior to colonization, the teacher or *guru* provided practical instruction to students in local village schools, or *pāṭhaśālās*. Reading, writing, arithmetic and Sanskrit were the main subjects. Teachers played an authoritative role and students related to the teachers with reverence (Dharmapal, 1983).

During the colonial period, the British introduced a complete English system of education in India. Rote learning was encouraged and British knowledge or curriculum (as embodied in the textbook) played a prominent role (Kumar, 1991, p. 14). In *Political Agenda of Education*, Kumar (1991) points out that the British curriculum was not related to the experiences of the Indian child, and represented a discontinuity. As a result of this discontinuity, Indian students were forced to memorize the information. As Clarke (2001) in her work on *Teaching and Learning: The Culture of Pedagogy* states, 'it is difficult to conceive that the British could have transformed this pervasive practice of rote entrenched among us for generations even with curriculum that may not have represented discontinuity with our own culture and traditions' (p. 41). Even though the British attempted to transform pedagogy through a 'more progressive' method of learning (through Froebel's method of instruction), they were not successful.

The assumption that the system of education in its entirety is still completely Western-oriented has been the basis for several reform initiatives for education in India. Innovations in pedagogy after independence were attempts at indigenizing education. It was held that the education system could be transformed and enriched through the inclusion of the core elements of being Indian. One of the early initiatives in the process of indigenization of education was Gandhiji's *Basic Education (Bunyadi Talim)* in the 1930s. He believed this was possible through craft learning, not as a subject of instruction, but by imparting the whole process of education through some handicraft specific to the local context. Gandhiji believed that education in India should represent the Indian ethos, and required the teachers to be virtuous. The post-independence period was characterized by a series of reforms 'to give an indigenous identity so as to reflect the Indian ethos and concern for society' (National Curriculum for Elementary and Secondary Education—A Framework, 1988, p. 2).

The educational system of modern India had its beginnings in the nineteenth century. Lord Macaulay could be said to have laid the foundation of the modern Indian education system through his well-known *Minute on Education* in February 1835. It would not be wrong to say that in Indian education, one effectively sees a continuation of an imperial culture; unfortunately, Macaulay's ideas still dominate education in India. Elements of colonialism are evident in the position of authority teachers hold in the class, control over students' responses, and the use of teacher-centred methods, which lead to a passive acquisition of knowledge.

'Teachers, regulated by the primacy of the syllabus, help their students understand and know this syllabus in its entirety through repetition and memorization. Higher order thinking typified by analysis and the reasoning is largely upheld in the Indian educational system' (Clarke, 2001, pp. 166–167). It is suggested that the culturally defined patterns of hierarchical interaction influence the teacher's pivotal authoritative role within the classroom in India. Kumar's study (1991) considers the dominance of the teacher in the classroom a natural outcome of the respect and authority given to age and experience within the religious, social and cultural ethos of the country. From a developmental standpoint, Kakar (1984) described the authority conferred on the adult by children in Indian society. Adults accede to all the demands of the child generally till the child is about five years old. After that the roles reverse: the child is required to respect and obey the adult. It is suggested that teachers are aware of and constrained by these tacit understandings of authoritative adult roles within society, and tend to fashion their pedagogy and classroom organization accordingly. Besides the teacher, textbooks have played a major role in the way teaching-learning is organized in classrooms. The Yash Pal Committee report of the mid-1990s identified the information overload in textbooks used in schools across the country as the major problem in the Indian educational system.

The educational traditions of colonial times still permeate practices in post-colonial India. This is so despite the fact that a number of education commissions and policies, such as the University Education Commission led by Dr S. Radhakrishnan (1946–1948), the Secondary Education Commission headed by Dr A. L. Mudaliar (1952–1953), the Education Commission headed by Dr D. S. Kothari (1964–1966), and the National Policy on Education 1968 and 1986 were concerned about the state of education. It has been observed that the Westernization of the education system has been far greater since independence than it was under British rule. Even after more than 60 years of independence, we have not been able to liberate ourselves from the colonial mind-set.

In present times, teaching-learning in schools is subject-specific, time-bound, focused on structured forms of learning, characterized by repetitive rote memorization, and examination-dominated. Creating a fear of failure, schools have become merely centres for selection, monopolized by tests and examinations. As Shotton (1998, p. 32) observed, 'what one effectively has in Indian education is a continuation of an imperial culture, something that is essentially elitist and autocratic'. Variations through innovations within traditional mainstream schooling do exist, but are nominal, marginal and peripheral. These alternatives challenge the existing culture of rote learning and cramming, arising from prescriptive teaching, teacher dominance in classroom transactions, learning focused on securing marks, and evaluations that create feelings of inferiority and insecurity. In view of the existing realities, there is a need to address the question: what is the aim and function of education? The educational ideas of Indian thinkers provide a base upon which to build a perspective for a new system of education.

Educational thought: Some Indian views

The philosophical thinking of eminent personalities like Sri Aurobindo, Rabindranath Tagore, J. Krishnamurti, Swami Vivekananda, Mahatma Gandhi, Zakir Hussain, and others has influenced the system of education in India. Gandhi's *Basic Education Scheme (Bunyadi Talim)* formed the basis of various education committees that were created during the independence period. Education for Gandhiji 'is one in which the individual develops his character, trains his faculties, and learns to control his passions in the service of the community' (Kabir, 1961, p. 202). Tagore pleaded for an education which would lead to an 'all-sided and well-integrated development of the human personality'. He also felt that in order to be truly creative, education should be in touch with the lives of people in their entirety—economic, intellectual, aesthetic, social and spiritual. Sri Aurobindo too placed emphasis on the all-round development of the personality, which included education of the senses, body and mind, as well as moral and spiritual education. Swami Vivekananda's educational thought laid emphasis on the realization of the perfection already present in man. He placed the greatest stress on education as the gradual unfolding of the intrinsic quality of the individual, and was of the view that no knowledge comes from outside. For Iqbal, the essential purpose of education was to develop man's individuality. He saw education as a process that ensures the possibility of eternal progress. Indian philosophers, according to Kabir (1961), 'regard education essentially as process of drawing out what is implicit in the individual and to develop his latent potentialities till they become actualities'. Indian thought, as expressed in the educational philosophies of Indian thinkers, lays stress on a comprehensive education aimed at the development of the total personality of the individual, in harmony with society and nature.

Amongst the various thinkers and writers on education who contributed to the philosophy of education in India, Sri Aurobindo's perspective is significant in the light of a comprehensive education and an all-round development of the learner. It calls for a shift in the educational paradigm, one where curriculum is individualized, linkages with life experiences established, a love for learning inculcated, and the personal growth of the learner aimed at. It seeks a new approach to schooling: it considers alternatives to curriculum planning, teaching approaches, evaluation procedures, the role of the teacher and the learner in the learning process, and aims to bridge the gap between home and school.

Sri Aurobindo's ideas on education

The educational views of Sri Aurobindo are closely linked to his futuristic vision of human destiny. He maintains that the kind of education we need in our country is 'proper to the Indian soul and need and temperament and culture that we are in quest of, not indeed something faithful merely to the past, but to the developing soul of India, to her future need, to the greatness of her coming self-creation, to her eternal spirit' (1956, p. 7). Sri Aurobindo's concept of 'education' is not only

about acquiring information. 'But the acquiring of various kinds of information', he points out (1956, pp. 9–10),

is only one and not the chief of the means and necessities of education: its central aim is the building of the powers of the human mind and spirit, it is the formation or, as I would prefer to view it, the evoking of knowledge and will and of the power to use knowledge, character, culture—that at least if no more. And this distinction makes an enormous difference.

Sri Aurobindo's chief concern is not merely with the acquisition of information placed at our disposal by the science of the West 'in an undigested whole or in carefully packed morsels', but

the major question is not merely what science we learn, but what we shall do with our science and how too, acquiring the scientific mind and recovering the habit of scientific discovery ... we shall relate it to other powers of the human mind and scientific knowledge to other knowledge more intimate to other and not less light-giving and power-giving parts of our intelligence and nature (1956, p. 10).

The aim and principle of a true national education, according to Sri Aurobindo (1956, pp. 10–11), is 'not, certainly, to ignore modern truth and knowledge, but to take our foundation on our own being, our own mind, our own spirit'. A truly national system of education according to him will be 'as comprehensive as the European and more thorough, without the evils of strain and cramming'. This can only be done 'by studying the instruments of knowledge and finding a system of teaching which shall be natural, easy and effective' (1956, p. 19).

Sri Aurobindo (1956, pp. 20–21) elaborates certain sound principles of good teaching, which have to be kept in mind when actually engaged in the process of learning. According to Sri Aurobindo, the first principle of true teaching is 'that nothing can be taught'. He explains that knowledge is already dormant within the child and for this reason, 'The teacher is not an instructor or task-master, he is a helper and a guide.' The role of the teacher

is to suggest and not to impose. He does not actually train the pupil's mind, he only shows him how to perfect the instruments of knowledge and helps him and encourages him in the process. He does not impart knowledge to him; he shows him how to acquire knowledge for himself. He does not call forth the knowledge that is within; he only shows him where it lies and how it can be habituated to rise to the surface.

The second principle of true teaching is that 'the mind has to be consulted in its own growth. The idea of hammering the child into the shape desired by the parent or the teacher is a barbarous and ignorant superstition.' Sri Aurobindo has more faith in the *svabhāva* of the educand, that is, 'it is he himself who must be induced to expand in accordance with his own nature'. He states:

To force the nature to abandon its own *dharma* is to do it permanent harm, mutilate its growth and deface its perfection. It is a selfish tyranny over a

human soul and a wound to the nation which loses the benefit of the best that a man could have given it and is forced to accept instead something imperfect and artificial, second rate, perfunctory and common.

For Sri Aurobindo, the chief aim of education should be to help each and every soul to draw out its best. He firmly believes that everyone has her/his own individuality and potential, with a chance of perfection and strength, however imperfect. As he succinctly observed:

Every one has in him something divine, something his own, a chance of perfection and strength in however small a sphere which God offers him to take or refuse. The task is to find it, develop it and use it. The chief aim of education should be to help the growing soul to draw out that in itself which is best and make it perfect for a noble use.

The third principle of education is 'to work from the near to the far, from that which is to that which shall be'. As Sri Aurobindo states,

The basis of a man's nature is almost always, in addition to his soul's past, his heredity, his surroundings, his nationality, his country, the soil from which he draws sustenance, the air which he breathes, the sights, sounds, habits to which he is accustomed. They mould him not the less powerfully because insensibly, and from that then we must begin.

Sri Aurobindo observed that if genuine development is to take place,

We must not take up the nature by the roots from the earth in which it must grow or surround the mind with images and ideas of a life which is alien to that in which it must physically move. If anything has to be brought in from outside, it must be offered, not forced on the mind. A free and natural growth is the condition of genuine development.

Sri Aurobindo's philosophy of education is based on the principle of evoking the potential of the individual in all its entirety, which should be developed according to human nature. Free Progress Education is based on the assumption that a human being is good in himself, and that positive freedom is a pre-requisite to helping children by allowing them space to experiment and providing opportunities for growth. As The Mother says, 'A free and natural growth is the condition of genuine development'. Free progress is 'a progress guided by the soul and not subjected to habits, conventions or pre-conceived ideas' (The Mother, 1956). According to The Mother (1956), education, in order to be complete, must contain five principal aspects relating to the five principal activities of the human being: physical, vital or affect-related, mental, psychic and spiritual.

In contrast to the educational ideas of Sri Aurobindo and The Mother, the present-day education system in India is purely an instruction-of-information enterprise, supported by a subject and time-bound curriculum that neither relates to the needs or abilities of the learner nor takes into consideration the way children learn successfully. Instead of being child-oriented, it is subject-oriented. The schools focus on competition with others, on mastery of the subject matter for

getting better marks or grades than on learning in cooperation with and from one another for personal growth and the welfare of others. This is not an exclusively Indian phenomenon; rather, education all over the world is largely reductionist, materialist, ego-enforcing, and devoid of the joys of the spirit (Cornelissen, 2003). It is in this context that there emerges a need to examine initiatives rooted in the Indian tradition; seek alternatives in curriculum, teaching, learning and measuring success; involve children in the process of learning; and focus on learning from one another and not from an authoritative pedagogue.

Against this backdrop, this chapter seeks to examine the school Mirambika, which is based on the ideals of Free Progress Education as envisioned by Sri Aurobindo and The Mother, specifically with regard to the effect of school philosophy on school organization, teaching-learning processes and student outcomes (Sibia, 2006).

The present research

Located in New Delhi, Mirambika came into being in 1981. The school, with 132 of its students aged between 3 and 12 years and 48 teachers,¹ was studied using a range of ethnographic methods, the aim being to study various school aspects such as organization, culture and teaching-learning processes. It involved examining the roles and responsibilities of school functionaries and their role perception, the study of routine and formal activities (meditation, sports, evaluations etc.), the way teaching-learning is organized, the involvement of children in the process of learning, and the role of the teacher. Our understanding of the school was built through participant observation, interviews, informal talks and questionnaires, which were used for collection, documentation and analysis over a period of eight months. A thematic analysis of the data revealed the salient teaching-learning features, and interpretations of the classroom were drawn through inductive analysis. Validity of the interpretations was sought in 'triangulation'. The interpretive analysis provided a view of curriculum organization, teaching styles, disciplining techniques, grouping and seating patterns—a kaleidoscopic vision of classroom realities in Mirambika.

It is important to state that the process of entry to the school is to be viewed as an integral part of the ethnographic research undertaken. A brief narrative of our entry into Mirambika offers an important backdrop for understanding the research findings and the possible gaps that remain.

Gaining entry

On my first visit to Mirambika, I talked to the Principal about the nature of the research work—observing the teachers and children in and outside the classroom, as well as the other activities taking place from the start to the end of the school day. The major concern expressed was that the study, especially the presence of the observer in the class, might interfere with the functioning of the school. I was briefly

introduced to one of the school coordinators (core group of teachers) to work out my schedule. The teachers gave no straight answers to my questions; instead, they suggested that we get a feel of Mirambika for a couple of days by sitting in the classes, observing, watching the happenings during meditation, games etc. As they said, 'one does not enter anyone's house till one gets to know the occupants', and Mirambika to them was their home. Informal talks with the coordinators helped us to develop a working schedule. We had our first formal contact with the Diyas (teachers) during one of their weekly Saturday meetings, in which I talked about the proposed research work, its objectives, and briefly about what the research team intended to do. No questions were asked by the teachers, who seemed to know about the research. My early interactions with the teachers were limited to greetings while sitting in the class. I felt my presence probably held an 'evaluative stance', which was erased with time through a deliberate, conscious effort. Our initial contact with the children occurred while observing their daily activities in and outside the class. Although we were silent observers and did not initiate talk, informal talk did develop when the children enquired whether we were the new teachers. We tried to answer their queries honestly. However, the children viewed us as new teachers, and addressed us as Diyas. Total acceptance on the part of the children was the key factor in making intensive observations. Informal contact was established with parents during the initial days in the school. Some of them knew about our research work and were interested in our perceptions of the school activities. Formal contact with the parents was established when interviews were held with them. They allowed us enough time in which to answer our queries and were quite open with their opinions. As the research progressed, the research team began to be viewed as a part of the school, especially by the children, which helped us in maintaining a credible research role.

Mirambika: The physical ecology

Nestled among trees in the premises of the Sri Aurobindo Ashram in South Delhi is Mirambika. The school came into being in 1981. Mirambika is approached through the 'Sunlit Path', which has a statue of Sri Aurobindo, and signifies the road taking Sri Aurobindo's vision to the outside world. Wide open green spaces lined with eucalyptus trees surround the school, which has swings, slides, a *neem* grove—which at various junctures provide the space for learning activities for different groups. Mirambika has a number of resources, physical and material, which are characterized by the principles of 'openness' (Malehorn, 1978), that is, self-directed learning, enhancing uniqueness, encouraging exploration, flexibility in planning, sensitivity and affective awareness. Some of these are provided by the architectural layout of Mirambika, for instance, the wide roof terrace, which is used for various activities during the cooler months of the year. Similarly, the '*neem* grove' and the open spaces surrounding the school are used for multiple purposes like group walks, games, exhibitions etc. Some common spaces of use located in the school include the teacher training wing, the library, the science laboratory,

meditation hall, the art room, stationery room, gymnasium, computer room, talk room, the living museum and the dining hall. The physical facilities may therefore be considered resources in the school, keeping in mind their functions, activities organized, equipment, and the material they provide for school processes.

The architectural and physical organization in Mirambika has a distinct structure, and is an attempt to foster an environment that can keep the interests of all the children alive. The architectural space of the school, that is, its building, surroundings, equipment, materials, services and other resources set certain restrictions, but at the same time offer a certain degree of freedom to its inhabitants. The way each group uses the school's environment as a pedagogic resource is of paramount importance.

The 30 or more models, charts, experiments, that were made as part of the 'Environment' project were displayed in the 'Living Museum' for a week and the children talked about their display, conducted small experiments, operated their models for other children, teachers and parents who visited (Field Note).

The importance of physical organization in Mirambika is highlighted in the context of the cultural meaning it acquires. The furniture, books, trees, all assume culturally defined meanings, which determine their limits and uses. All these set a range of opportunity, mobility, independence, flexibility and responsibility. The child's experiences in school are thus moulded by her/his surroundings, which may have a personal or special meaning for her/him. The personal meaning the school environment has for the children is expressed in words like *wonderful, peaceful, calm and quiet, different, superb, beautiful, best in the world*. Some children have provided reasons for liking their school environment and related it to trees, the surroundings, building, open fields, cool breeze etc. In the children's own words:

I like the building of Mirambika because it is very open and there are so many places to hide when you play hide and seek (Humility Group, 9 years).

I like the building of Mirambika in winters because the chilly air and fog come in the group (Humility Group, 9 years).

I like the playground and the trees, flowers, grass, plants, leaves, fresh air ... ducks and the pond (Progress Group, 8 years).

A day at Mirambika

It is Monday morning, 8.30 A.M. The children, dressed in their daily wear and not in school uniforms, are seen approaching the school building through the Sunlit Path. Some enter; others begin informal games in the grounds. No bell rings. Children move towards the dining hall for a collective breakfast. They have informal exchanges over sandwiches and fruit. Soon they are ready for studies and disappear into their 'groups' (classrooms) ever so quietly. Children and Diyas (as the teachers are called in Mirambika) clean their workplaces, dusting, sweeping, mopping—getting ready for the day. The term 'Diya' has been coined from the words '*didi*' (elder sister) and '*bhaiya*' (elder brother). As explained by a teacher, 'it

symbolizes beckoning the light, the one who kindles the light in children'. Music for 'meditation' (concentration) marks the start of the school day, and a tranquil silence prevails. Students and teachers are seen sitting, some standing with eyes closed, a few looking out of the large windows, deep in thought. Children are told to think of what they left at home and what they will do in school. As a Diya said, 'these thoughts help them make a smooth transition from home to school and help them to set the pace for the day's work'. This activity is seen as an attempt 'to help children look inwards, which in turn helps them to evaluate and control one's feelings like anger, jealousy etc.', as expressed by the teachers. As a child said, 'I feel peaceful after meditation.' Meditation is clearly governed by an ideology that aims at self-reflection, and is in accordance with Sri Aurobindo and the Mother's views on education, that is, that it should be a path towards self-knowledge, self-mastery and inner realization. The purpose of 'meditation' as stated by the school coordinators is to provide 'vital education', that is, control over emotions, impulses and desires, which also helps to link 'psychic' and 'spiritual' education. The school, however, feels that the latter (spiritual education) is a life-long process; yet, by 'creating awareness of it in the child, a small beginning is made'. The mornings are devoted to group work where pedagogic transaction takes place through 'projects', wherein different subject areas are integrated to achieve the project goals. Children work individually, in small groups, or take field trips. The work done in the mornings is evaluated either through self-evaluation sheets prepared by their Diya, or by discussions in a group. Lunch at 12.00 noon is an informal affair where children and teachers sit together on *durries* spread on the floor. Children from each group serve the food voluntarily. After eating, each person cleans his/her own '*thāli*' (big metal plates) and places it in specified stacks. This activity acquires particular significance because it is an attempt by Mirambika 'to develop a sense of responsibility, duty, self-help, dignity of work, self-restraint and co-operation', as expressed by the Diyas. After lunch, from 1.00 to 3.00 PM, there is 'formal training' and 'clubs' for the older groups. During this time mathematics and languages (English and Hindi) are taken by subject specialists, the majority of whom are volunteers (part-time teachers). Twice a week children take part in 'club' activities in areas like cooking, jewellery making, calligraphy, arts and crafts, pottery etc. The child is free to choose and participate in an activity of his/her interest. The day's work closes at 3.00 PM with a 'home session', marked by the playing of music for concentration. The Diyas said, 'it is meant to prepare the children to get connected to their homes, and reflect on what they did during the day'. This is followed by light snacks and milk or juice, after which the children leave for their homes.

Diyas—Teachers in school

The Diyas at Mirambika comprise of full-time teachers (those residing in the Ashram), volunteers (part-time teachers) and trainee teachers doing their B. Ed. (at the time of the research project, they were affiliated to Indore University).

They are not salaried staff and are paid a token stipend, which varies for full-time and trainee teachers. The volunteers are given a conveyance allowance. The teachers are chosen on the basis of their interest in working with children, affection and motivation to do their job. When asked what their aim in life is, the teachers replied, 'I want to be an ideal teacher', 'be a perfect instrument of the divine', 'work for The Mother and Sri Aurobindo', 'to make my life worthy to live', 'teaching is my *sāadhanā* (devotion)', and 'to do *sevā* (service)'. Commitment to the school ideology is a common factor among the teachers at Mirambika. It provides a strong basis for carrying out their responsibilities within the stated boundaries of an ideal teacher. They view themselves as 'reflective' learners, and their role is to help the children discover their potential through guiding them, and helping them to know their interests.

Organising the school processes

Watching the teachers and children at Mirambika, we became convinced that the ideology of the school provides a framework for structuring and organizing its work. The manner in which the classes, the entire day, the teaching-learning is organized, the way decisions are taken, are all influenced by the ideology on which Mirambika is based. As Brunsson (1985, p. 16) states, 'Ideology is important in that it provides the set of ideas that decision makers take with them to guide decision making and to interpret their context.'

Mirambika does not compartmentalize itself into strictly graded or numbered classes; students are grouped together keeping in view their developmental needs. When asked how groups are formed and named, a teacher said,

Children are grouped according to their age, but each group has an overlap of ages. The five groups for younger children are given names related to colours, namely Red group (3+ years), Blue group (4+ years), Green (5+ years), Yellow (6+ years) and Orange group (7+ years). Colours are chosen because at this age, children can easily relate to them. From seven years onwards the children themselves, keeping in view the qualities and virtues they want to develop in themselves, name the groups. The name decides the focus of the group for that specific year (for example, progress, receptivity, humility etc.) and the children are encouraged and guided to achieve their group goal. This gives children a focus to their being in that specific group, and at the same time is a constant reminder of what they need to develop, which helps them assume responsibility for their actions.

The day-to-day functioning of Mirambika reveals that the working relationship between members is located in an informal work organization. We observed that there are no records or written memos maintained or sent. All communication is informal, and verbally conveyed to the teachers. The functionaries view their roles in line with their commitment to the school ideology, which enhances identification with the school goals. Hence, they carry out their responsibilities in a collective and collaborative manner. We observed that

there are no peons to do office work which is normally shared amongst the members; no extra hands are employed to help the children with their personal needs, which the group teachers tend to; no office bearers are appointed to look after the principal's paper work—he himself works on the computer along with some others (Field Note).

Hierarchy in work is not evident, and the school comprises of workers of equal status.

Symbols marking special status and embodying authority are conspicuous by their absence in Mirambika. The principal is not regarded as the supreme authority on school related matters. When asked who takes the decisions, the teachers replied, 'We all sit and talk and decide what has to be done'. Teachers and children often seek the principal's guidance and support, and he makes himself available to the children whenever required. His office is a small space with little furniture, often used by younger children as a 'hiding' place during play. This may be taken as evidence of his relationship with the children, irrespective of the role performed by him in the school. The perceptions of the children regarding their principal are: 'is a pal', 'he is great', 'knows everything', 'is a friend', 'like talking to him'. Clearly, the principal is not viewed as a 'supreme authority', deserving deference. As expressed by a teacher: 'he is one of us, we don't see him differently. He discusses everything with us and if we do not want to do a particular activity he does not force us. In Mirambika we are free to decide with our children. But he has a vision which I like hearing from him.' The principal's influence on members of the school, that is, teachers and children, may be attributed to his knowledge, personal skill, charisma and power of persuasion.

The unpredictable nature of teaching-learning at Mirambika makes centralized monitoring difficult. Since there is intra- as well as inter-group variations in the tasks, activities and organization of work, Mirambika finds alternative ways to monitor performance and inspire the members with a sense of purpose and commitment. In line with Sri Aurobindo's philosophy, evaluations in Mirambika are for self-improvement and personal development and not for comparison. Neither are they related to grading, ranking, certification or upward mobility of classes. On being asked how children are evaluated, the teachers said, 'We do not assess the child to show his weaknesses, but to show him how much he has learnt. Sometimes the evaluations are done by children in groups or individually and at times jointly by teachers and children. The idea is to let the child know how much he has progressed.' Joint collaborative efforts during evaluations are influenced by the school philosophy, which stresses the undesirability of comparisons and competition among students in any of the school processes, including evaluation.

As alternatives to authority in school, attempts are made to make teachers and children responsible for their actions by letting the responsibility of action lie with the individual member. Activities like letting the children take the responsibility of serving food, issuing oneself sports equipment and returning it after play, providing medical aid to younger children with minor injuries, issuing books on their own from the library and solving minor fights in their respective groups are

some efforts Mirambika makes to inculcate responsibility, cooperation and self-discipline. Therefore, the participants at Mirambika may be seen as autonomously functioning individuals. Accordingly, Mirambika functions within flexible work groups, which have open patterns of communication and coordination amongst themselves through mutual adjustment.

Classrooms: The context of learning

The classroom is where pedagogic interactions take place and apart from the transaction of content, it is the physical organization that affects interactions. The classrooms in Mirambika have a distinct physical structure and a unique organization, which fosters 'openness' in learning and forms the classroom climate.

The physical organization of the classroom bestows a structure on the activities carried out. It is therefore significant to know that the classrooms or workspaces of children in Mirambika are designed keeping in mind the needs of different groups. The three younger groups (classes) have large areas of work, low tables and *durries* for sitting. The younger children's classrooms have an annexe which, their teacher explained,

is used by children for sleeping or for those children requiring special attention or for attending to a crying child away from the curious eyes of the peers. The round sunken area in the corner of the room is used for activities like singing, story telling, and playing with children. Making children sit in this area helps us to be close to them, to keep them in one place without actually saying anything to them.

Diyas were seen sitting in the sunken area narrating stories and reciting poems, the children often sitting on their Diyas' laps or climbing on their backs. The areas of work for older groups have tables and chairs arranged in a circular manner to facilitate interaction during group discussion. Since the children do not carry books home, each one has an individual cupboard (for keeping books, copies, pens, pencils etc.). Common cupboards are used by the Diyas (teachers) for keeping dictionaries, other reference materials (maps, globe), books, stationery, colours, chalk, duster etc. All the groups have spaces for photographs of Sri Aurobindo and The Mother. Low walls separate the work areas of different groups. This gives an impression of one large group space with different groups working in different areas. Large classroom windows are a notable feature of the school, as they create an impression of unobstructed space and at the same time gives the building the benefit of natural light and breeze. The following description provides a view of how teachers and children function within such arrangements:

Location '*Neem Grove*': Receptivity group (10 years) children and Diyas carry low tables and small mats to the open grounds, which they arrange in two semi-circles. Each group has 4-5 children and one Diya. Movable display boards mark the boundaries of work areas, on which charts and write-ups are displayed. The two groups are working on the project '*Egypt*', with one group interested in drawing the map and the other working on making a pyramid,

a few sticking pictures on chart paper while others are seen participating in a quiz related to the theme. (Field Note)

In Mirambika classrooms, the traditional pattern of tables and chairs is missing and the physical space is casually organized into interest areas, with children sitting around tables, working in small groups, lying on the rug, reading or drawing alone, wandering around the room aimlessly, or approaching the teacher for attention and help. The activity (curriculum) is not centred round the teacher, but dispersed throughout the room around each child. It can be concluded that the distinctive character of the physical space in Mirambika gains importance in light of the opportunities and experiences it provides.

Teaching and learning through projects

The ideological setting influences pedagogic processes and differentiates Mirambika from other schools in Delhi, thus lending it a special character. The project-oriented teaching in Mirambika has its origin and base in the school ideology, which stresses on education according to the child's needs and capacities and aims to provide an environment conducive to such type of learning. It is based on the school's philosophy that learning at primary levels should not be subject-specific but instead an integrated, multi-disciplinary approach that should be followed within an evolutionary curriculum, which develops according to the needs of the children. Kerry and Eggleston (1996) state: 'The terms topic, project, theme, integrated work are interchangeable labels which describe the approach to teaching-learning and includes all those areas of the curriculum which are explored in a thematic way. Project work exhibits a particular attitude towards the nature of knowledge or epistemology.' Gunning et al. (1981, pp. 83-84) summed up the ethos of the philosophy underlying project work:

One of the most prolific sources of such information lies within the child's own day-to-day experience. Everyday the child is involved in a vast range of experiences at first hand. These contacts and experiences can be used very effectively by the teacher to provide the child with developing insight into a great range of ideas since they provide very 'concrete' pegs on which to hang important concepts.

In accordance with Sri Aurobindo's philosophy, the projects in Mirambika form the base of Free Progress Education, which is defined by The Mother as 'Education guided by the soul and not by preconceived ideas'. The founder-principal of Mirambika has described projects as 'little ships on which our children explore themselves and the beautiful world around them'. Teachers expressed that 'academics in the conventional way are not the focus, Mirambika mainly aims at an all-round development of personality, that is, the vital, mental, physical, psychic, and spiritual, and projects are the best way to achieve our goals'. The following description provides a view on how the curriculum is transacted through projects at Mirambika.

Project 'Environment' was taken up by the whole school as the school functionaries felt that the topic was the need of the hour, and that children needed to get acquainted with issues related to the environment. During the planning stage, the Aims, Resources, Activities and Evaluation to be undertaken were written on the 'Planning Sheet'. The goals varied according to the learning needs of the respective groups. Keeping in view the groups' goals, activities were listed by the Diyas after discussions with the children and among themselves. The children were divided into four levels, keeping in view their age, knowledge, and the focus on the content to be covered at a particular level. At each level different subject corners, including arts, were set up to focus on activities related to the specific subject content. For example, in an Alternative Models corner basic concepts to understand the global implications of pollution were discussed. Children traced man's dependence on his environment in the past, the ozone layer, the Narmada Valley Project etc. Children planned an ideal city in terms of solar energy. Issues like what is real development were discussed, and teachers guided children to envisage the future they desired for themselves. During the first week children experimented in different corners to choose an area of their interest. The culminating activity of project work took the form of fairs (organized by younger groups), and exhibitions, quizzes and experiments carried out by the older groups for the younger groups. The teachers made each child's profile covering all areas of work undertaken, and no marks or grades were given—progress was measured against the child's own record and not with others in the group. The older children carried out self-evaluations to provide themselves feedback on their work. (Field Note)

In Mirambika, project work implies an approach to teaching-learning that deals with theme-related topics and cuts across all subjects, that is, science, social science, mathematics, languages, arts etc. The Diyas guide children, individually or in groups, towards the process of inquiry in order to develop certain skills and mental faculties. The focus is on the construction of learning experiences based on children's interests. The choice to work in an area or activity is made by the children, and not just by the teachers. The teacher does not control the time spent on an activity; that depends on the activity undertaken, such as building a pyramid, making a model of solar energy or measuring the length of shadows, or helping to water the plants and clear the leaves. While working on projects, subject boundaries do not exist, and children are encouraged to view the relationship of one activity across different subjects. This is a combination of a 'child-centred' and 'teacher-facilitated' curriculum.

Flexibility in work

At Mirambika, the children and teachers may be seen as united by their shared experiences in a project or activity in their groups. As Thapan (1991, p. 48) states, 'the ideology creates an ethos in which living together necessitates cooperation between participants'. An observation was made during our stay at Mirambika

regarding the way teachers and children collectively make collaborative efforts and mutual adjustments while undertaking activities during project work.

Older children are required to go in small groups to the younger groups and get the survey proforma filled. The older children have developed this survey proforma. It has drawings showing the different seasons and the younger children are required to write what they would like to do in a particular season. Children visit the younger classes and one child of the older group tells the teacher the purpose of their visit, and on being granted permission to proceed, s/he explains the purpose and activity to the younger children. The younger children have queries like, 'Do we have to write only?' Or 'Can we draw also?' 'Can I write one word?' 'I want to use coloured pencil' Answers are provided to each query. The children in the older group were later seen helping the younger (Orange) children with their spellings, at times giving examples, clarifying doubts The older group teachers stand aside and watch quietly. The younger group teachers take this interruption calmly, helping the children when required. They seem least disturbed by the intrusion and resume work after the children's excitement has subsided. (Field Note)

Project work is a way of planning and organizing teaching material with spontaneity as an essential feature influencing the content of the lesson, which then begins to evolve on its own, as one cannot decide whether the topic will 'take off' from the very point it ended the previous day (Plowden Report, 1967). The curriculum therefore evolves according to the needs of the group. While organizing project work, the Diyas have to deal with open-ended activities, spontaneity, flexibility in organizing work, and adopt an informal style of teaching. It is difficult to pinpoint a teaching style, but the ethos of project teaching is 'cooperative enquiry-based learning', and therefore a range of teacher behaviours was witnessed.

The following observation conveys the relationship of Diyas with the children.

Location: Sunken Area. Blue Group (4+ years) children are all piled in the round sunken area along with one of the Diyas. They are listening to a story with the Diya dramatizing and enacting some instances. While some children are sitting 'all over her' (one on her lap, one on her shoulders), she seems equally comfortable with them. A solitary young artist is seen sitting in a corner, colouring intently, least distracted by the class activity. The second Diya is cleaning the cupboard and joins in the group's laughter at times. (Field Note)

Project work gains significance in view of the affective meaning it has for the children. Some of the perceptions of 52 children regarding projects in their own words are: 'I like projects because they are very interesting'; 'Project time is nice'; 'In project time I like doing drawing, reading and doing drama'; 'When it's project time, I like it very much, and have a lot of fun also'; 'I feel the best doing project work'; 'Projects help me know lots of things'; and 'In projects the fun is in doing activities'.

Interviews with parents also revealed that teaching-learning through projects help children develop confidence, accept responsibility and take decisions regarding their learning. As a parent remarked, 'Mirambika's system of learning encourages the child to come forward and do whatever they like without the fear of being compared with his/her peer group. This makes the child confident. Confidence in children makes them clear about their goals, likes, dislikes, which helps them to take their own decisions.' Another parent said, 'Children accept responsibility for good or bad decisions, and this is because Mirambika has provided enough space to the child to experiment and learn from their mistakes.'

The child: An active learner

Special aspects of teaching need special mention as they impinge upon project teaching. Rules of work are planned out in consultation with the children; organization of work takes place in small groups, which are formed in accordance with learners' needs and keeping in view the group goals. Diyas work together to create a peaceful conducive environment that emphasizes learning by sharing and the complete involvement of children in constructing reality, that is, in eliciting answers. Children are given the full responsibility and freedom to make observations, personally experience and use the resources in the library; creative use of space is a common feature with children as they are free to work in the open grounds, lobby, library, laboratory etc. The Diyas stated that 'It is important to know what the child knows and start from that point, build up on the strength of the child. It is no point saying, "You don't even know this".' An interview with another teacher revealed that she believed her work should suit the needs of children. As she said, 'I don't like to think in terms of shaping children in a pre-existing mould. I am trying to help the child develop into a complete human being.' The teachers' concern with the all-round development of children is in accordance with the school ideology.

The Diyas view their role as that of a facilitator, a co-constructor of children's learning experiences, and to build on students' strengths.

- Diya: When you go to the library and want to consult a book, how do you look up a book?
- Child: Have a look at the chapters.
- Diya: That's right. What if it is a big fat book and you have to get information on 'Universe'?
- Child (1): See the 'Contents' of the book.
- Diya: Yes, that's right. What is it?
- Child (2): List of chapters given at the beginning of the book—that is contents.
- Diya: Good, what more it contains? (After some time the teacher again asks, is there anything else given or not?)
- Child (3): Nothing else is given.
- Diya: (Picks up a book and shows it and says) One has a list of tables (Children say in some books more information is given.)
- Child: Do we have a list of pictures in books?

- Diya: Yes! That's right, we have illustrations and figures also. Now tell me, what will I do if I have to find information on 'orbit'?
- Diya: If I see the chapter on 'Life' or 'Earth' I will get the information.
- Child: Yes! You mean look at the most appropriate chapter.
- Diya: Okay! That's one way. Don't you think it will take a lot of time to search for information in this manner? (Children collectively agree.)
- Diya: Okay! Now let's make small groups of 4-5 students each (Gives each group a book.) (Children are seen examining the books.)
- Diya: What is an 'index'? Where is it?
- Child: At the back of the book.
- Diya: That's right! What does it contain?
- Child: Words are given and nos... is it page nos?... Yes, page nos are given.
- Diya: Choose a word and see the page no.
- Children: 'Orbit' is given on pages 8, 41, 126 ...

In this excerpt, we consistently see certain qualities that can be said to be the teachers' characteristic ways of behaving with children: patience, giving them freedom to express their ideas and opinions, providing opportunities to search for information, and being basically loving and considerate.

A 'child-centred' orientation on the part of Diyas is also reflected in behaviours such as asking questions, interest in and responsiveness to children's individual needs, a great willingness to give children latitude in responding, and greater tolerance and approval of their behaviour. The discernment and development of uniqueness in children is highly valued by the Diyas. Their view is that 'each child has his/her personality which needs to be developed, and our role is to channel the personality'. This is nicely illustrated in the following excerpt, which shows the interaction between a teacher and children. All through, the children are encouraged to express their personal ideas and opinions.

- Diya: We have been doing a project on environment. Let us talk about types of environmental pollution. Can you tell me what causes pollution?
- Child (1): Smoke in the air is pollution.
- Diya: (Writes this on the board) Do you know other things which cause pollution?
- Child (2): Smoke from buses, cars and scooters ...
- Diya: Yes, you are right, there are many sources of smoke which cause air pollution.
- Child (2): Didi, also smoke from factories and cigarette smoking.
- Diya: Good, are there other kinds of pollution?
- Child (3): Water pollution, when we throw garbage in water, it causes many diseases.
- Diya: That is very good! Who else is affected by water pollution?
- Child: Animals in water ... fish, whale ... (The other children add on).
- Child: Didi, even plants in water are affected.
- Child: Sometimes animals die and become less (A discussion on dinosaurs followed, and how they became extinct).

Child (2): For this we have to protect animals from hunters.

Diya: What else can we do to help the animals?

Child: The animals can be protected in a Zoo ... or such places.

Diya: You are used to a particular environment, how would you feel if your home is shifted elsewhere? A discussion followed on this.

Child (2): No! I think they should live where they are used to.

Child (3): We should not pollute their environments and let them live in their own places.

(The discussion continued to show the inter-dependence of man, animals and plants.)

Diyas allow each child optimum space, time and context to develop and display his/her interest and personality. Interviews with Diyas revealed that 'opportunities given to each child to come forward encourages independent behaviour in seeking solutions to problems and issues'. Parents felt that for children, 'learning is enjoyable and they develop a strong craving for knowing', which may be attributed to projects, which 'helps them to look at things from different angles and develop a wider perspective by relating one subject to another'.

Mirambika, in view of its educational and philosophical goals, invites the child's participation in various activities, and provides experiences to explore, create, experiment and observe.

Negotiations at work

Exchange or negotiation is the mode of interaction often used by teachers and children to maintain a working relationship. Negotiations, according to Woods (1979, p. 127), 'enable interaction to proceed in a manner agreeable to both sets of participants, so as to achieve their goals and maximize their interests'. Children in the older groups are involved in negotiations to a much greater extent as compared to younger groups, and are aware of the (almost) equal power existing between the teachers and children. This is perhaps the result of the complete freedom they are given to express their opinions, and the absence of teacher authority. As Thapan (1991) states, 'If pupils are encouraged to express their opinions freely they become aware of this bargaining power.' The following observations show how children negotiate during work.

(The teacher gives them worksheets to work independently.)

Children: Didi, can we work in pairs? (The teacher wants them to work on their own and is not willing to go along with them; discussion follows.)

Diya: Do you want to work in small groups?

Child: Please, we want to work together (points to her friend).

Diya: Convince me.

Children: We are a free world. We have a right to choose our partners. (Children in this particular group had done a project on the 'rights of children'.)

Diya: Even I have some rights—don't I?

- Children: No, you don't—(laughingly). We want to work in pairs (they insist).
 Diya: Ok, work in pairs. Who are going to be the partners? (The children decide among themselves, and the teacher agrees).

Children in Mirambika are typically frank and expressive. During an interview, a parent revealed, 'The freedom given to the child in class allows them to put forward their views without being "ridiculed" or "laughed at", which makes them express their opinion.' Informal communication lines exist between the teachers and children. 'Power' or 'control' do not lie with the teacher, and negotiations help to maximize the student's effort. Attempts are made to provide children with opportunities to increase their sense of obligation to others, and to encourage the self-reflection that helps to maintain good working relationships.

The teacher (Diya) is not viewed as the positional authority who 'knows best' or is the only one who is relevant and correct, and hence wiser and stronger. The next example illustrates the view of a teacher as learner in Mirambika.

During self-evaluation of the work done, a Diya writes questions on the board.

- Diya (1) writes: Which experiment did not you understand at all and why?
 One girl: Bhaiya, it should be 'you did not'.
 Diya (1): Asks her to sit down (ignores what she has said).
 Child again: Bhaiya, 'wrong language is written', and again points at the mistake.
 Diya (2): Talks to the teacher who is writing the question, who then corrects it.
 (The other children continue writing without reacting.)

Diyas are often heard using the phrase, 'I am also learning, no one knows everything', in order to get the children to move, explore, seek information or facts on their own. This is clearly in accordance with the official version of Mirambika as a learning centre for all, for children as well as teachers. No sharp boundaries are maintained between the one who 'knows' and the one who 'knows not'. This makes children 'independent learners in the sense that they search for information/knowledge on their own', as expressed by a Diya. This suggests a fundamental shift in the teachers' thinking and in the strategies they apply to children's learning.

Disciplining strategies

Interviews and informal conversations with Diyas reveal that Mirambika does not relate teacher success to securing silence and orderliness in their classrooms; instead, it is related to personal (self) and situational control, that is, being 'centred'. We too observed that 'neither corporal punishment nor verbal aggression by teachers play any role in school interactions'. The teachers said that the 'focus in Mirambika is on developing "inner discipline" in students, that is, control of emotions and actions.' As alternatives to punishments, attempts are made to develop inner discipline. Some controlling strategies evolved by the Diyas for the

younger groups include calling peace—a symbolic gesture of the hands to quieten children down; asking children to become a ‘statue’; symbolic gestures like ‘take the rat of fight and throw it out’; putting on music to make children dance and expend their extra energy; playing tug-of-war with the trees in the grounds; and talking softly to get the attention of children and making them in turn lower their own volume. With older groups, the teachers use different strategies. The teachers stated, ‘Each child is given five sticks, each time the child speaks unnecessarily, one stick is taken away. Once the child has exhausted all the sticks, s/he is not allowed to participate or ask questions.’ Children are also encouraged to form their own rules, and are then asked to adhere to them. Assigning responsibilities to the children seemed to be a popular disciplining strategy in Mirambika; this also helps the children become aware of their actions. Informal talk with children reiterates the school’s notion of developing inner discipline. They said, ‘If you are given freedom, you don’t misuse it but in a strict environment you feel like breaking the rules.’

The principal had a talk with some 6-7 children from the senior groups after hearing about the use of offensive language by a student in class. He tells them that through their misbehaviour, they are harming themselves and Mirambika. The children say that ‘he is always using’ such words, and wanted the Principal to take a tough stance. He is not willing to do so, and the children put forth their arguments in their defence. The boy in question is bewildered and explains his point, saying, ‘Boys I play with also use the same language but no one checks them’. He, however, shows willingness to make an effort to not use undesirable language. The class is adamant, ‘he has earlier made false promises’—no excuse is to be given now. The Principal asks the children to decide amongst themselves how they could find a solution to the problem. He reminds them, ‘we all make mistakes, you may also be at fault some day.’ Together they fix a date and time to discuss the solutions and opinions put forward by the children. (Field Note)

These attempts are derived from the school’s philosophy, which restrains teachers from encouraging conformity to a set of rules.

The findings are suggestive of the strengths of the project work approach followed in Mirambika. In addition to the cognitive aspect, project work also intends to develop the affective and conative aspects of development. Projects help students to become more resourceful, prone to taking initiatives and responsible for their work, and promote searching skills, reasoning power and experimentation. The role played by such experiences in shaping the personal-social development of children cannot be overlooked. The perceptions of parents, teachers and children revealed that teaching-learning in Mirambika attempts to turn children into confident ‘thinking individuals’, and inculcate values like the dignity of labour, sharing, cooperation and openness to others’ view-points. Mirambika children are perceived as being very confident, resourceful, adventurous, dynamic, responsible, sincere, hardworking, and information seekers. The results, however, also suggest the need for preparing and orienting Mirambika students to the prevalent

teaching-learning-evaluation system, so as to aid them to adjust better after the students shift to other schools.

Conclusion

The basic premise of teaching in Mirambika is based on acknowledging that students have experiences, insights and talents, and that the role of the teacher is to help find ways to use them in the classroom. The project approach is interdisciplinary, integrates arts in the curriculum and leads to collateral learning. This is accomplished through an evolutionary syllabi that emerges out of the needs of students. The use of projects is an alternative way of organizing work in such a manner that the activities taken up are designed to fit each student's needs. Since projects are open-ended and flow in a direction determined by the children's interest rather than by a pre-determined schema, they tend to develop the skills of inquiring, investigating and presenting the information in students. This makes children independent, responsible and confident of their learning. Frequent opportunities are offered to children to 'reconstruct knowledge for themselves, rather than receiving it from the teacher'. Such interactions allow for an atmosphere of freedom and informality, in which lies the classroom ethos. In line with Sri Aurobindo's philosophy, teachers at Mirambika attempt to build their teaching on what children know. The approach usually used by the teachers has a number of features: it is based on the student's interests and experiences; it creates a climate of mutual trust and faith in the child's capabilities; it provides the freedom to explore and experiment; and it lays emphasis on collaborative learning. The teacher's role is that of a facilitator, a generalist. Fewer constraints operate on teachers and their success is not measured in relation to the contents covered, but calls for situational and personal control. The teaching style can be labelled as informal, participative, democratic and illuminative. In spite of a wide disparity among teachers—in terms of qualifications, background, experience and expertise—what emerges is a strong consensus to work for the 'divine'. The teacher is a learner; as a teacher aptly put it: 'we all make mistakes and it's never too late to learn'. We also noted in our observations that teachers are constantly in the process of 'self-reflection', which, as Wade and Yarbrough (1996) stated, is a step towards professional growth. It may be said that the success of innovations in teaching-learning is dependent on the overall school climate. The new techniques used at Mirambika originate from its ideology and values, as well as from the motivation and commitment of the teachers. Such experiences at Mirambika help students to take initiatives, be self-disciplined, cooperative and responsible for their work, and play an active role in their learning.

Suggestions for future research

The success of the innovative patterns of teaching-learning followed in Mirambika, based on the educational ideas of Sri Aurobindo and The Mother, is relevant for bringing about a change in the current highly structured, time-bound system,

which imparts information and knowledge in subjects separated into tight compartments, and is acquired by the learner in the same manner.

To meet the present-day challenges of the changing, inter-dependent world, there is need for a paradigm shift in the way schools impart education, the methods used by the teachers, and the total function and nature of schooling. Therefore education, besides providing cognitive skills (the traditional 3 Rs), needs to emphasize other aspects of learning that help children develop self-confidence, a sense of personal integrity, and individual personalities capable of helping and relating to others, evaluating one's own learning, understanding relationships with people, being appropriately motivated etc. The focus should shift to learning how to learn, where to get information, and how to apply what has been learnt in everyday life. This will lead to autonomy in one's learning and promote the development of both cognitive and affective skills—those of taking initiatives, being creative, decision-making and cooperative living. The development of cognitive and affective qualities demands a curriculum that is process-oriented and not content-based. This would require organizing teaching-learning in a manner that is sensitive to the needs of the learner, unlike the current teaching-learning in schools, which is uniformly given and tested within a rigid frame to all learners, irrespective of their liking or capacities. Teaching time and methods will have to be reorganized for self-learning, problem-solving, questioning and fieldwork, so as to encourage learner participation over a flexible time period in an activity most suited to her/his capacities. Grouping students according to their interests and capacities would be a step towards individualizing teaching and learning. The implied role of a teacher in this scheme is that of a learner and not one who 'knows-all' or is the sole purveyor of knowledge. Alternative methods of evaluation would facilitate learner self-evaluation for personal development, cooperative effort and further learning. Self-evaluation helps in knowing one's strengths and weaknesses, is not judgemental, and aims at understanding oneself. The focus of such evaluation is to help the child overcome her/his weakness, which fosters personal development. It also provides the teacher with feedback on teaching techniques, learning methodologies and curriculum planning. Since self-evaluation helps in learning how much the child has covered and what more is needed, it would provide the teacher with inputs for modifying the syllabi and organizing her/his teaching to suit the child's needs and capacities.

Endnote

1. There are three types of teachers who work at the school: full-time, B. Ed. trainees and volunteers. The total number of teachers keeps changing, depending upon the number of volunteers in the school.

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Section 3

Social issues

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Introduction

Over the years, the main concerns and preoccupations of psychology have drifted towards applications, as the discipline has been asked to attend to the practical issues influencing human action at the individual, interpersonal and group levels. In addition to alleviating human suffering through efforts like psychotherapy, a more important goal has become the optimization of human resources and its contribution to capital formation and economic growth. Keeping these overarching goals in mind, psychologists have been developing methods and techniques to promote organizational goals, ameliorate suffering in the health domain, facilitate developmental processes in the context of the family, and regulate growth and development during the entire life span. Psychologists are expected to play a critical role in all these, as well as in related domains.

The social institutions of parenting, healing and earning a livelihood are embedded in various cultural contexts. As meaning-systems and practices, cultures often have certain goals, sustained through artefacts, beliefs and social arrangements, which form a pattern. In recent years, scholars have identified a number of cultural syndromes (for example collectivism, individualism, cultural complexity, tolerance of ambiguity, femininity-masculinity etc.), and cultures are ranked in terms of the strength of the manifestation of these syndromes. These syndromes are used to explain variations in behaviour. However, this position does not pay enough attention to the process aspect of culture, which is constructive and relates to the past and the future in a dynamic manner. Cultures are also engaged in imagination and envisioning life concerns. The various kinds of organizations within a culture are essentially arrangements for such pursuits.

Since the very beginning of modern psychology, efforts have been made to put psychological principles into practice. Such efforts have been predominantly individualistic in orientation. Assessments of individual differences in various dispositions were undertaken through standardized tests of abilities, aptitudes, interests, motives, attitudes etc. In addition, interventions of various kinds were planned to bring about changes in self-concept and related areas. All these attempts were invariably organized with a focus on the egoistic aspects of the self. They nurtured and fuelled the notion of a self-contained individuality, in which man was the be-all and end-all of existence. The centrality of this kind of separate and bounded self, with strong boundaries between self and other, has furnished one of the grounding assumptions of most Western theories of psychology.

The extended and relational notion of self prevalent in the Indian cultural context offers a very different ground on the basis of which to organize life at the physical, social and spiritual planes. Identity can be conceptualized in the form of concentric circles, in which the lower level is embedded in the higher level. Thus, identity at the spiritual level is relatively more encompassing than identity at the physical or social levels. Taking the body as an instrument of the divine plan, a person is required to play different roles in different situations. While a person is expected to be effective while playing these different roles, they should not consume him. The roles are to be performed without much involvement or attachment. This means minimum ego-investment, which otherwise may interfere with action and undermine the level of competence and performance. The task at hand assumes central importance because it is a kind of sacrifice (*yajña*), performed for the betterment of society (*loka sangraha*). Such a goal is congruent with the assumption that everything in the world is inter-dependent. People are linked through a shared self and a shared consciousness, which makes empathy and communion inevitable.

The decentred model of self and its intrinsic potential to grow has implications for intervention, with commensurability between the individual and the collective. An awareness of the divinity present in every person results in faith in an individual's potential to overcome difficulties. The pain and suffering a person experiences eventually lead to patience and tolerance, and open up new possibilities of growth. Happiness and suffering are relative, and both contribute to making a person complete. The model of intervention thus developed demands a different plan and focus.

It may also be noted that applied psychology encounters a dilemma insofar as developing and implementing such programmes is concerned, because they involve moral questions, which in turn require taking certain positions. For instance, one prevalent framework for application is guided by the metaphor of the market. In this framework, one has to appropriate psychological knowledge and know-how according to the requirements of various agencies, as per market demands. Thus, in the area of management or organizational behaviour, one has to respond primarily to the requirements, aspirations and directives of employers and shareholders. The main concern becomes making profit by enhancing productivity and achieving effective performance. This frame of reference renders psychology into a technology.

This section illustrates the linkage between culture and native knowledge systems in different walks of life, which involve organizational functioning, a community's effort to deal with tragedies, rearing children, resolving conflicts, planning the course of life in specific cultural settings, and working with the formal structure of the military. As readers will notice, most of these reflections are situated in the current social context, and are close to the lives of common people. They cover a wide spectrum and bring out the relevance of Indian thought in significant ways.

Since most human endeavours are not merely confined to the level of the

individual, it is important to see how the group or organizational level functions. Organizations have been created to achieve more comprehensive and complex goals. In chapter 12, 'Exploring the images used for the individual-organization interface: Experiences and reflections', Anand Prakash examines the dominant images created and sustained by organizations vis-à-vis their employees. Two representations of the communities to which the employee belongs—the family and the team—are generally favoured. These representations basically assume common goals, reciprocal loyalties and mutual support. Other images view employees as internal customers, as commodities, and as resources. Prakash notes that both the dominant images, those of the family and the team, are precarious and can easily dissolve because in the family, one is accepted for what one is rather than for what one does, while the opposite holds true for commercial organizations. Likewise, if team performance falters, individual members may often be sacked or transferred. Finally, Prakash reports three empirical studies for which he was a co-researcher. These studies further substantiate the disparities in the employee-organization interface.

'Broadening of consciousness: A healing process among the survivors of the Kachchh earthquake' (chapter 13) is an ethnographic study carried out by Kumar Ravi Priya. The study utilizes a cultural psychological perspective on health and illness to understand the phenomena of suffering and healing which took place in the crisis faced by Kachchh during the post-earthquake period. In the chapter, Priya illustrates how the villagers' belief in *karma* (taken here as an internalized notion of duty towards family, community and nature) facilitated the healing process, as it allowed them to transcend the notion of a limited 'I' or ego and broaden their consciousness to experience themselves as part of a pure and absolute consciousness, as one with the Eternal. Priya also provides a poignant account of how the research process contributed to his own growth as a person.

In 'Resolution of social conflicts: An Indian model', R.S. Pirta explores the features, dynamics and outcome of the Chipko (hug-the-tree) movement, a people's non-violent struggle for justice and sustainability in the Garhwal Himalayas. Pirta notes that Chipko had its origins in the environmental desecration of the Garhwal Himalayas, characterized by large-scale logging operations managed by private contractors. The villagers revolted against the logging policies of the forest department as it made their lives much more difficult and complicated. A hawk and dove conflict ensued, in which the doves (native Garhwalis) won. This later transformed into a broad-based Himalaya Bachao Andolan (Save the Himalayas Movement). Pirta provides a unique social-psychological analysis of the movement, while exploring the role played by the local deities and their relation to the mental health of the people.

In '*Lālan-pālan*: A psycho-spiritual experience for the Indian mother', Anjali Singh explains that the entire process of rearing a child in Hindi is termed *lālan-pālan*, and is quite different from Western models of socialization. Anjali articulates the way indigenous views and cultural constructs operate and impact the experiences and behaviour of mothers in a large segment of traditional Hindu

society. *Lālan-pālan* primarily consists of instilling certain *samskāras* (subconscious habits) in the child, preparatory to the process of his or her developing into an ideal human being. Anjali further notes that this process involves not only the parent-child relationship, but engages the entire social ecology. The family members and the community in which the family is embedded all participate in an integrative fashion in the development and care of the child through a variety of social and spiritual practices, including customs, rituals, ceremonies and role relationships.

In 'Being human the Sikh way: Some psychological reflections', Preeti Kapur and Girishwar Misra outline the Sikh vision of life which is a holistic approach to the notion of personhood, and one that offers a synthesis of evolution at the bodily, social and spiritual planes of existence. This conceptualization is rooted in a view of life of responsible action, situated in the social world. Kapur and Misra note that in the Sikh view, an individual is simultaneously a unitary and a multidimensional being, with physical, emotional, mental and spiritual aspects. The Sikh way of life integrates the spiritual, cognitive, affective, motivational and behavioural elements, and provides an orientation towards the 'total' and 'complete' person. Kapur and Misra conclude that in the Sikh way, the key to 'being human' can be found in the realization of an expanding or encompassing vision of the self, as emerging through a bonding of the inner and the outer, rather than being confined to any one of them. The self is nurtured by its surroundings and absorbs knowledge and socio-cultural practices from its environment to 'be' and 'become' human.

In the early 1990s, Kittu Reddy was invited by the then Chief of Staff of the Indian Army to help raise the level of motivation in the Army from the prevalent, normal level of consciousness to a higher spiritual level. 'Organizational transformation through consciousness-centred training: A case study from the Indian Army' is an informal, non-academic discussion of some of the outcomes that emerged from that experience. Reddy notes that only in recent years has attention been paid to the spiritual foundations and principles of work. The chapter is organized into three sections. The first section explains the organizational structure in the army and the problems of training and motivation. The second section focuses on the application of a consciousness-based perspective and the challenges inherent therein, such as movement across levels of consciousness and the problems of integration. The third and final section shares a practical agenda and draws certain conclusions based on experience.

12

Exploring the images used for the individual–organization interface: Experiences and reflections

Anand Prakash

Introduction

Organizational studies became institutionalized as a distinct research field in North America in the 1960s as leading universities expanded to include the new behavioural and management sciences. In keeping with the prevailing image of science, it adopted an empiricist epistemology and an atomistic ontology that portrayed formal organizations as isolated, reactive hierarchies adapting to market selection mechanisms. At this juncture, two kinds of developments shaped the growth of the discipline of Organizational Behaviour (OB). First, the failure of logical empiricist research programmes, together with the failure of the Anglo-Saxon philosophy of science and the decline of Fordism, which encouraged a considerable fragmentation of organizational studies around rival frameworks. Second, the success of East Asian firms in many international markets and the continued divergences from US norms of many European forms of capitalism contributed to a growing interest in the role of institutional frameworks in structuring and reproducing competing forms of economic organizations. This invited a radical reconceptualization of both the nature of formal organizations and of their environment, which complimented developments in evolutionary and institutional economics. As a result, the contemporary image of organizations is portrayed as a mediating collective entity between national and international politico-economic institutions and market economies.

The inter-relationship between people and organizations represents one of the major concerns of contemporary organization theory. Any analysis of management of people within work organizations is necessarily embedded in a model of hierarchical structures and asymmetrical power relations. However, while acknowledging that under capitalism, the management of relations at the workplace requires the mobilization of a subjective understanding of the people and the underlying organizational processes. But within the framework of the market economy, organizational analysis appears extremely reluctant to absorb and integrate the question

of individual subjectivity into its core theory. This is paradoxical enough, as processes of subjective resistance by employees to managerial initiatives are integral to the core theory approach, while employees' subjectivity, grounded essentially in a humanist model, remains marginalized (Thompson & Ackroyd, 1998).

Organizations are primarily created as effective mechanisms for transacting with the environment to achieve certain goals. Organizations often seem solid—solid buildings, solid people, solid products, and solid money. Many of them are shining too, at least if we judge them from the glamour of their brochures, opulence of their buildings, the aura of their logos and the sheen of their products. The images of these organizations carried by some young people when they go for their training or job interview can be highly idealized. Yet reading through their accounts of actual work experiences, we are struck by how quickly the appearance of solidity and appeal evaporates. New recruits are surprised at their own gullibility. Was what they imagined the organizations to be nothing but a mirage, a carefully crafted and presented image? Is the reality really confusion and pettiness? (Fineman & Gabriel, 1996)

Such idealized images of organizations are not only the product of parental and local community influences but are also due to excessive respect for academic theory. People are not so much disillusioned by organizations as with theories, which seem to fail them in their hour of need. What happens to good theories when an organization is doing wrong to them? Interestingly, what goes wrong hinges on one factor—the inability of those who design organizations to relate to the common people who are going to work for the organizations. Extending Gabriel's argument, it can be said that organizational quicksand is frightening when one is in it and in hindsight it seems like a comedy of errors. I have been engaged with students in their field training exercises and project training, and come upon numerous stories about the facets of role expectations and the demands of organizational life, especially stresses from work underload or overload. These indicate how jobs can be stultifying, a threat to self-image and personal competence. There is voluminous research on organizational stress (for example, Luthans, 1992; Cooper, 1994; Pestonjee, 1999). Most of the literature on stress offers ways of conceptualizing stress, the effects of underload, overload, ambiguity and conflict and different ways of managing or coping with stress. The last area includes personal and therapeutic techniques and changes in the structure of organization. Stress theorists tend to agree that understanding individual differences in the cognitive appraisal of a given situation is very important, as one person's sense of challenge can be another's overwhelming burden. Recently, the process of stress has been linked to emotions at work (Fineman, 1993; Lazarus, 1993).

The conventional perspective on stress has come under radical attack by Newton et al. (1995). Is stress necessarily an inevitable fact of life, an individual's own disease and responsibility? Who defines who is stressed? Stress should be seen as the emotional product of the social and political power structure of organizational life, not as an individual weakness. Is it, perhaps, too convenient for managers to label a stressed worker as a suitable case for treatment? Managers are reluctant to

question the structure and ideology of managerial and corporate structure and ideology expectations that contribute to the problems. Are we not engaging in blaming the victim?

As hinted earlier, in their recruitment literature most organizations present glossy images to their new employees and managerial trainees. Smart offices, high technology equipment, challenging work and supportive management almost always figure in the picture. What is not shown is that many people, even in 'good' jobs, find their actual work very boring, and surviving or simply getting through the day is what preoccupies them. Handling their negative emotions at work is central to such experiences. This raises questions about the way organizations set the expectations for their employees. How well are the job requirements matched with people's abilities and personalities?

Organizational life is often based on a set of role relationships, procedures and expectations where the emotional cost is not counted, and where the expression of feelings such as compassion, loss, anger and hurt is seen as interference in task performance. Furthermore, an organization will often respond to personal distress bureaucratically, establishing routine procedures for handling grievances, disputes and stress. The visible display of such emotions must, therefore, be contained, so that normal life can be resumed as soon as possible.

Capitalism as the dominant social ideology brings with it competition for customers and intense fights for profit and innovation and, of course, products. As organizations struggle to survive, they always seek to outgrow and outperform their competitors. What is different about today's organizations is that business is only about winning. Each day appears to be a fighting day in which battles are won and lost, reputations are made and destroyed, alliances are struck and broken, opponents are manoeuvred, neutralized and defeated. It is not surprising to find that military terminology—strategy, tactics, targets, kill, predator, flak, piracy, ambushes, outflanking and sieges—has invaded and taken over the very vocabulary of business. Being seen as a winner is not merely the outcome of success, but also the result of defeating someone else. If we consider these an inevitable part of existence, where is the scope for the values of more humanitarian orientations?

The human side of organizations

As the previous century unfortunately taught us, how we conceptualize and label people will reflect and influence the way we treat them. People at work are no exception. Whether consciously or unconsciously, Derridian terminology tends to define 'human' in terms of deference. For example, human beings are seen as creatures distinguished from other animals by superior mental development, the ability of speech, and an upright posture; or as having qualities that distinguish them—not as being divine or animal or mechanical, but qualities such as kindness, compassion and pity (Oxford Paperback Dictionary, 1988). Here, we see very clearly that the concept we have of what it means to be human is inevitably a work of social construction—the self-attribution of superiority over other forms of life;

the highly contentious assumption that other animals lack articulate speech, or at least the implication that if people cannot understand interspecies communication it is of no importance; the identification of qualities that reflect an Aristotelian perspective on humankind; the assumption that 'mankind' is a neutral label, and so on. In defining what it is to be human, such acts of social construction imply different ethical positions. For example, a Kantian would assert, from a deontological duty perspective, that the essence of humanity is rationality and autonomy; that as rational beings with freedom and self-determination, humans should be accorded respect as an end in itself.

Thus, humanism and individualism go hand in hand. In contrast, a teleological 'virtue' ethics considers that to be truly human, people must strive to achieve a desirable end-state, in which their inherent potentialities are nurtured and fully realized. Humanity is not achieved through a purely individualistic mode, as to be human is to be part of a broader social community in which fulfilling one's potential involves developing wisdom, generosity and self-restraint, all of which help to make one a responsible member of the community. So, is it needed in order to be human to reference to others, in a community that itself defines what counts as human virtue? Are these two conceptions of humaneness compatible? Can an autonomous individual live with the constraints implied by an organization? In the current discourse of human resource management, one can find both the individualistic-Kantian and Collectivist-Aristotelian models of humanity in the advocacy of customer sovereignty and empowerment. The rise of the factory system and large-scale organizations served to project a particular model of humanity. The dominance of the machine, in imagery as well as in actuality, and the symbiotic assertion of an instrumental, technical rationality gave rise to a dehumanizing view of people as labour input. Thus, people became 'hands' and the 'act of working'; the verb 'labour' was turned into a noun to describe people at work. In bureaucracy, the whole person was subjected to rules that prescribed impersonal relationships and a high division of labour. The outcomes, according to Marx and Merton, were distortions of humanity or alienation (human estrangement rooted in social structures that deny people their essential human nature) and the bureaucratic personality (automata-like officials) carrying rule-following to pathological limits (Merton, 1940; Marx, 1976; Bauman, 1991).

Today, both human and inhuman images pervade the discussion on human resource management and people at work. Even though the 'hands' and 'labour' of the age of electro-mechanical technology might have been superseded by the 'knowledge workers' of electronic information communication, or 'smart machines', the underlying theme of humans-as-autonomous-individuals vs. humans-as-members-of-a-community has surfaced in the prevailing imagery of the market.

Functional and dysfunctional aspects of these images

The values that underpin the marketplace image of the employee—the values of individualism, free choice and economic rationality—are sometimes marginalized

in organizations in favour of collectivism, consensus and social rationality (that is, stressing the importance of social bonds and loyalties). From this perspective, the employee is presented not as an actor in the marketplace but as a member of a social organization in which the bonds are not those of contractual exchange but those embedded in reciprocities. Here, the employees can be fully human as part of a social community. Let us examine some of the dominant images created and maintained by organizations about people.

Employee as family member

The communities to which an employee belongs are generally portrayed in two representations—the family and the team. These images are essentially unitaristic, assuming, at the least, common goals, reciprocal loyalties and mutual support. The organization as family and employees as family members are, of course, situated in the model of paternalistic employee relations. The image relies on a very traditional (and idealized) hierarchical model of the family, with the management having control over the children. The image of mother has resonance with personnel functions where it has to intervene for the welfare of the employees as children. However, as in idealized traditional families, although the father may exercise control, it should be a benevolent paternalism. This benevolence should not be exercised as dutiful rationality but softened by affective bonds that underlie a genuine concern to treat family members as an end in themselves; each person is valuable in his or her own right. The family may have internal conflicts but protects itself from external criticisms by permitting its members to criticize internally in order to present a united face to the world. Hence, representing employees as family members simultaneously brings in the values of hierarchy with the assurance that each employee has his or her own value and place; control with a caring management; unity against competition and in the pursuit of managerially-defined goals with internal conflicts de-emphasized or trivialized. Above all, individual family members' interests are subordinated to what is in the interest of the family as a whole. As with families, this may be justified by arguing that the organization's well-being is the best guarantee of each family member's well-being. The image of the family survives for the same reason that paternalism survives: the belief that caring and efficiency are mutually supportive rather than in conflict. But this image is under threat. First, the traditional picture of the family on which paternalism rests is on a shaky foundation. This questions not only the simplistic consensus but also the existence of a long-term relationship between the employee and the organization. Gone are the job-for-life assumptions on which paternalism was founded. Second, in a family, one is accepted largely for what one is rather than for what one does, while in a commercial organization the opposite holds true.

Employee as team member

The team image in its principal manifestation is in some ways an update of the family image—a reincarnation of some sort. If we take the team as a sporting

metaphor, we have a picture of employees working together in the pursuit of a common goal, each member having a specialist role to play but recognizing that the interest of the team overrides those of the individual members. Following the sporting analogy, membership in the team is usually voluntary, for a short period of time and contingent on performance. Hence, while the family image appears to relate to earlier periods of employment, the team image satisfies the present day demand for right attitude combined with a concern for high performance and recognition of the insecurities of employment. If team performance falters, erstwhile 'stars' run the risk of being dropped or transferred, along with the sacking of the manager.

However, the image of a team implies certain other connotations. As pointed out by Parker and Slaughter (1988) the positive connotation attached to our everyday conception of a team rests on the assumption of the cooperation of specialists towards a common goal, rather than that of interchangeable members. In the latter type of team—virtually a chain gang—membership is not voluntary and the nature and pace of work is often prescribed by whoever has the whip in hand. It projects an image of work being hard, not to say oppressive, and lacking any potential for enjoyment. It also suggests that work will be the same, day in, day out, relieved only by the odd rest day. Team membership is not voluntary, in the sense that the alternative is unemployment and leading life on diminishing resources.

Employee as internal customer

The first market image of an employee is that of a customer. From a post-modern perspective, the consumer is presented as the epitome of the autonomous individual, who creates and recreates successive identities through a pattern of self-fulfilling and liberating consumption, exercising freedom of choice to the full. If post-modern, post-industrial society privileges consumption over production, the provider of goods and services that fuel consumption is best portrayed in the language of consumption. Hence, the employee-provider is the internal customer.

The employee as internal customer has a complex and symbiotic relationship with the employee as 'external customer'. Thus, the representation of the employee as internal customer is intimately bound up with the issues of quality and responsiveness to the external customer. This can be seen most clearly in the lean production system, whether in manufacturing or in the service sections. Lean production is about organizing in a way that is value added by (a) minimizing waste, whether of material, time, space or people; (b) developing responsiveness to major stakeholders most of whom—whether employees or purchasers of goods and services—are also defined as customers. The route to leanness in this scenario is that favoured by the Japanese excellence model, involving lean production techniques, Total Quality Management (TQM), Just In Time (JIT) production, supply chain management and so on, Business Process Reengineering (BPR), facilitated by information communication technologies and high commitment Human Resource Management (Kinnie et al., 1996). The employee as internal customer embedded in the process-oriented organizing system has the right to demand that inputs

received conform to agreed specifications and, as supplier to the next process, has the obligation to satisfy the need of the next customer in that process. If the essence of the customer is to exercise choice, logically the employee as an internal customer has to be afforded discretion as an element of his/her job. As is appropriate in a world of customer sovereignty, this is considered empowerment. This calls for a high-trust working environment, at least in theory. The employer, also as customer, buys cooperation in order to secure external customer satisfaction, the foundation of organizational viability. In fact, external customers are often the people at work, as, co-opted in the McDonaldisation of society, they perform activities once the preserve of employees, through a whole range of self-service activities (Ritzer, 1993).

Employee as commodity

The image of the employee as commodity is, of course, not a new image, as is only too evident from Marx's discussion of the commodification of labour. But, as is evident from the recent work on the growth of the contingent workforce, another aspect of leanness—or the elimination of waste—is to conceptualize the workforce as a *commodity* to be bought and dispensed with as the market dictates. This is most evident in the increasing use of so-called '*outsourcing*' and '*insourcing*' of labour. Both are predicated on the value of the marketplace as both signify a movement from hierarchy to market contract with the aim of reducing cost and enhancing profitability. Outsourcing may take two forms: straightforward sub-contracting or buy-in of products, often from cheap overseas suppliers, or facilities management, where the sub-contractor takes over in-house facilities and, often, staff to provide a service previously undertaken by the organization, but at a cheaper price. In-sourcing is where an employment agency sources people to work alongside the organization's existing staff and where, in the case of big contracts, the agency will place a manager on site to deal with issues of labour supply such as absenteeism, payroll and replacement, while the client organization remains in control of workspace allocation, allocation of work and quality.

The commodification of labour is evident in both practices. Leaving aside the issue of the freelance knowledge worker, or Reich's (1991) symbolic analyst, the bulk of labour in the subcontracting organization is a commodity in the sense of being an input brought in to minimize the cost and optimize the profits of the contractor organization. The image of this labour is not of people at work but of a costed labour input that may be reflected in competitive product pricing. This is encapsulated in two examples cited by Purcell (1997). A commodity has no view of its own, and there cannot be anything more dehumanizing than this perspective on employees. The arguments offered are that outsourcing enhances flexibility. There is no legal or psychological contract with the individual, you outsource management problems associated with non-core staff, and it offers greater cost efficiency. In other words, the image of an employee presented here is of a commodity (turn the tap on and off); and with a commodity, an organization can wash its hands off responsibility, all in the interest of economic rationality.

Employee as resource

This is an image beyond the company reports. Here, the employee is presented more as the source of the organizations' value-added and competitive advantage, and as an asset to be cherished and developed rather than a cost to be minimized. As an asset, there is stress on developing a reciprocal commitment. This is achieved on the employer's side by bundles of high commitment HRM practices, namely:

- Careful recruitment and selection, with emphasis on traits
- Extensive use of communication
- Teamwork with flexible job design
- Emphasis on training and development
- Involvement in decision-making
- Performance-linked reward systems

In return, the employee, in theory at least, offers attitudinal commitment rather than behavioural compliance, resulting in high performance. Rather than back-grounding or denying a psychological contract between the employee and organization, it is seen as an integral part of the relationship and is often expressed in terms of a commitment to no compulsory redundancy.

Before considering the tensions and contradictions, both within and between these images, let us consider an opposing image of community, and the way an employee would like to see himself or herself about his or her relationship with an organization, particularly in the Indian ethos and cultural context.

Uncovering underlying assumptions of person–organization relations

In order to appreciate the situation better, it is necessary to uncover some of the underlying assumptions. The economic, rational man assumption of Taylor is alive and well-ingrained in the organizational framework today. For example, many organizations make the employee satisfaction survey a sacred ritual. There is a strong belief that employees' satisfaction will contribute to better performance. However, the findings here are largely equivocal. While satisfaction has been linked to reduced absenteeism and turnover, its relationship with performance is far from clear. The positivist quest that is highlighted in reducing human subjective experience to a statistical gimmick of numbers is conceived as true representation of the state of affairs. Thus, the belief in employees' satisfaction continues to thrive, which is not necessarily bad. But, at the same time, there are many events and processes, as reflected in an employee's subjective world-view, whose existence may not be proved by statistical significance alone. So long as organizations remain fixated on using a positivist mindset, it will go on creating myths and illusions to match 'idealized and cherished' images rather than bringing forth the reality of people's experiences.

Hayek (1986) dedicated his Nobel Memorial Lecture to the dangers posed by the scientific pretensions in the analysis of social phenomena. Because of the very nature of what Hayek describes as the phenomena of 'Organizational Complexity',

the application of scientific methods to such phenomena is often unscientific. Moreover, in these fields, there are definite limits to what we can expect science to achieve.

Today, the more or less explicit assumption is that market and team-based organizational setups lead to better performance. This implies an interesting paradox because markets opt for entrepreneurial individuals to be given a free hand while teams opt for specialists holding hands. Thus markets are outside and teams are inside. This raises the issue of boundaries. How does one reconcile the paradox? Again we find ourselves, as believers, faithful to an ideology. By deconstructing the texts and metaphors of HRM, we can uncover the underlying assumptions regarding human nature, and the relationship between power and authority, conformity and control. These assumptions can then be challenged, as their consequences are better appreciated. This exercise encourages critically reflective practitioners, so that actions are taken with informed choices from those who are involved. We also know that the value a company creates is produced through a combination of resources contributed by different constituencies. For example, employees, including managers, contribute their human capital and shareholders contribute financial capital. If the value creation is achieved by combining the resources of both, why should value distribution favour the latter?

When employees who join an organization are offered a vision that is to be embraced without their knowing whether or not it is veridical, they embrace this vision largely based on faith or their trust in a charismatic leader, someone who is able to convince them with pictures, narratives and rhetoric; someone in whom, for some reason, they believe. This is why these leaders become folk heroes. But where is the link between leader and performance? Why is there the need to believe in leaders? Are leaders born or made? Recent research tends to indicate that leadership is in the genes. In that case, how about including genetic screening in the selection methods? Can leadership be trained or developed? Do we really know what are doing?

There is another related assumption that downsizing enhances performance. Announcements of layoffs raise stock prices. Why is this so? People in the stock market believe that there is a connection. Research evidence, however, seems to indicate that the relationship may be negative. Yet, most nations are now embracing the American management practice of restructuring. Mergers and acquisitions are instances of such a move. The human consequences of downsizing, restructuring, mergers and acquisitions are dramatic as well as traumatic, but they are being practised as an article of faith in stock market ideology.

Organizations are sending out conflicting messages and communications in several directions, and this is driving people crazy. Take the discourse regarding career management and employability. On the one hand, the best practice is for companies to invest in the careers of their employees; on the other, companies proclaim that lifetime employment is dead, and long live employability. Thus, while a company can no longer promise long-term commitment, it can help you acquire experience and training to improve competencies that would make you

employable. The message is loud and clear: manage your own career! But organizations are rather distressed that employees are no longer loyal and leave when offered better positions elsewhere, despite all that is invested in their training. How does one resolve this paradox?

Again, we find a tension between the logic of community and the logic of the market. Do we really want free agents? Or networks of independent workers contracted in and out depending on just-in-time needs? Here is the view of the worker in need of gratifying objects used to meet the needs of the organization with little regard for the person. Free hands, joined hands or tied hands—which is more humane?

In different ways, employees as customers (choice), resources (value), team members (specialist role) and family members (value) all have positive connotations. Employees as commodities and members of interchangeable teams have negative connotations. Empirical evidences as to the effects of a market for corporate performance control are highly ambiguous. Even Michael Jensen, the proponent of the theory, has been forced to admit that stock options have not worked quite in the same manner that he had hoped (*The Economist*, Nov. 16, 2002, p. 66). There is a tendency to attribute these images to different groups of employees—positive images to core employees and negative images to peripheral or contingent workers.

The defining characteristic of customers is their freedom to exercise choice. The employee as a customer is human by virtue of his or her autonomy. The internal customer in a TQM system can refuse to accept substandard inputs from an earlier production process, and is empowered to stop the line to deal with a process problem before a faulty product reaches another customer downstream. To what extent is this free choice? Just as external customers are manipulated through advertising, brand development, cross-selling and promotions into 'freely choosing' the products and services that the selling organization wishes them to buy, so too are the internal customer's choices constrained by the processes of organizational socialization and other covert forms of control. Why do we not fundamentally rethink issues of corporate governance? Why don't we actually acknowledge in our theories that companies survive and prosper when they simultaneously pay attention to the interests of customers, employees, shareholders and perhaps even to the communities and the physical environment in which they operate? (Ghosal, 2005)

The employee as a resource is certainly valuable. But the other side of being a valuable resource is the imperative that it is used to the best advantage, exploited to the full. The exploited resource, by definition, becomes a commodity, and the human element is degraded. This alerts us to the potential degradation of a valued core employee—the long hours and workaholic lifestyle that may be a corollary to high salaries and benefits. To survive, therefore, many 'resources' develop a workaholic lifestyle before burning out.

This, in itself, reflects three interrelated processes where market values collide with communitarian values. This collision is detrimental to personal and societal development.

- In organizations, we tend to engage with each other not as whole persons but in terms of specific organizational roles. In highly differentiated organizations, this can represent only a tiny self of our selves.
- The exigencies of these roles may require us to engage in unauthentic behaviour, both manipulating others and allowing others to manipulate us (Jackal, 1988). As McIntyre (1999) states, the most effective manager is the *best actor*.
- The workaholic life-style may prevent the development of the self in family and community roles that may allow us a fuller expression of ourselves as persons. No one on his deathbed has ever said, 'I wish I had spent more time in the office'. Many have said, 'I wish I had spent more time with my family'.

McIntyre argued—and I endorse his analysis—that we stand no chance of enacting the deal of full development of a human being's inherent potentialities as part of the broader social organizational community as long as role fragmentation, lack of authenticity and an unbalanced development of potentialities deprive us of the opportunity to develop substantial, integrated narratives of our lives and, hence, to render our lives meaningful to ourselves and to the community. The paradox, therefore, is that the more we value our employees as a resource, the more the very desire to exploit a resource to the full can lead to its consumption rather than to its development. In their effort to be defined as a valued resource, employees may well collude in this process.

To me, writing about person organization is like knitting a new garment from the wool unravelled from old discarded pieces of knitwear. The raw material does not change, but the function of the new item may, and certainly is likely to reflect the fashion of the day.

Indian organizations and cultural disparities

Most organizations in India, irrespective of their ownership, have a Western system of manpower planning, recruitment, training, delegation, decision-making, marketing, financial and information management, and so on. But they have been found to take cultural detours to get their work done efficiently in some cases, and not so efficiently in other cases (Virmani & Gupta, 1991). Actual management practices are characterized by familism, patronage, personalized relationships, centralization of power and obedience to authority. Seniority is an important consideration, but so is merit. Hence, organizations are spending a considerable amount of energy in balancing Western and Indian cultural realities.

Since the quest for understanding and knowledge rides on the vehicle of science, it is rooted in certain assumptions about the nature of reality and the objective forms of truth. It has long been realized that our quest for knowledge, both epistemological and ontological, requires a shift. This is more so on the part of those who have received their formal education in the scientific, secular, rational

yet fragmented mode. The secularization of life in general is perceived as being a direct consequence of the European Enlightenment and the processes of modernization. Gupta (2002, p. 112) contested the secularization of organizations and saw it as a thin veil of misperception.

Success of Japanese organizations and the studies thereof, have brought back the inevitable relevance of social cultures for organizational management. A sense of the sacred is an essential aspect of culture-societal aspects of organizational life—which must be taken into account to build truly humane and optimally effective organizations.

The values that underpin the market image of the employee—individualism, free choice and economic rationality—in communitarianism are back-grounded in favour of collectivism, consensus and a form of social rationality. From this standpoint, the employee is presented not as an actor in the marketplace but as a member of a social organization in which the bonds are not those of contractual exchange but of socially-embedded reciprocities. The employee can be human *only* as part of a social community.

It is beginning to dawn on us that unbridled secularism and unalloyed objective materialism breed a high-entropy culture and civilization. Irreversible disorder and dissipation are bound to occur when matter is converted into energy. If the living ethos were to comprise of high need and high standards, progressively more energy would be needed to keep the production system going. This approach may yield more in the short-term, but it is certainly going to leave far less for posterity. This is the responsibility of a technology-driven secular humanism, and it has impacted the making of organizations in India. India, being a multilingual, multiethnic, multicultural society, resists the notion of homogeneity at the level of values and beliefs. There are many common threads that together comprise the culture of 'Indianness'. Two most commonly held homogenous aspects are the continuity of Hindu religious beliefs and the hierarchical nature of the social structure. Besides, literature also delineates many other features such as the identification of religious sentiments with idols, fascination with maintaining language, and musical harmony. Based on the extensive study of historical research and empirical investigations from psychological points of view, Sinha (1993) concluded that the typical Indian holds the following values:

- Embeddedness in one's own group
- Harmony and tolerance
- Duty in contrast to hedonism
- Preference for personalized relationships
- Preference for arranging things in hierarchical structures

The issue that now needs to be addressed is how these values can be utilized in the creation of organizations, which would reduce the discontinuities in the lives of persons and organizations. Given below are three studies that describe the various facets of human experience in organizations, and the kinds of discontinuities that are created while meeting the demands of the job. The heightened sensitivity of

Indians to relationships with people and to time, energy and ecology, enable them to use traditional, social and Western modes selectively. Thus, organizational behaviour often seems inconsistent and contradictory, and is adaptive with a price tag. Traditional social values often get priority over contemporary Western values in shaping behaviour. However, in certain contexts, the latter may function as a primary mode, sidelining the salience of traditional values in order to cope with particular situations. But this leaves a scar in the psyche of the employees.

Study I: Employee retention in the call centre industry (Singh & Prakash, 2004)

A study was carried out in a Business Process Outsourcing organization with the objective of understanding the nature of stress acting upon the employees and its relationship to turnover of employees. The data were obtained in the form of narratives collected from 20 call centre agents. Semi-structured interviews were conducted to identify the stressors. The narratives were analysed thematically (Glaser & Strauss, 1967).

The themes can be meaningfully captured within two categories, namely *person–job misfit* and *person–culture misfit*. *Person–job misfit* mainly refers to a dysfunctional interaction that causes a sense of imbalance and discomfort pertaining to the job being taken from an individual's perspective. Stress seems to be generated when the job requirement does not match the individual's preference in terms of timing, patterns of interpersonal interaction, larger goals and idealizations, and self-image.

The notion of *person–culture misfit* refers to the dissonance between an individual's cultural baggage, which is shaped largely by the process of socialization in the formative years of life, and the organizational context. A person experiences a severe disconnect when he or she perceives a misfit between aspects of Indian and Western cultures, between traditional and modern cultures, and between idealized and encountered cultures. There is a tremendous sense of loss at the personal level of identity, and an erosion of coping and defence processes. To illustrate these themes, some excerpts from interviews with employees are given below.

A 25-year-old agent staying with her parents:

I used to socialize a lot with the family. When I joined this job, I had to miss a lot of family parties and get-togethers. Sometimes, they would call and I could hear everybody chattering away in the background. That felt so bad, I can't tell you.

My tea consumption has gone up to 16 cups a day. I drink tea every hour that I am awake in order to remain awake.

Another interviewee:

Earlier, I hated speaking English, but now I find it difficult to converse in Hindi. In my mind, I have taken to this English speaking culture and I even look down upon Hindi types.

I am a very conservative person at heart. Like certain distances should remain between boys and girls. But when I go for work, I have to be 'the liberal Scott, not the conservative Sumeet'.

Once you get used to this hectic routine and fast life, you cannot slow down even if you want to.

Some of my friends, who came from my place and joined with me, were sacked, for some quality issue. I felt very insecure and frustrated. We had been told during induction that nobody would be sacked: if our performance was not up to the mark, we would be sent for retraining, so this was a big shock.

Narratives of this kind were recounted by many interviewees. They reported a strong preference for personalized relationships with supervisors. They considered the idea of such a relationship natural, and they looked for empathy from their supervisors when asking for adjustment in leaves and shift timings in times of need. Bossy supervisors who pulled rank and talked only business were disliked. This might be due to contradictions inherent in the organizational process. Many of these organizations promote a culture of equality, with everyone calling seniors by their first names. However, seniors are also expected to maintain a proper psychological distance in order to maintain control. There seems to be an expectation that the supervisors should be more parental in their approach and share feedback in a non-threatening manner.

Thus, a blatant disjunction seems to exist in the lives of employees. The way organizational designs are created and employees hired creates a sense of discomfort that goes beyond manageable limits.

Study II: Stress among personnel working in call centres (Tandon & Prakash, 2004)

This study is aimed at understanding the *meaning of work* shared by employees in the call centre industry through an interpretive mode of inquiry. The interviews were aimed at finding out personal details of background, experience and education. The work related issues of the participants related to meaning attached to the work and the motive behind taking up the job other than salary. Societal and cultural aspects such as support systems, family perceptions and job comfort were also inquired into.

With these broad parameters in place, questions were asked in order to reconstruct the experiences of people and their emotions vis-à-vis their work life and other related issues. The narratives obtained brought forth the complex interplay of internal and external factors in shaping the meaning of work.

Images of the organization

The perceptions of organization-related factors revealed a very interesting trend. When people were asked about job continuance, the dominant themes that emerged from their narratives had to do with the nature of the relational climate within the organization. These included workplace relationships between employees, the

nature of rapport with seniors, the values practiced by the top management, the experienced normative structure and employee-friendly arrangements at the work site. If they had positive feelings about the organization, employees showed a greater sense of identification with the job and the organization.

Actually, I feel great especially when I see that whenever faced with any problem I can go up to any authority person in the company. I mean, be it the team leader, the manager, the VP, anyone Everyone here is very friendly and very pally, so it feels great working here.

In my case, actually I feel the environment is up to my satisfaction. I like to interact with a lot of people and do just that. I have a set of friends and it's really enjoyable working with them. Actually, I have a set of friends who share a cab with me and with whom I travel regularly, and then there are people with whom I work ... it is great fun with all of them.

Social disconnect

Most narratives drew attention to the role of families in the decision to stay on or to quit an organization. To several interviewees, encouragement from their families led them to stay on in the industry; to others, low support from their families was stressful and resulted in dissatisfaction with the job. The confidence created and importance given by the family enables an individual to hold his or her job in high esteem and facilitates long-term relationship-building. The following narrative is an example:

My dad came to drop me to the office and saw two girls smoking. He was very upset to see the environment. He was totally against my joining the organization. He thought that I would not be able to adjust to the environment. I told him to trust me and have faith in the values that he has instilled in me. Now even they are OK with my shifts and the prevailing work culture ... actually, they are concerned over my work in a different manner ... they take care of me more and especially so after a hectic day or night shifts, as I had some months back

Another interviewee also stressed the role of the family.

My grandmother is not at all happy with my work profile. She keeps telling me to join a public sector company or get into the army (*laughs*). She keeps telling me about the possibilities in NGO and Army vacancies and insists that I should apply there. Even my parents think that it is a stop-gap arrangement and should be left at the earliest opportunity.

My family has serious problems with the current job and, particularly, they feel bad about my night shifts They feel that it is unsafe for me to go through the night shifts They also feel that I have no social life. They tell me to look for a day job as then at least I will have a normal routine.

Study III: Disinvestment process in ITDC (Sehgal & Prakash, 2004)

In the present study, the authors examined various narratives of members of an

organization undergoing a change in the form of a disinvestment process. The research was an attempt to capture the way that employees, occupying various positions in the organization, understood and experienced large-scale organizational change and how they reported their experiences in retrospect.

The study was grounded in the constructivist approach, highlighting the subjective nature of individual realities. Semi-structured interviews were conducted with three participants. Data obtained from the interviews was analyzed using narrative plot and theme analysis (Boje, 2001) in order to identify patterns. Some of the themes that emerged from the data are provided below, substantiated by excerpts from the interviews.

Shock and helplessness: The news about disinvestment came as a jolt to the participants. Employees were mere recipients of the change and had no control over the prevailing conditions. Power dynamics was an important element in the perception of being helpless.

We were shocked at what was happening ... I could not believe it ... I went home that day and kept looking at the children. I could not sleep throughout the night.

The pinch of unemployment is very painful In the government policy a poor man should not be visible.

I felt that I had been thrown out of the house.

I am feeling that I have been thrown out as one would remove a fly from the milk.

The biggest thing is that the inferiority complex that develops in a person makes even a winner feel as though he has lost. Every officer wants that his subordinates should do the work, so that no burden comes on him.

These excerpts lead to an interesting understanding of the nature of the relationship between an individual and the organization.

Images of the organization: It was interesting to note an apparent conflict in the employees' experiences within the organization. On the one hand, they were proud to be part of a government-owned public sector organization. On the other, they were frustrated with the poor functioning and lack of competitive spirit inherent in the organization's fabric.

I was so happy—anyone wanted a TV or wanted to keep a security guard, my I-card would do the needful. I am a government employee and if anyone were to stop me on the way, I would show him my I-card saying that I have to go on duty.

Here in the organization, you can't move people from one seat to another. It is not possible without the consent of the union and others.

Political interference at every level and unions are responsible for the public sector image. There is very little freedom to mend the rules. Workers think that there is security in the job.

Violation of psychological contract: The disinvestment process has made the

employees revisit their entire journey with the organization. The basic psychological contract that existed between the employees and the government was that of job security, which is antithetical to the disinvestment policy.

It was Pandit Nehru's opinion that in order to protect a common man from the private parties and for the sake of a country's progress, there should be other options. Therefore, the public sector was established. But this disinvestment is against those policies.

The management has made prior arrangements. People know that they are completing their grace period. Everyone is enjoying themselves. It is for this reason that I am opting for the Voluntary Retirement Scheme (VRS) and leaving. When no one has the desire to fight it out, then what can one do? These people must have arranged with some private party that you may reduce the staff as much as you can. You are responsible for the worker here (you have trapped us), and you are telling me that you can throw me out whenever you like, then what will I do? I will accumulate as much money as I can and go away.

It can be argued on the basis of this data that the lens through which employees view change differs according to their frame of reference and their personal encounters with various agencies within the organization. Change inflicts a sense of insecurity on the employees as prominence is given to economic factors rather than to addressing the chaos felt by the employees. Disinvestment, then, becomes a defining perspective, infiltrating not only the organization but also the lives of the employees who have been left to grapple with their respective difficulties.

The meaning of work

The narratives generated from the semi-structured interviews help us to understand the meaning of work shared by the functionaries of these call centres. They are looking for work that is closer to their own life processes, where they experience not only the familial climate but also where they want the organization to make the necessary accommodation for their personal issues. At the time of recruitment and induction, organizations supply the employees images which give the impression that they are entering a familial set-up, though this is not the normal pattern of relationship experienced by people in contemporary organizations. The interviewees did express a sense of relatedness if they perceived career growth and self-development possibilities in their respective jobs.

In some ways, the preceding accounts reflect a tension that is a part of everyday experience. One of the ways through which it can be negotiated is, by and large, through critical reflexivity (Cooper & Burrell, 1988). As a researcher, making sense of daily experience in a more organized manner becomes a challenge.

In order to understand and interpret the narratives presented above, a binary framework consisting of bipolar facets like the human–inhuman elements in the organization–employee relationship has been invoked. I use binary opposition (human–inhuman or spiritual–non-spiritual) to put forward these narratives while

hoping to create a resulting contrast that may act as a backdrop to the emergence of a clear picture of employee relationships with organizations.

Possibility of an integrative approach

Indian organizations are gripped by the hysteria of liberalization, privatization and globalization floated by the richer economies. It is unfortunate that the planners of organizations in India are steering a faulty course. This contaminated and berated shift in the Indian cultural milieu, which is manifest in the excerpts above, has been commented upon by many scholars umpteen number of times (Prakash, 1993; Chakarvorty, 1993, 2000; Sinha, 1995).

It is evident that there is excessive competitiveness in the air today. Under the veneer, this leads to increasing greed—a speed frenzy driven largely by fear. Even ‘networking’, a new buzzword in organizational design, and observed actions in various personal and organizational functioning, proves, in the ultimate analysis, to be a calculative and instrumental exercise. The entire perspective of the survival of the fittest must be replaced by the more humane mantra of ‘the survival of all’ (*sarve bhavantu sukhinah*) (Chakarvorty, 2000). It is high time that modern man realizes that the more dependence there is on external standards of consumption, the more impoverished he becomes in internal standards of life, and the greater is the degree of alienation among the people in the organizational world. People armed with checklists, networks, diagrams, games of winning and losing, and aspiring to become materially richer are likely to lose the delicate art of simple communion with the larger goals of life. Most of them, in any case, can hardly feel it any longer as a part of given reality. Sri Aurobindo amplified this concern with the true ideals of society, which can be constructed by translating the order of the cosmos into the order of society (Sri Aurobindo, 1973). This assertion is equally valid for creating ideals for organizations, and for employee–organization relationships. The cosmic order of *dharma* includes the material as well as the moral and the spiritual.

The true law of our development and the entire object of our social existence can only become clear to us when we have discovered not only, like modern Science, what man has been in his past physical and vital evolution, but his future mental and spiritual destiny and his place in the cycles of Nature (Sri Aurobindo, 1973, p. 56).

In order for organizations to create a healthy balance in the employee–organization relationship, the order of the cosmos needs to be adhered to. Organizations today are, however, doing things in just the reverse sequence, groping and fumbling with newer slogans and dragging the society and people into more and more baffling predicaments. Therefore, we see today a rising horde of dealers and a dwindling tribe of leaders. Leadership in contemporary organizations as well as in society is degenerating into dealership, which is perhaps the destiny of this epoch of ‘commerce’ or ‘*vaiśya yuga*’. Yet, it is enshrined in the traditional wisdom of the ancient scriptures that the *mantra* of business ought to be governed by ethical guidelines and the spirit of wisdom.

Let a man think well on wealth, and strive to win it
 By the path of law and by worship
 And let him take counsel with his own inner wisdom
 Grasp with spirit still greater ability (*Rg Veda*)
 (As quoted in R. Tagore, 1988, p. 81)

Drawing from and building on this learning, it is suggested that wisdom leaders in organizations, or any other field, need to be furnished with an orderly, inward, subjective foundation through an integral framework. In this framework, wealth is not disparaged but is firmly anchored within the order of the cosmos and the same should govern human society. Viewed in this context, the key issue would be to create organizations in which a continuity of human values is possible, and in tune with the cosmic order. The values must be based on the principle of having emotional life processes and states that make the person more ideally and fully human. These values should underpin and guide choices and decisions, and direct the intellect towards methods of executing and implementing such choices. These values, clearly, will not be those states or things that human beings and organizations are presently pursuing, for example, individual freedom, expensive consumer goods, high market share, high credit rating, greater productivity and so on. The term 'human' implies that we are not dealing with an objectified economic, commercialized, scientific, technological and political value system, but with the subjective value system of human beings devoid of disguise, cloak or label. Besides, the connotations of being human here are not confined merely to the humanistic worldview, but also include an overarching spiritual meaning that addresses cosmic concerns. It is not anthropocentric. Therefore, creating an organizational design based on truly human values is imperative for the designing of more humane organizations. In such organizations, the core human values would be cooperation, forgiveness, intrinsic relationships, internal wholeness, duty, consciousness and self-development, rather than competitiveness, self-interest, self-projection, instrumental relationships, vindictiveness, insistence on one's rights and needs.

System-and structure-oriented organizational designs, though praiseworthy, often lack a holistic perspective, as noted in the fractured existence of people working in these organizations. They also seem to miss out on the true objective of individual life and organizational goals as well as in the making of an egalitarian society and, even more, an evolved culture. It is asserted that the human side of an enterprise would originate in the subjective realm. The cleaner, the purer and the more internally autonomous it can be for each employee, the better chances it will offer to employees in delivering true and sustainable benefits and achieving a sense of well-being.

If the twenty-first century is to see sustainable efforts in making organizations more employee-friendly, offering them the continuities of life processes in the personal domain, we must realize that succumbing or surrendering to the economic model of man is self-defeating. It is making life more and more fragmented. It is at our peril that we evade engagement with such trans-empirical and psychological

theories and continue to intensify the dehumanizing of organizations, wherein employees experience increasingly fragmented relationships.

Indian organizations have been examined by researchers for their value preferences at the workplace (Hofstede, 1980; Trompenaars, 1993). The common strand emanating from these studies is the importance of hierarchy, power distance and relation dependence. Other characteristics of Indian organizations that are much talked about are their collective orientation and their strong focus on the family as the in-group. There are other pan-Indian features of culture such as the preference for personalized relationship and religious orientation. All the above is important for effective organization-building. The impact of cultural values is stated as employees' resistance to self-managed teams and organization. There are two underlying assumptions in creating such organizational features: the process of self-management on the lines of the cosmic order as espoused in the way *sva-dharma* (internalized sense of moral duties and obligations), and collaborative existence in day-to-day activities. These are crucial for rediscovering organizations in the Indian context with the objective of synthesizing personal life and organizational objectives. Since organizational reality requires individuals to have an interdependent approach to work and an ability to create rules for contingencies it would be imperative to look at typical Indian cultural values. This would increase the probability of synergy and creative problem-solving, resulting in timely innovations, new product development, quality improvement and customer service. True collaboration results when the consciousness of I, me and mine recedes into the background while the group purpose or task becomes the focus of the team members.

The contemporary problems in the organization-individual relationship are the result of fragmented thinking and the inability of our planners to accept our social and ecological inter-dependence. All goods and services are reduced to their monetary values and the social and environmental costs generated by economic activities are ignored. They are extraneous variables that do not fit into the economist's theoretical models. Corporate economists not only consider water, air and various reservoirs of the ecosystem as free commodities, but also the delicate web of social relationships that is severely affected by the continuing economic expansion. Private profits are being made at the cost of the public quality of life. There is a need to drastically redefine the basic concepts of the individual-organization relationship. There are enough examples of how these concepts were narrowly defined and have been used without their social and ecological contexts. The gross national product (GNP), which is supposed to measure a nation's wealth, is determined by indiscriminately adding up all economic activities associated with monetary values, while all non-monetary aspects of the economy are ignored. Social costs, those of accidents, litigations and healthcare, are added on as positive contributions to the GNP rather than being subtracted. Ralph Nadler said, 'Every time there is an automobile accident the GNP goes up.' It is speculated that those social costs may be the only fraction of the GNP that is still growing. In the same vein, it is crucial that the concept of wealth must shed some of its present

connotations of capital and material accumulation and give way to a redefinition of human enrichment, and profit must be redefined to mean only the creation of real wealth, rather than private or public gain won through social and environmental exploitation. It must be understood at this juncture how the concepts of efficiency and productivity have been similarly distorted. Efficient for whom? Do they refer to the individual, the corporation, the society or the ecosystem?

Concluding comments

This brings me to a pure look at the entire arena of the corporation–individual relationship in a holistic rather than in a purely economic way. They force me to view it in a systemic way. This can be achieved by initiating a change to redefine the system itself, to restructure our economy by decentralizing it, by developing soft technologies, and by running the economy with a leaner mix of capital, energy and materials and a richer mix of labour and human resources. Such a resource-conserving, full employment economic order will also be non-inflationary and ecologically sound.

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Broadening of consciousness: A healing process among the survivors of the Kachchh earthquake

Kumar Ravi Priya

A massive earthquake, magnitude 6.9 on the Richter scale, hit Kachchh (a district in Gujarat state) on 26 January 2001 at 8.46 am. According to the Gujarat State Disaster Management Authority, 12,200 people died and several thousand were injured. The salient psychological, ecological and social conditions that threaten the well-being of the survivors of a massive earthquake may include the trauma of losing those near and dear to them, fear of aftershocks, the absence of basic necessities of life (food, shelter and clothes), fear of epidemics, the absence of means of livelihood, the emergence of varied cultural norms among the survivors (Acharya, 2000), the dehumanization implicit in taking compensation money (Scott, 2000; James, 2004), and the deformation of family and social support networks caused by the availability of compensation money (Parasuraman & Acharya, 2000).

I used the bio-psychosocial model, or the cultural psychological perspective of health and illness, and the ethnographic method to understand the phenomenon of suffering and healing under such a crisis situation in the post-earthquake period in Kachchh. In this chapter, I attempt to illustrate how the villagers' belief in *karma*¹ (internalized duty towards family, community and nature) aided the healing process by enabling them to transcend the boundary of the 'I' or the ego and making them realize that their selves were part of a pure and eternal consciousness. In other words, their belief in *karma* facilitated healing by 'broadening their consciousness'.² In this chapter, I first provide the perspective of health and illness on which this study was based. Then, after describing the ethnographic method employed in this study, I present and discuss the findings related to how the survivors' cultural beliefs shaped the healing process as a 'broadening of consciousness'. Finally, I also share some of my reflections on how carrying out this study has contributed to my growth as a person.

Cultural-psychological perspective on health and illness

The bio-psychosocial model of health and illness shows how cultural beliefs shape the suffering and healing experiences of people (Kleinman, 1988). First, the

meaning of a behavioural symptom and a sufferer's response to it are driven by implicit cultural beliefs. For example, in Western cultures, symptoms of illness are taken to be the outcome of lack of control over the environment (Sinha, 1990; Misra & Varma, 1999). Second, every culture has moral exemplars of how pain and loss should be borne. Not adhering to such culturally-prescribed behaviour may shape suffering as a moral form of agony. In a subsequent work, Kleinman, Das and Lock (2000) have shown that political, economic and institutional power ruins collective and inter-subjective connections and thus propagates alienation among sufferers. Indeed, alienation induced by structures forms another kind of suffering.

In accordance with the culture-sensitive conceptualization of terms in the domain of health and illness, 'suffering' may be understood as the experience of pain or agony, within its socio-cultural, economic and political context, which is assumed to be *shaped* by one's cultural belief system with regard to illness and health. Also, healing is conceptualized as gradual recovery from such an experience of pain or agony (Kleinman, 1980, 1988; Kakar, 1982; Stacy, 1988; Ramaswami & Sheikh, 1996). Palsane (1988, p. 7) indicates the roles of beliefs and customs of a culture in the process of suffering and healing, saying, 'The belief system based on tradition helps in immunization against suffering, and in adaptation to and acceptance of suffering with equanimity. The belief together with custom provides the necessary psychological strength in times of crises and also makes available social network resources.'

Kleinman (1988) points out that cultural beliefs orient a sufferer to the questions, 'Why me?' and 'What can be done?' This orientation initiates the healing process as a reconstruction of suffering. Depending on the cultural belief, the healing process leads the person either towards better control (primary or secondary) over the situation or towards harmony with nature. As far as moral suffering and alienation due to socio-economic forces are concerned, providing emotional space to the sufferer initiates the healing process (Kleinman, 1988; Pennebaker, 1991). The verbal expression of suffering within an authentic relationship often helps reinstate a sense of self in the person (Brison, 1997; Ellingson, 2001).

'Broadening of consciousness' as healing: What literature says

Literature on the healing process also points to the 'expansion' or 'reframing' of consciousness as another indication of healing. According to Dethlefsen and Dahlke (1995), transcending suffering means giving up the 'I' or the ego, for wholeness is attainable only when one finally stops dividing off one's 'I' from the rest of existence. Healing, thus, means getting closer to being 'whole'.

Several ancient Indian systems of thought have focussed on how healing begins once a person is aware of his wrong identification with 'I' or the ego. Health, or healing, is a way of life, according to this tradition, where one recognizes and endeavours to realize the true nature of the human being, that is, pure or cosmic consciousness.

The Sāṃkhya system postulates two distinct ontological categories: *puruṣa*, which is pure consciousness, and *prakṛti*, which Larson and Bhattacharya (1987, p. 23, cited in Paranjpe, 1998b) have termed 'primordial materiality'. Although conceived as a single category, the term *puruṣa* refers collectively to innumerable distinct centres of awareness, or individual 'souls'. The basic nature of *puruṣa* is sentience, or the capacity for experiencing objects and events. In and of themselves, *puruṣas* do not act; they are passive witnesses to what goes on in the domain of *prakṛti*. The characteristic of *prakṛti* is to be the object of experience or 'enjoyment' (*bhoga*) for the *puruṣas* and thereby bind them within its domain, and to release (*apavarga*) them from its bonds so that they can remain in the ideal state of 'isolation' (*kaivalya*). *Prakṛti* comprises of three continually interacting components or 'strands' (*guṇas*), namely *sattva* (intelligibility, 'enlightenment' or lightness), *rajas* (activity, energy) and *tamas* (inertia, resistance, darkness). These strands continually supersede one another; one dominates while the others recede, thereby accounting for the constant changes in the domain of mind and matter.

According to Sāṃkhya tradition, *puruṣa* may mistakenly identify itself with the conditions of *prakṛti* and consider itself happy, sad or depressed, in accordance with the conditions of the three strands of which the mind and body are composed. As long as that mistaken identification continues, one experiences different kinds of affect—feeling happy for some time and sad or disturbed later, and back again, in endless cycles. However, it is definitely possible for the individual to use the inherent capacity for knowledge or correct discrimination and to realize that true selfhood involves being the uninvolved witness, as *puruṣa* is in its nascent state. After this insight, *puruṣa* returns to its nascent condition beyond the ever-changing domain of *prakṛti*, never again to return to the sorrowful experiences of mundane life.

Thus, as Paranjpe (1998b) points out, it is implied that the end of suffering means going beyond pleasure and pain, happiness and sadness. It is the ideal state of 'isolation' (*kaivalya*). After his death, the individual doesn't return to the cycle of birth and death as he has attained release from *saṃsāra*, the wheel of life and death.

The monistic (*advaita*) school of Advaita Vedānta shares the similar goal of attaining 'self-realization', as observed in the Sāṃkhya and Yoga traditions. However, while both, the Sāṃkhya and the Vedānta systems, maintain that the Self is beyond pleasure, Advaita Vedāntists view it as blissful in nature.

The Vedānta tradition emphasizes that pleasure and pain, happiness and misery are a result of cognitive reconstruction, and so is the ego, which is usually mistaken for the true Self. If one performs meditation as prescribed by this tradition, the ego is cognitively deconstructed. When it is realized that the true Self does not believe itself to be a knower and agent, there is no one left to do something, to know whether the results are good or bad and thereby feel pleasure or pain.

In the Buddhist tradition, too, desire is viewed as a source of stress for several reasons (Evans, 1998). First, as in the *Vedāntic* tradition, it contributes to dualism

between the self and the object of desire. Instead of seeing the transcendence of the self with other persons and the natural order, desire sets up a false dichotomy of self and possessions of the self. Not only does this dualism make it hard to appreciate the source of one's suffering, it also creates suffering since desires become self-perpetuating—one can always find more money, more food, more beauty etc. In this tradition, desire in itself is not necessarily a problem. Desire, but without attachment to its objectives, helps unlock overdependence on sensory stimuli by enabling a person to respond to pleasure and pain with equanimity.

Apart from acquiring an attitude of *equanimity*, Mahāyāna Buddhism provides the concept of *mindfulness* (Sattler, 1998). Mindfulness is becoming aware of how the law of cause and effect functions. Everything we encounter is caused by our former actions. These, in turn, affect the present situation, so we do not look for causes for our *karma* and situation other than in our own past actions. This minimizes our projecting of guilt on others, reduces stress between each other, and encourages mindful behaviour. With this realization, we may expand on these thoughts by becoming aware of all the countless beings we may have related to in our countless lives. As human beings, we depend materially and spiritually on other beings' kindness. By gratefully remembering their kindness, we are moved to repaying it through developing *bodhicitta* (the mind of the enlightened) to help all beings.

It is important to note that Sinha (1990) points out that the belief in *karma* and fate and an attitude of acceptance have their basis not only in the religious-philosophical tradition but also in the nature of the physical environment and the climate that characterizes the Indian subcontinent. Many studies carried out to understand the attribution of illness in India and the Indian subcontinent have revealed *karma* and/or other metaphysical beliefs such as God's will and fate as causal factors for illness or disability (Naidu, 1986; Ojha, 1986; Joshi, 1988; Desjarlais, 1994; Dalal, 2001;).

Before we try to understand how the survivors of the Kachchh earthquake were able to overcome the impact of trauma by the broadening of consciousness, here is the method used for this study.

Method

I adopted an ethnographic approach for this study. It was planned that 20 adult members³ of earthquake-stricken families (in which at least one death had occurred) in each of Selari Village and Bhachau town would be followed up in three phases (fieldwork of 45–60 days once a year over a period of at least three years). The rationale behind selecting these two research sites was that one being rural and the other urban, they differed in their community life and cultural beliefs and customs. Another rationale was the difference in the number of people they lost to the earthquake (thirty three in Selari and several thousand in Bhachau).

I began the fieldwork in November 2001 in Selari. Although I had initially participated in a rehabilitation programme (run by the University of Delhi in the areas of health, earthquake resistant housing, education etc.) as a volunteer, I had

to take up the role of a teacher in the high school at the village. Through the relationship I developed with the students there, it became possible to build trust with the villagers. Throughout the research process, the villagers considered me a resource person in education. Similarly, in Bhachau town, I began fieldwork as a volunteer at 'Child Line', an NGO. It helped me in getting connected with the affected families.

Participants

Of the 20 families that participated in all the three phases of the study at Selari village, 19 were Hindu families and 1 a Muslim family. Of the 13 survivors who were farmers, 5 had pump sets to use underground water for irrigation. The other 8 farmers were solely dependent on rainwater for irrigation. It may be noted that a 'good monsoon' that is 'sufficient' for cultivation comes to Kachchh once in every three or four years. Therefore, these families have to work in the fields of other farmers. Their poor economic condition sometimes leads them to borrow money. The 7 non-farmer families belonged to the lower socio-economic strata. Their traditional occupations were tailoring, sheep-rearing, manual labour and shop-keeping.

Among the survivors in Bhachau, 2 were Muslim and rest 31 were Hindu. They held a variety of occupations, including business, manual labour, government employment (teacher, engineer and water-motor operator) etc.

Data collection and analysis

The interviews were conducted in Selari and Bhachau, in family settings in which other family members also voluntarily shared their experiences. In Selari, one of the key informants, Sudhakar Bhai, helped the researcher by acting as a translator (Gujarati to Hindi and vice versa). The interviews in Selari were conducted during the evening hours, when the men in the family returned from work. In Bhachau, interviews with students were conducted in a school. In the first phase, interviews were tape-recorded; in the subsequent phases, notes were taken during interviews. The interview guidelines were:

1. What were the experiences and constructions of suffering and healing among the survivors?
2. What was the influence of cultural belief systems (about earthquakes, health, life and death) on the experiences and constructions of suffering and healing?
3. What was the role of social support networks (family, relatives, social groups and NGOs) in the healing process?
4. How did the socio-economic conditions influence the support networks and shape the healing process?

Besides the semi-structured interviews with survivors, focus group discussions and participant observations among the survivors and semi-structured interviews of key informants (journalists, social workers, creative writers etc.) were also conducted

in order to provide a holistic understanding of the suffering and healing process, utilizing different data sources through theoretical sampling.

I analysed the experiences of suffering and healing in the light of the cultural beliefs and constructions of health and illness, which is in accordance with the meta-theoretical framework of the bio-psychosocial model (or cultural psychological perspective of health and illness) adopted for this study. A combination of thematic analysis and constructionist grounded theory was utilized to analyse the narratives. The approach of constructionist grounded theory (Charmaz, 1995, 2001; Pidgeon & Henwood, 1997) also enabled me to recognize the influence of my perspective (of existential philosophy) and experiences on the development of themes and categories through an empathic understanding of the experiences of the survivors.

The following section presents constructions of health and illness among survivors in the village, which has been shaped by their belief in *karma*.

Constructions of health and illness in Selari village

The interview with Mansingh Baba (a priest of Selari village and one of the key informants) was of much value as it helped in gaining a better understanding of the phenomenon of suffering and healing.

When I asked him what he understood of the reasons for the suffering caused by the earthquake, he said,

According to me, the earthquake occurs because gases get accumulated inside the earth and it has to come out due to pressure. But the gases get accumulated inside the earth due to the result of our *karma* (one's duty towards oneself, family, community and nature). Tell me, who saved us (pointing towards himself and Amrit Bhai, the interpreter) from the earthquake? It was nothing but our *karma*. If people lead their lives according to *dharma* (principals of virtue)—and by *dharma*, I mean *mānava dharma* (humane religion), which is above all caste, religion and community—they will achieve *ānand* (joy). If they don't do it, they will suffer.

It was evident from the interviews of Mansingh Baba and the survivors that the notions of 'suffering' and 'healing' were constructed and experienced around *their* 'theory of *karma*', which centred on the following themes. [Themes (a), (b) and (c) emerged from the narratives of all the survivors, and theme (d) emerged from the narrative of a priest who was one of the key informants]:

(a) Exercising one's potentialities to the fullest

One of the survivors, Amba Bhai, while sharing his construction of *sukh* (health and/or happiness) and *dukh* (illness and/or sorrow), said, '*mānav dharma* says that we must do our *karma* by doing utmost labour we can to earn our livelihood to take care of our family and serve the society.'

Almost all the men in families where one or more deaths had occurred were back to work after a month or two. Among them were Naresh Bhai, Amba

Bhai, Kailash Bhai and Pravin Bhai, whose families had lost two or three of their members.

(b) Diffusion of boundaries between self and other 'beings'

Thus, action should be oriented towards the welfare of not only the self, but also the other 'beings' of nature.

In our interaction about how he construed *sukh* and *dukh*, Jayendra Bhai said, 'Our *karma* should be directed not only towards the welfare of our family and the poor but also towards the birds and animals which are a part of our living. I regularly give *bājra* (millet) to the birds.'

In this connection, it would be pertinent to take note of the common practice in the village of feeding birds, cows and other animals, apart from helping fellow human beings. This is not merely a ritual to be completed—several survivors (for example, Jayendra Bhai, Maya Ben, Nirmala Ben and Vira Bhai) expressed their serious concern with keeping animals fed. They said that such a practice gave them *santoṣa* (satisfaction) and *śānti* (peace of mind).

(c) Possessing just enough for a 'healthy', non-luxurious living

Amba Bhai told me,

The disasters like this earthquake take place due to the fact that we commit *pāp* (wrong deeds in violation of *karma*). Having plenty for myself and not bothering about the poor is 'not following my *karma*'. We should have only that much *dhan* (material possession) with which we can take care of our family members. The rest should be given to the needy people and be utilized towards the welfare of the society.

During the days of scarcity two or three days after the earthquake, despite being poor and suffering a death in the family, Vira Bhai distributed all of his stored *bājra* to the homeless. Paras Bhai, a farmer who had lost his 13-year-old daughter, built a bus stop in the village with the money he had received as compensation for her death.

(d) Forces of nature (that cause happiness and sorrow) are beyond human control

How much these forces oppress a human being depends on the nature and intensity of the wrong deeds of his/her past and present lives. Through exercising one's potentialities to the fullest in this life and living in harmony with the forces of nature, one can rise above these forces and merge with the *paramātmā* (the Almighty) to end the cycle of life and death.

The survivors had a firm belief that carrying out one's *karma* (which intricately relates one to family, society and nature through one's duties towards them) is the necessary condition for the attainment of *śānti* (peace of mind) despite one's experiencing *darad* or *dukh* (agony, pain, illness). *Karma* was taken as the key means of maintaining *śānti*. For example, a farmer, who was prevented from farming due to severe asthma, expressed his *śānti* as he was able to perform his duty of

‘guarding the house’. That *Karma* or *pravṛtti* is the only medium for *śānti* in their lives is captured well by the following saying:

*Bhūtkāl no bhuli jāo,
bhaviṣya ni chintā nahim karo,
vartmān mā pravṛtti karo.*

(Forget the past, do not worry about the future and perform your duties in the present.)

Let us now find out how their belief in *karma* aided healing through the ‘broadening of consciousness’.

Healing through ‘Broadening of Consciousness’: Some evidence

An analysis of the narratives provided certain themes about the healing process. They pointed out that (a) with their belief in *karma*, they could *re-organize their selves as a continuous process across time* and this process gave them new and positive meaning in life; (b) carrying out their *karma* (internalized duty towards self, family, community and nature) made them experience *śānti* (peace of mind or equanimity); and (c) the death of a loved one became an *inspiration for them to follow the path of karma*. These themes that show the healing process as a broadening of consciousness are presented and discussed below with verbatim accounts or my observations in their support.

Healing as reorganizing self as a continuous process across time

Survivors construed self as a continuous process across time by attributing their present condition of illness and health to performing *karma* in the past. Krishna Bhai, 38, who lost his 12-year-old daughter, said,

We are experiencing *dukh* due to our indulgence in *pāp* in the past or in *pūrv janm* (previous birth). In this life also, in the past, we committed *pāp* (sin or non-adherence to *karma*). For example, when the Kargil war⁴ took place, people of Kachchh didn’t give any financial support but, now in troubled time of Kachchh, people from outside have come to provide all kinds of support. I have decided that I am going to build a structure where animals like cows and birds can have some cereals to eat. Let us do something for others. What shall we take with us after we die?

Most participants in the focus group discussion also shared a feeling that the *pāp* they had committed in the past had led to the earthquake and the resulting *dukh*. One of the participants said, ‘Our *dukh* is a result of our own *pāp* that we committed by becoming selfish and not caring about poor and weak. If we carry out our *karma*, God will provide us with the strength to endure the difficulties produced by the earthquake.’

It was evident that their belief in *karma* had facilitated a *cognitive restructuring* of their state of loss. Almost all the men of those families where one or more deaths had occurred were back to their work after two to three months. Among

them were men like Naresh Bhai, Amba Bhai, Kailash Bhai and Rama Bhai, whose families had lost two or three members. All said that through their work, they attained some *santoṣa*, or satisfaction, that they were taking care of their families. Also, they considered their involvement in *karma* to be the only way to face and transcend *dukh*. Naresh Bhai said,

Dukh is there and it will subside only with time but our *karma* is in our hands which is the only *truth* or the *way out*. It is perhaps because of our *pāp* only that the family members have expired. Through doing our *karma* only, we may attain some *santoṣa* in present and in future.

It is quite clear that health for them is to 'move on' or to carry out their duties towards their families and the society, despite suffering the sorrow of losing their near and dear ones. Atwood and Maltin (1991, p. 375) have noted a similar pattern of healing among Easterners: 'The best way for [Easterner] patients to handle unpleasant feelings is to recognize them, to accept them, and to go about their business. In time, unpleasant feelings will pass Just as one cannot hold on to positive feelings forever, one cannot hold onto negative feelings forever. Feelings are temporary experiences.'

Omprakash (1989) points out that belief in *karma* has important psychological implications. These include an uncritical acceptance of misery and hope for a better life in the future through 'right' actions. The patterns of feelings and behaviours observed during the second and third phases of the study indicated that most of the survivors engaged actively in their daily activities. Even those farmers who had to depend solely on the monsoon worked hard in the agricultural fields of others (who could afford to have alternate means of irrigation) to earn their livelihood. They expressed a sense of satisfaction that they were able to earn.

Amba Bhai, a tailor, who suffered an injury in his pelvic joints, said that he had to work for double the hours he used to work before the earthquake because he had to get his sister married and repay the debt he had incurred. It is apparent that the belief in *karma* enabled the survivors to accept their suffering and move towards a *positive meaning in life*, which was to get involved in their work so that they could take care of their families.

Belief in *karma* is widely accepted as a causal explanation for suffering not only in the Buddhist and Hindu philosophical traditions (Radhakrishnan, 1926), but also among contemporary Indians (Sinha, 1990; Kohli & Dalal 1998). Also, as evident from the examples quoted above, it did provide a space for the survivors to reconstruct their loss and move towards a positive meaning in life.

Śānti through karma

The survivors expressed a strong sense of self located in relationships with family, society and nature by carrying out their internalized duties towards them. They also shared experiencing *śānti* or peace of mind or equanimity through carrying out their *karma*. Maya Ben, 48 years old, lost her husband in the earthquake and lives with one of her granddaughters in her house. She wanted neither to live with

her son, who does some business in Mumbai, nor tried to persuade him to stay with her in the village. She told us that while her son did all the rituals associated with his father's funeral and stayed with her for two weeks, she didn't ask him to stay back as she didn't want him to stay against his wishes. She told us,

My only son, who lives in Mumbai, calls me there feeling that I would be lonely here. But I do not like to leave this place. I have brought back one of my granddaughters from Mumbai and I look after her. Living in this place, I would be able to do some *punya* like, *sevā* or service to animals, birds, cows and poor people. Living here, doing this gives me *śānti*.

Vira Bhai, 52 years old, and respected in the village, lost his mother in the earthquake. He said,

Due to health reasons, I am unable to go to the field and work hard. Therefore, I stay back at home, guard and manage it. All the rest in the family, my children and my wife are there in the field to contribute to farming. *Dukh* has reduced among them too. *Śānti chhe* (I have peace of mind).

Through their belief in *karma*, survivors experienced *śānti* as they could reorganize (or meaningfully define) their selves in harmony with their family members, community and nature. In some cultures, as in Selari village, a harmonious relationship with other human beings and nature is considered important in order to experience positive health. For example, Torsch and Ma (2000) found that among elderly Chinese-Americans, 'inter-personal harmony' was regarded essential to healthy living. Inter-personal harmony was characterized as caring for others, sharing among people and maintaining a strong family system. Pachuta (1996) emphasized that healing in the Eastern system is *circular*, that is, the universe as well as the individual can be conceived of as a circle that contains every explicit duality as an implicit unity; where oneness with the universe is a given, and one continually seeks balance and harmony within this oneness. Jensen and Allen (1994) noted that 'wholeness' with the world is associated with the experience of health. Similarly, Tolle (2003) emphasized that every form of existence in the cosmos is intricately related. One cannot understand what role a seemingly senseless event may have within the totality of the cosmos, but recognizing its inevitability within the vastness of the whole can be the beginning of an inner acceptance of what *is* and thus a realignment with the wholeness of life. Thus, a socio and eco-centric health belief may help reorganize one's self within a harmonious relationship with some form of existence (family, society or the entire cosmos).

Lewis-Fernandez and Kleinman (1994) and O'Neill (2004) have pointed out that in some cultures, cultural beliefs of health and illness are based largely on a socio-centric ideology, that is, the experience of suffering and healing are situated in the networks of social relationships. Similarly, survivors' belief in *karma* is one such socio-centric cultural belief that also locates one's experiences of suffering and healing in relationship with one's society and ecology. Also, it is generally believed that in the Indian cultural tradition, no sharp boundaries are drawn between the individual and his environment. A healthy individual is one who has a

harmonious relationship with the community, surroundings and the supernatural world (Sinha, 1990; Paranjpe, 1998b).

Departed family member as an inspiration to performing one's karma

Some survivors also shared their feeling a sense of self through carrying out their internalized duties towards family, society and nature out of an inspiration gained from the death of a family member. It was evident in the case of Paras Bhai, a 42-year-old farmer who owned a *sūkhī khetī* (farmland completely dependent on rainwater) and who lost his 13-year-old daughter.

Paras Bhai, being a manual labourer, had received Rs 80,000 as compensation for her death. I was filled with a sense of reverence for him when I came to know that he had added Rs 20,000 to this amount and had spent the entire sum in rebuilding the village bus stop, which had been severely damaged in the earthquake. He told us that he had not earned the compensation money, and therefore didn't want to use it for himself. And since the money was associated with the death of his daughter, he wanted to spend it on a good cause. He said, 'My daughter Fuli Ben was very dear to me. She is no more (physically) with me but she still inspires me to do my *karma* which is meant to do good to all the people around us. So, she has inspired me to build this bus stop.'

In the third phase of our interaction, Paras Bhai reiterated the change in his approach to life that was brought about by the death of his daughter. He said,

The death of my beloved daughter showed to me that our lives and those of our loved ones won't last for ever. Therefore, whatever time we have in this world, we must try to do whatever we can for the society and humanity. That is real *prem* (compassion). Building the bus stop for the village is a small step in that direction.

As maintained in various traditions of Indian thought (Sāṃkhya-Yoga, Advaita Vedānta, Buddhism etc.), we are not merely bodies or minds: we are a part of, or a manifestation of, a cosmic or pure consciousness (Evans, 1998; Paranjpe, 1998a; Sattler, 1998). A crisis situation like the death of a loved one may, besides inducing a sense of loss, lead to the realization that the sense of loss is because of the belief that we exist only as bodies or minds. Once we realize that we exist as a manifestation of a higher or pure consciousness, we may experience that, irrespective of existing or not existing as bodies or minds, we are *one* as we are the manifestations of *one*. And this experience or realization may be an inspiration that enables us to devote our lives to contributing (or doing our *karma*) to harmony among all beings of nature. This inspiration is reflected in the above-mentioned case of Paras Bhai.

Ramesh Bhai, a 45-year-old businessman in Bhachau town, lost his 38-year-old wife and 14-year-old son in the earthquake. Although he didn't belong to a village and shared a health belief based on *karma*, he considered himself and his loved ones as part of a larger 'process' or consciousness that is continuous over time. That is probably why for him his departed family members became a source of inspiration to do something positive in life by looking after his daughters. He and his surviving daughters, in their constant struggle against standing losses and

fighting the discrimination by authorities, had apparently accepted their trauma. They wrote the following couplet below the photographs of their departed family members:

*Tame āwyā nahotā kain
thodā ghanā varas laine
tame to jāwso hṛdaymā
bhavo bhavni taras laine*

Couldn't you come (to this earth)
for some more years?
You shall remain in my heart making me long deeply
(for your physical presence) for eras to come.

Ramesh Bhai said, 'This couplet is a mark of what they (the departed souls) mean to us. They are still a part of our existence and give us strength to face this difficult time and that is why they will be missed.'

When I met him again in the third phase, he looked much calmer and more active. He told me that he had got one of his daughters married and was planning to get another daughter married within a year.

The themes outlined above indicate that healing may be considered a process of broadening of consciousness which enables a person to think of all forms of existence as manifestations of a higher consciousness (continuous over time and space). And the death of a loved one may, in fact, provide an opportunity (despite a feeling of loss) to experience "being a manifestation" of that higher consciousness. It is also evident from these themes that such a realization leads one to act towards the harmony or well-being of all beings of nature, which provides a person the experience of equanimity (*śānti* or *santoṣa*).

Reflections: How I felt 'expanded'/harmonized during the research

In the 'Method' section, I had mentioned that my own subjectivity as a human being was also affected during the process of data collection and analysis. Qualitative methods do accept and provide space to the idea that we, as researchers, cannot remain 'neutral' to or detached from the process of research. I must share with the reader that my inclination towards existentialism did shape the coding process, which made the patterns in the narrative intelligible. It is evident from a theme such as, how a crisis situation re-affirmed the survivors' belief in *karma* with which they could *re-organize their selves as a continuous process across time* and how this process gave them new and positive meaning in life. Besides this, the fact that I could empathize (to whatever extent possible) with the experiences of loss of some of the survivors also lent meaning, or authenticity, to the coding process. Besides aiding to the authenticity of analysis, an empathic understanding of the survivors' experiences also became for me a harmonizing experience of painful personal experiences of the past and the present that were revived in the process of research.

During the first phase of the study in Selari village, I recall sitting in the house of the middle-aged, childless Nirmala Ben, whose husband had died in the earthquake. An *ex-sarpanch* (a relative of hers) and Sudhakar Bhai (my interpreter) were sitting with me. After speaking with the *ex-sarpanch* about whether she had received compensation, I tried to initiate an interaction with her by asking her about the work that she was doing. After a silence of about two minutes, she slowly said something that I took to mean, 'Something ... I do something.' Then tears came in her eyes and none of us spoke for more than 10 minutes. With tears in our eyes, I indicated to Sudhakar Bhai to tell her to rest, and that we would come again. She responded that we would have to take tea, which she then went to make. The intensity and nature of the pain that that single sentence of Nirmala Ben contained was far greater than any pain I have faced till now in my life. It was extremely difficult for me to empathize with the pain she was feeling. Her sorrow and her silence made me feel once again the grief and loneliness that I had felt when my mother was seriously ill (and had to be hospitalized in a different town) following the death of my eldest brother in 1982. I was five or six years old then. I do not remember crying, but I can still feel the loneliness and the peculiar sense of 'meaninglessness' associated with that time.⁵ My interaction with Nirmala Ben made me realize the 'littleness' of my suffering in life.

I was, however, happy to see Nirmala Ben in Phase II of the study, when she was managing her life in a much more positive way by regularizing her daily routine, which consisted of worshipping, rendering services to a priest, Mansingh Baba, and organizing religious activities such as *satsaṅg*. In line with what Ellingson (2001) said, this participatory research also provided me the space to positively and compassionately re-experience my own trauma while empathically relating with Nirmala Ben's suffering.

Having met and interacted with Vira Bhai and Paras Bhai (who contributed towards the well-being of others while themselves being in crisis), I was filled with reverence for them. I realized that I too was in search of a positive meaning in life. It was probably that search that led me to the earthquake-affected area in expectation that the survivors would also move towards some positive meaning in life after the crisis. I could empathize with them when they said that they experienced *śānti* by carrying out their duties towards family and society. I, too, had a harmonizing experience—that of being able to contribute towards the healing of traumatized people by providing them, to the best of my ability, with emotional space through our interactions.

Endnotes

- 1 In this study, although I found the belief in *karma* to be quite prevalent in Selari village, some urban survivors too shared their realization of the temporariness of worldly objects and activities. Furthermore, their action (for example, nurturing younger ones to give a new meaning to life) showed a commitment towards

- contributing whatever they could to nature's "beings". So, in some of the urban survivors, too, I observed a tendency to transcend the boundary of their 'I'.
- 2 Although in this paper I have written about how the metaphysical beliefs of the survivors made healing possible, I also found that healing was rare among those survivors who held on to materialistic beliefs. Particularly in the urban setting, I found threatening post-earthquake socio-economic events (e.g., development of the boundaries of caste and class) that were impeding the healing process, as there the individualistic lifestyles and materialistic notions of health and illness disabled them from positively re-constructing their sorrow. I have reported these findings elsewhere (see Priya, 2004).
 - 3 These participants are referred to as 'survivors' throughout this paper. Because of ethical concerns, the names of these survivors and other key informants that have been reported are not their original names.
 - 4 'Kargil war' is a popular term given to an Indian Armed Forces' military operation in 1999 in the state of Jammu and Kashmir to drive out infiltrators from Pakistan who had crossed the Line of Control into India. These infiltrators had constructed bunkers in the Indian state of Jammu and Kashmir from where they waged a mini-war on the Indian armed forces.
 - 5 It took my mother almost a year to recover from meningitis and another year to completely recover from the loss of memory resulting from the disease and its treatment.

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14

Resolution of social conflicts: An Indian model

Raghubir Singh Pirta

Introduction

Human social conflicts have both an evolutionary and a cultural past. However, changes in inner (intra-psychic) and outer (inter-personal/environmental) contextual features drastically affect the nature of conflicts as well as their resolution. A conflict arises when two activities are incompatible. It may occur within the individual, when it is termed an intra-psychic conflict. However, more important for our purpose are those conflicts originating from the incompatible belief systems of two or more groups. The resolution of these social conflicts depends on the consonance among the cognitive beliefs. Consider the following examples.

When India was facing the challenge of independence and was fraught with turmoil and social conflict, Sri Aurobindo (1998, p. 90) envisaged taking up the essence of all religions and gathering these streams into

one mighty river, one purifying and redeeming Ganges, pour it over the death-in-life of a materialistic humanity as Bhagirath led down the Ganges and flooded with it the ashes of his fathers, so that they may be a resurrection of the soul in mankind and the Satyayuga for a while return to the world.

There is yet another important dimension, which includes conflicts between individual and collective interests. These are called 'social dilemmas' or 'social traps', and generally include conflicts between individual and collective preferences embedded in the environment. The ecologist Madhav Gadgil has explored such social conflicts in the institution of local deities in the villages. He writes, 'One often finds associated with such deities a rich body of folklore which can illuminate the history of human groups that worship these deities. Such folklore can be particularly fascinating when it appears to have its origin in conflicts of interests amongst the different human groups' (Gadgil, 2001; p. 164). These two perspectives, the first that of a philosopher and the second of an ecologist, are important in understanding the conflicts involving people in Indian villages.

It seems strange that in India, psychologists have never been especially interested in either Indian mysticism or the material issues troubling Indian people. However, several contemporary thinkers (Sarala Devi, 1982; Chidananda, 1991;

Thakar, 1999; Chaitanya, 2000) have observed that this development was perhaps not in consonance with the Indian psyche. According to the Nobel-winning economist Amartya Sen, the process of development has various aspects that should be evaluated in the context of the well-being of people. If we see the elements constitutive of well-being rather than the utilitarian elements, 'much of the task that Nehru had identified remains largely unaccomplished' (Sen, 1997, p. 5). The constitutive elements signified a view of a 'mental state', whereas utilitarian elements signified the 'desire-fulfilment' aspect (Sen, 1999). In the latter, utility is achieved through the objective realization of the 'desired state', while in the former it is achieved through some 'mental state'.

A very significant aspect of human social conflicts is that they are embedded in culture. Western material culture evolved in towns and cities, while Indian culture has its origins in the small village communities of the forests. Material science is therefore of little use to the villages of India, where most of its people live, unless it is assimilated into the indigenous culture. This was a point of discord between Gandhi and Nehru (see Mitrany¹) at the time of Indian independence. However, even more important is the premise of the famous poet Rabindranath Tagore (1986) that the origin of culture in the forest is the basis for the uniqueness of the land known as *Bhāratavarṣa*. Isolation in dense forests made people turn their minds inward in search of the infinite mysteries of the world. This inward quest is the typical method through which people who make their discoveries in the *tapovans* acquire knowledge.

In the first half of the twentieth century, Mahatma Gandhi successfully tested an ancient discovery, 'the law of non-violence', through his inward quest (Pyarelal, 1959). The use of non-resistance as a method of resolving conflict has been validated in the naturalistic observations of Kropotkin (1914) and Lorenz (1976), who are well-known for their explorations of how the laws of the jungle maintain peace in animal societies.² For psychologists, there is more to explore in Gandhi's unusual experiments; consider, for example, Bandura's (2001) study of how non-violence can be an effective method for enhancing self-efficacy.

Whether the theory of the 'idiocy of village life' carries any weight in India is a contentious issue, and the noted historian Kosambi (1975, p. 16) asserts that the self-contained village provided 'the material foundation for Indian culture and civilization'. He feels that Indian society has developed more through successive religious transformations (and associated philosophical developments) than through violence.

The people of India have a profound spiritual affinity with the river Ganges, the legendary Bhāgīrathī. And their deep cultural association with the Himalayas as a numinous sacred landscape is also well-known. But over the past several decades, the Ganges and the Himalayas have faced the onslaught of rapacious and destructive policies under the guise of essential development. These activities have had an extremely detrimental effect on the living landscape and its inhabitants. Not only have native residents of the Himalayas been deeply affected, but so also have others in distant places. According to thinker Vidyanivas Misra, this

is noteworthy, and the important question is not 'who does the Ganga belong to, but who belongs to the Ganga' (Misra, 1995a). In order to be of the Ganga, it is not material ownership that has a bearing, but the assimilation of the Ganga's rich cultural identity and the determination of our own identity from the Ganga (Misra, 1995b). Through this framework, he has probably resolved the dilemma of some social psychologists about emic and etic approaches (see G. Misra & Gergen, 2002), while introducing the concept of cultural relativism.

One way to achieve cultural sensitivity is through grassroots resistance movements. The idea emerges from two opposite streams—the American social psychologist Kenneth Gergen³ and the Indian thinker V. Misra (1995b). This way of resolving social conflicts is no different from the affirmative action that *Chipko* social workers took in the 1970s in the Himalayas, which we will soon explore more fully.

The indigenous model

This section describes an indigenous approach towards resolving social conflicts. Our context will be the processes of development currently underway in the Himalayas. In this approach, there is an inherent awareness of the sustainability of life. Besides the physical and environmental aspects, our approach encompasses the social, psychological and spiritual aspects of life, all of which are deeply rooted in the Hindu world-view. The main concepts of the indigenous model will also be related to those found in mainstream psychology.

A note on methodology

This is a qualitative account of people's cognition which follows a holistic approach; therefore, a short note on methodology should suffice. The study involves the people of the tiny kingdom of Garhwal in the western Himalayas. After independence, it was merged with Uttar Pradesh, and is now a separate state, Uttarakhand. A holistic point of view guided the author's explorations into people's thoughts, feelings and actions. Next, an attempt was made to articulate the native understanding of the world through a model of holistic development. A significant fact is the author's involvement in this struggle for over 25 years (Singh, 2001). Thus, this account includes the author's reflections and experiences as a participant-observer. The author strongly identified with the people while joining them in foot marches, attending their meetings, giving interviews on their behalf, speaking for their cause at seminars and writing about their problems. Furthermore, his own experience as a native of the western Himalayas helped him to experience all of this from close range.

An overview of the Chipko movement

Since independence, a large-scale intensification of two development activities, dam-building and clear-cutting, has been taking place in the western Himalayas, with planners showing scant regard for an integrated vision of life. All this has

happened with total disregard of the aspirations of the native people, making a mockery of their holistic approach to development.

To really understand the spirit of this social movement, we must visualize the situation in the Garhwal Himalayas in the late 1960s and early 1970s, when the folk poet Ghanshyam Sailani was struggling along with his compatriots to resolve a deep conflict. For many years, forest policies had been a matter of dispute in the Himalayan region and the healthy, symbiotic relationship between the local people and their forests was beginning to rupture. By the 1970s, the trouble was so bad that forests became almost inaccessible to the poor local folks, while a few wealthy contractors from the plains managed to lay their hands on the forest produce of their choice. The scale of denudation of the Himalaya by contractors, facilitated by government policies, was so enormous that the sacred landscape began to die.

Perceiving the helplessness of the local people and the disregard of the government, the deeply wounded folk poet seemed to almost foresee the next turn of events. His insightful solution to the impending threat on the lives of trees and the local folk was written in a poem at midnight. The message of the poem was very clear; there was a call for collective action, '*Hug the trees, don't let them be cut*'. These words, uttered by Ghanshyam Sailani⁴ in 1972 during a period of social turmoil truly touched the hearts of the people.

The following years bore witness to the Chipko (hug-the-tree) movement in action, which the poet later declared as 'the War of Dharma'. In this way, an apparently selfish struggle for survival after getting embedded in the indigenous spiritual context took a new turn. This chapter explores the features, dynamics and outcome of this movement—an unusual socio-cognitive invention—a non-violent struggle for justice and sustainability in the Himalayas.

The people of the Garhwal Himalayas became aware quite early of the impending ecological crisis in the Himalayan region. As mentioned above, in the 1970s some local social workers picked up strands from the cultural heritage of India and neatly wove a grassroots environmental campaign known as the Chipko (hug-the-tree) movement (Bahuguna, 1974; Sarala Devi, 1980; Kunwar, 1982). Chipko had its origins in the environmental desecration of the Garhwal Himalayas, which was characterized by large-scale logging operations managed by private contractors, as previously stated. The villagers revolted against the logging policies of the forest department since it made their lives much more difficult and complicated. A hawk and dove conflict ensued. The doves, or native Garhwalis, engaged in a contest with the hawks, the government, by following a non-violent method of protest to save their forests from the axe of the contractor. In this unique, unprecedented game, the doves won the contest. The message of this non-violent struggle of the brave Garhwali people spread to distant parts of the world. The Man of the Trees, Richard St. Barbe Baker, was among the first to pay tribute to the thousands of Garhwali men and women by visiting their far-flung villages (Baker, 1982).

The people of Garhwal applied this non-violent method of resistance to those policies of the government that flouted the basic principles of sustainable development. The first phase of the environmental movement, devoted to the protection

of Himalayan forests, continued from the 1970s up to the 1990s. During this period, the social workers of Chipko not only helped to foster an environmental consciousness, but also convinced the government to make a drastic change in its forest policy. The Government of India announced a 10-year moratorium on the felling of green trees in the Himalayas in 1983. The moratorium was reviewed in 1993, but the ban has continued.

During the transition period, approximately from 1985 to 1990, it appeared that the Chipko social workers may have lost interest. However, some of them soon started a new struggle to save the entire ecosystem and culture of the mountains. This new campaign was called Himalaya Bachao Andolan, or Save Himalaya Movement. The main objectives of this movement have been to stop the construction of big dams in the Himalayas and to generate electricity from small hydroelectric projects. The Ganga-Himalaya Kuti (near the upcoming 260.5m high wall of the Tehri Dam in the Garhwal Himalayas) became the centre of the non-violent protest against the aggressive development policies being implemented in the Himalayan region. As planned, the impounded water engulfed the Ganga-Himalaya Kuti in December 2001; however, the spirit of the non-violent struggle remains alive.

Other social workers involved with Chipko have continued their efforts to save the ecosystem of the Himalayas. Some in the Henwal Ghati who had also participated in Chipko have chosen to save the traditional varieties of crops grown in the Himalayan region (Prasun, 1996). Social workers in Gopeshwar and Kumaon have continued their efforts to save the green cover of the hills in various novel ways, including eco-development camps and the publication of a journal, *PAHAR*. Besides these workers, people from every walk of life and from all over the world have at times been involved in Chipko. The major achievement of the Chipko leaders has been to reach the masses directly, through popular media, by publishing small booklets in Hindi narrating the success stories and providing instances of environmental catastrophes.

The Chipko movement has attracted the attention of social scientists from all over the world. One after the other, researchers have climbed the hills of the Garhwal Himalayas and returned with a different story of the Chipko (Shiva & Bandyopadhyay, 1986; Weber, 1988; Berreman, 1989; Guha, 1989; Rangan, 2001). There can be no doubt about the academic excellence of these stories; however, it is unlikely that they have helped in the real cause—the ‘upliftment’ of the local population and the sustainable development of their precious environment. Although some of the authors of these accounts became ‘renowned environmentalists’ (for a self-appraisal, see Rangan, 2001), the people are still ‘natives’ for them, unable to comprehend their Western analytic finesse. This raises a second but more relevant question. Are we really trying to understand and honour the viewpoint of the local people? These academic storytellers have analysed the role of the local people with the untested propositions of other academics in the West. Those whom they study, on the other hand, have at least tested their propositions in the field of real life during their non-violent struggle.

The holistic model of development

The local people of the Garhwal Himalayas look at the developmental process holistically (see Figure 14.1). In their holistic thinking, the development of both the individual and the community is important. In their minds, the goal of the individual is to attain self-enlightenment through a way of life, one where there is harmony in one's knowledge, devotion and action. Following this path, if one learns that oak trees are good for the hills, one has to plant the oak species whenever there is an occasion to do so, and finally, one has to honour and even empathize with oak trees. One example of such integrated devotion, action and knowledge was Mira Behn. She inspired the Gandhians who later spearheaded the Chipko movement in the Garhwal Himalayas. She also saw in the oak (*banj*) tree the all-important link between the Himalayan ecology and the well-being of hill people (Mira Behn, 1978).

At the community level, sympathetic scientists, poets and writers, social workers and others of a compassionate nature should work towards the welfare and sustainability of all systems, living and non-living. Sarala Devi,⁵ another disciple of Gandhi, sacrificed her life for the people of the Himalayas. She ran a school for girls and also inspired and encouraged Sarvodaya workers to take up pro-environmental action. Those Sarvodaya workers were the forerunners of the Chipko Movement. They followed a holistic, sustainable approach to development and paid special attention to the cause of the poor. For instance, 'Bimla Behn and her husband Sunderlal Bahuguna, it will be remembered, chose to set up their ashram in the Simiyana valley because of the high concentration of harijans in that area' (Alter, 2002, p. 122).

The Garhwali people's understanding of development reminds modern man that his 'material development' is a path towards *vikṛti* (destruction). That this life is not intended to be a form of escapism should be clear from the call of Swami Chidananda, a *sanyāsin* and patron of the Chipko movement (Chidananda, 1987): 'We have to wake ourselves up and save the Himalayas and the Ganges'. There are deep spiritual (*Vedāntic*) roots to the Chipko understanding of nature, development and social action, and Chidananda (1991) explains that *prakṛti* has a dualistic nature. As a principle, it affects, or afflicts, *puruṣa*, and *yoga* has been especially developed to separate *puruṣa* from *prakṛti*. However, the phenomenal world in which we experience happiness and sorrow is also *prakṛti*, the Mother who sustains us all. Indeed, in this world, each person is instructed to follow a path that sustains life (*dharma*), pursue some economic means for day-to-day living (*artha*), participate in procreational activities (*kāma*) and work for the attainment of salvation (*mokṣa*).

Everyone has to engage in the *yajña*, the noble cause, of reviving our dying planet (Sarala Devi, 1982). We have to say 'Yes' to life and 'No' to death while following the path towards *saṃskṛti*, culture, characterized by qualities such as peace, happiness and fulfilment (Bahuguna, 1997). The hill people of the Himalayas are against those values that regard nature as a commodity to be exploited in the service of human greed and profit. In their world-view, the all-pervasive modern

way of life in which we have acquired enormous information (a big head) devoid of compassion (no heart), and where there is little scope for manual work (feeble hands), is the path towards *vikṛti* or destruction.

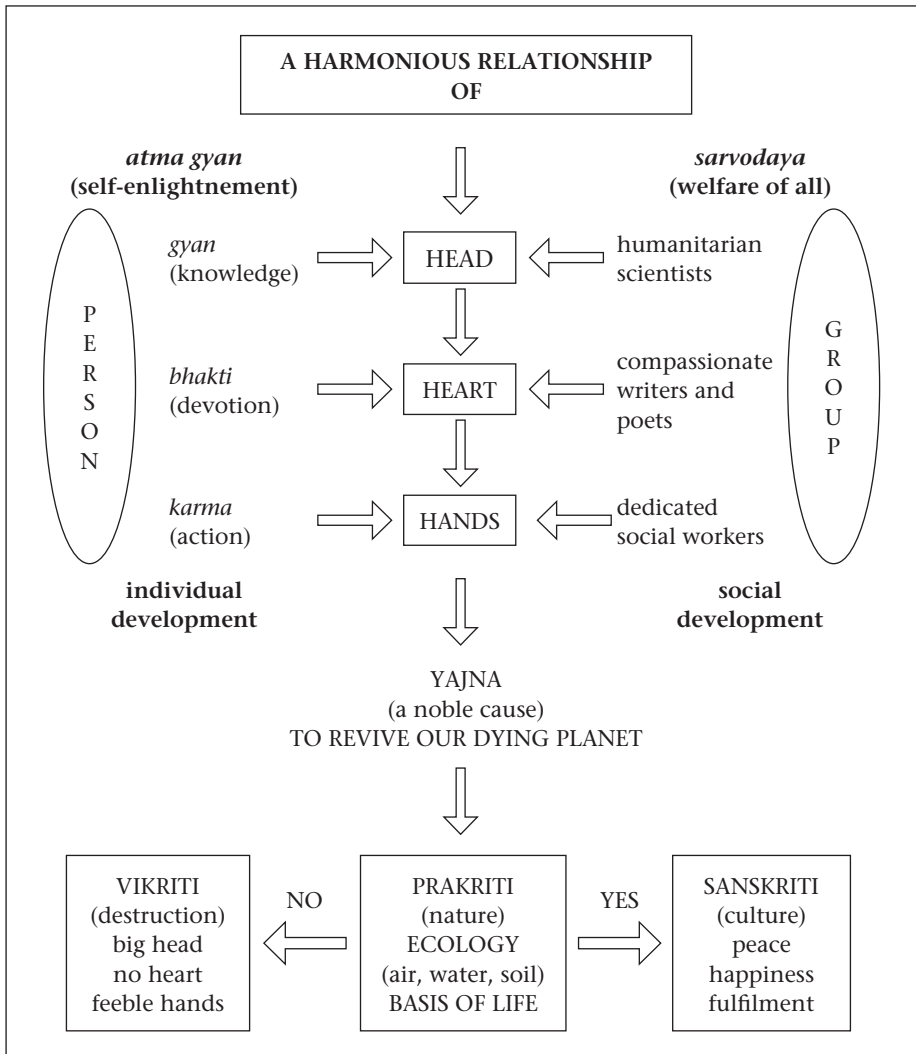


Figure 14.1: The indigenous model of sustainable development.
(Adapted from Pirta, 2003, 2005a)

The wisdom of the Himalayan people states that the very air, water and soil are the life-blood and main products of the forest, whereas for a silviculturist, the forest and timber exist only as a commodity to be sold for profit. And for the hill people, believing translates into doing. This phrase aptly describes the method of

the Chipko social worker in fostering environmental awareness. For example, the Chipko activist would show the rural masses slides of the denuded countryside in the hills, of depleted water sources, fodder scarcity, soil erosion, flooded rivers and more to explain the negative consequences accompanying the destruction of the forest. The images are accompanied by a commentary that blends information from scientific studies with the wisdom of ancient Indian traditions (Tikekar, 1988; Bandyopadhyay, 1992; Pirta, 1994, 2000; Bahuguna, 1996).

In this model of sustainable development, some concepts are used that need further explanation for them to be related to mainstream psychology. The following section deals with this issue. The author's intent is to suggest some broad relationships between native understanding and the apparently similar issues of behavioural scientists.

Implications for psychology

Earlier studies conducted by the author indicate some similarities between certain concepts in the holistic cognitive model and corresponding concepts in mainstream psychology (Pirta, 2003, 2004, 2005a). There appears to be a considerable parallel in the meaning of the concepts and the underlying processes. Some of those concepts and processes are harmony, holism, development, and the relationships between thinking, feeling and behaving.

In recent years, several points of convergence have been visible between the Eastern and Western views of the environment. One is the realization that there is a need for a radical change in the human relationship with nature. To build a new relationship with nature, a holistic approach is imperative—one that is partly spiritual in temperament (Chaitanya, 2000) and is open to the native wisdom of primal societies (Goldsmith, 1998). Deep ecology (Naess, 1989) is also a meeting point for Eastern and Western streams of thought. Another area of convergence is emerging from the acceptance of holistic relationships by biologists and physical scientists, evidenced in the widespread citings of Lovelock's Gaia Hypothesis (Bunyard, 1996). Gaia is the living and all-encompassing whole of the planet earth and its atmosphere. In India, people relate to *dharatī mātā*, the Mother Earth, in multitudinous ways (Tripathi, 2002). We may have to develop a new vocabulary to describe these holistic relationships, because science customarily uses fragmentary language to narrate these phenomena of nature. It holds importance for us because 'The Hindu mind is essentially synthetic. It always analyses a problem into its various aspects, and considers them in their synthetic relation to one another' (Sinha, 1986, p. xvii).

There is some evidence to support a similarity between the concept of harmony as proposed in the indigenous model and as it is used in some theories of psychology. Gestalt psychologists assert that interest in environmental psychology was stimulated by the suffocating experience of the urban environment, leading to the study of living more in harmony with nature (Ittelson, Proshansky, Rivlin & Winkel, 1974). At the micro level, we may find a similarity with the models of Gestalt social psychologists such as Heider and Festinger (Rock & Palmer, 1990).

Heider, in his principle of balance, proposes that individuals prefer harmonious cognitive relations. Along similar lines, Festinger's cognitive dissonance model hypothesizes that people seek to reduce inconsistencies in their beliefs, feelings and behaviours. We may also consider two examples where the need for exploring harmonious social relationships has led to the development of indigenous models of organizational behaviour in the Indian context (Gupta, Surie, Javidan & Chhokar, 2002; Batola, 2003). The primary reason suggested for these alternative models is the ineffectiveness of the materialist model of development in certain Eastern cultures. These investigators have independently found that a harmony of thoughts, feelings and actions is important in a variety of inter-dependent relationships within organizations. The importance of this has already been pointed out in relation to the indigenous model of development.

Our research on four issues related to environmental psychology and mental health provides evidence in support of the assertions derived from the local people's cognitive model. First, it may help us to understand pro-environment action in terms of thinking, feeling and behaving. It appears that the holistic approach of Chipko is likely to be more influential in creating environmental consciousness among people than other behavioural approaches (Goswami & Pirta, 2002). Second, it may be fruitful to examine the displacement of people due to the construction of big dams and their psychological rupture with the indigenous cognitive experience in conjunction with attachment theory (Pirta & Agrawal, 2003). Third, people tend to favour the humanistic approach characteristic of the holistic model rather than authoritarian policies in solving environmental problems (Pirta, 2005a). Fourth, holistic mental health programmes need to honour traditional healing systems, a trend indicated in our preliminary survey of mental health and its association with the institution of local deities (Pirta, 2005b).

Conclusion

In brief, the local people of the Garhwal Himalaya region, while resolving social conflicts, are engaged in a non-violent struggle, a *War of Dharma*, to save their forests and rivers, for ultimately these define their culture. The movement became known as the Chipko (hug-the-tree), which later transformed into a broad-based Himalaya Bachao Andolan. There are excellent alternate sources (previously cited) that provide general information and extensive analyses of this pioneering social movement of India. One must, however, be careful about the biases of those analysts regarding the social issues taken up by the movement and the actors involved in it, because their involvement was confined to the early phases of the movement. Also, the movement has so far escaped the scrutiny of psychologists and thus the author has articulated a psychologist's view-point—an indigenous cognitive model that has deeper psychological ramifications.

The Gandhians working in the Himalayas believe that the resilience of the local people is a cultural peculiarity resulting from their biological and cultural adaptation to the mountains of the Uttarakhand region. However, they also recognize

that various large-scale environmental interventions increase the vulnerability of people in the mountain ecosystem. This vulnerability varies in different sections of society and along the dimension of gender (Bahuguna, 1968, 1973; Sarala Devi, 1978, 1980; Kunwar, 1982; Bhatt, 1992; Mira Behn, 1993).

One consequence of these environmental and developmental changes in the Himalayas is probably associated with the psychological dimension of the allostatic systems of people migrating due to the pressure of external forces. A future study could integrate the vulnerability and resiliency approach of psychology (Charney, 2004; Ray, 2004) with the holistic approach described in this chapter, so as to understand the mental health of displaced populations. Migration is a global problem. The World Health Report 2001 on mental health mentions a huge accumulation of displaced persons away from their native areas. Moreover, the problem of displacement has several theoretically important issues for psychology. Two such issues pertain to the areas of affect and memory. For example, we use Bowlby's theory of attachment (Stroebe, Gergen & Gergen, 1992; Ciechanowski, Walker, Katon & Russo, 2002) to understand the psychological vulnerability of displaced people. Second, we are also interested in episodic memory (Tulving, 2002), especially the traumatic memories (Yehuda, et al., 1998) of people about their lost homes.

Furthermore, we are exploring the role played by the institution of local deities and their relation to the mental health of people. Many years ago, in a series of Gifford Lectures, Frazer (1926) explored the worship of nature in many parts of the world, including India. Nature worship remains a powerful force for the people in the Himalayas and has crucial significance for studies in man-nature relationships. For example, in recent times Kosambi (1975), a historian, Gadgil (2001), an ecologist, and Kakar (2001), a psychoanalyst, have explored deity worship in different parts of India in order to understand social, material and mental conflicts respectively. An open-minded psychologist (see Crook, 1997) would certainly find these culture-specific mental phenomena, for example possession by deities, quite interesting. On the other hand, it is difficult to understand the elitist attitude taken by some psychologists towards these 'little traditions' (worship of local deities), despite their being interested in consciousness studies, including parapsychology (Rao, 2001). At the same time, a lay person finds the relationships between people and their forest gods, water spirits, ghosts and demons full of psychological content (Singh, 2003). The indifference of mainstream psychology to such phenomena should not come in our way—we can join the social psychologist Kenneth Gergen in his resistance to the Western colonization of mental health. For all our politically correct agnosticism, it is undeniable that the local deities enrich the mundane lives of people and fill their understanding of the world with the awe of transcendent reality.

Endnotes

- 1 David Mitrany has discussed this conflict between the cognitive beliefs of two great leaders of India in the introduction to Pyarelal (1959).
- 2 These naturalistic studies inspired Pirta to undertake studies on two common Indian monkeys that have relevance to this issue (Pirta, 1990).
- 3 From Kenneth J. Gergen (n.d.) and personal communication through email in August 2005.
- 4 From the famous poem 'Chipko' written by the folk poet Ghanshyam Sailani on the night of December 12, 1972 (see Sunder Lal Bahuguna and Kunwar Prasun in a booklet published in the memory of this famous Garhwali folk poet who was born in 1934 and who died in 1997: 'Yad rhenge Sailani' published by Himalaya Bachao Andolan, Tehri).
- 5 Sarala Devi (Sarala Behn; Catherine Mary Heilman) and Mira Behn (Madeleine Slade) were European disciples of Gandhi, who chose Himalayas for their social work. They inspired local Gandhians like Sunder Lal Bahuguna, the prominent leader of Chipko Movement, and his wife Vimala Bahuguna (see Bahuguna, 1983).

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***Lālan-pālan*: A psycho-spiritual experience for the Indian mother**

Anjali Singh

Motherhood is a universal phenomenon and its concerns are common across cultures. At an apparent level, they are shared between a British, a German or an Indian mother so far as daily-life schedules of maternal behaviour are concerned. But there is an inner layer of consciousness involving a deeper experiential aspect which makes them distinct. To an Indian mother, motherhood tends to be a psycho-spiritual phenomenon. A mother represents Mother Earth, Mother Nature and the Mother Goddess. The experiences of the Indian child growing up in this milieu are explicitly rooted in this unique context. The entire process of bringing up a child in India is termed *lālan-pālan* in Hindi, and is quite different from the Western models of socialization.

Lālan-pālan primarily consists of instilling certain *saṁskāras* (subconscious habits) in the child, preparatory to the process of her/his developing into an ideal human being in the context of performing her/his duties towards family and society, and the long-term goal of self-realization. This involves not only the parent-child relationship as a nucleus, but engages the whole social ecology. The family members, kith and kin, and the community in which they are embedded all participate in an integrative fashion in the development and care of the child through a variety of social and spiritual practices, including customs, rituals, ceremonies and role relationships. The present chapter is an attempt to articulate how the indigenous views and cultural constructs operate and impact on the experiences and behaviours of mothers in a major segment of traditional Indian (Hindu) society.

Childhood in a cultural context

Contemporary scholarship in the field of human development often emphasizes that development is a contextual phenomenon, in the sense that the cultural setting within which an infant grows exerts a predominant influence on her/his emotional, cognitive and overall development. Ethnographic studies of specific

cultural practices illustrate the cultural differences in ideals of gender, conceptions of mature adulthood and stages of life. As Shweder (2003) observes, cultural symbols organize psychological phenomena by labelling and categorizing information and directing responses in particular ways, as well as by determining how we interpret the phenomena which together determine our experiences. For instance, in a study of parent/child sleeping patterns in different societies, it was noted that the cultural arrangements for sleeping stem from the moral concepts embedded in various cultures (Shweder, 1996).

The cultural grounding of various psychological phenomena is substantiated by their social origins. As Ratner (1991), using Vygotsky's socio-historical view, delineates, they are primarily social in two important respects: they depend on social experience and treatment, and they embody cultural ideals. According to Vygotsky, the way we conceptualize or understand an event determines our emotional reaction to it. Thus perception, memory, sensation, and many other psychological phenomena are culturally determined. The development of higher psychic functions shows that social experience is the most important psychological reality in child development. In an important sense, therefore, child development does not obey biological laws as animal development does; instead, it follows socio-historical laws.

The preceding framework of development, however, is constrained in its coverage as it does not attend to the spiritual dimension of human existence, which enjoys a taken-for-granted status in the construal shared by the masses in India. The Indian perspective on development treats humans as physical, social and spiritual beings, and the process of development has to attend to all these aspects. For example, (bringing in a wider spectrum of existence), the evolutionary framework of Sri Aurobindo encompasses all the lines of development (ontogenetic, phylogenetic, socio-cultural, microgenetic and cosmogenetic) (Gupta, 2004). This framework refers to the presence of a deeper psychic consciousness as the key to human evolution. One needs to move beyond the exploration of the emotional, vital and mental realms to the recognition of the true self, or the inner psychic being called *caitya puruṣa*. The psychic part of us is something that emanates directly from the divine and supports our outer mind, life and body. The psychic is an evolutionary entity which is further supported by the *jīvātman*, the pure, unborn, non-evolving spiritual Self. Thus, Sri Aurobindo's evolutionary perspective provides us with a framework that is wider and deeper in its conceptualization of the human being (Gupta, 2004).

In general, Indian and Japanese cultures stress the 'familial self' integrated with the 'spiritual self', with very little attention to the individualized self, unlike American culture. It is also important to note that in most contemporary research, the cultural dimension of individualism-collectivism is used to describe, explain and predict differences in psychological attributes and behaviour patterns. While individualist cultures tend to stress independence, autonomy in choice and action, self-reliance, uniqueness, achievement orientation and competition, collectivist cultures tend to emphasize social inter-dependence, a sense of duty towards one's

own group, connectedness, desire for social harmony, conformity with group norms and mutual deference as dominant values. Cultural differences also occur in parental attitudes and cognitions, which are related to the parents' personalities, particularly that of the mothers.

Studies highlighting cultural diversity suggest that each culture has its own set of beliefs and concepts regarding human development over the life span, for example childbirth, child-rearing practices, marriage, old age and so on, which inform the disparate experiential realities (Cruts, 1994). Every culture has its own needs and has evolved its own agenda. In Japan, people are largely devoted to collectivity and to the harmony of group identity. Japanese mothers expect emotional maturity, self-control and social courtesy in young children; they are indulgent in the early years and promote childhood virtues like patience, persistence and group accommodation. In contrast, in the US, child rearing is individualistic. The goals of socialization for an Indian child are general inter-dependence, and a deepening of relationships within the family (Seymour, 1976). Development is seen as a move forward towards inter-relatedness, awareness of the feelings of others and concern with fitting in, and the child is trained to clearly reflect the contextual importance of the culture. It is essential, therefore, to look at the salient features of Indian classical culture.

The context of the Indian (Hindu) family

In the Indian view, the child is seen as a pure, innocent, and amoral being. The concept of the 'child' is constructed around three axes. First, the child is seen simultaneously as a creation of the parents and a gift from God, the axis of human and divine. It assumes parents to be mere instruments through which the divine is realized. Second, the child is both a collective being and a unique individual—while the concept of karma emphasizes individuality, relationships with family and others emphasize the collective aspect. Third, there is an assumption that while the child is born with certain fixed unalterable propensities, many aspects of his initial nature can be transformed through *saṁskāras* and rituals—this is the alterable transformative axis. Thus, it is consistent with the idea that a person is a product of both spiritual and natural worlds. A child is thought to be born in the image of the divine. At the same time, it is to be moulded into a social being through a number of *saṁskāras* performed at different times during the life span. They mark the shift from one stage to another.

Religion is one of the most powerful influences on the lives of Indian people. The concept of religion as used in Hinduism is broad and incorporates life principles which are together called Dharma, and not merely rituals and institutional practices. Indeed, Swami Vivekananda (1964, p. 314) had observed that Indian social life is based on religion and spirituality. Hindu religion is primarily based on the *Vedas*, a large body of texts named after the knowledge or wisdom they contain. The *Vedas* spiritualize everyday life by recognizing the existence of the supreme spirit, which pervades and energizes every aspect of existence (Rao,

2004). The codes and laws contained in various texts like the *Smṛtis* and *Purāṇas* are oriented towards the ideal way one should lead one's life in order to attain the ultimate goal. Sacraments and rituals have been at the core of Hinduism for ages. *Homa*, *yajña* (sacrificial fire) and *saṁskāras* (purificatory rites) are ways to purify the soul and the body. The most pertinent guidelines for child rearing and parenting come from the Indian school of medicine called Āyurveda—the science of life.

The Āyurvedic model of human development

Āyurveda considers the life of a person an integral whole (*rāśi puruṣa*), consisting of body, mind, soul and sense organs. Just as a gem requires polishing, so *saṁskāras* are required for the ideal development of a human being. *Saṁskāras* have two main objectives: to eradicate disorders and inculcate virtues in the developing being. The *saṁskāras* seek to counteract the child's regressive longings and primal fears of abandonment and separation, which are invariably activated in the course of transition from one stage of life to another. According to Kakar (1978), the child in the Indian tradition is ideologically considered a valuable and welcome being to whom the adults are expected to provide their fullest protection, affection and indulgence; and note that adults use the expression *pālana-पोषण* for protecting-nurturing during the entire life span, based on the belief that life begins at the time of conception. Some of the *saṁskāras* are performed even today as ceremonies and rituals on various occasions, with some regional variations. Nine of them are mainly related to child development, and the first three are performed during the prenatal period.¹

Kaumārabhṛtya, *Caraka Saṁhitā* and *Suśruta* in Āyurveda have laid great emphasis on the purity and sanctity of reproductive behaviour, considering this a major *āhuti* (offering) for the *yajña* (sacrificial fire) of humanity. The aspiring couple, husband and wife, should therefore prepare themselves both physically and mentally to conceive a child. They should be pure at heart and pray to God for a healthy and competent offspring. The mother of Paramhansa Yogananda told her eldest daughter that 'they slept as husband-wife only once a year for progeny' (1972, p. 5). The implantation of the foetus is called *garbhadhāna saṁskāra*, the starting of the prenatal period, followed by *pūṁsavana saṁskāra* performed in the third month for the protection and optimal development of the foetus, and *sīmantonnayanasaṁskāra* in the eighth month of pregnancy. The care for the pregnant woman detailed in Āyurveda shows the importance attached to the prenatal stage.

According to the Hindu belief system, the *jīva* (foetus) is *caitanya* (conscious) and has a soul. The first stage is called *dauhṛdaya* (bi-cardiac), when the expectant mother and foetus constitute a single unit. The bond between mother and child is critical for the development of the child. The narrative of Abhimanyu in the *Mahābhārata*, about learning the specific art of fighting while in his mother's womb, illustrates the idea that the mind of the foetus is active long before birth. Modern research on foetal learning affirms the presence of auditory discrimination skills prior to birth (Hepper, 1991; Huotilainen, et al., 2005). Mirabilis (2003) has

reported that neurologists at the University of Helsinki showed that a foetus can not only differentiate between spoken sounds, but can also begin to memorize them. They can hear their parents' language. Mythily (as cited in <http://www.decanherald.htm>, 2004) conducted an experiment to test the effect of music therapy on 200 pregnant mothers. All mothers reported agitated kicking when they refrained from listening to the music at the habitual time, which proves that punctuality may develop early. When, two to three weeks after birth, the same music was played for 20 minutes, the infants gave extra kicks.

In north India, a ceremony is held in the seventh month of pregnancy where five females of the family or community fill the pregnant woman's lap with a coconut marked with a *svāstik* (an auspicious sign) in red and yellow (turmeric) colour, fruits and sweets, which symbolize and wish for the protection of both the expectant mother and her unborn child. The social significance of this event is to give her support and decrease her anxiety related to delivery. Since being a mother gives her status and recognition in the family, this ceremony holds great importance for her (Kakar, 1979).

Childhood embedded in *saṁskāras*

Jātakarma (cutting of the umbilical cord) is the *saṁskāra* performed immediately after birth, accompanied by recitation of the mantra for the generation of talent, longevity and strength. Worship of Shashthi Devi, though not a regular *saṁskāra* as such, is observed on the sixth day. It has a special significance, both spiritually and socially. It is believed that the Mother Goddess writes the fate and guides the future of the newborn during this ritual. After the woman delivers her child, she is considered to have been granted a new birth as well, and so it is a matter of joy for the whole family. Songs are sung in north India and food and clothes offered to five women on this day.

Nāmakaraṇa saṁskāra, the name-giving-by-the-father ceremony (in some places by the father's sister) is commissioned on the 10th or 12th day after birth. The mother and newborn child take a special herbal bath and then the mother places the child in the lap of the father. Amidst chanting of mantras, the father, along with the child, bows before the elders and accepts their blessing. *Nisakraman*, the child's first sight of the sun, is generally solemnized in the fourth month.

Annaprāsana is the first solid food given to the child at the age of six months. The food is offered first to deities and then the whole family participates in the celebration. This is the beginning of the weaning period, which varies from six months to two years. In some cases it may be prolonged as the child continues taking milk from the mother's breast. *Cūḍākaraṇa saṁskāra* is generally performed before the age of five. According to Āyurveda, removing the hair grown during the prenatal period from the child's head protects him from congenital disorders and facilitates development. The child is taken to a temple or a religious place on an auspicious day and time, and his head is tonsured. In some places it is a big celebration, with the whole community invited to lunch/dinner.

At the age of five, to mark the initiation of learning to read and write, the *vidyārambha* rite is performed by worshipping the *Vedas* and the Mother Goddess of learning of all skills. *Upanayana saṁskāra* is the last one, marking the end of childhood and initiation into a higher life of social responsibility. The most striking feature of the *upanayana* lies in the belief that through its performance, the person undergoes a cultural and spiritual rebirth. The details of the related ceremony reveal that it symbolizes the beginning of self-control and a life-long spiritual struggle. The child goes around seeking alms, an act that reminds him of his dependence on society, whose debts he has to discharge throughout his life.

A close look at the order of these *saṁskāras* and the objectives behind them reveals that they enable a gradual integration of the child into society (Kakar, 1979). *Saṁskāras* are sacraments and aim at transforming a new person in the world into a cultured individual in society. The rituals and customs associated with them integrate members of the family with society, and generate a sense of responsibility among them for child-care through role relationships. In most of these ceremonies, for example *chathi*, *nāmakaraṇa* and *upanayana*, there are particular rituals to be performed by every person related to the newborn, like the father's sister, mother, brother's wife and mother's sister. An affective bond between the newborn and other family members is initiated through these rituals, and the other female members participate in the child's care with motherly affection and involvement. In the *Brahmavaivarta Purāṇa*, there is a description of 16 types of mothers, like the maternal grandmother, paternal grandmother, mother's sister, and all related females, including a maidservant. Grandmothers have a special place in the hearts of children. One can see separation from grandmothers inciting the same protest in children as separation from mothers.

Sage Mārkaṇḍeya has talked about the *lālan-pālan* of children before *upanayana saṁskāra* (*Mārkaṇḍeya Smṛti*). According to him, just as seedlings grow healthy in well-cultivated land, small children, if treated properly, gain more from the training imparted by their parents and teachers. He cautions that small children should be treated like God. Treating them harshly may have adverse effects on their development as fear and frustration may decrease self-confidence, without which they can neither achieve success in life nor perform their duty properly. Parents should try to satisfy them, and should not be angry, impulsive or punitive.

The two great epics, the *Mahābhārata* and the *Rāmāyaṇa*, present many themes related to child development. The *Mahābhārata* depicts the upright upbringing of the Paṇḍavas. The *Rāmāyaṇa* shows the impact of *saṁskāras* on ideal role relationships and on the structure of society. Kauśalyā, the mother of Rāma, knows that her son is an *avatāra* (an incarnation of God), but pleads with him to behave like an ordinary child so that she can enjoy the heavenly pleasure of seeing and participating in his *bāla-līlā* (child play). Hindi *bhakti* (devotion towards God) literature, particularly the poems of Sūrdās and Tulsīdās on the childhoods of Kṛṣṇa and Rāma respectively, reflect the deep, intense craving and longings of mothers for their sons. These poems are not only the expression of religious worship, they also depict the essence of the love and affection a mother feels for her child.

Motherhood and the concept of *lālan-pālan*: Learnings from mythological narratives

The impact of *saṁskāras* on human development in the preceding section may be considered an over-generalization in a complex and heterogeneous culture like India. There is a large variety, especially in the area of gender differentiation. Some societies, like the Kashmiri Hindu Samaj, claim, for example, that the *upanayana saṁskāra* was performed even with girls in the *Vedic* period, and it exists even today amongst them in the form of *kanyā saṁskāra*, which is performed one day before marriage (Raina, 2002). Without dwelling on such controversies, this section tries to focus on the transition of a daughter to womanhood, and then to motherhood. The socialization of the Hindu girl evolves around the theme of idealization of the roles of daughter, wife and mother, even in contemporary society. Girls are blessed and expected to be like Satī, Sāvitrī and Sītā (exemplary women in ancient India).

Satī was the wife of Lord Śiva, who sacrificed herself in the fire to save her husband's honour (*Śiva Purāṇa*). Sāvitrī, a beautiful princess, married a prince of a lost empire who had only one year to live, and saved her husband's life from the hands of the god of death, Yama, through her love, wit and spiritual insight. Sri Aurobindo, in his epic *Savitri*, has placed womanhood and motherhood in high esteem. Sītā, the wife of Lord Rāma, is the epitome of suffering, but never gave up her ideals. Sītā's character has been depicted as an exception, but she is the true ideal of the Indian woman. Apart from these examples, Ahalyā, Śakuntalā, Damayantī, and many others from the stories of various *Purāṇas* are consciously and unconsciously rooted in the psyche of Indian women. The norms for women are mainly derived from two sources—classical culture, reflected in scriptures and other texts, and folk culture, reflected in the thoughts and daily lives of people. In both realms, the greatest value is attached to traditional roles and responsibilities, especially in the context of family.

Of all these roles, motherhood is considered the most important and sacred. The father's role is limited to child rearing, and the mother is given a dominant role in the joint family set-up in India (Bisht & Sinha, 1981). Women in *Vedic* times were revered. The injunction was to respect mothers (*mātr-devo bhava*). The mother Goddess or *mātr-śakti* has great importance in the lives of people. For instance, there are two occasions in a year when nine days and nights (*nava rātra*) are dedicated to the worship of the mother goddess. The *Manu Smṛti* says that 1 teacher is better than 10 *upācārya* (sub-teachers); a father is better than 100 teachers; and one mother is 1,000 times better than a father.

A girl's upbringing was oriented chiefly towards raising her progeny in the right direction, promoting *dharma*, spirituality and the foundation of moral development. In this respect, the narratives of Madalasa and Sītā are very instructive. Madalasa was a queen. She was a learned mother, who taught spirituality to her three sons during their childhood. They, not being interested in worldly matters, went to the forest to pursue *sāadhanā* (personal effort towards spiritual development). The king, her husband, then requested her not to teach this to their fourth

son. She taught him from the very beginning how to rule, and he turned out to be a great and pious ruler. Sītā, despite being exiled, taught her twins all the spiritual and royal skills, and they later went on to revive their mother's lost prestige in Rāma's kingdom.

Some contemporary trends

Womanhood is seen as incomplete without motherhood, and in Indian society, a woman who can't be a mother is often stigmatized (Saraswati & Dutta, 1988). In a study of sex role attitudes of college students in three major universities in Andhra Pradesh (Rao & Rao, 1988), both sexes, when asked about the mother's role, expressed their view that marriage is incomplete without children. The mother-child relationship is considered supreme amongst all relationships.

These beliefs show continuity with tradition. For instance, the belief that *karma* (deeds) of previous births relates parents and offspring in the present life is often endorsed by the parents. A powerful narrative is found in the *Śrīmad Bhāgavatam*. Devakī and Vasudeva, the parents of Lord Kṛṣṇa, had been granted a boon for their devotion and worship of God, which stated that they would be His parents in each *avatāra* (incarnation). A second belief comes from the *Vedic* aphorism which states that a child has three obligations or debts (*ṛnas*): *ṛṣi ṛṇa* (towards the sages), *deva-ṛṇa* (towards the gods) and *pitr-ṛṇa* (towards the ancestors). Beyond these is the *matr-ṛṇa*, related to the duties of a child towards the mother, to protect and nurture her while she is alive and perform *saṁskāra* on her death for her peaceful abode in heaven. This inter-dependent and mutual inter-play of protection and nurturing is a cyclic phenomenon—in early life it is the *dharma* (duty) of the mother and in later life the *dharma* (duty) of the son. A deep religious faith, along with an intense bond of affection, constitutes the psycho-spiritual element of *lālan-pālan* of the child.

The impact of modernization and urbanization can be seen in the family structure and gender roles, but the mother-child relationship is still given priority (Seymour, 1999). Preparation for mother-child interaction begins much before a girl attains motherhood, in the form of *saṁskāras*, through observing the religious ceremonies and festivities that accompany the birth of a child in the family. Saraswati and Dutta (1988) observed a heavy dependence on Western theories and models in the fourth survey of developmental studies in India; however, it is essential to look at the classical sources of culture. Stories of Rāma and Kṛṣṇa are all-pervasive in folk culture. Ordinary people think of themselves in terms of Yaśodā maiyā and Kauśalyā. Even the divine portrayal of the mother of Shivājī, Jījābāī, in Maharashtra, the birthday celebrations of Mā Śāradā and the Mother of Pondicherry, explicitly reflect the divinity associated with motherhood. At the same time, it is important to empirically explore how far the ideas of psycho-spiritual parenting described earlier still contribute to parenting practices in contemporary India.

Parenting in a north Indian city: Some observations

Being a multi-cultural country, India does not allow for any single Indian view. Within this limitation, to facilitate an initial exploration of the impact of folk ways and beliefs on the behaviour and experience of motherhood amongst contemporary mothers in India, a study was conducted in Allahabad, a major city in north India on the banks of the holy Ganges.

Thirty mothers in the age group 18–35, 15 each from a rural and an urban area, constituted the sample. Data was collected through semi-structured interviews, focusing on the attitude towards childhood; attitude and experience during pregnancy; beliefs, rituals and ceremonies relating to pregnancy and childbirth; child-rearing behaviours and experiences; the role of other family members in rearing the child; experiences as a mother; attitude towards motherhood; and the role of wife as compared to that of a mother. An analysis of the interviews conducted revealed four major themes, as described below.

Rituals, beliefs and practices during pregnancy and childbirth

Most participants did not plan their first child, but it was an eagerly awaited occasion. The urban participants showed a greater involvement in the various ceremonies related to childbirth and child rearing. Although the rationale behind these ceremonies was sometimes not known to the mothers, they were religiously performed for the protection of the child.

Child-rearing practices

Breast-feeding was a salient feature for both urban and rural mothers. All mothers had a positive attitude towards it. They preferred and continued breast-feeding up to one year, as they considered it healthy and satisfying for both mother and child. Feeding the child was their *dharma* (duty). A general body massage was commonly practised both in urban and rural areas as mothers believed that it made the child's bones sturdy, smoothened the skin and relaxed the baby. An awareness of health and sanitation was less visible in rural mothers.

Indulgence-protection

Results showed that feeding, massaging, bathing, putting the child to sleep and providing health care were all activities that manifested indulgence and protection shown by the mothers. Despite living in joint families, most participants showed complete involvement with the child and spent most of their time with the child. A custom prevalent in both rural and urban areas was of observing a fast on specific days for the health and well-being of the child.

Psycho-spiritual experience

Motherhood was highly valued by all interviewees. A sense of devotion and sacrifice was expressed for rearing the child. Apart from caring for physical needs, the mother-child relationship was considered supreme amongst all relationships. One of the participants described it as follows:

A mother-child relationship is not just a matter of chance ... this is an arrangement by the Creator Himself It is a relationship that continues from the previous births ... actually, one considers motherhood as supreme ... amongst all relationships, ... till that time a woman is only a wife, her husband means everything to her, but on becoming a mother her child is of supreme importance and then the rest of the world follows

Many expressions suggest this same theme: 'she dissolves all her desires and expectations in nurturing and protecting her creation against all vagaries; ... she is mother first and mother last'. Judging by the expressions of mothers, it can be said that there is a kind of intensity which can only be experienced, '... it is a vibration that even the child perceives, or else why would he cry if put in someone else's lap?'

Concluding comments

The present analysis of parenting shows that motherhood continues to be the most valuable and cherished aspect of life for an Indian woman, both psychologically and socially. It is indeed a psycho-spiritual experience, rather than merely a biological instinctual behaviour. The deep, intense, emotional relationship interwoven with religious faith, a sense of devotion, sacrifice, unconditional love and divinity constitutes the essence of this experience. Breast-feeding seems to play an important role, which emerged not as a simple bodily contact, but as a spiritual experience for them. The difference in the way breast-feeding is perceived delineates the cultural interpretation of a biological/natural phenomenon. What is termed as 'physical dependency', instrumental in promoting the right attitude towards the baby (Woroberg, 1993), is essential *dharma* for an Indian mother. It is the out-pouring of all her affection, and the infant reciprocates these vibrations. 'It is the total emotional climate, the gestalt of mothering' (Kakar 1978, p. 56).

The image of an ideal mother seems to be imprinted on the psyche of the Hindu woman. The sources of these inputs involve beliefs and practices, role models and role expectations, contextualized by a religious culture. In Indian culture, religion and spirituality are two overlapping constructs (Rao, 2004). Legends, festivals and rituals (for example, birthday celebrations of *bāla* (child) Rāma and Kṛṣṇa) reinforce the belief in the divine presence in everyday life. Some participants reported that they dressed their children as *bāla* Kṛṣṇa on *Kṛṣṇa janmāṣṭami* (Kṛṣṇa's birthday). Other respondents, while narrating their experiences during pregnancy, reported that they placed a picture of the child Kṛṣṇa near their bed, with the aspiration and belief that the foetus might acquire the same virtues as Kṛṣṇa. The spiritual self, as described by Roland (1988, p. 9), 'is deeply engraved in the preconscious of all Indians, even if they make no particular effort or realize it.' The findings show that holding the child as God-like, giving priority to the mother-child relationship over the husband-wife relationship, and complete involvement in the maternal role all contribute to making the Hindu woman's experience of child-bearing much more than a mere biological phenomenon.

Endnote

- 1 There is a difference of opinion regarding the number of *saṁskāras*. There are 48 *saṁskāras* in *Gautamasmyti*, whereas Aṅgirasah ṛṣi has prescribed 25 *saṁskāras*. *Caraka Saṁhitā* and *Suśruta Saṁhitā*, the main texts in Āyurveda, have not mentioned any particular number of *saṁskāras*, but there is a definite description of *saṁskāras* concerned with the child's health and care. Vedavyāsa ṛṣi has prescribed 16 *saṁskāras* (*Vyāsa Smṛti*), which is the most commonly accepted number.

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16

Being human the Sikh way: Some psychological reflections

Preeti Kapur & Girishwar Misra

The answer to the query 'Who and what am I?' shapes our understanding of human nature (Heelas, 1981; Lock, 1981; Clark, 2002). Each perspective on human nature offers us a distinct position to grasp and approach psychological reality (Paloutzian & Park, 2005; Park, 2005). Each way of life delineates the composition of one's life-world and one's place in it. It constitutes a meaning system that allows a person to organize and understand his/her life and world. Mainstream psychology endorses an essentially anthropocentric perspective and maintains the image of humans as isolated, discrete and self-contained entities. The same, however, has been projected as universal, although alternative perspectives do exist. By bringing Sikhism into focus, this chapter makes an effort in this direction. Sikhism is a relatively young religio-social tradition followed by 20 million people who have a strong presence, nationally and globally.

The Sikh way of life provides a relevant framework for understanding the psyche in a life-span perspective, situated in the societal matrix. It maintains that achieving humanness is accomplished by one's own effort, which reflects the integration of the 'mundane' and the 'spiritual' by appreciating the multidimensional nature of one's existence. A person becomes a *Sikh* when he invests personal effort in seeking and experiencing things at the bodily, social and spiritual planes. Participation in worldly activities provides a platform from which to learn about the essentials of self-expansion and growth.

The Name can be treasured up if the mind-vessel is upright;
In the inverted vessel, nothing can be contained. (*Sri Guru Granth Sahib*, 158)

The idea and tradition of Sikhism

The historical struggle of the Sikh community spans five centuries. Their religious tradition, known as Sikhism or the Sikh Panth (the path of the disciples), was initially called the Nanak Panth, referring to the path of Guru Nanak, its founder. Set in the 15th century, Guru Nanak stated that the key to 'being human' lies in

the realization of the self as an emergent entity wedded to practical activity. Thus, life is a journey of transformation that makes people useful to society and the environment. This contributes to one's own welfare and well-being, as well as to that of others.

Guru Nanak (1469–1539) was followed by nine successor Gurus. The Sikh scriptures, the *Sri Guru Granth Sahib* (SGGS), embodies their precepts and has become the instructional manual that guides the community to shape its behaviour in accordance with the prescribed value paradigm (for details, see Harbans Singh, 1988). It is revered as the eternal Guru, and Sikhs hold the '*bani*', or word, as revealed by the Guru in great veneration.

The world of human experience

The basic theme of most Indian perspectives is that a person becomes human only when s/he extends and grows beyond limited ego-bound individuality. Sikhism shares this view along with other Indian systems of thought, yet, it is innovative and distinctive in many ways.

The SGGS, a work of devotional poetry, contains verses composed by the Sikh Gurus as well as *bhaktas* (God's devotees) of different faiths and creeds. The *bhaktas* include Kabir, Farid, Namdev, Jaidev, Dhanna and Ravidas, to name a few.

Interestingly, each of the 10 Sikh Gurus was not a celibate religious teacher but a householder, thus fulfilling his responsibility to society. They followed this basic paradigm and set an example for their followers. The Sikh devotees learnt to attain emancipation through the practice of human qualities like piety, service, sharing, equalitarianism and honest living. The blending of piety and practical activity, meditation and discipline, without renunciation and withdrawal from the world is characteristic of the Sikh (McLeod, 2000).

Basic principles

In order to understand human nature as described in Sikh thought, it is necessary to highlight the following concepts.

The contours of reality: In Sikh thought, the Creator and His creation (that is, the universe and man) are conceived of as seemingly differentiated, yet are interdependent. Since both are His creations, they constitute a part of Him. Man has his individuality as a part of the principle of individuation (Neki, personal communication). *Haumai*, as I-am-ness (Being!) is an essential part of man. It is the multiplicity of the *Haumai* and its manifestation into differentiated entities, each of which provides man with the necessary medium/mode to survive and establish himself in the everyday life-world.

The world: The World is viewed in diverse ways, and the landscape of the world is organized dialectically. The being and the Ultimate (Consciousness) or Truth, and transitory experiences are, therefore, reciprocally related to each other. The universe is real in the true sense, and Neki (personal communication) clarifies

that the universe, from the Sikh viewpoint, is *māyā* (illusion), not in the sense that it is illusionary, but in the sense that it is ephemeral:

Maya changeth its colour every moment, as do shades of the clouds
The colour of maya is like the colour of a safflower,
In a moment will it wear off. (SGGS, 654)

God, who is the creator of the universe:

Salute to Him who from His Absolute Formless Being
Became manifest. Permeates He the world that He created.
The life of the world, he is also the life of life.
He is unmanifest and manifest, transcendental and personal.
Such then, is the Creator of this world, who can be recognized from His creation:
Sayeth Nanak, the True Lord reveals Himself through his Nature. (SGGS, 141)

The world is an opportunity for man to play his destined role. The way to God can be accomplished only through living life to its fullest and developing his human nature.

Man and human nature: Man lives in the world created by the Supreme Being. Therefore, there is no social or religious division: 'There is no Hindu, no Muslim'. The only entity is the human being. Guru Nanak stressed on the primacy of the human essence as the central and fundamental identity that connects and merges with the essence of the Divine Spirit. The secondary or derived identity/identities are nothing but artefacts. Such a manifestation is also of significance, since it is the human being, as the essence, who derives and establishes himself *in* and *through* a system of complex secondary identities, whether social, religious, ethnic or cultural. The derived identities are essential as they provide the path to being human, but they are the means and not an end in themselves.

It is to be noted that the role of man is thus analysed in the context of *unity* and *differentiation*. *Differentiation* reflects the secondary identities that man must take on to realize his true self. It reflects the routine and ordinary mode of life as being crucial to attain growth and self-realization. The principle of *unity* implies man's relationship with the world around, for man abides in the same plane as the world. Man and world were created at the same time, from the same light, through the same substance and, of course, by the same Supreme Being. The aim of becoming a human being, therefore, is to seek or work out the balance of the egocentric, sociocentric and theocentric domains of life, which owe to the same Lord. The equilibrium thus sought helps to establish the framework upon which one must mould one's life.

The structure of selfhood

Since the actual world exists as a functional realm and is manifested in its myriad forms, human consciousness also mirrors this world and engages itself in the discovery of its existence.

The biological/bodily self: The physical self as manifested in the bodily form

and its expression is an essential facet for achieving human nature. The basic needs of man and his body have a close bond. Having certain basic needs met is a matter of right. The *Var asa* hymn (SGGS, p. 464) refers to the acts of consumption, eating, drinking and dressing; to all the worldly affections; to the multihued, vivid and vibrant life world of man. It varies from virtues to vices, to ego and pride, to the five elements of nature. The fifth Guru, Arjan Dev, states that if a person remembers His name, then s/he has the right to get daily needs, even to the extent of enjoyment, comfort and pleasure (SGGS, 100). The biological self helps in maintaining the internal homeostasis. Hunger, thirst, sex, emotions and feelings are essential aspects of human nature. These aspects of man must be realized before he can progress in other life ways.

The individual (egocentric) self: In addition to the bodily self, the individual sense of self plays a vital role in human nature. The process of individuation takes place at the cosmic and individual level and is described as the basis for all development.

Haumai at the cosmic level of individuation

Guru Nanak himself laid down the foundation of the creation and formation of *Haumai*. The concept of *Haumai* is difficult to define in English terms. It is not the ego, nor is it the sense of 'I'. According to Guru Nanak, the basis of the Universe, of Creation, is *Haumai*: '*The world comes into being through Haumai*' (SGGS, 916). He further says, '*Impelled by Haumai, Creation takes place*' (SGGS, 466).

The concept of *Haumai* expresses the cosmic principle of individuation. In short, in order for Creation to come into existence, it was of vital importance to have *Haumai*, that is, to allow the world to exist in terms of reality/actuality. Each person is part of the whole, that is, the formless, timeless One, the Almighty, from which we must separate in order to live in this world. As Neki (2002, p. 10) observes, 'there is the sense of separation of the part from the *undifferentiated whole*.... The sense of individuality having been injected, every single individual of the Creation comes to assume a separate entity, experienced as well as designated as "I"' (italics Neki). *Haumai* plays a dual role, '... as a cosmic principle (it)... represent(s) the destiny of the whole mankind', with each one of us being copies of the original pattern. At the individual level, it refers to that act and process of individuation from the '*undifferentiated whole*'.

Haumai at the individual level

At the individual level, *Haumai* plays dual roles. *Haumai* exists in all living beings, it is an essential element for man's survival, for man is not likely to act if we did not have the 'I'. In fact, whatever man accomplishes and achieves, is because of this 'I'. It gives rise to socially approved forms of feelings, such as pride, glory, self-esteem, dignity. They motivate a person to act and perform in acceptable ways. These acts then become conventional and customary. They constitute the 'natural' part of the individual or the society in which people grow. These acts, giving rise to satisfactory positive feelings, then become the culturally appropriate behaviours, giving rise to values/beliefs/attitudes that a community may emulate.

Yet, *Haumai* plays another role that each person must be aware of—*Haumai* troubles mankind and often becomes a burden. The existence of *Haumai* causes great distress and makes man miserable. It takes on the negative, socially disliked form of vanity, conceit, pretence, arrogance, self-importance, self-centeredness and the like. Further, ‘... *Haumai* is the declaration of exclusivity by the individual’ (Neki, 2002, p. 14). Finally, *Haumai*

... is a functional entity, the agency for all actions. *Haumai* caters to the exigencies of mundane life, foremost among which is struggle for existence with the attendant impulses of self-preservation and self-protection. These impulses require one to be alert and forewarned. Perception of danger and alarm is, therefore, a major function of *Haumai* (Neki, 2002, p. 15).

In Japuji, Guru Nanak states that there are five lower passions of *Haumai*, viz. *kāma*, *krodha*, *lobha*, *moha* and *ahamkāra*, reflecting lust, anger, greed, attachment and egocentricity, respectively. These passions are barriers for achieving freedom and salvation. Man is required to control them, otherwise life worth a diamond is lost quickly (SGGS, 156); and once he has been able to command these lower passions, he becomes free. Man can overcome these five emotions by striving for humility, control, contentment, charity, compassion and happiness. Yet living in this world is important, and man acquires freedom while facing the trials of the mundane and ephemeral life. Guru Arjan, the fifth Guru, states:

One can achieve liberation
Even while participating in life,
Laughing, playing, wearing finery and eating delicacies (SGGS, 522).

Thus, life consists of worldly actions, pleasures, joys and satisfaction. This clearly recognizes the reality of the empirical and material aspect of human life. Living in the world allows the release of our procreation needs, the emotions of joy and sorrow, love and hate. These states have one important facet: they are all real because man experiences them. They provide certain degree of definiteness and concreteness to one's existence.

Karma

In addition, Sikhism advocates the belief in *karma*. Man is morally accountable for his deeds, and accordingly faces its consequences. Man's actions are causally dependent upon his character. The latter is impacted by his experience and the social environment. God has also given man the power of free will and choice, as he is also endowed with intellectual capabilities. Man is capable of exercising this choice. Hence, SGGS continuously reminds man to exercise his choice and make his destiny. Man has this sense of discrimination, of right from wrong, and it follows that he is then responsible for his actions. The right choices and decisions thus make his destiny, his character, his habits and attitudes. In short, this helps govern his spiritual-mystical progress. Sikhism, hence, emphasizes the *Moral Self* and the *Real Self* in man. The evolution of the real self refers to the path from being *Manmukh* (Ego-conscious), where the person is self-involved, vain and proud,

governed by negative personality characteristics, to the path of *Gurmukh* (God-conscious), where the person is attuned towards the real and true self. He uses his energies to develop the psychological processes of perception, learning, remembering, thinking, judging and discriminating (Marwaha, 2006, pp. 202–205).

We find that Sikhism proclaims the active and vibrant reality and the legitimacy of the world and the life of the person. Since the person and the world he lives in are real, work, activity, performance and deeds are of basic importance. The Sikh Gurus, both in their lives and hymns, have reiterated that living in this world is not an encumbrance, burden or liability; rather, it is a rare opportunity given to mankind to achieve spiritual growth.

Man has come to this beautifully created world, and his struggle in it provides the context for his own and others' progress and development. One cannot attain salvation by showing scorn and disdain at God's world. Appreciation of God's creation is demonstrated by living in the world as a householder. As a householder one faces the challenges of everyday life in all its hues and shades. Living in the world becomes the arena for the manifestation of the real self.

Social consciousness

Since the dichotomy of Creator and man, and the person and the world, does not exist, man can achieve and attain wholeness by authentic living. Such a living is possible only when he lives and shares with others in the world. Existence and active participation in the social world form the basis for achieving spiritual accomplishment. A fully integrated person must revert to the world and society to contribute and share in its activities, so as to guide and assist in achieving a state of being in which the human mind is realistic and reliable, and pragmatic living is facilitated. Hence, one finds that the concept of householder (*grhastha*) is of immense importance. Leading a family life while at the same time performing one's responsibilities and duties towards others in the society is the way life should be moulded. The household life is the fundamental and the essential test. The journey of the household life helps us become spiritually, emotionally and psychologically robust, resilient and mature. Ideals and standards valued by society are understood and established in social contexts. Family and community life promotes the values that are to be absorbed by the growing individual. Thus, rather than running away from the responsibilities of life, the householder's life teaches us to succeed in life while facing its daily trials and tribulations.

The salient role of society was well demonstrated by Guru Nanak when he travelled to the Himalayas. He reached Mount Kailash and Mansarovar Lake, the abode of yogis (ascetics), one of whom asked him, 'How goes the world of the mortals?' Guru Nanak replied, 'The society is in a bad shape. For if men (like you) who are the intellectuals have chosen to be self-indulgent, and you do not guide society, then how can it sustain itself?' Hence, each person has an important and significant role to play in the human world. Only then can God's creation progress along.

It is possible for a person to develop the virtues necessary to become an acceptable and recognizable person, and to have an identity, only when he remains a

part of the social world. The chief virtue is earnestness, as it directs a man towards duty and effort. Earnestness is exhibited in simplicity and conscientiousness. The conduct of sociability is indicated in the acts of help, patience, appreciation, right speech, modesty, love of justice and dealings with others. Hence, man should educate himself in order to serve others as well as himself.

Guru Nanak places emphasis on work to sustain life as the responsibility of each person. Complete participation in life and social responsibility in all fields are to be accomplished. Service (*sevā*) is the primary step forward in moral and spiritual progress as it teaches the person to be unselfish; the latter is at the root of all virtues, the primary responsibility is acknowledgement of the equality of man. Guru Nanak talks about the futility of caste, for the aim of man is to be in harmony with the Lord:

Recognize Lord's light within all and inquire not the caste
For there is no caste in his world. (SGGS, 349)

Again, he states:

Ask not the caste of anyone;
Ask in whose heart God has come to dwell.
Caste is known, There, by the deeds done by one. (SGGS, 1330)

The character of the person develops when he resides in the society, for an isolated person cannot accomplish anything worthwhile nor progress in life. In addition, great emphasis is placed on the society of the 'good', referred to as *sad sangat* or *sat sangat*. For it is in the company of the saints that the person becomes a whole person. And, in respectable and noble company, all worries disappear. Further, good company in the form of a learned person educates the growing person:

In the company of sandal wood,
One (an ordinary tree) becomes sandalwood also. (SGGS, 1365)

The necessity of a living teacher to serve as a role model for moral and spiritual development is essential. Such a person is characterized as a *gurmukh*, referring to the God-centred person. A *gurmukh* follows the principles and teachings (*bani*) as expounded in the SGGS:

The *bani* is the teacher, the teacher the *bani*,
All the nectars are present in the *bani*,
If the faithful follows the *bani* of the Guru,
The Guru himself helps him in the realization of his ideal. (SGGS, 982)

Due respect is accorded to the sayings of the wise, the sages and also to ancestors for the development of character and personality. The virtue of friendship is highlighted as an essential aspect for each person (SGGS, 42, 47, 219, 1369, 1412).

Guru Nanak advocated equality of all humans and accorded equal rights to women. He writes:

From the woman is our birth;
In the woman's womb are we shaped.

To the woman are we engaged; to the woman are we wedded.
 The woman is our friend, and from the woman is our family.
 If one woman dies, we seek another;
 Through the woman are the bonds of the world.
 Why call woman evil who gives birth to kings and all?
 From the woman is the woman;
 Without the woman there is none;
 Nanak without the woman is the One True Lord alone. (SGGS, 473)

Guru Nanak emphasized social responsibility, as found in his attempt to fight injustice and oppression in society. Freedom of religion and cultural rights are emphasized for the true human nature to unfold. Guru Nanak spoke against the greed and hypocrisy of priests (SGGS, 1191), and corruption and injustice by rulers and officials.

The journey of human development begins and ends with the immersion into the particular, material and secular world, and an experience of the here and now. Even though the person has an individual and social self, there is no inherent dichotomy between these two domains. Foremost, the concept of original sin is not found in Sikhism. Human birth is special, a joy, where the person has been given the opportunity to fulfil a given potential. It is the duty and responsibility of man to realize that potentiality. The abuse and misuse of knowledge, and not knowledge itself, lead to corruption, aberration and deviance. As I. J. Singh (1997, as quoted by Marwaha, 2006, pp. 211–212) lucidly states, ‘The sin is not in being human but in *not becoming* all we can be as humans.’

Spiritual-mystical consciousness

SGGS clearly states that saying a mantra, repeating it, reading scriptures such as the *Vedas*, *Smṛtis* and the *Purāṇas* (SGGS, 226, 251, 467) and observing rituals and customs (SGGS, 424) are not the path to reach and attain spiritual consciousness (SGGS, 730). There can be no salvation or freedom unless spirituality is expressed in life, action and endeavour (SGGS, 1180). In this way, spiritual and empirical progress of humans are interdependent (D. Singh, 1997; Marwaha, 2006). Spirituality has to be expressed in everyday life so as to enrich human nature. The empirical life has to draw from the moral-mystical realm in order to grow and develop. These two dimensions of man, the mystical and the empirical, nourish, support and cultivate each other and produce a human being. A man is not to withdraw from the Creation of God (world) but to become an agent engaged in the socio-spiritual development of the self and of others. Each Sikh is the representative of the Guru and must abide by the Will of God (*hukam*).

Societal concerns are universal in nature and character, and are remembered every day in the Sikh daily prayer. The obligation towards God finds translation in the form of obligation towards humanity, and towards society as a whole. Further, the communitarian obligations of a Sikh have their significance, in that these are imperatives for the cohesiveness and solidarity of the community.

Individual, social and mystical domains: Self-consciousness

For the Sikh individual, the perception of the self as an in-group member provides the fundamental basis and background on which the individual self is to be played out. The individual cannot exist without the psychological bonding and belongingness to a group. This provides a sense of identity, agency and psychological well-being to the Sikh individual. The Sikh individual develops through participation and maintains harmony and unity of all things. At the same time, this aspect of we-self in no way indicates a depersonalization or loss of self and identity, nor submergence into the group. It calls attention to the issue of how each Sikh has a role and position in the world and must contribute to the social order. Hence, Sikhs view themselves as active agents who pursue goals and make decisions. The teachings of the Gurus, especially Guru Nanak, recognized the role of daily human activity in terms of the needs, the emotions and the concrete psychological experiences necessary for self-expansion. Each individual needs the space for the performance and release of normal human activities. The suppression of basic desires, wants, needs or emotions is not a healthy prescription for a growing and developing self.

The social world is an integral part of the spiritual domain. It exists in everyday life activities. The more the active participation of the person in the empirical world, the deeper becomes the awareness of the Supreme Being. Man achieves wholeness by authentic and realistic living. The self is formed when one has a fluid, open boundary between self and non-self. For, it is only when we draw others into our sense of self that we are 'human', and, in the process, become human. The key psychological conceptualizations of being human may be summarized as follows.

As a being in this world, each person has to experience and chart his own journey in the life-world. No one else can act, perform and accomplish this aspect for him. Neither can it be gifted to him, nor can money buy it for him. The responsibility to act is solely personal. Each individual has to put in the effort and labour, toil and strive to strike his own path (*mārg*) to become human in the true sense, or to realize his true nature. This kind of realization is possible as humans have the capacity to participate consciously in the processes of growth and development.

1. Being human in the Sikh way does not require escaping from the reality but staying within the folds of daily life, facing its struggles and undergoing trials. Guru Nanak himself set an example of work and meditation, that is, a balance of the empirical and spiritual worlds—a blending of the inner and outer worlds, the egocentric and the theocentric forms, which forms the essential core of humanness. The need to belong to the moral and empirical world is stressed on, for it is the harmony of these worlds on which the Sikh personhood is shaped.
2. The blending of the egocentric and the theocentric realms elucidates the acceptance of the social realm. A *man* becomes *human* only when he

resides within the social matrix (*sangat*). Man can carry out his duties, obligations and responsibilities only when he actively and responsibly participates in the social world. Man alone, by himself, is incomplete and isolated. The social fabric acts as a medium that allows a person to grow, develop his capabilities and realize his potentialities by responding to the desires, needs, motives and emotions (for example, joy, sorrow, love, hate, jealousy and anger).

3. Being a higher creation, man inherently shares a social responsibility, for only when each person stays in the world to perform his duties can the world be transformed into a more encompassing spiritual level of existence. Sikh thought emphasizes that an individual alone cannot seek salvation; rather, it is a collective responsibility, a community based salvation, in which each individual is a vital component.
4. Finally, the experience of becoming a 'Sikh' is collective in nature; it takes place in the congregation (*sangat*) as well as within the self. The lived experience, 'as intrinsically being-in-the-world', plays an important role. The self-experience is, therefore, a shared experience configured by relationships. Also, the person, in some way, loses his individuality and joins the collective at both the social and the spiritual levels. Thus, the self is simultaneously negated as well as expanded.

The primary emphasis is on the personal experiential development of a human being. The progression from the personal experiential realm to the social and the theological realms marks the path each Sikh has to tread as a student, disciple and seeker. This process of being and becoming a 'Sikh' is really never complete. Man's pursuit of and progress towards a coherent, related, integral whole, is an ongoing process. The effort to maintain the balance between the three worlds remains a continuous endeavour.

Sikh vision of life and world view in the contemporary period

The Sikh way of life as elucidated in the *SGGS* presents the normative aspect of becoming human. Its rendition in mundane, everyday life activities presents another facet, that is, of how the followers are able to translate desirable behaviours into action. A brief study of the Sikh contemporary world, and how it constitutes meaning systems to organize and understand the world and experiences, helps us understand the transformation of the normative into the performative.

The contemporary Sikh manifestation of humanness is found in the three domains of human life that are termed in Sikh parlance as '*nam, dan, ishnan*', which refer to the divine name, charity and purity. At the level of the masses, it is characterized as '*naam japo, kirat karo, wand chako*', meaning 'chant the divine name, work hard, and share the fruits of your labour'. These two phrases encapsulate the essence of the teachings of the Sikh Gurus and of Sikhism. It is in order to explain these two sayings that Guru Nanak states that the *gurmukh* is a person oriented towards God who practices the three-fold regulation of '*nam, dan, ishnan*'.

These refer to the relationships with the divine (*nam*), the society (*dan*), and the self (*ishnan*), which set the stability of maintaining equilibrium of the individual and society. This constitutes the core and 'correspond[s] to the cognitive, the communal, and the personal aspects of evolving Sikh identity' (P. Singh, 1985). The continuity of the core (Kapur & Misra, 2003) is evident even today, as the Sikh self is governed by the principle that 'one should live on what one has earned through hard work and one should share with others the fruit of one's exertion'. Further, selfless service (*seva*), truthful living (*sach achar*), humility, compassion, sense of brotherhood and the dignity of labour are qualities that determine the intrinsic worth of a person. The *sangat* (congregation) and the *langar* (common meal) provide the individual self a group to identify with. The group prays and sings the praise of the Lord at the *dharamshala* (place of worship, which also refers to the fact that we as humans come into this world, reside in it for some time and go our way) and partakes of a common meal (*langar*). These institutions help nurture and foster the social values of equality, fellowship, humility, sharing, cooperation and solidarity. Asceticism is discouraged in Sikhism because detachment from everyday life is a form of escapism, or denial of earth/world, which amounts to a denial of God, the Creator, who abides in life. A man's dedication to God is his devotion to the well-being of all life.

The second phrase, '*naam japo, kirat karo, wand chako*', helps focus on three aspects. Meditation on the Name of God (*naam japo*) reflects self-realization and self-growth of the individual. The spiritual growth of the inner world of the person brings about true consciousness. Hard and honest work (*kirat karo*) reflects action and performance. It helps in developing 'practical consciousness' and playing out of the materialistic world. Further, it draws attention to the dignity of labour, and recognizes that every act performed by man has its consequences. Sharing with others (*wand chako*) focuses on societal concerns and the welfare of the others existing in an individual's milieu.

A Sikh style of life never finishes or has an end; it is an ongoing process. In fact, it has been stated that to be born a Sikh is the instantaneous achievement of arriving into the human world, but to 'become' a Sikh 'remains a work in progress', meaning that it is a process that continues till the end of one's life journey. This important issue is summed up by I. J. Singh (2003): 'the journey of Sikhism is itself the destination', and this highlights the 'on going process' of becoming a Sikh. A person becomes a Sikh when he invests personal effort in seeking, experiencing or discovering things. The experiential component is of immense significance to Sikhism. Hence, the need to work, and participate in worldly activities.

Recently, Kapur and Misra (2003, 2004) made attempts to explore and portray the essence of Sikhism in self-formulation, and investigated the social, psychological and historical processes through which the community has established itself as a distinct social entity. It has a core that shares religious, social and cultural attributes. The Sikhs show high levels of adaptability, which helps in accepting new challenges and seeking new opportunities to grow. This unique blending of continuity and change has helped them to grow from a local community to a

global presence (Kapur & Misra, 2003). The Sikh self is largely a matter of location of the self in the dynamic nexus of wider group relations. For the Sikh self, the collective aspects are all-pervasive in defining who they are; and they also think, feel and behave in a manner that it becomes the self-definitional background to their routine lives. Yet the results also indicate the salience of the individual self. The individual self contributes to the development of the collective self also. The Sikhs imbibe the teachings (*bani*) of their Gurus, which emphasize activity, performance and accomplishment as important values to be inculcated in each Sikh follower. All three forms of self—the collective, the individual and the relational, go on to become the entity that motivates, protects and enhances the Sikh individual psychologically (Kapur, 2007).

Some implications for a comprehensive psychology

Experiential shaping of a person

It is clear that Sikh thought regards human nature not from an egocentric position. It accepts the salience of the empirical and material self, and states the dignity and rights of the individual. Primarily, it enables one to unleash one's creativity, which in turn allows the healthy and mature development of the personality. It provides the individual with respite and liberation from the basic primary and secondary urges. The need for the empirical and material self, the conflicts, tensions and stresses of life have one common aspect: they all are perceived and experienced as real. Experience (*anubhav*), whether physical, mental or spiritual, plays an important role in the human world.

The Sikh way of life is directed toward the transformation and socio-cultural evolution of the human mind and experience. Each person is capable of experiencing truth, provided he is open to it and submits himself to disciplined training and learning. And this state, among others, has to be lived and experienced, for without experience nothing is adequately known. Hence, authority, intellectual or verbal exercise and philosophical speculation or argumentation are of no consequence in establishing the truth. It is the experiential role of a person that is the basic requisite to being and becoming human. Actions, deeds and quality of living determine a person's personality. Life and its activities reveal the distinction between a self-centred (*manmukh*) and a God-centred (*gurmukh*) person:

True living is living God in life. (SGGS, 684)

Hence, an active life of truth is important, and just to know the truth is not an end in itself.

Self-definition and motivation

The Sikh way of life spells out goals and prescribes behaviours to achieve these goals. It accords a position to *personal strivings*, referring to the recurrent and ongoing goals that a person characteristically tries to attain or maintain; and to *spiritual strivings*, referring to goals that involve knowledge of God, relationship with him,

his nature, Will and power. However, there is no difference between the two strivings. A wide range of personal strivings are invested with spiritual meanings. The quest for each person is to revolve around both the intrinsic and extrinsic ways of life. Thus, the Sikh view of life attends to the dimension of 'growth' and 'seeking' and the 'seekership' quality of the person.

Living in the world is not bondage for the Gurus. They proclaim the dynamic reality and authenticity of the Creation by God. The Lord and His World are real and, hence, the activity of man living in this very world also has its legitimacy and validity. The Gurus were conscious of this fundamental difference—regarding the expected role man plays in this world—with some other Indian religious traditions. The latter advocated an ascetic lifestyle and renouncement of worldly activities (*sanyās*). Further, the householders' duties and responsibilities were not considered advantageous toward spiritual attainment. In fact, they were viewed as coming in the way of attaining salvation and freedom. Being extremely conscious of this aspect of human life, and therefore their personal lives, standard of living and lifestyle, along with their hymns the Gurus lay stress upon the synthesis of the mystical-spiritual and the empirical life ways. Worldly life is not opposed to spiritual life. It is the *self-centred* (*Haumai*) life that is the root of all problems. The Sikh system involves the activity of creating a balance between the empirical and the spiritual life-worlds.

Mutuality of self and other

Egocentric tendencies are not denied but are treated as stumbling blocks in the path of becoming human. Adherence to this path is possible only when man realizes the need for significant others who aid in his growth and development. Belongingness to a group is seen as giving life a purpose and direction. Healthy development cannot take place when the focus is on separation and individuality. 'Others' contribute to the formation of the self. Guru Nanak emphasized the importance of relationships in the community (*sangat*), and dependency constituted a functional matrix for personality development. The individual cannot live alone; he is embedded in the family, group, community and the larger society. The self-in-relation, where relatedness is the vital component, does not allow the drawing of a distinct boundary between self and non-self. A self can exist only by drawing others within the sense of self. Like many non-Western perspectives (Harre, 1981; Choi, Kim & Choi, 1993; Ho, 1993; Misra, 1999), Sikh thought accords recognition to the status of the individual, but he is embedded in a web of social relationships and obligations which grants centrality to the socio-centric perspective.

Socio-centric view of personhood

The socio-centric view considers relationships as the basis for self-experience and development. Relatedness is seen as the basic goal of development. Further, self-in-relation is the mechanism for the manifestation of all attributes, including creativity, assertiveness, love, independence and autonomy. The sense of individuality

and sense of relatedness to others develop throughout the life cycle in a dialectical manner (Misra, 1999). While a person is pulled in multiple directions, development can take place only when achievements in one domain facilitate development in other domains. Thus, person and society jointly operate or transact. An integral and mature sense of self arises from the relationships with significant others, and for this a developed and mature self is essential. A balance of individuality and relatedness is desired, as the Sikh view of life has no place for merely personal or private salvation. Man is an essential part of the Supreme Being. By serving others, man serves the Supreme Being. Hence, the emphasis is upon salvation and well-being for society as a whole, along with active participation in society. The person is not only rooted in the social but also shares in it. The acts of sharing, cooperation, giving, assistance and help, all create and establish a sense of well-being encompassing the personal as well as the social. The relevance of the social and physical realms is that they transform and allow reinventing ourselves in the course of the demands and challenges of life. Social relations provide the necessary framework within which alone human nature can develop and be realized.

Interaction of individual and relational selves

While accepting the different modes of self-existence, Sikhism attempts to understand the experience and behaviour of the person as the product of psychological variables and social contexts. The dimensions of individual and relational selves interact, are dynamic in nature, and are a part of an ongoing process in which the self and social conditions shift in relation to one another. Sikhism provides scope for individual differentiation and independence within the group, for these aspects are desirable for self-determination. Compatibility between the individual and the collective self is achieved when both spheres are accorded their respective spaces to grow and develop.

Self-regulation

Sikhism iterates that relationships or affiliations between the self and others influence self-construal. Self-regulation requires knowledge of one's self in relation to others' reactions to them. Thus, self-concept is of import not only at the individual level but also at the interpersonal and group level (*sangat*). Relationships with others serve as the primary source of self-definition, but it is also emphasized that social conceptualizations of self reflect a shared understanding of one's role in the social world. The individual and relational self are interdependent and play the roles of the 'I/me' and 'We/us'. The collective self as a group, or, say, a family member, works for the common good. From the standpoint of social identity, the concern is about the 'us' rather than the 'I'. The target is the individual, or a group of individuals. The shift that takes place from one level to the other indicates the interplay between the two conditions of existence. It helps the person to regulate one's self, that is, expressing one's individuality is necessary to be able to activate and sustain relationships and satisfy the need to belong.

Social cognition and self-transformation

The Sikh way of life, with its configuration of reality, the world and man's place and role in it, provides its adherents with a cluster of schemas and scripts for the formation of self-concept in given contexts. This, then, plays an important role in the domains of social perception, social memory, emotions, values, beliefs and decision-making. The social-cognitive processes provide various dimensions along which people conduct themselves. These can be identified as the schemas for *personal control*, an aspect central to coping with day-to-day life and times of crises. The Sikh way of life, which is performative in nature, offers opportunities for self-transformation. Guru Nanak emphasized that the main aim in life was to search for meaning. Meaning is not inherent in life but must be actively created and constructed by each person on a daily basis, and embodied in every action and thought.

Embodiment as knowledge-in-action: The social-spiritual continuum

Social phenomena constitute an indivisible aspect of the spiritual continuum (N. Singh, 1995). The mystical-spiritual experience is not distinct from everyday living. In fact, it is emphasized that the more active participation of the person in the secular, empirical world, the deeper would be the awareness of the Supreme Being, and vice versa. The *SGGS* places emphasis upon '*karnae/karni*' (right practice, efforts; *SGGS*, 21, 25, 952), that is, correct and constant practice. Knowledge is to be put to work in one's daily living, and only then can a person face life in all its hues and colours. Knowledge is not a load to be carried, and when put into practice it lightens the burden of everyday life activities.

Man cannot separate himself from the *sangat*, or community, as both go hand in hand for the growth and development of the person. The community is a necessary medium through which a man is transformed into a human being. Guru Nanak envisions a social universe that brings about a coherent social structure for spiritual unity. A balance of the social and spiritual worlds within a person is the desired state of being. Man has to attain spiritual progress via simultaneous inward enlightenment and outward social involvement. 'Both the approaches are complementary to each other. Without realization of inward self-illumination (*atam gyan*) actions are mere formalization and ritualism. And without social aspects it is a fruitless egoism and negation of social relations. In this way Sikhism advances a synthetic viewpoint which entails affirmation of the social reality.' (N. Singh, 1995, p. 22) As it is stated:

Creating the world, God has made it a place to practice spirituality. (*SGGS*, 1035)

Thus, social commitment and a householder's life are both central to Sikh practices. Otherwise, man would exist as a discrete, abstract, independent and isolated entity. Social relations synchronize the social and the spiritual values. The social world (*sangat*) is necessary, as man cannot accomplish spiritual uplift in a vacuum. In this context, it is important to note that the primary role of man is 'to make

the entire social fabric creative and virtuous' (D. Singh, 1994, p. 54). This indicates a shift from personal piety and salvation to social uplift, for only then can an individual person also achieve salvation. All ideals of man can be accomplished in the empirical world (W. Singh, 1992).

Finally, the integration of the fragmented, divisible selves of social and material worlds into one whole provides stability, continuity, flow, coherence and permanence.

Concluding comments

The emphasis in the Sikh vision of life is upon a holistic approach to the notion of personhood. It offers a synthesis of evolution at the bodily, social and spiritual planes of existence. This conceptualization is rooted in a view of life of responsible action, situated in the social world. The spiritual plane is not something other-worldly. It provides the necessary foundation to realize this very evolution and growth, thus contributing to human welfare and progress. It does not represent separation and individuality as the highest level of maturity. An individual is unitary and, at the same time, a multidimensional being, with physical, emotional, mental and spiritual aspects, manifesting in a physical, social and cultural context. Hence, Sikhism reframes the terms of our existence and helps us to understand our multidimensional nature. Group life, with its intricate web of relationships, complex connections and multiple demands, sets the pattern of how we understand our nature and shape ourselves. The Sikh way of life integrates the cognitive, affective, motivational and behavioural elements, and provides an orientation of the 'total' and 'complete' person.

Human nature can be realized through the recognition and acceptance of all the vital components present in man: his biological, spiritual, social, individual and private selves. It seems clear that since man is man, and not God, he must *accomplish* and *achieve humanness*. It cannot be given to him, nor can it be bought off the shelf. He has to work for it. Thus, the harmonization of all the possible selves makes a single human being.

The discovery and experience of an individual self is essential, for it is the channel, or the process, through which the person interacts with the outside world. The more a person is *aware* of himself in relation to others, the less he will be dependent on their influence and authority, and the more he will think for himself. 'Individualism in an interdependent society is the social ideal' (Marwaha, 2006, p. 211). Self-consciousness at the biological, social, individual, private and spiritual levels creates a human being. As Clark notes, humans have three basic needs—autonomy, bonding and meaning. 'A system that tells the individual of how bonding and autonomy is to be achieved, that is, how a secure self is to be formed is of importance. It must spell out and establish what constitutes "belonging" and in what ways individual "freedom" may be exercised' (Clark, 2002, p. 237). 'One function of the ideal cultural narrative is to show how all the various contributions to social life made during the several stages in the human life cycle

have equal significance, and are to be respected and valued equally in their particularities' (Clark, 2002, p. 235). In short, how a culture perceives human nature determines the way its people behave and conduct themselves.

The challenges of contemporary life place demands on performance, deeds and behaviour. The appeals for progressive, open-minded solutions compel us to look for some salient answers on how to be a complete being. When the Western perspectives view humans as one-dimensional, it becomes inadequate and a problematic issue, because a one-dimensional perspective of mankind provides an incomplete explanation of the myriad human activities. It provides a highly-restricted space for man to flourish. Further, such a stance, where person and society are viewed as separate entities, spells out an unfinished and fragmentary deliberation. Apparent achievement, accomplishment and success in materialistic terms translate into a transitory and short-lived feeling of triumph and attainment. They compel us to seek alternate solutions, and the Sikh perspective provides a balanced and holistic approach where the spiritual world and the material world, or *māyā*, are both held necessary for the emergence of the self. The materialistic/empirical consciousness, along with the spiritual consciousness, developed *in* and *through* social consciousness, reflects the all-inclusive aspect of the Sikh way of being human. The key to 'being human' is found in the realization of an expanding or encompassing vision of self, as emerging in a bonding of the inner and the outer, rather than confinement in any one of them. The self is nurtured by its surroundings, and absorbs the knowledge and socio-cultural practices from its environment to 'be' and 'become' human. Needless to say, while Sikhism has emerged as a specific system of thought, it offers a universal design and blueprint for human development.

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Organizational transformation through consciousness-centred training: A case study from the Indian Army

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In the context of contemporary organizations, training is deemed central not only for socialization in the professional environment and skill development, but also for improving productivity. The theories and practices of training and organizational development consider the rational individual a component of socio-economic processes, akin to a mechanical technology geared toward promoting wealth. In such efforts, the emphasis is primarily on augmenting various organizational outcomes by providing additional inputs to fill in the gaps. It is only recently that attention is being paid to the spiritual foundations and principles of work (see Chakraborty & Chakraborty, 2006; Singh Sengupta & Fields, 2007). The Indian tradition has useful models and practices rooted in a consciousness-centred mode of operation, which enables one to work more effectively and efficiently for some cause.

This chapter intends to briefly share the process and outcomes of the application of this approach in the unusual but very important organizational setting of the Indian Army. It was in the early 1990s that the Chief of Staff of the Indian Army, General B. C. Joshi, invited the present author to help raise the level of motivation in the Army from the prevalent, normal level of consciousness to a higher spiritual level. What follows is an informal, non-academic discussion of some of the outcomes that emerged from this experience. The chapter is organized in three sections. Section one explains the organizational structure in the army and the problems of training and motivation. Section two focuses on the application of a consciousness-based perspective and the challenges inherent in it, such as movement across levels of consciousness and problems of integration. The third and final section shares a practical agenda and draws certain conclusions based on the experiences.

Organizational structure

First of all, the Army is a collective organization where the individual is always

secondary to the group. In fact, the individual sacrifices himself for the group. The very first thing officers in training are taught before being commissioned is the famous motto of Chetwode, which says that the safety, welfare and honour of the country comes first and foremost; the safety and welfare of the men whom I command comes next; the safety, welfare and happiness of myself comes last. Now this idea, by means of its own force, instils an attitude of openness to spirituality, because the essence of spirituality is to forget oneself, and not to be egocentric. And this is drilled into the men right from day one.

The second point is that the Army is an organization which is very hierarchical. A major, if he has a problem, can only approach a lieutenant colonel. He is not permitted to move even one step further. A major general goes only to a lieutenant general. So it is a strict, clear hierarchical organization.

Third, motivation in the Army is centred in the ego. Rewards and punishments are doled out through a very rational system, but it is the ego that is the spur. And it is into this organization that a certain element of spirituality was to be brought in.

The Army has training courses before the men are commissioned. And after they are commissioned, regular courses continue to be given till the stage of lieutenant generals. The plan was to prepare teaching capsules right from the pre-commissioning level up to the highest level. The General wanted to introduce these capsules, which would be offered to the officers and sometimes to the *jawans*. There would be no compulsion for anyone to attend. The hope was, in the words of General Joshi, that a little spark of fire would turn into a blazing inferno and would motivate the men at a higher level.

The context of recruitment and training

There is another important point about the Army that helps one to understand better what is meant by the 'spark of fire' that was taken as a starting point. The day an officer or *jawan* is commissioned, he takes an oath in which he says that he is prepared to make the ultimate sacrifice for the organization and for the country. Now, none of us has to do that. You can join Delhi University and the moment you are dissatisfied, you can walk out. You can join the corporate world and the moment you are dissatisfied, you can go elsewhere. But in the Army there is no choice; once you are in, you are there for 20 years, or 15 years, depending on whether you are an officer or a *jawan*. You need not join the Army. It is not compulsory. But when you join, you *voluntarily* take the oath. And the beauty of the system is that these men who choose to take the oath mean every word of it. They do not do it blindly, they do it knowingly; they do it consciously, very deliberately, and you will see that when there is a possibility of war, every soldier and officer in a peace station wants to be in the midst of the action, knowing very well that tomorrow he might not come out of it alive.

Now, it is this on which one has to lay hold—that there is solid stuff there in the Army. This is so because the men are prepared to sacrifice their lives; and

after all, that is the most precious thing a man has! Survival is the first instinct and when men are consciously and deliberately prepared to sacrifice their lives, it shows that there is a spark of spirituality.

The use of this word, 'spark', does not mean that all these military men are floating high up somewhere near the consciousness of the overmind and the supermind; that is not true at all. They are from the same common stock as you and I are, but the training and demands they undergo create certain situations by which they move, or, more precisely, where there is a *possibility* of them moving upwards.

The issue of motivation

Here, it would be interesting to address the question of motivation. Why do people join the Army—especially in a free country like India, where there is no compulsion? I have analysed this and found that there are five basic motivations. The normal motivation, like everywhere in the world, is to make a living. This is especially true for *jawans*; when they have no jobs they join the Army—at least they know that they are going to get food, clothing, housing and some money. Officers join not only for that reason but also because of the element of glamour present in an Army career. Every time an Army officer comes dressed in uniform, all the young men look up with glittering eyes. So there is the attraction of career; there is a style of living which appeals to those who have seen it. And third, there is a spirit of adventure, which is especially attractive when one is young. In the Army there is a tremendous spirit of adventure. Fourth, there is the spirit of patriotism. This is especially noticeable every time there is a war. Immediately after the war, there is a rush to join the Army, and this rush is huge because the feeling of patriotism has been awakened. And finally, there is the spirit of self-sacrifice, which is not a very common motivation for joining the Army but which does come in at certain moments. And this, as we have already discussed, is the highest and noblest element in the human being. So there is a whole gradation of motivation.

With that background in mind, let us now examine some of the experiences undergone while implementing the teaching capsules, which were the means of operation. There were several concepts that the men needed to understand, one being that whatever man does in life is entirely dependent on what is happening inside him. A thief is first a thief inside, and then he goes to the shop and steals. A murderer is first a murderer inside and then he commits the act of murder. Therefore, if one wants to change anything in the world, one has to change it from the inside. Consequently the first step would be to try to promote self-recognition or awareness of what is inside, a step which could then lead to what I have called a 'resultant self-shaping'.

The meaning of consciousness

To begin with, the concept of consciousness needs to be well-understood: consciousness is the root of creation, consciousness evolves, and there are levels of

consciousness which go from the physical to the vital and then to the mental, and finally to the psychic and spiritual.

Here, one must note that the Indian Army is made up of all the religions in the world; and straightaway there were some objections. There were some men who refused to accept the concept of evolution. It took some time to get the idea across, but within six to eight months there was a complete reversal of position. Everyone began to accept the concept. Also, I had to take utmost care to not project any specific spiritual authority. The Army is secular in the sense that it does not have an official spiritual figurehead, because then people would immediately want it to be their own; there would be proponents of Sai Baba and Ramana Maharshi, as well as many others. When the first paper was presented, it included a quotation with the names of my gurus, and the Chief told me, 'Remove the names, paraphrase it a little bit, change one comma here and there and put it as if it is yours, and I will be able to get approval for the paper; otherwise I will have to face a huge protest.' So the necessary changes were made.

As mentioned earlier, the idea of consciousness had to be imparted to the soldiers. It is an important concept and requires the following explanations. First, there are levels of consciousness; second, behaviour depends on the level of consciousness on which one is. For example, somebody living entirely in the physical consciousness will be dull, inert, lazy, unwilling to make any effort. The basic characteristic of the physical being is inertia.

When one lives in the vital being, the characteristics are energy, enthusiasm, drive and desire; this desire, which is a help, becomes the root problem after some time. For, as it is said, desire is the helper at one stage; and desire becomes the bar at a later stage. So the second level of consciousness is the vital consciousness. An Army without a vital consciousness will not survive. It is the driving force.

The third level is the mental consciousness. When you are living in the mental consciousness, you are objective, you stand back, you watch. A referee on the basketball court has to be living in the mental consciousness. Also, as another example, when I am writing an ACR, I have to be completely detached.

Fourth is the spiritual consciousness, and here I have to touch upon a point because we use this word spirituality rather loosely. When one is living in the spiritual consciousness, one's motivation is absolute. Now, what is the meaning of this word 'absolute'? The opposite of absolute is 'relative'. Today all human beings, at almost every moment of life, experience things in a relative way. My happiness is relative because it depends on external circumstances. If somebody praises me, I am very happy. If somebody criticizes me, I am unhappy. My peace is entirely dependent on the circumstances outside and sometimes inside. With love it is still worse; I love you as much as you love me, I love you because you love me, it's pure commerce. You hardly ever find a human being who has peace which is absolute, who has love which is absolute.

An example of absolute love is Jesus Christ, who, when on the cross, can say, 'Forgive them for they know not what they do.' Even in that moment of crucifixion he is showering his love. But the normal human being says, 'If you kick me,

I'll kick you back', regardless of whether the kick is a physical one or another kind entirely. It comes down to the same thing. It is *extremely* difficult to enter a state of absolute consciousness, and yet—this is what I want to point out—there are soldiers and officers who *knowing fully well the consequences*, have sacrificed their lives to save their own commander, to save their own unit and nation. Now this is motivation of an extraordinarily high order. And also all those men, heroes, who have been awarded the *Param Vir Chakras* and the *Maha Vir Chakras* were moved by a total, non-calculating motive-force that drove them. The same person, after six months, can return to being absolutely egoistic, showing his *Param Vir Chakra* off to everyone. It only means that a spark of going up, a possibility of ascending to a higher level of consciousness is always there.

Movement across levels of consciousness

So the question is, how do we move from the physical consciousness to the vital consciousness to the mental, and ultimately to the psychic and spiritual? The first thing is self-recognition, which I mentioned earlier. Self-recognition means awareness. We must become aware of the levels of consciousness. That by itself takes time—to discover that everything is the play of consciousness; to discover that the physical, the vital, the mental are independent of consciousness. Consciousness is an independent factor.

To accomplish this, a series of exercises were given to the officers in workshops where 15–20 officers were present. Once the men began to perceive that there is something called consciousness, the next stage was introduced, which was to learn the *shifting* of consciousness: deliberate, concentrated shifting of consciousness. Little by little, by doing a few exercises, one can understand this and learn how to do it. Here is one example: I have decided that every morning after I get up at 5:30, I will go for a 4 kilometre run to keep myself fit. When I get up, I am lazy and I feel, 'Oh god, again I have to do this!' You are in the physical consciousness. Shift! Kick yourself a little bit and say, 'No! I have to prove to my commander that I am a good officer', and then you have shifted to the vital consciousness.

So, the first thing is to sit at home and do this exercise of being in the physical consciousness, being in the vital consciousness, being in the mental consciousness. This you are doing deliberately. All of us are constantly shifting between the physical, vital and mental; not deliberately, not knowingly, it is just happening. Very few are conscious of themselves, know what they want, and can consciously shift their consciousness. But it is a very, very important skill.

There have been officers in the Indian Army, senior officers, who have had bad tempers. One general couldn't stand fools. And if someone said something that he thought was nonsense, he wouldn't just say, 'You are talking nonsense', he would angrily swear at the person and call him names in typically rough, Army language. You cannot use that sort of language with a senior officer. It leads to great disharmony. The general knew he suffered from this defect and wanted to get rid of it. So the advice given to him was that as soon as he realised he was

beginning to lose his temper, he should go to the bathroom and splash some cold water on his face. That would bring the consciousness down to the physical level; however, one cannot always do that. It is better to learn how to shift one's consciousness at will from the vital to the mental. This is what children are being taught during a basketball game when they are asked to count to 10 when they get angry. Counting to 10 is simply another way of shifting from the vital consciousness to the mental consciousness.

The challenge of shifting from lower to higher levels of consciousness

After learning to observe and recognize the level of consciousness one is on, and after learning how to shift from one level to another, the next step is to develop the ability to live consciously at the level of consciousness that one wants. So first comes an awareness of consciousness, second is the ability to shift one's consciousness when at home alone. The third step is to do it in actual life circumstances, which is a little more difficult; sometimes, in fact, it is very much more difficult. It means a full gathering of one's self. And the fourth is something that all of us will discover if we look carefully at ourselves. We will find that we are made up of not just 4 parts, but 400 parts. The physical has its sub-divisions, the vital has plenty of sub-divisions, the mental has all its sub-divisions, and each one is pulling us in a different direction. In one state of consciousness one goes this way, when one comes down one goes in another direction. The result is that what you do in the morning, you undo in the evening. What you do well for a week, you undo completely in the next week.

The question of integration

It is indispensable, therefore, to go to the next step, which is called the integration of consciousness. Integration around what, though? You have to pick up the highest part of your being. I am not speaking of what Sri Aurobindo calls the psychic being, because the psychic being is not available to everyone on demand. One needs a very severe and intense discipline to discover the psychic being. But the highest part of your being, the higher mental or even something a little higher, quite close to the psychic being, can be within reach. Keep that at the centre of your being, and every thought, every feeling, every sentiment, everything that happens has to be referred back to that. And if that is done consciously and deliberately, the very fact that you have begun doing it will itself lead you gradually to a sort of cohesion in the being. Little by little, there will take place an organization of the being.

In that process, one of the most important things is to develop will power, because although the spirit is willing, the flesh is weak. One often knows what has to be done and yet one continues to do the wrong thing. One good example of this can be seen with smokers. Every smoker sees on his cigarette packet the legend 'smoking is injurious to health', and yet keeps smoking. He knows it is wrong and may even want to stop smoking, but continues doing it nonetheless. Now this

is a big problem for all of us. We cannot escape from this defect, even though some have it more than others. We have to integrate the whole being; we have to develop will power. So this is very fundamental.

A practical agenda

To summarize, then, these four exercises were given to the men. First was developing an awareness of consciousness, second was learning how to shift the consciousness when one is alone and quiet in one's room, third is learning to deliberately shift the consciousness in actual life, and fourth is the integration of consciousness. All this together forms a first, but very important step.

Next, there is a point regarding motivation within the Army itself. The Army has a structure which is absolutely pyramidal. Every year, about 1,000 officers are commissioned. Each officer, each young man of 22 years, thinks that after 35 or 40 years, 'I will become the chief'. So with 1,000 aspirants for a single post, there will be 999 disappointments, and only one success. And the unique thing about the Army is that there is only one chief, one vice-chief, 50-odd lieutenant generals, around 150 major generals, and so on; the numbers are fixed and so it looks like a pyramid. And as one goes up the pyramid, the disappointments increase. Frustrations start building up if career and reaching the top is the chief motivating force and aim of the officer.

Therefore, it is important to start shifting your aim early. And there have been people who have suffered a lot. There was a brigadier in the Indian Army in Secunderabad who invited me to give a talk. In the middle of the talk, he said, 'Please excuse me', and rushed out to catch a plane to Delhi. The Army Board was meeting, he was a brigadier and wanted desperately to become a major general, and so he had to put in a word here, and another there. The poor fellow came back disappointed. I was then staying at another brigadier's house and when I told him all this, he said, 'I don't worry because there is something called the Grand Design; if it is designed that I am going to be a major general, I will become one; if it is not designed I can rush to Delhi any amount of times, nothing will happen.' The first fellow returned without the promotion while this other man, sitting quietly in Secunderabad, was promoted to major general. The wife of the first man once came to me, very disturbed; 'I want peace, can I come to the Ashram?' I said, 'You can always come to the Ashram, but I can assure you that you can sit there for four hours and yet you will get no peace. Peace has to be installed and brought in from the inside. If you are hankering after a promotion to major general for your husband, I can write it down, you will not have peace.'

But ambition is one of the strongest motivating drives in the Armed Forces, and indeed in most human beings. If you take out the ego from the human being, he becomes a doormat without energy. There will be absolutely no initiative, no enthusiasm. A little criticism, and see how upset we get. So it means a lot of consciousness is needed, a lot of work has to be done on oneself. This is the first point.

The second point to be dealt with is leadership. A sentence from Sri Aurobindo

in his *The Renaissance in India* (1997, p. 49) provides the basis on which the whole concept of leadership is built:

The man who most finds and lives from the inner self, can most embrace the universal and become one with it; the Swarat, independent, self-possessed and self-ruler, can most be the Samrat, possessor and shaper of the world in which he lives, can most too grow one with all in the Atman.

So if you want to lead others, first learn to lead yourself. You must become the complete master of yourself, and that is why it is not necessary to go storming about in the world. Sri Aurobindo sat in one room and was changing the world completely. He didn't give lectures, didn't move about all over the place. He did all those things at one stage, but afterwards sat in one place, having attained complete self-mastery. And once that self-mastery is established, everything changes. Now this is a very important thing and is very evident in the Armed Forces because here, everybody knows everything about everybody else. You can talk any amount and brag about yourself; but when you are a true leader and are truly loved and respected, it becomes apparent when the time comes to leave your unit. It is said that during the farewell ceremony for a major general who is being transferred to another unit, if all his soldiers stand in line and shout '*Major General ki jay*', it is a clear indication that he is not popular. When they don't speak a single word and the voices are choked and sometimes tears can be seen, be sure that he is loved. And that is because in the unit, everybody knows everything about everybody else. One's character cannot be hidden. So to be a true leader, you have to have not only the power that authority gives you, but also that inner power that comes only because you have complete mastery over yourself. You are transparent in your dealings with everybody.

Conclusion

To conclude, I'll give two examples of the power of consciousness. A very senior officer, who was a major general in Kashmir, was posted in Rajauri and heading a Division which covered a huge area of several hundred square kilometres and had a large number of posts on the border that were daily facing the threat of some trouble from the other side. How could he supervise all of this? He had not heard of consciousness, but every evening he used to sit for meditation, and quietly concentrate on the whole area. And as he was passing from one area to another in his meditation, there would suddenly be some disturbance. He would note it down. Immediately after his meditation, he would ring up the brigadier of that area and warn him to be careful, 'tonight or tomorrow morning there will be trouble'. And invariably there was trouble. Now all this was done through the projection of consciousness to the different areas in the territories under his responsibility. And indeed, it was done very effectively.

Similarly, one of the most important elements of consciousness in the Armed Forces is being able to identify yourself with those serving under you. When

someone comes to you with a complaint, you can learn to come down to his level of consciousness and identify yourself totally with him. After that, before taking action, you should rise and shift back to your level of higher consciousness. Very often you don't care to listen to what the man is saying; you remain at your position and level of consciousness. In other cases you are just swept away by the person who comes to you. So you must learn to get inside, identify with the consciousness of the complaining officer, and afterwards get out and above and then act. We included this in our training classes, and the results have been excellent.

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Glossary of words of Sanskrit or Pali origin

For abbreviations, see list at end of Glossary

ācārya, a teacher, a spiritual guide who knows what to do and how to proceed, from *ācāra*, 'practice'.

ādhibhautika, belonging to the five elements, elemental.

ādhidaivika, belonging to the gods, or faculties of consciousness known as '*amam prāṇam cakṣuḥ śrotraṃ mano vācam*' (TaitUp 3.2); see also KeUp 1.1-9 etc.

ādhyātmika, belonging to the Self; in epistemology of consciousness, psychological.

advaita, non-dualistic, unique, monistic, identity of spirit and matter.

āgama, a tradition handed down; Tantra of the Śaiva and Śākta traditions.

agni, a sacrificial fire; universal godhead growing within the creation, incarnating and manifesting the gods.

ahamkāra, ego-sense; lit. 'saying or making "I"'; conception of one's individuality, self-consciousness (ChaUp etc.); the making of self, thinking of self, egotism (MBh etc.); the third of the eight sources of creation; the conception of individuality, individualization (in Sāṃkhya phil.).

ājñā, a command, an order; the fifth *cakra* in *sūkṣma śarīra*, subtle body, located in-between the eye brows, the *cakra* of will power, known as the third eye.

anāhata, lit. 'unbeaten', the fourth *cakra* in the heart centre of the *sūkṣma śarīra*, subtle body.

ānanda, bliss, the transcendental Bliss as a part and result of relation of *sat* and *cit*, divine Being and Consciousness.

aṅgirasah, seven legendary *ṛsis*, being an offspring of the godhead Agni, they carry his faculties. Indra and Uṣas are called

in the *Ṛg Veda* as 'the most of Angiras', *aṅgīrastama*. Agni is a main Aṅgiras. Bṛhaspati is also called Aṅgiras, with seven flames, seven tongues, or rays of light.

apāna, the breathing out; one of the five major *prāṇas*, the lower breath located in the navel and connected with *mṛtyu*, death; it is by *apāna* that *ātman* could come into material body, by death it could stay in the material form (AitUp 1.3); in the later literature it is located in the anus.

aparā, lit. 'not higher', 'lower' nature.

artha, aim, purpose, meaning, reason, object, thing, wealth etc.

āsana, lit. 'sitting'; sitting in a particular posture (eighty-four postures are mentioned, such as: *padmāsana*, *bhadrāsana*, *vajrāsana*, *vīrāsana*, *svastikāsana* etc.).

āśrama, a hermitage, a place in the forest for ascetics and sages to live; four major periods in the life of a *Brahmin*: *brahmacārin*, 'the student of the *Veda*'; *gṛhastha*, 'the household'; *vānaprastha*, 'living in the woods'; *saṃnyāsin*, 'the ascetic'.

aṣṭāṅga, consisting of eight parts; the *Yoga-sūtra* of Patañjali is sometimes called 'aṣṭāṅgayoga'.

asura, lit. '*asu-ra*', 'having power of being'; *asu* is a power of existence. In the *Veda* the great godheads, such as Varuṇa, Mitra, Aryaman, Agni, Indra etc., are called *Asuras*. They have their own power of existence. In the later literature this power to endure was assigned to the spirits of the lower hemisphere only, to the demons and the whole interpretation of the word has changed into *a-sura*, lit.

'no light'. In the *Purāṇas*, *Asuras* are the elder brothers of the gods and are in constant battle with them. *Asuras* belong to the first stage of creation, the fall of the Spirit, and therefore are older and stronger than gods in the field of manifestation. Gods belong to the second stage of creation, who came down to upraise the fallen spirits.

ātman, the self; the soul, the principle of life; used often as the word 'self' is used in English; distinguished from and one with *Brahman*, universal Spirit. When *Brahman* becomes self-aware it is distinguished as *ātman*. *Ātman* has three major poises: 1) *Paramātmān*, the supreme universal Self, 2) *Ātman*, the supreme individualised Self, unborn and everpresent and 3) *Antarātmān*, the individual soul involved in manifestation, the evolving Psychic Being (SA).

avatāra, lit. 'descending down', incarnation of a deity on earth; 10 *avatāras* of Viṣṇu are well-known.

avidyā, lit. 'not knowing', 'not finding', searching but not finding; partial knowledge as compared to *vidyā*, 'full knowledge'; ignorance; partial knowledge in time and space (ĪśUp 9-11).

avyakta, lit. 'unmanifest'; in Sāṃkhya philosophy 'the unevolved (Evoluer of all things)', the primary germ of nature, primordial element or productive principle whence all the phenomena of the material world come into being (KāthUp, Sāṃkhyak etc.).

āyu, living being, a group of living beings (mankind); a life force.

āyurveda, the science of health or medicine (it is classed among sacred sciences, and considered as a supplement of the *Atharva-veda*).

bhagavad-gītā, lit. 'The Song of the Blissful Lord (Kṛṣṇa)'.

bhaga-vat, Nom. '*bhagavān*'; lit. 'the Possessor or the Lord of Bliss', usually translated as 'Blissful Lord', Śrī Kṛṣṇa, Viṣṇu etc.

bhakti, lit. 'sharing', implying 'joy with the Lord'; devotion, devotional love.

bharadvāja, N. of a ṛṣi; in the *Rg Veda* he is the author of the sixth book.

bhāva, lit. 'a state of being'; can be any state of emotion, feeling etc., in the later literature means mainly the emotion.

bhoga, 'enjoyment', from the root *bhuj*, to enjoy.

bhūta, lit. 'that which has become', ppp from root *bhū*, to become, to be; 'the past', 'creature which is born on earth'; an element, there are five great elements, *pañca mahābhūtāni*, known as ether, air, fire, water, earth: *ākāśa*, *vāyu*, *agni*, *āpaḥ*, *prthivi* (TaitUp 2.1); a spirit (good or evil), the ghost of a deceased person, a demon etc. (Up, Mn etc.); see also 'ādhibhautika'.

brahma, Nom. from *brahman* n.; *Veda*, lit. 'expanding one', a *mantra* rising from the heart, the lord of which is Brahmanaspati, the *Guru* of the gods in the *Veda*. In the later literature *Brahma* is the all-embracing Spirit.

brahmā, Nom. from *brahman* m.; lit. 'the speaker of *brahma*, a *mantra*'; a priest in the sacrificial ceremonies; 'a creator' known in the later literature as *Prajāpati*; in the *Purāṇas* he is spoken of as part of the divine Trinity of *Brahmā*-Viṣṇu-Śiva, Creator-Preserver-Destroyer.

brāhmaṇa, n. *Brahmanic* literature (*Aitareya Brāhmaṇa*, *Taittiriya Brāhmaṇa*, *Kauṣitaki Brāhmaṇa* etc.); m. a person in the *varṇa* of *brāhmaṇa*, *Brahmin*.

buddhi, f. reason, intellect (Mn, MBh etc.); comprehension, apprehension, understanding. The second *tattva* of 25 *tattvas* of Sāṃkhya philosophy; the higher mind as distinguished from the sense-mind, *manas*.

caitanya, lit. 'conscious'; soul, spirit; N. of a reformer of the Vaishnava tradition (1485 AD).

caitya, (fr. cit) the individual soul (BhP iii, 26); the Psychic Being (SA), see 'antarātmān'.

carakasamhitā, Caraka's book on medicine.

cikitsā, medical attendance, practice or science of medicine.

cit, thought, intellect, spirit, soul; pure Thought; the divine Consciousness.

cit-śakti, the power of Consciousness or 'Consciousness-force'.

citta, lit. 'noticed', 'perceived', 'realised in consciousness'; the stuff of consciousness realised as memory.

citta-vṛtti, state of mind, feeling, emotion; continuous course of thoughts

(opposed to concentration), thinking, imagining.

cūḍāmaṇi, lit. 'a jewel worn by men and women on the top of the head' (MBh); N. of the work of Śaṅkarācārya.

dakṣiṇa, able, clever; right (not left); south, southern (also N. of a fire on the altar of *Agnihotra* rite) (RV); a donation, gift (for the priest of the sacrificial ceremony), reward.

damayanti, lit. 'subduing (men)'; N. of Nala's wife (MBh).

darśana, lit. 'view'; 6 major philosophical systems: Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā by Jaimini, Uttara-Mīmāṃsā by Bādarāyaṇa, Nyāya by Gotama, Vaiśeṣika by Kaṇāda, Sāṃkhya by Kapila, Yoga by Patañjali.

dhairya, intelligence (from root *dhī*, to think); firmness, steadfastness (from root *dhṛ*, to hold).

dhammapada, Buddhist treatise on *dharma* (3rd century BC).

dhāraṇā, lit. 'holding', 'concentrating (mind upon)'; the sixth stage of Patañjali Yoga before *dhyaṇa*, 'meditation'.

dhī, thought, esp. religious thought, reflection, meditation, devotion, prayer; pl. holy thoughts personified (RV); understanding, intelligence, wisdom; personified as the wife of Rudra-Manyu (BhP).

dhṛti, lit. 'holding steady' from the root *dhṛ*, to hold; steadfastness, steadiness, firmness etc.

dhyaṇa, meditation, thought, reflection; the seventh stage of Patañjali Yoga before *samādhi*; (in Buddhism) divided into 4 stages.

duḥkha, lit. 'difficult or spoilt space'; suffering, sorrow, pain.

gītā, lit. 'a song', ppp of root *gai*, 'to sing'; *Bhagavad-Gītā*, the song of the Blissful Lord (Śrī Kṛṣṇa).

grhastha, lit. 'staying home', a household; the second *āśrama* in the life of a *brāhmaṇa*, the period of marriage.

guṇa, a single thread or strand of a cord or rope; a garland, a bow-string; the string of a musical instrument, chord; subdivision, species, kind; a quality; an attribute of the 5 elements; (in Sāṃkhya phil.) three major qualities of *prakṛti*: *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*, i.e. tranquillity, activity

and inertia; (in Nyāya phil.) a property or characteristic of all created things.

harṣa, (from root *hrṣ*) excitement, erection (esp. of the hair in a thrill of rapture or delight); joy, pleasure, happiness (also personified as a son of *dharma*).

haṭhayoga, lit. 'yoga of persistence'.

homa, an oblation of *ghṛta*, clarified butter, to the fire as offering to the gods.

indra, the Lord of the Divine Mind (SA), who in the *Veda* with his striking Lightning destroys all the demons: Vṛtra, Vala, Śuṣṇa etc.

indriya, lit. 'the power of Indra', cognitive faculty of consciousness, sense: hearing, touch, sight, taste and smell, known in Sāṃkhya as *jñānendriyās*, the senses of cognition corresponding with five elements: *pañca mahābhūtāni*: *ākāśa*, *vāyu*, *agni*, *āpaḥ*, *prthivī*.

īśvara, master, lord, king; the Lord of Creation manifesting himself through his *Śakti* with no difference between Him and Her (SA).

jīva, lit. 'living being', from root *jiv*, 'to live'; the principle of life, the living or personal soul (as distinguished from the universal soul, see '*jīvātman*'); the individual soul involved in manifestation.

jīvātman, the living individual soul, not involved in manifestation but present as witness from above, distinct from the *paramātman* or universal soul.

jñāna, lit. 'knowledge', 'self-realization' (SA); there are many types of self-realization of consciousness: *saṃjñāna*, *ājñāna*, *vijñāna*, *prajñāna* (AitUp 3).

jñānayoga, the *yoga* of knowledge; the last six chapters of the *Gītā*.

kaivalya, lit. 'alone-ness', the state of being alone, where there is no other; absolute unity; detachment of the soul from matter.

kālī, black, of a dark colour, dark-blue; the goddess of utmost power of destruction, most powerful, furious and intolerant goddess, destroying the demons, also the universe and all creatures. The divine Mother in the form of divine Love, most intolerant of falsehood (SA).

kāma, (fr. *kam*), wish, desire, longing; desire

for, longing after (gen. dat., or loc.), love, affection, object of desire or of love or of pleasure; pleasure, enjoyment, love, especially sexual love or sensuality; N. of the god of love (in *Purāṇas* represented as son of Dharma and husband of Rati). In the *yogic* literature it is considered to be one of the major enemies of the *yogin* (BhG etc.) together with *krodha*, anger, and *moha*, bewilderment.

karmān, lit. 'work'; from root *kr*, 'to do'; duty, occupation; any religious act or rite; labour, activity; product, result, effect etc. In linguistics it is the second *kāraka* of Accusative case, indicating an object of action. In the *Vedic* literature it mainly means a 'sacrificial action', for the sacrifice in general was seen as the only right action to be performed here in the lower hemisphere, which is to accommodate the higher powers of consciousness (the gods) into the narrow life of Ignorance and thus to transform it into its higher prototype.

karmayoga, *yoga* of works; the first six chapters of the BhG describe it in great detail; according to Śrī Kṛṣṇa, the long forgotten path of the Ancients, where the dynamic way of self-discovery and self-realization was accepted as the most efficient way to reach the Divine. There are three major liberations in *karmayoga*: 1) freedom from the fruit of action; 2) freedom from attachment to any particular action; and 3) freedom from the notion of the doer.

kartā, lit. 'a doer'; in linguistics the first *kāraka* of the Nominative Case.

kṣetra, lit. 'a field', land, county; a field for manifestation of the soul; the body.

līlā, a play, amusement, 'child's play', pretence, disguise; in the Vaiṣṇava tradition it is the *līlā* of Kṛṣṇa which creates the world.

lobha, perplexity, confusion; impatience, eager desire for or longing after.

loka, lit. 'shining [space]'; from root *ruc*, 'to shine'; in the *Veda* *u-loka* or *uru-loka*, *ava-loka*, 'the vast world' is mentioned; country, world; in the *Purāṇas* seven *lokas* are mentioned: *bhūloka*, the earth; *bhuvāloka*, the space between heaven and earth, the sky, inhabited by *siddhas*; *svarloka*, the heaven above the Sun and

below the Polar Star, Indra's kingdom; *maharloka*, the great world above the Polar Star, inhabited by Bhargavas and other *ṛṣis*; *janarloka*, the world of Bliss, *ānanda*; *taparloka*, the world of Consciousness-Force, *tapas*; *satyaloka*, the world of the divine Existence, *sat*.

mahābhārata, epic of the Bhāratas.

mahāyāna, lit. 'great path', or 'great vehicle' (opp. to *hinayāna*); N. of the later system of Buddhist teaching by Nāgārjuna in the *Mahā-yāna-sūtras*.

mahī, lit. 'great one', N. of the Earth; in the *Veda* in duality 'heaven and earth', cp. to *rodasi*.

manas, sense-mind or mind (in its widest sense as applied to all the mental powers), intellect, intelligence, understanding, perception, sense, will (RV etc.); in philosophy the internal organ or *antaḥ-karaṇa* of perception and cognition, the faculty or instrument through which thoughts enter or by which objects of sense affect the soul; in this sense *manas* is always regarded as distinct from *ātman* and *puruṣa*, 'self or soul' and belongs only to the body. In RV sometimes joined with *hṛd* or *hṛdaya*, the heart; or with *cakṣus*, the eye; thought, imagination, reflection, opinion, intention, inclination, affection, desire, temper, spirit.

mānava, lit. 'the descendent of Manu', man, mental being.

mātā, Nom. from *mātr*, lit. 'a measuring one', creatrix, mother.

māyā, lit. 'creative power', 'measuring power'; in the *Vedas* it is a 'power manifesting the Supreme'; later in the post-*Vedic* literature an 'illusion'.

māyāvāda, the doctrine of *Māyā*, based on the belief that the material world is an illusion, asserting the permanence of the Spirit, and the temporality of material creation, *brahma satyaṃ jaganmithyā*, (Śrī Śāṅkarācārya).

medhā, mental vigour or power, intelligence, prudence, wisdom, (RV. etc.).

mokṣa, liberation, ultimate emancipation, (see 'mukti').

mudita, lit. 'delighted', ppp from *mud* 'to be happy'; joyful, glad, rejoicing etc.

mukti, liberation, from *muc* 'to free'; setting or becoming free, release, liberation; final liberation or emancipation, final

beatitude (= *mokṣa*). The concept of *mukti* is changing over the period of time from the *Vedic* understanding, where *mukti* is only a condition for a more effective action in manifestation of a freed spirit, to the concept of *mukti* where the manifestation itself is seen as an ultimate prison which is to be gotten rid of altogether as soon as possible (Māyāvāda doctrine).

muni, a sage, seer, monk etc.

nāḍi, any tube or pipe, (esp.) a tubular organ (as a vein or artery of the body); there are 72,000 *nāḍis* in the *sūkṣma deha*, subtle body, of man, of which 5 major *prāṇas* are mentioned: *prāṇa*, *apāna*, *vyāna*, *samāna*, *udāna*.

naiṣṭhikī, from *ni-ṣṭhā*; forming the end, final, last; highest, perfect, complete.

nāmakaraṇa, lit. 'making a Name', one of the *saṃskāras*.

nārada, N. of a sage, known as *deva-ṛṣi*, the divine *Ṛṣi*.

nārāyaṇa, N. of Viṣṇu; the universal Soul, whereas *nara* is the individual soul.

nidrā, lit. 'deep sleep'; from *ni-drā*, 'to fall deep into sleep'.

nirodha, lit. 'total obstruction', from *ni-rudh*; restraint, check, control, suppression, destruction; aversion, dislike etc.

nirvāṇa, lit. 'extinguished state', 'without a breath'; from *nir-vā*, 'to blow out', to live without life, as it were; a state of ultimate peace in which the whole world is seen as unreal, as if in a movie (SA); the ultimate goal of Buddhism and Jainism as an absolute extinction or annihilation (= *śūnya*) of individual existence or of all desires and passions; perfect calm or repose or happiness, highest bliss or beatitude.

niṣkāma, lit. 'without desire'; desireless, disinterested, unselfish.

niṣṭhā, lit. 'totally stable'; situated within.

niyama, lit. 'fixed rule' or 'vow'; the second stage in the eightfold discipline of Yoga: *yama-niyama-āsana-prāṇāyāma-pratyāhāra-dhāraṇā-dhyāna-samādhayo aṣṭāva aṅgāni* (YS 2.29); five *yamas* are: *ahiṃsā-asatya-asteya-brahmacarya-aparigraha yamāḥ* (YS 2.30); and five *niyamas*: *śauca-santoṣa-tapaḥsvādhyāya-īśvarapraṇidhānāni niyamāḥ* (YS 2.32).

nyāya, lit. 'going to the bottom of things', a logic; an original type, method, rule,

esp. a general or universal rule, system; a logical or syllogistic argument or inference, consisting of five members: *pratijñā* (a proposition), *hetu* (an argument, deduction, or reason for an inference), *udāharaṇa* (example), *upanaya* (application), *nigamana* (conclusion); a system of philosophy delivered by Gotama or Gautama (see also '*darśana*').

parā, lit. 'beyond', 'transcendent'; supreme.

parama, see '*parā*'.

patañjali, N. of the author of *Yogasūtras*; N. of the author of *Mahābhāṣya* on *Pāṇini Aṣṭādhyāyī* (2 cent. BC).

piśācas, the lowest kind of demons, who like to eat flesh (*piśa*).

prahlāda, lit. 'delight'; N. of a pious *daitya*, son of the Asura Hiraṇyakaśipu.

prajñā, 'discrimination', 'knowledge by apprehending cognition'; wisdom etc.

prakāśa, lit. 'light', 'shining forward'; illumination, elucidation; clear etc.

prakṛti, lit. 'making or placing before or at first', the original or natural form or condition of anything, original or primary substance; cause, original source; nature, character etc.; (in Sāṃkhya phil.) 'the original producer' of the material world (consisting of 3 constituent essences or *guṇas* called *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*); Nature as distinguished from *puruṣa*, Spirit, just as *Māyā* is distinguished from *Brahman* in the Vedānta.

prāṇa, lit. 'breath'; there are five major *prāṇas*: *prāṇa*, 'breathing in', *apāna*, 'breathing out', *vyāna*, 'pervading breath', *samāna*, 'equalizing breath', *udāna*, 'rising up breath'.

prāṇāyāma, 'breath-exercise'; there are three major breaths on which *prāṇāyāma* is built: *pūraka* (breathing in), *recaka* (breathing out), *kumbhaka* (holding).

prapañca, lit. 'spreading forward'; from root *pañc*, 'to expand'; expansion, development, manifestation; phenomenon; (in philosophy) the expansion of the universe, the visible world.

pratyāhāra, lit. 'withdrawing'; in Yoga 'withdrawing of the senses (*indriya*)' from the object of sense (*artha*). It is the sixth stage of Patañjali *Yogasūtras* (see '*niyama*').

pravacana, recitation, oral instruction,

teaching, expounding, exposition, interpretation.

pravṛtti, lit. 'rolling forward'; moving on-wards, advance, progress; coming forth, appearance, manifestation; rise, source, origin.

prekṣā, seeing, viewing, regarding; consideration, reflection.

preta, lit. 'gone', dead.

preyas, lit. 'more loved', more desired; desirable.

puṇya, moral or religious merit.

purāṇa, lit. 'ancient'; N. of a class of sacred works. 18 major *Purāṇas* are grouped in 3 divisions: 1) *Brahmā* of the *Brahma*, *Brahmāṇḍa*, *Brahmavaivarta*, *Mārkaṇḍeya*, *Bhaviṣya*, and *Vāmana Purāṇa*; 2) *Viṣṇu* of the *Viṣṇu*, *Bhāgavata*, *Nāradiya*, *Garuḍa*, *Padma*, and *Varāha Purāṇa*; 3) *Śiva* of the *Śiva*, *Līṅga*, *Skanda*, *Agni* or in place of it the *Vāyu*, *Matsya*, and *Kūrma Purāṇa*.

puruṣa, a man, a principle of man, a person; in the *Vedas* the transcendental or universal Man, embodying all the faculties of Consciousness, who was sacrificed (RV 10.91) or whose faculties were sacrificed (AitUp 1-2) projecting the universal Consciousness in the terms of faculties of consciousness into manifestation and thus evoking the evolution of individual being; in *Sāṃkhya* the principle of the Soul, a witness whose engagement with *prakṛti* creates the Universe.

rajas, 'coloured or dim space', the sphere of vapour or mist, region of clouds, space; in the *Veda* the lower and higher atmospheres; sometimes also three vital spaces; (in phil.) the second of the three *guṇas* or qualities (see also '*sattva*', and '*taṃas*'); sometimes identified with *tejas*.

rākṣasa, lit. 'of *rākṣas* quality'; an evil or malignant demon; in the post-*Vedic* literature divided into 3 classes: a semi-divine nature and ranking with *Yakṣas*; corresponding to Titans, relentless enemies of the gods; demons going about at night, haunting cemeteries, disturbing sacrifices and even devouring human beings; this last class is the one most commonly mentioned.

rāmāyaṇa, great epic poem of Vālmīki about Rāma and Sītā; it contains about 24000 verses.

rasa, lit. 'essence', a juice, a marrow, a liquid; taste, flavour, there are 6 original tastes — *madhura*, sweet, *amla*, sour, *lavaṇa*, salt, *kaṭuka*, pungent, *tikta*, bitter, *kaṣāya*, astringent. In Rhet. the taste or character of a work, the feeling or sentiment prevailing in it, *śṛṅgāra*, love, *vīra*, heroism, *bībhatsa*, disgust, *raudra*, anger or fury, *hāsyā*, mirth, *bhayaṇaka*, terror, *karuṇa*, pity, *adbhuta*, wonder, *śānta*, tranquillity or contentment, *vātsalya*, paternal fondness.

rāśi, a heap, a pile.

ṛg, from *ṛc*, the sacred word or hymn of the *Ṛg Veda*.

roga, a disease, sickness.

rogī, ill, sick.

ṛṣi, a seer, an inspired poet, a composer of the *Vedic* hymns. There are two kinds mentioned in the *Veda*: *pūrva ṛṣayah*, the first *ṛṣis* and *nūtanāḥ*, the modern ones. In the *Brāhmaṇas* seven *ṛṣis* are often mentioned; according to ŚBr xiv, 5, 2, 6, these are: Gotama, Bharadvāja, Viśvāmitra, Jamadagni, Vasiṣṭha, Kaśyapa, and Atri. In astronomy the seven *ṛṣis* constitute the Great Bear constellation. For each *manvantara* there is a different set of seven *ṛṣis* who bring the *Veda* into action within the human consciousness.

saccidānanda, Existence-Consciousness-Bliss; the transcendental Divine.

ṣaḍ-darśana, 6 major philosophical systems: *Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā* by Jaimini, *Uttara-Mīmāṃsā* by Bādarāyaṇa, *Nyāya* by Gotama, *Vaiśeṣika* by Kaṇāda, *Sāṃkhya* by Kapila, *Yoga* by Patañjali.

sadguṇa, lit. 'having good qualities'.

sādhana, means of realising the goal, a discipline of *yoga*.

sahasradala, lit. 'thousand-petalled' lotus; the *cakra* at the top of the head; the seat of Śiva in Tantra, where Śiva and Śakti meet and become one.

sahasrāra, see '*sahasradala*'.

śākta, belonging to the tradition of Śāktas; relating to power or energy, or worshipping the *śakti* or divine energy, especially as identified with Durgā, wife of Śiva.

śakti, lit. 'force, power, ability', from root *śak*, 'to be able to'; the power of the Divine, known as *Mahāśakti*, in the post-*Vedic* tradition known in her four aspects: *Maheśvarī*, *Mahākālī*, *Mahālakṣmī*,

Mahāsarasvatī, representing Knowledge, Power, Beatitude and Perfection, respectively (SA).

samabuddhi, esteeming all things alike, indifferent.

samādhi, lit. 'becoming one with', union with, completion; concentration of the thoughts, intense absorption or a kind of trance; profound meditation, intense contemplation of any particular object (so as to identify the contemplator with the object meditated upon); this is the eighth and last stage of Yoga; (in Buddhism) the fourth and last stage of *dhyāna*.

samāna, see 'prāṇa'.

sambandha, lit. 'binding together'; association, relation, relative, friend etc.

sāṃkhya, N. of a philosophical system, ascribed to the sage Kapila, meaning lit. 'enumerating' the major essential categories or twenty-five *tattvas* (twenty-three of them evolved out of *prakṛti*, 'the first-producer', these are *buddhi*, *ahaṃkāra*, *manas*, the five *tanmātras*, the five *karmendriyas*, the five *jñānendriyas*, the five *mahā-bhūtas*; the twenty-fifth is the *puruṣa*, spirit or soul, which is neither a producer nor production); there are many *puruṣas* and one *prakṛti*; each separate *puruṣa* causes by its union with *prakṛti* a separate creation out of *prakṛti*; the object of this philosophy is to effect the final liberation of the *puruṣa* from the bondage caused by that creation. The Yoga branch of the Sāṃkhya recognizes a supreme spirit, the universal *puruṣa*, dominating each individual *puruṣa*. The Tantras identify *prakṛti* with the wives of the gods, esp. with the wife of Śiva.

sāṃkhya-yoga, *yogic* practice based on the Sāṃkhya philosophy, *yoga* of Sāṃkhya.

saṃskāra, lit. 'putting together' or 'making perfect', accomplishment etc.; a sacred or sanctifying ceremony; faculty of memory, mental impression or recollection; impression on the mind of acts done in a former state of existence (one of the 24 qualities of the Vaiśeṣikas); (pl., in Buddhism) a mental conformation or creation of the mind (such as that of the external world).

saṅkalpa, intention, determination;

conception or idea or notion formed in the mind or heart.

sannyāsa, lit. 'dropping totally off', resignation, renunciation of the world; the fourth *āśrama* in the life of a *brāhmaṇa*.

śānti, peace.

santoṣa, 'happiness', total satisfaction.

sarasvatī, lit. 'who possesses the stream'; N. of a river; the river-goddess who in the *Vedas* has seven sisters and is herself sevenfold; in the *Brāhmaṇas* she is identified with *vāc*, 'speech'; N. of the goddess of eloquence and learning in the post-Vedic period; truth-audition, inspiration, the divine word (SA).

śarīra, body, physical body.

śāstra, instruction, rule, order, a manual, a treatise, a book of knowledge etc.

satī, 'faithful wife'.

sattva, lit. 'the quality of that which is'; true existence, the highest of the three *guṇas*, qualities, of *prakṛti*, that of purity and knowledge (see '*rajas*' and '*tamas*').

satyayuga, lit. 'the age of Truth'; the first and the longest of the four *yugas* in every *manvantara*.

śava, a corpse, a dead body.

śavāsana, the *āsana* of full relaxation.

śāvitṛī, a verse in *gāyatrī* meter addressed to the god of the Sun, Savitr, (RV III. 62, 10); the daughter of Savitr, the divine Word (SA); the wife of Brahmā, the creator of the world; the wife of Satyavān, in the story of *Śāvitṛī* in the MBh.

sevā, service, attendance to, worship etc.

śikṣaka, a teacher, instructor.

smṛti, memory, the whole tradition which was handed down by composing and memorizing the text, in opposition to *śruti*, a direct revelation of the inspired Word, which was not composed but 'heard' by a deeper listening of the soul.

sphuraṇa, lit. 'trembling', 'bursting out', breaking forth; expansion, manifestation.

śreyas, lit. 'better', 'more splendid', from *śrī*; in *Kaṭha Upaniṣad* it is used as a concept of the ultimate good, in opposition to *preyas*, which is 'more desirable', so that one can choose the path between what is 'liked or desired' and what is 'better or best', respectively.

sukha, lit. 'good space', from *su-kha*;

happiness, well-being; in opposition to *duḥ-kha*, 'bad space', as suffering, grief, unhappiness, sorrow etc.

sukha-duḥkha, happiness and unhappiness; the *yogin* is to be equal to both according to the *Gītā*.

suśrutasaṃhitā, the collection of verses dedicated to medical studies by Suśruta, who is its author and a son of Viśvāmitra (see also another medical treatise *Carakasamhitā*).

sūtra, 'a thread', a cord, a string, which connects or holds many beads; a short sentence or aphoristic rule; major works of *smṛti* literature were composed in this style; we have *śrauta-sūtras*, *grhya-sūtras*, *dharma-sūtras* etc.

svabhāva, lit. 'one's own nature'; according to the nature of the individual soul.

svadharma, lit. 'one's own law or way of action'; according to the law supported by one's *svabhāva*.

svādhyāya, lit. 'reading for oneself'; a technique of reading the scripture for oneself in order to realize its deeper significance.

tamas, lit. 'darkness'; mental darkness or ignorance; one of the three modes of *prakṛti* constituting inertia and dullness in the being.

tantra, lit. 'the principal or essential part', characteristic feature, model, type, system, framework; a class of works which presents the *Vedic* knowledge in the *kali yuga*. There are three kinds of Tantra: Vaiṣṇava, Śaiva and Śākta.

tāntrika, the *tāntric* who practices Tantra.

tattva, lit. 'that-ness'; the essential quality; a true principle; truth etc.; in Sāṃkhya there are 25 *tattvas*: *a-vyakta*, *buddhi*, *ahaṃkāra*, *manas*, the 5 *tan-mātras*, the 5 *mahā-bhūtas*, the 10 organs of action and perception, and *puruṣa*.

triguṇa, lit. 'of three qualities', of *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*.

triguṇātīta, lit. 'gone beyond three qualities'; liberated etc.

trṣṇā, thirst.

udāna, one of the five *prāṇas* of the human body (that which is in the throat and rises upwards).

udāsīna, lit. 'sitting above'; sitting apart, indifferent, free from affection.

upanayana, the ceremony in which a *guru* initiates a boy (*brāhmaṇa* at the age of 7 or 8 years, *kṣatriya* at 11, and *vaiśya* at 12) into one of the three *varṇas*, called twice-born, where he is invested with the sacred thread and thus introduced to his second or spiritual birth, and becomes qualified to learn the *Vedic* texts.

upaniṣad, lit. 'sitting down close to'; the sacred texts which are a part of *Brāhmaṇa* literature.

upekṣā, overlooking, disregard, negligence, indifference, contempt.

uttara, lit. 'higher'.

vaidya, lit. 'belonging to *Veda*'; medical: a learned man, a doctor.

vairāgya, lit. 'loss of colour'; disgust, distaste for; freedom from all worldly desires, asceticism.

vaiśeṣika, philosophical doctrine by Kaṇāda about the distinct nature of the nine substances: air, fire, water, earth, mind, ether, time, space, and soul, of which the first five, including mind, are held to be atomic.

vaiśya, lit. 'belonging to people, *viś*', one of the *varṇas* of traders and agriculturists.

vāsudeva, lit. 'the son of Vasudeva', N. of Kṛṣṇa.

vedanā, lit. 'letting know' or 'announcing'; perception; pain.

vedānta, lit. 'the end of *Veda*'; *Upaniṣads*; there are different interpretations of Vedānta: Advaita, Dvaita, Viśiṣṭādvaita.

vedavyāsa, N. of a legendary *ṛṣi*, who arranged the *Vedic* hymns into the branches and books of the *saṃhitās* in the form they are known to us today.

vidyā, knowledge; as in opposition to *avidyā*, ignorance or partial knowledge; knowledge of phenomena in time and space; *vidyā* and *avidyā*, according to the *Īsopaniṣad*, are both necessary for the realisation of the Supreme Consciousness.

vikalpa, variation, difference in perception, doubt.

vinaya, lit. 'leading away' or 'separating'; leading, guidance, training, education, discipline, control; in Buddhism the rules of discipline for monks; decency, modesty.

vīra, a hero; strong, powerful.

viṣṇu, lit. 'vi-ṣnu, who broadens the oneness'; in the *Veda* the godhead of vastness, Overmental Consciousness, the younger brother of Indra, who is the godhead of the Divine Mind (SA). In the post-*Vedic* literature is described as having 10 *avatāras*, becomes one of the major gods of Hinduism.

viveka, lit. 'discrimination', distinction; in Vedānta the power of separating the invisible Spirit from the visible world (or spirit from matter, truth from untruth, reality from mere semblance or illusion).

viyoga, lit. 'dis-union', separation.

vr̥tti, lit. 'rolling', 'that which is repeating itself'; conduct, behaviour, character, practice etc.

vyādhi, lit. 'sickness', from root *vyadh*, 'to be pierced'.

vyādhita, sick.

vyāsa, N. of a legendary *ṛṣi*, the composer of *Mahābhārata* and a compiler of the *Vedas* and *Purāṇas*.

yajña, sacrifice, lit. 'the conscious act of advancing towards more conscious manifestation'; 'manifesting the Spirit in a conscious way'; 'bringing the powers of light into the darkness'; 'offering the powers of darkness to the Light for transformation'.

yama, lit. 'restrain', (see '*niyama*'); In the *Veda* he is one of the *Āṅgīrasa ṛṣis*; the first of men who was born from Vivasvat, the god of the Sun, and his wife Saranyū; in Post-*vedic* mythology he becomes the lord of Death, judging and punishing people for their deeds after death, whereas in the *Veda* he is the saviour of the soul in the time of death rather than the Death incarnate.

yoga, (fr. *yuj*) the act of yoking, joining, uniting (RV, MBh); an abstract contemplation, meditation, (esp.) self-concentration; practised as a system taught by Patañjali and called *yoga darśana*, it is the second of the two Sāṅkhya systems, its aim is to teach the means by which the human spirit may attain complete union with Īśvara; in the practice of self-concentration it is closely connected with Buddhism (Up, MBh, Kāv etc.). In Sāṅkhya it means the union of soul with matter (one of the 10 *mūlikārthas* or radical facts, *tattvas*); with Jinas, contact or mixing with the outer world; in astronomy, conjunction, lucky conjuncture (MBh etc.). There are many kinds of *yoga*. *Karmayoga*, *bhaktiyoga*, *jñānayoga* are dealt with in detail in the *Bhagavad Gītā*. There are also other kinds of *yoga*: *dhyāna-yoga*, *rājayoga*, *haṭhayoga*, *kriyāyoga*, *pūrnayoga* etc. Patañjali defines *yoga* in the *Yogasūtra* as ceasing the activities of *citta*: *yogaś-citta-vr̥tti-nirodhaḥ*, which can be translated as: 'yoga is a cessation of the habitual movements of consciousness.' Generally speaking, any practice which leads the practitioner eventually to union with the Divine can be called *yoga*.

yoga-nidrā, lit. 'sleeping *yoga*', 'meditation-sleep', a state of half meditation/half sleep (which admits the full exercise of the mental powers); light sleep, esp. the sleep of Viṣṇu at the end of a *yuga*.

yoga-sūtra, N. of a work by Patañjali (2nd cent. BC).

yogavāsīṣṭha, N. of a work on *yoga* in the form of a dialogue between Vasiṣṭha and Rāma as his disciple.

yogī, lit. 'one who practices *yoga*'.

yoni-mudrā, N. of a particular position of the fingers.

Abbreviations of source-texts used in the Glossary

AitĀr	Aitareya-Āraṇyakam
AitBr	Aitareya-Brāhmaṇam
AitUp	Aitareya-Upaniṣad
ĀśvŚr	Āśvalāyana Śrauta-sūtra
AV	Atharva-veda Saṁhitā
BṛhUp	Bṛhadāraṇyaka-Upaniṣad
BhP	Bhāgavata Purāṇa
BhG	Bhagavad-Gītā
Buddh	Buddhist
ChaUp	Chandogya-Upaniṣad
Gr	Gṛhya-sūtra
ĪśUp	Īśa-Upaniṣad
JaiUpBr	Jaiminiya-Upaniṣad-Brāhmaṇam
Hariv	Harivaṁśa
KāthUp	Kātha-Upaniṣad
KātyŚr	Kātyāyana Śrauta-sūtra
KauṣBr	Kauṣitaki-Brāhmaṇam
KauṣUp	Kauṣitaki-Upaniṣad
KeUp	Kena-Upaniṣad
MaitrS	Maitrayaṇi Saṁhitā
Mn	Manu Smṛti
MāṇdUp	Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad
MunḍUp	Munḍaka-Upaniṣad
MaitUp	Maitrī-Upaniṣad
MBh	Mahābhārata-yuddham
Nir	Niruktam
Pāṇ	Pāṇini
PraUp	Praśna-Upaniṣad
Rm	Rāmāyaṇam
RV	Rig-veda Saṁhitā
ŚBr	Śatapatha-Brāhmaṇam
Sarvad	Sarvadarśanasanāgraha
Sāy	Sāyaṇa
SA	Sri Aurobindo
Sāṁkhyak	Sāṁkhyakārika
ŚvetUp	Śvetāśvatarā-Upaniṣad
Suśr	Suśrutasaṁhitā
TaitĀr	Taittirīya-Āraṇyakam
TaitBr	Taittirīya-Brāhmaṇam
TaitUp	Taittirīya-Upaniṣad
TS	Taittirīya Saṁhitā
Tattvas	Tattvasamāsa
Up	Upaniṣads
VS	Vājasaneyī Saṁhitā
VP	Vākyapadīya
Vedāntas	Vedāntasāra

Other abbreviations used in the Glossary

Abl.	Ablative case
Acc.	Accusative case
aor.	aorist
Caus.	Causative
cent.	century
cp.	compare
Dat.	Dative case
Desir.	Desirative
du.	Dual
esp.	especially
Freq.	Frequentative
f.	feminine gender
fr.	from root
fut.	Future Tense
Gen.	Genitive case
ger.	Gerundive
gram.	Grammar
incl.	including
inf.	Infinitive
inj.	injunctive
imperf.	Imperfect (Past Tense)
Imp.	Imperative Mood
Inst.	Instrumental case
ling.	linguistics
lit.	literally
Loc.	Locative case
m.	masculine gender
n.	neutral gender
N.	name
Nom.	Nominative case
opp.	opposite
Opt.	Optative Mood
perf.	perfect
phil.	philosophy
pl.	plural
ppp.	Participle Perfect Passive (Participle II in English)
pfp.	Participle Future Passive
pres.	Present Tense
Rhet.	Rhetoric
sg.	singular
subj.	subjunctiv

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Index

- Abhimanyu, story of, 123–124
ācārya, 157
actionless Self, 143
adhikāra bheda, 60
Advaita Vedānta, 211
agni, 4
Ahalyā, 245
ahankāra (ego sense), 142
ājñā, 89
akartā, 143
Alcoholics Anonymous (AA), 74
Amṛtanāḍopaniṣad, 86
anāhata, 89
ānanda, 44, 58
anapana-śati, 87
annaprāsana, 243
antaraṅga yoga, 85, 87
apūrva vaidya, 121
artha, 119
āsana (posture) 84, 122
āśrama, 41
aṣṭāṅga or Eight Limb *yoga*, 5, 84–85
ātman, 85, 135
Ātreya, Bhikṣu, 126
Aurobindo, Sri, 19
autonomic functioning, 90
avidyā (ignorance), 39–40, 48, 50, 54–55, 57–58
Āyurveda
 and *āyu*, 11
 Caraka's philosophy, 9–13
 division of text, 9
 healing and healthy living, 118–119
 higher education, 122–127
 physical postures and breath regula-
 tions, 121
 physician, ability of, 121
 'Physician, heal thyself', dictum, 120
 psycho-spiritual transformation, 120
 self-transformation, approach to, 120–122
 state of health and well-being, 3, 118
 twin goals of healing and education, 122
 ultimate healing, 119
 yoga, practice of, 121–122
Bahuguna, Sunderlal, 230
Baker, Richard St. Barbe, 228
Basic Education Scheme (*Bunyadi Talim*),
 157, 159
Behn, Mira, 230
being– becoming, relationship between, 109
Bhagavad Gītā, 13, 86, 104, 142
Bharadvāja, 126
Bhāratavarṣa, 226
Bible, 59
Bihar School of Yoga, 90
Bimla Behn, 230
bio-psychosocial model of health and ill-
 ness, 209–210
body-talk (awareness) technique, 93
brahman, 40, 135, 142
Brahmavaivarta Purāṇa, 244
broad-based integral education, 109
Buddha, Gautama, 87
buddhi (intellect), 85
buddhi (reasoning principle), 142
Buddhist psychology, 66
caitya puruṣa, 107
capitalism, 189
Caraka Saṁhitā, 118, 120, 126
Caraka's philosophy of medicine
 acts that lead to ailments, 12
 afflictions, 11
 cikitsā, 10
 curing methods, 10
 definition of happy life, 11
 prajñāparādha, 12
 puruṣa, 10
 removal of mental ailments, 12
 sadvṛttis, 12–13
 sāttvika, 12
 suffering, 10
Chidananda, Swami, 230
child rearing (*lālan-pālan*)
 Āyurvedic model, 242–243

- breast-feeding and observing a fast, 247
- childhood in cultural context, 239–241
- contemporary trends, 246
- Indian view, 241–242
- in Indian mythology, 245–246
- Japanese view, 240–241
- in north Indian cities, 247–248
- ritualistic child welfare beliefs, 247
- and *saṁskāras*, 241–244
- children's classroom model for *pratyāhāra*, 88
- Chipko (hug-the-tree) movement
 - achievement of leaders, 229
 - community involvement process, 230–232
 - Garhwali people's understanding of development, 230
 - implications for psychology, 232–233
 - model of sustainable development, 231–232
 - overview, 227–229
- cit-śakti*, 56
- civilisation and progress, 139
- cognitive psychology, 134
- composite being (*āśi puruṣaḥ*), 3
- computer-aided learning, 134
- contemplative mind, 143
- cosmic forces, concept of, 56
- counseling, 42
 - guru-śiṣya* form of, 59
 - psychotherapeutic, 39
 - spiritual, 58
- cūḍākaraṇa saṁskāra*, 243
- cultural imprints, 154
- cultural sensitivity, 227
- Damayanti, 245
- Darśanopaniṣad*, 85
- Datey's relaxation technique, 91
- defeatism, 58
- Devi, Shashthi, 243
- dharamshala, 261
- dhāraṇā* (concentration), 84
- dharma*, 108, 119, 157, 230
- dhyāna* (meditation), 84
- dirgha āyu*, 11
- discipline, 153
- Divine Consciousness, 15
- Divine Grace, 59
- doṣas*, 4
- dvārapāla*, 113
- Eastern philosophies, 38
- educating the mind, process of, 148–149
- Education Commission (1964–1966), 133
- education in India
 - Buddhist period, 157
 - during the colonial period, 157–158
 - after independence, 157
 - Indian ethos, 159
 - Macaulay's ideas, 157
 - of modern times, 157–158
 - paurāṇika* period, 156
 - Sri Aurobindo's thoughts, 107–108, 136, 159–162
 - Swami Vivekananda's educational thought, 159
 - vedic* period, 156
 - Yash Pal Committee report, 158
- education, Āyurveda
 - adhikāra* mode of teaching, 126
 - learning process, 123, 127
 - medical care, 122–124
 - nutrition, 122, 124
 - parenting skills, 122–124
 - right environment, 126–127
 - right student, 123, 126
 - right teacher and teaching, 123–126
 - Upaniṣadic* tradition, 127
- education, benefits, 101
- education, new model of
 - attitude towards mistakes, 113
 - Āyurveda, 122–127
 - content of syllabus, 111–112
 - evaluation procedure, 114
 - processing of information, 112
 - self-control, developing, 113
 - teacher education, 114–115
 - teaching-learning practices, 112
- ego, 43
- employee images, in organizations, see also organizational behaviour (OB)
 - as commodity, 193
 - as family member, 191
 - as internal customer, 192–193
 - as resource, 194
 - as team member, 191–192
- equanimity, 49
- ethnography, 137
- eugenics, 119
- existential anxiety, 65
- factionalism, 154
- fakirs*, 23
- folk wisdom, 22
- Fordism, 187
- Free Progress Education, 162
- Free Progress school, 108
- Gadgil, Madhav, 225
- Gandhi, Mahatma, 159, 226
- Ganga-Himalaya Kuti, 229
- Ganges, river, 226–227
- garbhadhāna saṁskāra*, 242
- gestational behaviour, role in developing

- personality, 123–124
- Gitā*, 47–50, 59
- globalization, 106
- God concept, 49–50
- guided imagery, 47
- guṇas*, 44–45
- gurmukh*, 256, 260
- guru dakṣiṇā*, 60
- Guru Nanak, 257–258, 260, 263, 265
- guru-celā* relationship, 25, 59
- gurus*, 23, 60
- haṭhayoga* exercises, 45–46
- haṭhayoga*, 90
- Haumai*, 254–255
- healing systems, traditional, see also Kachchh earthquake, study of healing process of survivors
 - Asian cultures, 25
 - Avari Mātā temple, Rajasthan, 33
 - at Balaji temple in Ayodhya, 24
 - bhajans*, role of, 33
 - cultural compatibility, 26
 - domain of experience, 29–30
 - efficacy of, 26–28
 - folk beliefs and practices, 22
 - guru-celā* relationship, 25
 - healers as diviners, 24–25
 - holistic approaches, 24
 - imageries of health, wellbeing and prosperity, developing positive, 31–32
 - in India, 21, 34
 - institutionalized catharsis, 31
 - livelihood of healers, 25
 - Maliamma's temple, 31
 - mind-body symbiotic relationship, 24
 - paranormal powers of healers, 25
 - re-patterning of emotions, 30
 - as a result of crises, 24
 - sacredness of, 23
 - shamans*, 30, 32
 - Śiva temple in Varanasi, 32
 - social nature of, 25–26
 - subliminal messages, 28–29
 - supernatural causation, theory of, 26
 - at Tejaji's shrines, 28
 - treating family and community, 32–33
 - and well-being, 33–34
- health*, Indian perspective, 3–5
 - mind-body medicine, 16–19
- healthy individual, 118
- Himalaya Bachao Andolan, 229
- Himalayas, the, 226
- hitāyu*, 11
- human consciousness, 15, 55–56
 - modern consumer society, 109
- human misery, source of, 43
- humanism, 190
- idiocy of village life, theory of, 226
- Indian Army, case study
 - consciousness, concept of, 271–274
 - Integration of consciousness, 274–275
 - leadership, concept of, 275–276
 - motivational strategies, 271
 - organizational structure, 269–270
 - recruitment and training, 270–271
 - self-recognition, path of, 273–274
- individualism, 190
- individuality, 152
- individualized process of education, 107
- indriya* (sensory perception apparatus), 4, 142
- Information Processing System, 134–135
- information society, 111
- inner disharmony, 55
- Integral Divine, 54
- integral education
 - need for, 110
 - principles of, 107–108
- integral psychology
 - evolution of man, 15–16
 - implications of, 19
 - as a tool in mind-body medicine, 17–19
- integrality, in Indian context
 - in terms of education, 107
 - key concepts, 109
 - implications in education, 109–110
 - meaning, 106–107
 - principle of self-exceeding, 108
 - principles of integral education, 107–108
 - responsible citizen, becoming a, 109, 111
 - shifts in content of education, 111–115
 - and spirituality, 108
 - theoretical and practical aspects of, 107–108
- internship, 141
- iśvara*, 135
- jātakarma*, 243
- jīva*, 135
- Jīvaka, 126
- Jñanayoga, 137
- Kachchh earthquake, study of healing process of survivors
 - cultural-psychological perspective on health and illness, 209–210
 - ethnographic approach, 212–214
 - literature review, 210–211
 - phenomenon of suffering and healing, understanding of, 214–216
 - themes, understanding of, 216–220
 - Western cultures, 210

- kāma*, 119
karma puruṣa, 119
karma yogi, 104, 144
karma, principle of, 48, 144, 215–219
kartṛtva, 143
Kothari, D. S., 158
Krishnamurti
 approach to nurturing of values, 155
 on discipline, 153
 on education, 147–148
 enquiry and human values, 148–150
 freedom, 153–154
 individuality, 152
 knowledge about oneself, 150–151
 human conditioning, 147–148
 man's relation to nature, 151–152
 religious mind, 155
 role of educator, 152–153
 value systems in India, 154–155
Ḳṣurikopaniṣad, 89
langar, 261
learning: the treasure within, 110
Mahābhārata, 242, 244
Mahaprajña, Acharya, 90
Mahāyāna Buddhism, 212
mala, 4
man, evolution in terms of Vedānta, 15–16
manas (mind), 142
 and mental ailments, 12
 nature, properties and functions of, 11–12
manas, 85
mānasa vyādhi, 11
manmukh, 256
mānuṣim tanum āśritam, 49
Mārkaṇḍeya, Sage, 244
māyā, 41, 135
māyāvādin, 39–42
medhā, 124
meditation, 46, 66
 self-reflection and introspective, 47
mental peace, 17, 19
mind-body medicine, 16–17
 integral psychology as a tool in, 17–19
Minimum Common Syllabus, 111–112
Minute on Education, 157
Misra, Vidyānivas, 226–227
mokṣa, 119
Mother Goddess, 243
mother-child relationship, see child rearing
 (*lālan-pālan*)
motherhood, 245–247
Mudaliar, A. L., 158
mukti, 55
Nāgarjuna, 126–127
nāmakaraṇa saṃskāra, 243
National Curriculum Framework, 139
navarātri festival, 125
nirvāṇa, 39, 42
niṣiddhakarma, 144
niṣkāma karma, principle of, 48
niyama (self-purification), 84
nutrition and healthy mind, 124
object permanence, development of, 65
objective decision-making, 143
oḷhās (holy men), 26
organizational behaviour (OB), 187, see also
 employee images, in organizations
 assumptions of person–organization
 relations, 194–197
 Business Process Outsourcing organiza-
 tion, case study, 199–201
 contemporary problems in the organiza-
 tion–individual relationship, 206–207
 human side of organizations, 189–190
 Indian organizations and cultural dis-
 parities, 197–199
 ITDC disinvestments process, case study,
 201–202
organizational life, 189
Ornish, Dean, 16
paramātmā, 215
parenting, role in education, 122–124
Patañjali's *Yoga-Sūtras*, 84
pāṭhaśālās, 157
phenomenology, 137
placebo effect, 33
political agenda of education, 157
Prahlaḍa, story of, 123
prakṛti, 230
prāṇāyāma (rhythmic breath control), 45–
 46, 58, 84, 122
prāṇic healing, 5, 46, 52
prāṇic relaxation, 87
prāśnāmendriyamanah svasthā, 3
pratyāhāra (sense withdrawal), 84, see also
 yogic practices, for management of psy-
 cho-physiological problems
 contemporary issues, 87–88
 as a method of psychic modification and
 mental health, 94–96
 parts, 85
pratyāhāra, meaning of, 85
pravacana, 143
pravṛtti, 216
prekṣā method, 87, 90
psychiatry, Indian thoughts, 51–52
psychic being, 15, 53
psychic consciousness, 54
psychological alienation, 151
psychotherapeutic counselling, 39

- psychotherapy
 aim, 38–39
 approaches, 37
 Buddhist thought, 47
 case example, 77–79
 cosmic forces, concept of, 56
 counsellor-client relationship, 59–60
 and *Gītā*, 47–50
 goal of, 37, 60–61
guru, conception of, 57
 harmony of body and mind, 45–47
 ideal of inner purification, 43–45
 illness, 57
 Indian thoughts and psychiatry, 51–53
 instruments and tools, 58–59
māyāvādin solution, 39–42
 modern, 33–34
 psychological maladies, sources of, 54–55
 Sri Aurobindo's thoughts, 53, 56, 61
 and terrestrial divine perfection, 56–58
 tradition of Tantra, 50–51
Vedāntin view, 42–43
 world-view, 67
pūṃsavana saṃskāra, 242
puruṣa, 135, 142, 211, 230
puruṣārthas, 119
 Radhakrishnan, S., 158
rajas (activity), 142
rājasīc state, 43, 45, 125
rajo-sāttvic state, 43
rajo-tāmasīc *guṇa*, 44
rajo-tāmasīc state, 43
Rāmāyana, 244
rasāyana, 118–120
rāśī puruṣa, 119
 rebirth, 55
 recess-time announcement model for
pratyāhāra, 88
 reconciliation, 50
 Reiki, 5, 52
 religious mind, 155
 reproductive medicine, 119
 responsible citizen, becoming a, 109
roga, 11
 Rogers, Carl, 142
 Roman Catholic Church, 106
 rote-learning, 110, 157
saccidānanda, 67
 sacred therapies, 23
 Sadler Commission, 132
sadvṛttis, 12–13
 Śākta Tāntrika, 53
 Śakuntalā, 245
samādhi (higher unitive consciousness), 84
 Sāṃkhya Yoga system, 10, 211
Sāṇḍilya Upaniṣad, 86
 sane moderation, 44
sangat, 261
sannyāsa, 44
śānti, 215, 217–219
 Sarvodaya workers, 230
sattvasamādhāna, 119, 122
sattvasuddhi, 44
sātvic tendencies, 125, 142
sauhrdaya, 242
śavāsana, 86, 90–92
 Save Himalaya Movement, 229
 Sāvitrī, story of, 245
 schooled children, 140
 scientific relaxation technique, 90–92
 Selari village, 214–215
 self-actualization, 142
 self-abnegation, 152
 self-awakening, process of, 118
 self-awareness, 109, 113, 115
 self-concept
 Indian tradition, 142
 Sikh tradition, 264
 self-directed learning, 110
 self-exceeding, principle of, 108
 self-healing, 16
 self-identity, 53
 self-indulgence, 153
 self-knowledge, 152
 self-observation, 109
 self-perfection, 113, 115
 self-reflection, 113, 115
 self-regulation process, 264
 Sen, Amartya, 226
 Sikhism
 aspect of spiritual continuum, 265
 contemporary Sikh manifestation of hu-
 manness, 260–262
 idea and tradition, 251–252
 implications for psychology, 262–263
 karma, 255–256
 and other Indian systems, 252
 perception of the self, 259–260
 principles, 252–253
 processes of growth and development,
 259–260
 self-hood, 253–255
 self-regulation process, 264
 Sikh way of life, essentials, 251
 social-cognitive processes, 265
 social consciousness, 256–258
 socio-centric view of personhood, 263–266
 spiritual-mystical consciousness, 258
 transformation process, 262–263
simantonmayanasamskāra, 242

300 Foundations of Indian psychology: Practical applications

- śiśyaparīkṣā*, 126
Sītā, 245
smṛti, 124
social conflicts
 aspects of, 226
 indigenous approach towards resolving, 227–233
 non-violent method of resistance, see Chipko (hug-the-tree) movement
social dilemmas, 225
sociological enquiry, 150
soul, progressive manifestation of, 109
spiritual faith, 65–66
spiritual growth, 18
spiritual philosophy, 19
spiritual psychology, 64
 defence mechanisms, notion of, 70–74
 developmental milestone, 65–67
 ego-transformation, 70–74
 practical implications, 74–77
 relationship between soul and ego, 67–70
spiritual self, 57
spirituality, 108
Sri Aurobindo's model, of Integral Yoga Psychology (IYP)
 existence of a divine Being/Reality, 65
 faith as developmental milestone, 65–67
 on matter, 67
 relationship between soul and ego, 67–70
Sri Aurobindo's thoughts, 53, 56, 61, 105, see also teaching-learning, in Mirambika school
 acquisition of information, 160
 discovery of soul, 61
 on man, 53
 map of consciousness, 56
 principles of education, 107–108, 136, 159–162
 principles of good teaching, 160–161
 on psychotherapy, 53, 56, 67
 rebirth, 55
 svabhāva of the educand, 160–161
 true national education, 160
 yoga, 53
Sri Yogendra, 87
Śrīmad Bhāgavatam, 246
subject teachers, 141
suffering, 52–53
 in Sāṃkhya Yoga system, 10
sukha āyu, 11
sūkhi kheti, 219
supra-human life form, 67
Supreme Consciousness, 15, 18, 135
Supreme Self, 135
Supreme Wisdom of Creator, 17
suṣumnā nāḍi, 89
sūtras, 47
svabhāva, 45, 109
svadharma, 45, 109
svāmis, 23
svāstik, 243
Swami Satyanandaji, 90
Tagore, Rabindranath, 159
Taittirīyopaniṣad, 85
tāmasic state, 43, 45, 48, 125, 142
tamo guṇa, 44
Tantra, principle of, 50–51
tāntrics, 23
tāntrikas, 51
teacher education, 114–115
teacher education, in India
 cultural context of, 135, 138–139
 curriculum of, 133–134
 experimental research paradigm of, 136–138
 genesis and development, 132–133
 need for changes, 133–134
 organic dimension of educative process, 134
 programmes for, 139–141
 psychology field, 134–135
 research in the field of, 134–136
teaching and learning: the culture of pedagogy, 157
teaching-learning, in Mirambika school activities, 165
 architectural and physical organization in, 163–164
 background, 162
 children's learning experiences, 172–174
 classroom environment, 168–169
 a day at school, 164–165
 day-to-day functioning, 166–167
 discipline strategies, 175–177
 Diyas (teachers), 165–166
 exchange or negotiations at work, 174–175
 flexibility at work, 170–172
 framework for structuring and organizing work at school, 166–168
 principal, position and role of, 167
 process of entry to school, 162–163
 project-oriented teaching, 169–170
 school environment, 163–164
 'Sunlit Path', 163
third force psychology, 136
transpersonal psychology, 136
triṅṇa, 142
triṅṇātita, 142
Trīśikhā-Brahmaṇa Upaniṣad, 86
Tulsi, Acharya, 90

- unconscious process, 55
- universal education, 107
- upādhyāya*, 157
- upanayana saṁskāra*, 244
- Upaniṣad*, 40
- vairāgya*, 40–41
- vājīkaraṇa*, 118
- value systems, in contemporary India, 154–155
- Vāsudeva, 49
- vātsalya*, 124
- Vedāntic* systems, 41
- Vedāntin* philosophy, 42–43, 53
- vidyārambha* ceremony, 126
- vihitakarma*, 144
- vinaya*, 157
- vipāssanā*, 87, 90
- vīra mārga*, 53
- viśuddhi*, 89
- viveka buddhi*, 12
- Vivekananda, Swami, 44, 137, 159
- Vygotsky, Lev, 240
- Western civilization, 106
- Western model of education, 110
- Western psychology, 133
- womanhood, 246
- women in *Vedic* times, 245
- WRIDASM model for *pratyāhāra*, 88
- yajña*, 230
- yama* (moral instructions), 84
- yoga*, 19, 49, 84, 121, 144, 230
- yoga-nidrā*, 86, 89–90
- yogāsanas*, 58
- Yogasūtra*, 13
- Yoga-Vāṣiṣṭha*, 42, 87
- yogic practices, for management of psycho-physiological problems
 - aṣṭāṅga* or Eight Limb *yoga*, 84–85, 87
 - 'body-talk' (awareness) technique, 93
 - breathing technique, 92
 - children's classroom model, 88
 - contemporary methods of mental and physical relaxation, 87–88, 92–93
 - detachment of senses, 86
 - Jainism and Buddhism strategies, 87
 - and pleasant state of consciousness, 86
 - prekṣā* method, 87, 90
 - recess-time announcement model, 88
 - śavāsana*, 90–92
 - systematic yogic relaxation technique, 91
 - in *Upaniṣadic* literature, 85–87
 - vipāssanā*, 87, 90
 - WRIDASM model, 88
 - yoga-nidrā*, 86, 89–90
 - yonimudrā*, 86, 89

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see also

Foundations of Indian Psychology

Volume 1

Concepts and Theories

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Preface

Introduction

The psychological perspectives of our times... Three shifts of a rhythm

Section 1: The social and philosophical context

- | | | |
|---|---------------------------|---|
| 1 | <i>K. Ramakrishna Rao</i> | Indian psychology: Implications and applications |
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|----|--|---|
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|----|-----------------------------------|---|
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Section 4: Affect, motivation and creativity

- | | | |
|----|--------------------------|--|
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| 19 | <i>Sunil D. Gaur</i> | Why am I here? Implications of self and identity for conceptualizing motivation |
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